



T J MAGUIRE

BRATVA

Menace



BRATVA MENACE

OceanofPDF.com

BRATVA: BOOK FIVE



T J MAGUIRE

OceanofPDF.com

Copyright © 2025 by T J MAGUIRE

All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced in any form or by any electronic or mechanical means, including information storage and retrieval systems, without written permission from the author. The story, all names, characters and incidents portrayed in this production is fictitious. No identification with actual persons (living or deceased) places, buildings, and products is intended or should be inferred.

Book Cover by: Fay Lane

Editing by: BLD Editing

OceanofPDF.com

CONTENTS

[Content Warning](#)

1. [Chapter One](#)
2. [Chapter Two](#)
3. [Chapter Three](#)
4. [Chapter Four](#)
5. [Chapter Five](#)
6. [Chapter Six](#)
7. [Chapter Seven](#)
8. [Chapter Eight](#)
9. [Chapter Nine](#)
10. [Chapter Ten](#)
11. [Chapter Eleven](#)
12. [Chapter Twelve](#)
13. [Chapter Thirteen](#)
14. [Chapter Fourteen](#)
15. [Chapter Fifteen](#)
16. [Chapter Sixteen](#)
17. [Chapter Seventeen](#)
18. [Chapter Eighteen](#)
19. [Chapter Nineteen](#)
20. [Chapter Twenty](#)
21. [Chapter Twenty One](#)
22. [Chapter Twenty Two](#)
23. [Chapter Twenty Three](#)
24. [Chapter Twenty Four](#)
25. [Chapter Twenty Five](#)
26. [Chapter Twenty Six](#)
27. [Chapter Twenty Seven](#)
28. [Chapter Twenty Eight](#)
29. [Chapter Twenty Nine](#)
30. [Chapter Thirty](#)

31. [Chapter Thirty One](#)
32. [Chapter Thirty Two](#)
33. [Chapter Thirty Three](#)
34. [Chapter Thirty Four](#)
35. [Chapter Thirty Five](#)
36. [Chapter Thirty Six](#)
37. [Chapter Thirty Seven](#)
38. [Chapter Thirty Eight](#)
39. [Chapter Thirty Nine](#)
40. [Chapter Forty](#)
41. [Chapter Forty One](#)
42. [Chapter Forty Two](#)

[A little note from me to you](#)

[*OceanofPDF.com*](#)

CONTENT WARNING

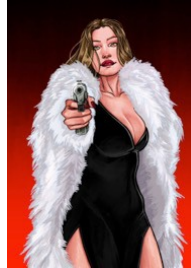
Before you continue, please be aware that this book has a content warning.
If you have any of the following triggers, please proceed with caution.

Harsh language
Graphic and detailed violence
Murder/death
Blood and gore
Graphic sexual scenes
Knife play
Stalking
Slight BDSM/Kink
Obsessive thoughts and actions

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER ONE

LYLA



I looked through the scope of my sniper rifle, my focus locked on the dark room in the building across from me.

I was lying flat on my stomach on the roof of Vibe Hotel, music blasting in my ears so loudly I couldn't hear the hustle and bustle of city life happening below me as I agonizingly waited to catch one more glimpse of my love.

My everything.

My Lukyan.

It had been three hours, seventeen minutes, and forty-three seconds since I'd last laid eyes on him, and I had been suffering for every millisecond of it. I'd watched him earlier in the night, modeling in a mock-up fashion show for his sister-in-law, Tatiana.

I'd sat right in the back, shrouded in darkness so he wouldn't see me, and silently cheered him on while taking a bunch of photos to add to my scrapbook.

He'd done so well! Strutting down that runway as if he owned it, Lukyan even blew a kiss into the crowd, and I knew—I just *knew*—he'd meant it for me.

It was mine.

He was mine.

Once the show had finished, I stuck to the shadows, watching him from afar as he helped his brother propose to his girlfriend. As he attended an after-party for the fashion show, he mingled throughout the room with an ease that seemed to come naturally to him.

With his long, dark, luscious hair, blue eyes with small, almost unnoticeable flecks of brown in them, and charismatic charm, people flocked to him, mesmerized by his presence and his ability to make them relax with merely a few words.

While I could see he enjoyed it—the attention and making people laugh—there was also something more lying deep beneath the surface that he was trying desperately to hide. Almost a...sadness to his soul.

No one else could see it.

But *I* could.

I saw the way he crumbled bit by bit whenever his family didn't believe in him. Saw how much it hurt that they didn't have faith in him. Didn't *see* him and all his potential.

I saw him.

I saw him in a way no one else possibly could have.

It was what made us so perfect for each other.

Lukyan had gone to the after-party with two of his friends from their group—identical twins whose names I didn't bother to learn because I didn't care enough to know them.

The twins each had a girl on their arm, and though I had expected Lukyan to do the same, he left the party as the fifth wheel.

It made my heart soar.

Was it because of me?

I liked to think so.

He must have finally started to feel our bond. Our connection. What other reason could there have been for him to leave a party by himself when so many men and women were throwing themselves at him?

We were two pieces of the same puzzle. Two sides of the same coin. And I knew, without a shadow of a doubt, that he felt it too.

It only made me more sure that the plan I had in place to make him mine was the right one.

I'd only glimpsed Lukyan once since then, when he arrived at his hotel room. He'd gone in and made a beeline straight for the glass sliding door, closing the curtains.

It irked me.

I wanted to watch, even if it was only him sitting on the couch, staring at the television or scrolling on his phone.

I'd have spent all my days and nights just watching him if I could.

My music cut off abruptly when my phone rang. I pulled it out of my pocket and released a groan at the name dancing across the screen.

I gave the dark room across the street one more glance. Still no movement. With a sigh, I took out one of my wireless headphones and rolled onto my back, staring up at the night sky as I answered.

“Yes?”

“Where are you, Lyla? Are you stalking that Volkov kid again?”

“Why do you bother asking the question if you just plan to answer it yourself, Lev?”

“Because I hope, by some miracle, you’ve finally seen sense and given up this ridiculous infatuation you have with Lukyan-Fucking-Volkov.”

I scrunched up my nose. “Well, that’s just foolishness on *your* part, and you should honestly know better. You have no one to blame but yourself for your disappointment. You can’t just ‘give up’ on true love.”

“True love,” Lev scoffed, his derision coming through the phone loud and fucking clear. “He doesn’t even know who you are.”

“He might not know *who* I am, but knows *me*. Our connection—”

“I can’t listen to this again,” he cut in. “You need to get over this. Now. Or have you forgotten our mission?”

I chewed the inside of my lip. Despite what my brother thought, I hadn’t forgotten about the mission. He just didn’t know that *mine* was slightly different from his.

And Lev couldn’t know that. Not yet. Not until it was too late for him to do anything about it.

I rolled back onto my stomach and glanced into the scope, not really expecting to see anything. It had been hours without a hint of movement from Lukyan’s room, but my breath caught in my throat when I saw him.

Standing on his balcony, shirtless, forearms leaning against the railing as he stared up into the sky, he was the picture-perfect definition of deliciously fuckable.

Every time I saw him, whether it be up close while he was sleeping or afar from the shadows, my heart pounded in my chest, my insides turning to complete mush.

“I have to go.”

“Lyla, don’t you dare—”

I hung up.

With renewed, excited energy flooding my veins, I adjusted my position, bracing my elbows on the ground as I clutched the rifle securely.

Lukyan's hair was down, just touching the tips of his shoulders, and a gleam of sweat lined his skin. A joint hung loosely in his fingers, his face relaxed. Calm. Serene. The sharp lines of his face, those full lips, and gorgeous eyes were what drew everyone in. Myself included.

My entire being came to life, every part inside of me exploding like a firework the longer I looked at him. Studied him. Admired him.

Memories of all the times I'd done that exact same thing—watched him from afar—mingled together, and I honestly couldn't recount how many times I'd actually done it. I knew it had to be in the hundreds, teetering on the thousands, and yet, it felt like it wasn't enough. That it would *never* be enough. I could have watched him do the most mundane things from the moment I woke up 'til the moment I fell asleep and never tire of it, as if it were the most riveting piece of entertainment in history.

All of a sudden, Lukyan stiffened. He straightened, his eyes narrowing into slits, suspicion streaking across his face. His gaze moved over the buildings in front of him. Slow. Assessing. Methodical. And then stopped. Right on me.

My breath hitched.

There was no way he could see me. It was pitch-black. I was on the roof of a building taller than the one he was staying in. There was not a chance in hell he could see me, and yet there was no mistaking the fact that he was looking *right* in my fucking direction. Right up at me. Right into my fucking eyes.

I knew it.

I *knew* it wasn't all in my fucking head. Lev was wrong. Lukyan felt that connection too. How else could one explain him staring right into my goddamn soul when all the evidence dictated that he couldn't possibly be doing that?

Because we were connected in a way no one else could understand.

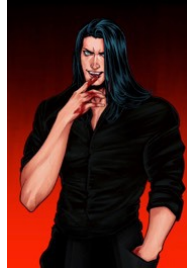
We were soulmates.

And we would be together.

Or die together.

CHAPTER TWO

LUKYAN VOLKOV



Taking a drag from the blunt pressed firmly to my lips, I inhaled deeply, letting the smoke fill my lungs before blowing it out, watching it dance up into the dark sky. Dozens of buildings were in front of me, some even bigger and taller than the one I was staying in.

There were thousands of windows, some dark and quiet, indicating the occupants were most likely asleep. Others lit up, making it very easy to see into their apartments or hotel rooms. Lights danced across the sky from the dozens of other buildings in front of me, the world still wide awake and going strong despite the fact that it was two in the morning.

It was my last night of absolute freedom.

It wasn't what you might think. I wasn't going to jail or dying from some sort of illness. I was just moving to Russia to marry some random woman I'd never met.

You know, normal shit.

An arranged marriage was pretty common in our world. It was the easiest way to solidify alliances between organizations. Fuck, even my sister's marriage was arranged.

I never thought that would be in my future, though. I always envisioned that I'd settle down, marry a woman of my choice who would pop out a couple of kids, and then live the rest of my life with my wife, children, and annoying siblings at my side.

But the world decided something else for me instead.

I had no one to blame but myself. It was all my fault, really. I had *offered* to take my big brother's place. *He* was originally going to marry

Anya, the bride my horrid grandfather arranged to be wed into the family in exchange for access to her family's trade routes.

But then, he'd gone and grown a heart.

Okay, that wasn't fair. Aleksandr always had a heart. It was just stuck behind an impenetrable wall of grumpiness until a five-foot-nothing cartel queen came a-knocking.

She had bulldozed that wall down with a goddamn sledgehammer. Suddenly, he was all lovey and sappy. Which, yes, I acknowledged was a good thing because he was finally happy. But it also meant there was no way in hell he could marry Anya.

The same went for Nikolai, my other, *slightly less grumpy but also still grumpy* older brother. He was even more head over heels for his woman than Aleksandr was for his, and *that* was saying something.

Plus, Tatiana was currently six months pregnant with his twins.

So, yeah, he was out. And if one of us didn't marry Anya, that horrid grandfather I mentioned earlier was going to kill Illayana, our sister.

It *had* to be me. Little old me.

I wasn't complaining. It was just the hand I'd been dealt, and I had no problem adjusting to my circumstances. Life always threw crappy shit at you. How you dealt with that crappy shit was what made a person. Determined if you were going to thrive or just survive.

The cold wind skated over my skin, and despite the goose bumps running down my body, I welcomed it. Welcomed the refreshingness of it.

I leaned forward, bracing my forearms on the railing, and took a deep breath in. Not a lot of people knew it, but I liked the quiet. It was calming. Peaceful. The complete opposite of the chaos in my brain. My life. I felt as though I could finally breathe in moments like that. The dark sky. The cold, icy wind. The splatterings of bright stars in the night.

Tranquil was the word to describe it. And for someone who ran a mile a minute in everyday life, moments like that were hard to come by. Hard to enjoy.

I savored it, basking in that moment and clearing my mind. Clearing all the noise and all the bullshit and just—

A dark chill shot down my spine. I stiffened and straightened to my full height, going from relaxed to hyperalert in an instant.

She's watching me.

There was a certain feeling you got when someone was watching you. You couldn't see them, you couldn't hear them, but there was a part of you that just *knew* they were there, almost as if they were breathing down the back of your neck.

That was the feeling coursing through my bones.

I shouldn't have been as excited as I was at that prospect...but *fuck*, I was. I was yet to meet anyone who matched my crazy, but that woman... My *stalker*...

Oh, she matched it to a tee, and it was fucking *exhilarating*.

I couldn't help but be curious about what she would do once she found out I was going to be married in only a few short days. She'd shown a certain level of possessiveness toward me already. That was evident based on the fingers she'd sent me of a woman she thought I'd had sex with.

You'd think something like that would have freaked me out.

Surprise, surprise. It didn't. It turned me on. And I found myself deliberately trying to antagonize her. To get her to reveal herself instead of hiding in the damn shadows all the time.

I wanted to see her.

My grandfather, Sergei Volkov, had called a few weeks before to tell me the date had officially been set. That I had three weeks to get my affairs in order before my ass was to be on a plane to Russia.

He'd been pushing the wedding back for months, giving excuse after excuse as to why it was being postponed. My father suspected Sergei was having trouble maintaining the deal. That my bride-to-be's family was trying to renegotiate the terms, forcing my grandfather to push the wedding back until they could come to some sort of agreement that suited them both.

I think it was partly that, *and* my father, that were responsible for the delay. Sergei had placed an open contract on my father. Ten millions dollars to whoever could end his life.

For the past six months, assassins from all over the world had tried to claim that bounty. Tried breaking into our home. Murdering him in his bed. Shooting him in drive-bys. The whole nine yards.

None of those attempts had been successful, thanks to Autumn, the Crimson Death. World-renowned assassin. His *girlfriend*. A word I never thought I would say in conjunction with my father, but there we were.

They'd met when they were both kidnapped by the same man. Talon Scardo. A fucktard of man with a huge daddy complex and a need to have

the world view him as a smart and important man.

Bore.

He'd made the mistake of making them partners in a gladiator-style fight-to-the-death tournament where four people entered the arena, and only two walked out alive.

My father and Autumn *hated* each other at the start. Had actually tried to kill each other several times before they reluctantly entered into an alliance with the sole objective of working together to try to escape Talon.

And thanks to a joint effort from the Bratva, La Cosa Nostra, and Los Zetas, that escape came to fruition.

After a lot, and I mean *a lot* of fuckery—mainly from my father's side—they had worked on their feelings for one another and were all in.

There was no denying the fact that it was a little weird for me. I'd only ever seen him with one woman before. My mother had been murdered over ten years earlier by a rival family, the Voznesenskys. But seeing how happy he was made all that weirdness more than worth it.

I never noticed before how much he was just coasting through life. How unhappy he truly was. Merely existing and not *living*.

Autumn had brought him back from the darkness.

She, along with a four-man security team, had managed to thwart every attempt on my father's life. I suspected Sergei was desperately trying to have my father killed *before* the wedding because he didn't want to risk something happening *during* the event itself and possibly ruining the deal he so urgently needed with the Tarasovs.

He must have given up, though, because it had been a month since the last attempt. And in two days' time, I would be walking down the aisle.

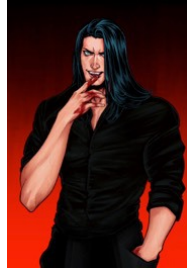
That dark chill vanished.

I exhaled heavily. She wasn't watching me anymore.

I ignored the tug of disappointment in my gut because it was completely and totally irrational, and went inside.

CHAPTER THREE

LUKYAN VOLKOV



“Surprise!”

I clutched my chest, gasping in pretend shock at the cluster of people standing in my backyard; my siblings, my father, Autumn, Tatiana, Drea, Arturo, his brother, Vincenzo, their two younger siblings, Lucian and Theodora, Christian, Luca, and about a dozen other people whose names I couldn’t remember.

“Oh my God! What is this?” I asked with a laugh. But, I knew exactly what it was.

For the past few weeks, my siblings had been meticulously planning a surprise going-away party for me. I’d found out about it pretty much as soon as the idea came to light because they sucked at keeping a secret.

Individually, they were fine. But when they had a secret to keep as a collective, one they were all in on together, it was a completely different story.

From the shifty looks to the way conversations would just cease when I entered the room, it was plainly obvious those idiots were hiding something. Planning something I wasn’t allowed to know about.

And me, being the nosy little fucker I was, needed to know exactly what it was they were keeping from me.

Arms encircled me in loving hugs as I made my way down the porch steps, everyone patting me on the back and making me the center of attention.

Which, let’s be honest...I fucking loved.

Light R'n'B music drifted through the air, and the scents of all of my favorite foods hit my nose. Meat, pastries, sweets. The fuckers had thought of everything.

I slowly made my way through the crowd of people, greeting them with that classic Lukyan charm. Wink here. Sly smile there. Inappropriate joke to finish.

The Lukyan Trifecta.

My family all stood together, side by side. Father and Autumn, arms linked—he dressed in his usual three-piece suit, looking as stoic as ever, and she with a friendly smile on her face and hair like fucking fire, red and blazing.

Aleksandr and Drea—my brother, the carbon copy of our father, right down to that same grumpy-as-fuck look on his face, and his wife, the complete and total polar opposite. She was short, covered head to toe in tattoos and piercings, and while Aleksandr always dressed plainly in dark, perfectly fitted clothing, Drea always had a gothic vibe to her attire. Ripped jeans, heavy metal band T-shirts, combat boots. It suited her and her personality to a tee.

Nikolai and Tatiana, the lovebirds—the couple that were so disgustingly in love with each other, you couldn't help but be happy for them *and* jealous of them at the same time. My brother was dressed nicely, which I could only assume was thanks to his fashion major fiancé. Tatiana was wearing a long, loose maxi dress, her belly big and round. I knew that was not something you were meant to say about a pregnant woman, but it was true. She was carrying not *one* baby, but *two*, and they were Volkovs. We were big babies.

Last but not least, Illayana and Arturo—Arty, I sometimes liked to call him, just because it pissed him off. While Aleksandr was the carbon copy of our father, Illayana was the carbon copy of our mother. Tall. Long dark hair. Bright blue eyes. Soft face yet fierce heart. And Arty? Well, I'll admit, I hadn't really liked him when I first met him. Still kinda didn't, if I was being honest, because of his somewhat dickish personality.

He made my sister happy, though, so I was willing to let that dickishness slide.

Gracious of me, I know.

They were all there, and while I loved having everyone there to celebrate moi, it only showcased how *I* was the odd one out now. All of my

family members had found their someone special.

“What do you think?! What do you think?! Do you like it?! Were you surprised?!” Illayana shrieked, her excitement overwhelming. She jumped up and down on the spot, hands clasped together in what I assumed was hopefulness, like her entire mood would hinge on my answer.

Arturo stared me down, eyes hard, brows creased in warning.

I got the message. Say I was surprised and loved it. Otherwise, he’d pummel me because he allowed nothing to upset his wife. My sister had him wrapped around her fucking finger.

I put on a ten-thousand-watt smile. “So surprised. I had no idea.”

“Yes!” She thumped Nikolai on the arm. “See! I told you it was going to work.”

Nikolai slapped her in the arm with the back of his hand in retaliation. “Don’t hit me,” he grunted.

“Don’t be such a baby. I barely touched you.”

Drea stepped forward and hugged me. “Your sister worked very hard on the party.”

“Yes, I’m sure she did.” I chuckled, returning the hug. Usually, I would have been down to fuck with Illayana because it was fun. But I knew how much she wanted to give me a good, fun going-away shindig, so I didn’t have the heart to tell her I had known about it from the beginning.

Tatiana hugged me next. Her hand was still clasped firmly in Nikolai’s as she stretched forward, as if he didn’t want to let her go for even a second. I was careful not to put too much pressure on her growing belly. “You’re a good brother,” she whispered in my ear. Tatiana must have known I was putting on a front.

“I know.” I sighed as if the task was draining. “It’s utterly exhausting,” I joked. “Oh, I have a present for you.”

“For me?” she frowned, stepping back. “We’re the ones who are meant to get *you* a gift.”

“Okay, it’s not for you. It’s for my future niece and nephew. I’ll give it to you later.” I winked.

“Don’t think that you can buy their affections. You’re not going to be the favorite. I am,” Illayana declared, standing tall.

I scoffed. “Please. We all know who their favorite is going to be, and it ain’t gonna be you.”

I had every intention of getting *Favorite Uncle* status. It wouldn't be hard. My only competition was Aleksandr, and he was big and grumpy. He was liable to make the babies burst into tears the moment they saw him.

"Don't you think it will be Aleksandr?" Autumn asked, a mischievous smile on her face. "One of the twins is named after him, after all."

I pointed a finger at her. "That's yet to be decided."

Tatiana laughed. "Sorry, Lukyan. It has *definitely* been decided."

"Fine. Lukyan works for a girl too."

"I'm not naming my daughter Lukyan," Nikolai blustered.

"What about Luky?" I countered.

"No."

"Lukinda?"

"No."

"Lukyana? A combination of Lukyan and Illayana?"

"I like that one." Illayana nodded.

"Drea's a good name too!" Drea cut in.

"Well, if we're throwing names out there—" Autumn began.

"What Tatiana and I decide to name our daughter will be between *Tatiana and I*," Nikolai declared.

"I kind of like the name Lukinda. It has a nice ring to it," Tatiana said, a cheeky smirk on her face.

Nikolai's eyes widened in fear and disbelief. His jaw clenched, and his next words came out strained, as if it pained him to utter them. "Really?"

Tatiana burst out in laughter. "No."

His shoulders slumped in relief. "Thank God."

I locked eyes with Arturo. Because I was a loveable, sociable chap, I stuck my hand out toward him. "Arty. Nice to see you."

His eyes narrowed. He placed his hand in mine and *squeezed*. Hard. *Fucking ouch*. "I wish I could say the same."

Illayana rammed an elbow into his ribs and gave him a scathing look. He rolled his eyes and mumbled, "Nice to see you too."

I smiled brightly. "I know you like me. Deep, *deep* down. I make you laugh. Admit it."

"I'll do no such thing."

I didn't need him to admit it. I reminded him of his own brother, and because of that, I would always have a special place in his heart.

Speaking of which, Vincenzo was standing just outside of our little circle, waiting to offer his own greeting. “I’m gonna go mingle. Catch up with you crazy lot later.”

At Vincenzo’s side were his younger siblings, Lucian on his left and Theodora on his right, their little hands in his. I smiled broadly, clasping his forearm. “You sneaky fucker. I didn’t know you’d be here.”

Standing at 6’3, he was tall, lean, with short dark hair styled in a meticulous way that looked both neat and messy at the same time. His emerald eyes were a big hit with the ladies. And the men, if we’re being honest. Coupled with the sharp jaw, high cheekbones, and dimples, he was *almost* attractive enough to give me a run for my money.

Almost.

Vin laughed. “I take it the party didn’t come as such a surprise then?”

I snorted, releasing him. I looked over my shoulder to make sure Illayana was no longer in earshot. “My sister loves to plan a surprise party, but she sucks at it. Remember Arturo’s thirtieth birthday?” I asked, arching a brow.

His body shook with a chuckle. “Oh, yeah. She just can’t help but give it away.”

“Exactly.” I looked at the two small children at his feet. “Miss Theodora,” I greeted, giving her a gallant bow.

She giggled and hid behind Vin’s leg, her cheeks stained red.

I straightened and held out a closed fist. “Lucian, my man.” He smiled and bumped his fist against mine. We both mimicked an explosion, our hands blowing up into the air.

Eleven years old and cute as buttons, the De Luca twins were already forces to be reckoned with. When I’d first moved to New York with Illayana, Theodora and Lucian lived in the family home with their parents, Alessandro, the former Don of La Cosa Nostra, and his wife, Isabella. After Arturo assumed control, they moved out, wanting to give their newly married son and daughter-in-law some privacy.

They still visited every week, though, maintaining their tradition of Sunday night family dinner.

“What have you ragamuffins been up to? Staying *in* trouble, I hope.” I winked.

They both nodded enthusiastically. “I put salt in the sugar bowl this morning, and Dad put it in his coffee!” Lucian announced excitedly.

“Nice!”

“And *I* punched Lucian so hard in the arm I made him bruise!” Theodora added proudly, her head held high.

“She did!” Lucian agreed. “Look!” He rolled up the sleeve of his shirt to show me.

I crouched down to their level and inspected his skin, not seeing a bruise but pretending I did anyway because I could see how proud Theodora was of herself. I didn’t have the heart to break that.

“Good job!” I praised. “Just like I taught you.”

Vin snickered, shaking his head. “My parents are still pissed you taught her how to throw a punch.”

“Someone had to.” I shrugged, rising back to my full height.

In my opinion, Theodora should have been taught how to defend herself from the moment she could walk.

It wasn’t as if we lived some normal, apple-pie life. The Mafia was filled with violence, bloodshed, and death. That was something Theodora didn’t choose. She was born into it, and her parents should have prepared her for that. To not do so was doing Theodora a serious disservice and leaving her vulnerable to all the danger that life brought forth.

So I taught the kid how to punch. How to kick. How to always aim for the eyes and balls if a man tried to hurt her.

“What’s been going on with you, anyway?” I asked Vin. “Last I heard, you’d been sent away on some sort of business for your brother.”

Something flashed across his face before he was able to shut it down. Vin’s smile turned strained. Somewhat forced. Fake. “Yeah, you know, just the usual work bullshit.” He laid both hands on Lucian and Theodora’s shoulders. “Come on, you two. Let’s go say hi to everyone.” And then he was off, ushering his two younger siblings in front of him at a brisk pace.

I let him make his escape because I knew I would get to the bottom of whatever the fuck that was about later. I had a persistent personality—absolutely no qualms about badgering the shit out of someone until I got the information I wanted.

Eventually, they would all get so annoyed they’d tell me just to get me to leave them alone.

Worked perfectly well, if you asked me.

I mingled with everyone, making small chitchat and meaningless conversation. I suspected a lot of them only showed up because those types

of events brought forth free food and booze. I knew that was why *I* always attended them.

Being the incredibly social being I was, I enjoyed it. I enjoyed the laid-back atmosphere, the music, the carefreeness of it all. It was a rare moment for us—not filled with violence and death for once.

I'd done the rounds, saying hello to everyone before I grabbed a plate of food and sat down at one of the dozens of tables spread out on the grass.

"How's guard duty going? My sister still playing by the rules?" I asked Christian as I took a sip of my beer.

He was sitting across from me, dressed in a dark button-down shirt and dark jeans. His brother, Luca, was beside him, a plate overflowing with food.

Christian fidgeted, his brows pulled into a frown as he adjusted himself. He'd been doing that since I sat down. "She's been very good. I swear, after Illayana got kidnapped *the second time*, Arturo was ready to fucking murder us."

"Chop up our bodies and sell the parts on the black market," Luca added, shoving food into his mouth. "He showed us the exact blade he'd use to do it too."

Christian nodded. He pulled at his pants as if they were uncomfortable and had started to annoy him. "It was big, and—"

"Motherfucking terrifying," Luca finished.

"You know it freaks me the fuck out when you do that *finishing each other's sentences* bullshit," I snapped.

They both smiled at me, and they weren't friendly, pleasant smiles. They were fucking chilling ones, like in that horror movie, *Smile*.

"It's—" Christian began.

"Twin-tuition," Luca finished again for him.

I glared at them. "You guys fucking suck."

They both laughed.

"So, do you know anything about your future bride?" Christian asked, leaning forward to try and steal a fry off Luca's plate. His brother slapped his hand away before he was able to without looking up, making Christian scowl.

"Nope. Nothing. Not a thing."

"Seriously?" Luca frowned. "You didn't look her up online or anything?"

I'd debated it, but in the end, decided not to.

Why?

Because I wanted a little fucking mystery for once. Everything in my life had become so predictable. Boring. I wanted something different. A little suspense.

"Nope." I took another sip of my beer, the bubbly liquid tickling down the back of my throat. "I just hope she's at least got a sense of humor." She was going to need one with what I had planned.

Luca pushed his plate away and patted his stomach contentedly. He watched his brother continue to fidget, an almost knowing glint in his eyes, and lips turned up slightly as if he was trying not to laugh. "It's just a marriage on paper, right?" he asked, diverting his attention back to me. "I mean, if she doesn't like you, at least you can have sex with other women."

I chose not to acknowledge his words, instead switching the conversation to Christian's constant fidgeting.

"Dude. *What* is going on with you?"

"I don't know," he all but groaned, scratching at himself. "My balls are so itchy."

Luca snickered, covering his mouth. "Maybe it's from that chick you hooked up with last night."

"Fuck you, asshole. You know I don't ride bareback."

"Or...*maybe*...just maybe...someone put poison ivy on your underwear as payback for leaving a wild snake in their bed."

Christian's jaw dropped open in outrage. "You didn't," he breathed.

"Snake?" I questioned, trying to contain my laughter.

Luca's eyes snapped to me, burning with anger. "I *hate* snakes, and that fucker knows it," he said, whipping up an accusatory finger at his brother.

"How was that any different from when you put a *tarantula* in the bathroom while I was taking a shower?!"

"Herbet wouldn't have hurt you. That snake could have *killed* me! Wrapped around my throat while I was sleeping and strangled me to death, or something even more sinister."

I pinched my lips together to stop myself from bursting into a fit of laughter. "H-herbet?"

Christian thumped a hand on the table angrily while his other one scratched at his groin vigorously. "That moron decided to *keep* it. *Keep* the

fucking spider that's as big as your hand. Brought it a goddamn tank and everything."

"Whoa, whoa, whoa, wait a second," I said, holding up a hand. "Tarantulas are okay, but snakes aren't?" I asked Luca.

"Snakes. Have. No. Legs."

"Spiders have *too many* legs. What the hell is wrong with you?!" Christian seethed.

"What's wrong with *you*?!" Luca blasted back.

The twins broke out into a full-blown argument, and I just sat back and enjoyed the show. In a way, it reminded me so much of Illayana and me. I couldn't help but grow a little nostalgic. I sat there, soaking it all up and enjoying it as their fight escalated, both of them getting to their feet to yell at each other.

It wasn't until a few minutes had gone by and I heard a song—"Moves like Jagger"—hit the air that my attention finally shifted, and I turned around.

Illayana was standing next to the DJ booth, a mischievous glint in her eyes as the song intro continued. She flicked her head, signaling for me to join her. I rolled my eyes as if the idea of doing so was nothing but a chore when, in actuality, excitement buzzed through my veins.

I got to my feet, leaving Christian and Luca to continue their bickering, and started making my way over to the little makeshift dance floor. I clicked my fingers, bopping along to the beat of the music, and Illayana did the same until we met in the middle and then we broke out into our routine—a dance from when we were kids.

After my mother died and my father left to track down her killers, life in the Volkov household was rough. We were all grieving. Suffering. And it seemed like life would never get any better. Illayana and I were inseparable during those first few years. We leaned on each other. Supported each other. Helped each other through the loss.

One of the things we liked to do was come up with silly little dance routines and perform them for Aleksandr and Nikolai because it made them laugh.

It wasn't a cure. The furthest thing from it. But for those few minutes, the hurt over losing our mother had stopped.

Illayana and I weaved around each other, hiking our thumbs over our shoulders as our bodies swayed side to side. We transitioned effortlessly

into the next move, and then the next and the next, doing all those silly, embarrassing dance moves from back in the 90s. The running man, the butterfly, even the fucking cabbage patch. Clapping, cheering, and whooping came from the crowd that had slowly started to gather around us.

I grabbed Illayana's hands and started spinning us like Jack and Rose in *Titanic*. Her head fell back and she laughed, squealing as I spun us faster and faster. It was the most fun I'd had in a long time, the smile on my face so big my cheeks started to hurt.

The routine itself was only thirty seconds long, so, once we'd finished it, we began to pull people in from the crowd to dance with us. Everyone joined in. Sitting at a table not far from the dance floor were my father, siblings, and their partners. Nikolai helped Tatiana to her feet, one hand on her belly, and guided her over, the two of them doing a slow dance despite the fact that the beat of the music was definitely not designed for such dancing. Drea dragged Aleksandr up, the grumpy look on his face speaking volumes. He didn't fight her as she bounded over excitedly on the tips of her toes, dragging him along. She just danced in circles around him while he watched her, completely bewitched.

Autumn wiggled her eyebrows at my father. He shook his head. She calmly moved to a stand and held out her hand. He sighed, rolling his eyes before placing his hand in hers. They made their way over, joining in.

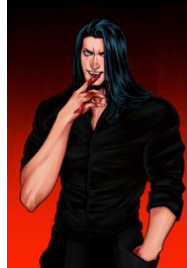
Arturo snuck up behind Illayana, wrapping his arms around her waist. She giggled, leaning her body back into his. Illayana turned to face him, and they got completely lost in one another, the rest of the world just fading away from them.

It was a sickenly beautiful family moment.

I should have known it wasn't going to last, though.

CHAPTER FOUR

LUKYAN VOLKOV



I sat at a table with Nikolai, Aleksandr, and Adrian, one of Illayana's guards. The fun and loving atmosphere of the party surrounded me from all sides, the mood infectious. We'd all danced together, Nikolai and Tatiana doing sickening yet beautiful slow dances, wrapped up in each other's embrace no matter which song was playing. It was kind of funny to watch, especially when it was an R'n'B or hip-hop song ringing through the air. But neither one cared, too engrossed in the other to even pay attention to anyone else but them.

Illayana and Drea did silly, awkward moves, not caring in the slightest how it made them look, while Aleksandr and Arturo stood beside them like guard dogs.

Even my father—a man who wasn't known for partaking in events such as that—danced alongside us, his movements as smooth as silk, as if he'd been a dancer in a previous life.

In fact, he was still out there after the rest of us had decided to take a break, moving effortlessly to the beat of the music, twirling Autumn around him. The music switched up, and my mouth dropped open in shock as I watched him.

I looked at Aleksandr sitting across from me. "Did you know he could *salsa*?" I breathed out, still unwilling to believe what my eyes were seeing.

The same look of shock on my face was mirrored on Aleksandr's. He shook his head slowly, his eyes as wide as saucers as he watched our father move his hips in time with Autumn, a genuine smile on his face.

"I can't remember the last time I've seen him so...so—"

“Happy,” Nikolai finished, a ghost of a smile playing on his lips.

Aleksandr nodded. “Yeah. Happy.”

“It’s been a long time,” Adrian commented. At 6’5 and built like a pro football player, he was a beast of a man. Originally my father’s main bodyguard, he’d been in our lives for as long as I could remember. He had short black hair, deep brown eyes, and a scar that ran through his left eye.

When Illayana and I were kids, we used to call him *Scar*, like from *The Lion King*. He’d hated it, but never stopped us. We’d always thought of him as our unofficial uncle, since our real one was a fucking asshole with a capital A.

“It’s nice to see,” Nikolai commented, his blue eyes following Autumn and Father around the dance floor. “I feared he would spend the rest of his life alone.”

“Me too,” Aleksandr grunted. The chair groaned underneath him as he shifted forward, placing his elbows on the table and clasping his hands together. “He deserves to be happy, and I’m glad he could find that again. Even if it *is* with someone who’s fucking crazy. Have you seen her kill list?”

My body shot up with excitement. “No. Who’s on it?”

“Some pretty impressive names. All I can say is I’m glad she’s on our fucking side. Otherwise, we would all be in serious trouble.” His eyes flicked to me. Held. Aleksandr didn’t have to say what he was thinking. My usually unreadable and stoic brother was focused solely on me, and that could only mean one thing.

“Don’t, Zander,” I warned.

“It’s not too late, Lukyan. You don’t have to go.” He was trying to talk me out of going to Russia—*again*—and my patience with the whole thing was about to fucking snap. “We can come up with another way.”

No. We couldn’t.

My grandfather’s most recent infraction was the final straw in a war that had been brewing between him and my father for years. There was no going back. Something had to be done, and *I* was going to be the one to do it.

I knew Aleksandr was only saying that because he wanted to protect me. He feared the unknown. Feared what might happen to me if I walked into the lion’s den without him.

Regardless of all that, I couldn’t deny the fact that it hurt.

It hurt because I knew that if it were Nikolai in my place, he wouldn't have been saying those things.

He trusted Nikolai. Had faith in Nikolai. *Believed* in Nikolai.

Me?

I was just the idiot class clown of the Bratva. I knew that was what they all thought of me. They made no attempt to hide it. And yes, in part, I was. But that wasn't *all* I was.

I was so much more.

But no one could see that.

That was why I was so determined to do it. To show them all that while, yes, I did enjoy fucking around and having fun, I could also be serious and mature when the occasion called for it.

Aleksandr must have sensed the inner turmoil I was going through because his eyes softened just a touch. "I just don't want anything to happen to you."

Again, a nice sentiment, but the lack of trust was really starting to grate on my fucking nerves.

A few replies came to mind. Thanking him for his concern despite the underlying insult in his words. Cussing him out. Brushing it off with a smile or a joke.

I went with one he would have expected of me.

One side of my lips hiked up into a playful smirk. "I'm your favorite, aren't I? No, no, no, don't deny it. It's okay. I know I'm everyone's favorite."

Aleksandr shook his head. "I'm serious, Lukyan. If Grandfather finds out you're trying to kill him, death will be a kindness compared to what he'll do to you."

"Then he won't find out." I shrugged lazily. "I can be sly."

Nikolai scoffed. "We know."

"Hey. I take offense to that tone."

"Oh, do you?" He flicked a french fry at me. It bounced off my chest. "Cry me a river."

I picked up the fry and popped it into my mouth. "You guys need to relax. I can handle it."

"I would relax if you stopped treating everything like it's a goddamn game," Aleksandr seethed. "One wrong word, one wrong move, and it's all over. Don't you get that?"

His words cut deeply, but I smiled regardless, pretending like it didn't hurt that he thought so little of me.

I opened my mouth to respond when Drea came bounding over, her face alight with happiness. She jumped on Aleksandr from behind, trying to wrap her arms around him, but they were too short to span the width of his body.

"Come dance!" she beckoned cheerfully, holding onto him.

Aleksandr rolled his eyes, but the smile dancing on his lips showed he wasn't actually annoyed or irritated by her antics. In fact, he secretly loved them. But he had that grumpy, stern persona to maintain, so he grunted and got to his feet, Drea clinging onto his back like a spider monkey. She threw her head back and laughed as Aleksandr made his way onto the dance floor, not even a hint of struggle in his movements from having her attached to his back like that.

"He's just worried about you." My gaze flicked to Nikolai. "If something happens, there'll be nothing we can do. We'll be too far away to help."

We were going around and around in circles. I could say, *everything will be fine, I can handle it*, a dozen times, but neither of them would believe it.

"How's Tatiana feeling? She's just about ready to pop soon, hm?"

The change of subject worked like a charm. Nikolai could never pass up the opportunity to talk about Tatiana or his unborn children. An expression filled with warmth and love took over his face in an instant.

"Her due date is only a few months away, and we've already got everything sorted. We've got the room next to ours all set up for the babies. We've got clothes, toys, wipes, nappies, formula in case Tatiana has trouble breastfeeding—"

"So basically the whole store then?"

Nikolai chuckled. "Basically." He grew quiet. Pensive. "You'll come back when they're born, won't you?"

It was a double-edged question. He wasn't just asking if I'd be back in time. He was asking if I'd be back *at all*. If I would live long enough to meet my niece and nephew.

I sat up a little straighter in my chair and locked eyes with him, pouring every ounce of honesty and conviction into my next words. "I'll be here," I promised.

He searched my eyes for something. What, I couldn't say, but he eventually nodded, seeming satisfied.

Conversation broke out around the table. People came and went. Eventually, Tatiana managed to wrangle Nikolai up for another round on the dance floor, much to his protest. Father and Autumn took a break, coming over to join Adrian and me, and we all sat in comfortable silence for a while, eating and just enjoying each other's presence for a while until Father spoke.

"Are you ready?"

I glanced up from my plate at his deep, baritone voice. He was leaning comfortably in his chair, elbows resting on the back of it, while a finger twirled absently with a lock of Autumn's fiery hair.

I couldn't lie. It was a little weird seeing him with her. Mainly because I hadn't seen him like that in so long. I'd actually forgotten what he looked like when he was happy. What he looked like when he smiled. The sound of his laughter.

Autumn had brought that side of him back to life, and for that, my siblings and I would always be indebted to her.

"I'm ready," I answered, steel layering in my voice.

I was more than fucking ready. My grandfather had fucked with us for the last time. The fact that *I* got to be the one to end that old fucker's life made it all the more sweeter.

"You remember the plan?" he asked, a frown on his face, eyes firmly on Autumn as she shoveled food into her mouth.

"Yep. Etched into my noggin." I tapped a finger against my temple twice.

"Do you think"—Autumn's words were cut off with a loud, abrupt *slurp* as she sucked a long piece of egg noodle past her lips—"Sergei will suspect you?" she mumbled, her lips smacking loudly as she chewed. My father's right eye began to twitch.

I bit my tongue to keep from laughing. "I doubt it. The man has said a total of three words to me in my whole life. 'Cut your hair'. It's the first and only thing he says to me when he sees me. He's very stuck in his outdated gender roles, and firmly believes that men shouldn't have long hair." I flicked my dark, thick, long locks over my shoulder and gave her a dazzling smile. "It's why I keep it long. To piss him off. And...because...well...the chicks love it." I winked.

Father kicked my shin underneath the table, and I winced.

Of course, he *knew* there was absolutely no chance of anything happening between Autumn and me, but he didn't like it when anyone flirted with her. Fuck, he didn't like it when another man so much as *looked* at her. Even the soldiers around the house would avert their gazes whenever she walked past so as not to gain my father's angry attention. He was as territorial as a wild animal.

Sometimes, I just did it to piss him off because it was funny watching his right eye twitch like that. A year before, I never would have dreamed of pissing him off intentionally. Otherwise, I would have found myself in the ring with him, and that was a place one did *not* want to be.

But Autumn had softened him. Opened up his heart again. And in doing so, she had made him see the fun side of life again.

Autumn dunked a fry into some gravy and put it into her mouth, slurping it off her fingers.

"There's a knife and fork right beside you," my father gritted out behind clenched teeth. Although he seemed annoyed by Autumn's eating habits, I didn't think he was *as* irritated as he was trying to pretend to be—he was still twirling that loose strand of hair around his fingers, even as he glared at the back of her head.

I hid my smirk behind my hand. *Oh, this is just too good.*

"Is there? Huh." She continued to dump the fries into the gravy as if my father hadn't spoken at all.

I could hear his jaw grinding from across the table.

"Your grandfather will be suspicious of me," he continued, throwing her one more scowl she couldn't see before focusing entirely on me. There was a stiffness in his shoulders that I suspected was because of what we were discussing, and not Autumn's abhorrent, albeit hilarious, eating habits. "He will most likely have me followed very closely, so I can have no part in this. You must do it on your own. But I will watch and have your back."

"I know." A thought plagued my mind, and my father, being the annoyingly observant man he was, saw it instantly.

His brows creased together slightly before he stopped playing with Autumn's hair and moved closer, placing his elbows on the table. "What's troubling you?" Father asked, voice soft. He leaned forward, his entire focus on me, and I couldn't lie...It was unsettling as fuck.

It wasn't like my father ignored me, but up until recently, he hadn't really taken me seriously either. The same went for my siblings, except their views on me hadn't changed like my father's had.

It was *that* fight that did it.

Although, "fight" wouldn't really be the correct word for it, I supposed.

I'd made a joke. A stupid, inappropriate joke like I always did. But that time, it had come back and bitten me right in the ass.

We could all see how much Father cared for Autumn, but he hadn't been ready to see or admit it himself. So, when I'd called Autumn his *girlfriend*, he snapped. Threw me up against the wall by my throat and almost made me pass out.

That wasn't what hurt the most, though. Physical injuries were second nature to me, and occurred almost daily, thanks to rigorous training and normal Bratva shit.

It had been his words.

"*Why do you have to say every **stupid thing** that pops into your head?*"

"*Why couldn't you for once—**just for once**—keep your mouth shut?*"

His words had cut deeper than any blade. Hurt more than any gunshot wound I'd endured before.

My humor wasn't a mask. An act I put on. It was just...me. I *liked* to make people laugh. Everyone in my life was so fucking serious all the time. Not that I blamed them. We teetered on the edge of life and death every goddamn day. That required being serious sometimes.

But if your life was filled with nothing but serious moments, you weren't really *enjoying* your life, were you?

So, yeah, I fucked around a lot. Cracked jokes at inappropriate times to make people smile and forget their own shit for a moment. If *I* didn't do it, who the fuck else was going to?

It'd been a mistake, though. My words had triggered an avalanche of guilt inside my father, and he'd crumbled under the pressure of it. He'd hurt me. Hurt Autumn. Not physically, but mentally. Emotionally. And in some ways, that could be just as damaging.

Although Father had apologized, sincerely and numerous times, his words had stuck with me, weighing me down like an anchor in the ocean, no matter how many times he'd told me he was sorry.

KNOCK, knock.

From my bed, I rolled my head lazily to look at the door. Darkness surrounded me. I didn't feel like talking. I didn't feel like moving. I just wanted everyone to leave me alone and let me sleep.

That feeling...that aching sadness in my soul...I had never experienced anything like it before. I knew what the cause was. My father's words rang through my head on repeat every minute, every second, making it impossible to focus on anything else. There was no stopping it.

My heart hurt, and I couldn't stop tears from building behind my eyes. I knew my humor was a lot to handle. That I was a lot to handle. But never in my wildest dreams did I ever think my father would snap like that. Would hate me so much that he would pin me to the wall and almost make me pass out from choking me.

I wondered why I was like that.

Why I couldn't just be normal. Why I couldn't be more like Aleksandr, strong and dependable. Or like Nikolai, smart and cunning. They would never fuck up like me. They would never let the family down.

And yet, that was all I seemed to do.

All I could do.

I hated it.

I hated...myself.

Knock, knock.

I couldn't find the strength to get up. Maybe, if I just said nothing, if I didn't answer the door, they would just go away.

A sliver of light cut through the room when the door opened slowly. I recognized the shape instantly. It was my father.

"Lukyan?" he asked tentatively.

He was the last person I wanted to see.

I made myself get up. It felt like my body weighed a thousand pounds. Like my limbs were stuck in jello. Like gravity was trying its damndest to keep me down.

"Father." My voice didn't sound like my own. I didn't feel like myself. I felt...empty.

He went to turn the light on.

"Please, don't." I didn't want him to see the tears. Didn't want him to think I was weak. Plus, I couldn't explain it, but I needed the darkness. The darkness felt like my only friend.

He nodded and stepped further into the room. "Lukyan, I—" His words cut off with a choke. I wasn't sure why. I wasn't looking at him. My eyes remained plastered to the floor. Fear almost consumed me. Not fear for my life. Fear that the same look of disgust would still be on his face.

His arms encircled me instantly. "I'm so sorry."

I blinked. My head remained lowered, that feeling of worthlessness still coursing through my bones. I was floored that he'd just apologized. I couldn't work out why that didn't make me feel better. It should have, shouldn't it?

He squeezed me tighter. "I'm so, so sorry, **moy syn, my son**. I was wrong. I was way out of line. I should have never said those things to you. Never should have laid my hands on you like that. I'm so sorry."

It sounded like he was crying. But that couldn't be right. Father never cried. And I doubted the first time would be over me.

"Please," he begged. "Talk to me. Say something."

"It's okay." It wasn't. But he said to say something, so I did. The pain was still there, cutting deeper and deeper into my soul. Emptiness filled me.

"No, it's not. What I did and what I said was definitely **not** okay." He moved back and gripped me by the shoulders. "Look at me."

I did. Following his orders was second nature to me, ingrained into my bones. Even when my brain felt as foggy as it did, my body knew to follow his orders.

Father's eyes were glassy, his face filled with sadness. "**Moy syn.**" **My son**, he said in anguish. "What have I done to you?"

"I'm fine," I responded, my voice monotone.

He shook his head. "No. You're not. I didn't mean it, Lukyan. I didn't mean any of it. I was completely out of line. Please. Forgive me."

"I forgive you."

I did. Everything he'd said was true. I couldn't be angry at him for telling the truth, could I?

He made a sound in the back of his throat that was full of pain and misery. He apologized again and again. Over and over and over. He told me he loved my light. Loved my spirit. Loved how I was unashamed to be myself.

It went in one ear and out the other.

I FEARED I would never come out of it. That the darkness would surround me forever. Then, my father did something he'd never done before. He'd trusted me to do something *important*. Something detrimental to our survival. And it had sparked me back to life.

"Lukyan," Father prompted. My eyes snapped to him. "What is troubling you?" he asked again, a little sterner.

I hadn't even realized that I'd allowed myself to get swallowed up by my thoughts. I cleared my throat and straightened my spine. "You don't think it's a little weird? I mean, Grandfather had people trying to kill you every single week. Sometimes twice a week. And now...nothing. It's been over a month since the last attempt. That's strange, isn't it?"

Father frowned, his expression thoughtful. "With your wedding to Anya Tarasova so close, I think he's just being cautious. He can't afford for this deal to go south. I don't think he's given up, by any means. I think he's just waiting for the best moment to try again."

While what he said made sense in theory, there was something still bugging me. Something that just wasn't sitting right with me about the whole thing.

"You don't agree?" he asked, cocking his head.

"I think he's leading us into a false sense of security and plans to attack when we least expect it. Like when we land in Russia. Or on the plane. Or the night before we leave."

His eyes widened slightly, which, for my father, was the equivalent of him passing out from shock. "I never considered that."

"It's a smart move," Adrian added, his dark brows creased with worry. "Something *you'd* do yourself."

"I would," Father acknowledged with a slow tilt of his head. He leaned back in his chair and raised his arm, signaling for one of the men on security patrol.

Yakov nodded and shifted in his direction to come toward us. He was a cool dude. One of the men who'd come over from Russia to help replenish our numbers after Dominik's attack.

We'd spent some time together. Sparring. Talking shit. Cracking jokes. I wouldn't say I knew him exceptionally well, but I *did* know him well enough to know something wasn't quite right about him.

I ran my eyes up and down his large, muscular frame. Dressed in smart casual black slacks and a black button-down shirt, he fit in easily—as if he

were just another guest and not security. The harness strapped to his chest, filled with two handguns, was the only thing to give him away.

Yakov stopped on my father's right side, bowing his head. "Sir?"

"I want an increase of patrols around the house for the next forty-eight hours. No one in or out of the estate. Double-manned gate shifts. Someone on video surveillance twenty-four hours a day."

Yakov nodded. "Yes, sir." He turned to walk away and then stopped. A chill ran down my spine at the same time as I saw a flash of silver. He *moved*.

"Watch out!"

The words had barely left my mouth when Autumn snapped into action, her hand whipping out fast as fucking lightning to grab Yakov by the wrist. Eyes wide in shock, Father looked down at the blade an inch away from piercing his throat and then back up at Yakov, betrayal deep in his rageful gaze.

Autumn yanked Yakov toward her at the same time she picked up the knife beside her plate and rammed it straight through his ear, right down to the hilt. Yakov made a sound that was a cross between a scream and a whimper before his entire body went slack, collapsing on the table.

She went right back to eating like nothing happened, shoving a handful of crackle into her mouth, the loud *crunch, crunch, crunch* echoing around us.

"Oh, fuck. Crackle is so good. Mm. I *need* the recipe for this," she mumbled in between bites, totally casual, like she hadn't just run a sharp instrument through someone's brain.

Father blinked slowly and ran a hand down his front. "You can't cook."

"I can too," she snapped, affronted.

"Two-minute noodles don't count as cooking."

"Well, *you* can make them *yourself* next time," she snapped.

They began to argue with each other. Not in an angry or aggressive way, but in a fun, *picking on each other* kind of way. After being around them for a few months, it was easy to see that they *liked* arguing. They *liked* riling each other up. It was like some sort of sick, twisted form of foreplay for them. I knew that because, shortly after their bickering, they would *always* disappear, and wouldn't come back for hours.

I looked around the yard, noting the fact that no one apart from the people at our table seemed to have noticed what just happened.

Autumn had killed Yakov so quickly and so effectively that none of the guests had even noticed.

My gaze swept through them all, one person after the next. Nothing. Not even a glance in our general direction. It was because I was looking around that I saw Denis, another of our soldiers, with his machine gun pointed at my father's head.

I was moving before I'd even fully processed what was happening, leaping across the table and tackling him out of the way as a stream of bullets hit the air. Autumn was quick to respond, spinning around in her chair to throw a knife at Denis, but it didn't matter. Half a dozen men—*our men*, men who were meant to protect us, watch out for us, lay down their lives for us—turned on us, all of them aiming their weapons at my father.

Chaos ensued. Time seemed to slow down as numerous things happened at once. People screamed, running in all directions the moment bullets started flying. Adrian picked up the table like it weighed nothing at all and slammed it down in front of us to act as a shield. Nikolai grabbed Tatiana and held her close, tucking her head into his chest and shielding her with his arm as he shoved people out of the way, trying to get her and their unborn children to safety.

Aleksandr and Drea went on the offensive, attacking the men. Illayana, Arturo, and Vincenzo grabbed Theodora and Lucian, making a run for the warehouse, knocking out whoever they needed to to get those kids to safety.

Time snapped back along with a rush of sound that had me covering my ears. Adrian was crouched on one knee to my left, using the table for support as he fired at our attackers. Autumn dropped down at my right, facing behind us. She'd somehow acquired a machine gun. How or from whom, I had no idea.

She let loose a stream of bullets, guarding our six.

"Get off me," Father grunted. Holes ripped into the table, shredding the wood like paper just as he went to get up.

I pushed him back down with a rough shove to his shoulder. "Stay down, you idiot. We're in a vulnerable position. We need to stay behind cover." I pulled out a gun, peeked over the table, took aim, and fired. One of our *ex*-soldiers went down like a house of cards. "Ten points, motherfucker," I growled under my breath. "Sorry for calling you an idiot," I threw to my father as I continued to fire. "You know, heat of the moment kinda thing. You understand—"

A flash of red caught my attention. I pulled my hand away from the gun, staring at my blood-soaked palm in shock.

What the fuck?

I looked down at my father. His eyes were closed, a giant red patch spreading out across his shirt from his shoulder. I froze, staring at it. A cold tremor ran through my body, and I couldn't move. Couldn't think. Couldn't do anything but stare in shock as blood seeped out of my father's body.

Autumn gasped. "Put pressure on it!" she barked.

I snapped into action, dropping my gun and lurching forward. My hands slammed down on his shoulder. He groaned.

That was good. Groaning was good. Meant he was still alive.

"Is there an exit wound?" Autumn asked in between shots.

"How the fuck should I know?" I growled.

"Turn him over," Adrian grunted, blocking a high kick to his own head with his forearm. He pulled a knife from the holster at his waist and jammed it into the dude's eye.

"Right. Turn him over," I said to myself. My hands shook as I rolled my father over to his side. "It's through and through." I breathed out with relief.

Any bullet wound was bad news, but what the projectile hit or passed through would determine the survival rate. If the bullet hit nothing of significance, my father's chances of survival would increase dramatically.

Panic clutched me in its claws. It wasn't very often that I felt panic. Not to toot my own horn, but I was pretty fucking resilient. Blood, violence, and death had been a part of my life for as long as I could remember. I'd grown accustomed to them. Numb to it all. Nothing really affected me anymore.

I really only had three triggers.

Sexual assault—anyone who had to force themselves onto another person was just fucking vile.

Hurting children—they were sweet, innocent, absolutely pure-hearted, and deserved to be protected at all costs. Anyone who harmed a child was a fucking coward.

And hurting my family—they might have been a bunch of idiots, and annoyed me most of the time, but they were *my* idiots. Only *I* was allowed to fuck with them.

Seeing my father like that, unconscious and bleeding out right in front of me, was something I never thought I'd see.

But I didn't have the time to dwell on it. I needed to—

Pull yourself together!

I slapped myself across the face. The slight sting of pain knocked me out of my panicked daze.

Autumn blinked. "The fuck was that?"

"Factory reset." Keeping one hand on my father's wound, I whipped out my phone with the other and opened the WhatsApp group chat, diving straight into it.

Aleksandr and Drea appeared, bloody and out of breath. Anger radiated from the king and queen of the Bratva, so palpable it stifled the fucking air. Their clothes were covered in blood, some even dripping down the sides of their faces.

I thought that anger was because we'd just been attacked by our own men, but my brother directed it right at me.

"Are you *seriously* on your phone right now?" he hissed.

Glaring, I showed him the screen. "I'm calling in all the docs on our payroll. Unless *you've* already done that?" I asked, arching a condescending eyebrow because I fucking *knew* he hadn't.

He held up the bloodstained knife in his hands. "I've been a little busy."

"Me too." I gestured down with a tilt of my head.

Aleksandr's eyes widened. Drea gasped.

"Fuck! What happened?!"

"Shot by one of those fuckers over there," I snarled. "Is the situation handled?"

Aleksandr's gaze did a lap of the yard.

Pure. Carnage.

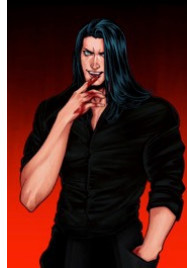
Tables were overturned. Food was strewn everywhere. Bodies littered the ground. Since it had been our own men who attacked us, I couldn't tell if the dead were friends or foe, but there were a lot of them.

My gaze clashed with Aleksandr's, the anger burning in his eyes mirrored in my own.

"Fucking Grandfather," we both growled.

CHAPTER FIVE

LUKYAN VOLKOV



“Can we not throw one goddamn party without someone trying to fucking kill us?!” my father roared, thumping a closed fist down onto the table. He immediately winced, clutching his injured shoulder.

The doctor standing over him watched with fearful eyes, licking his dry lips nervously. “Sir, please, try to stay still.”

“Fucking Sergei!” he spat. “I’m going to kill him. I’m going to fucking *kill him*. I’m going to strangle him, nice and slow, and then cut out his tongue and shove it down his fucking throat.” He went off on a tangent, switching to Russian as he continued to threaten and cuss out Grandfather like a drunken sailor.

The doctor glanced around the room, looking for help. He couldn’t treat my father’s wound until he calmed down—something I didn’t think was going to happen anytime soon.

My siblings and I all avoided eye contact with the man.

Spread out around the kitchen in our home, we all sported our own injuries—nothing too severe, thank God. Illayana and Arturo were sitting next to each other at the dining table opposite the kitchen island. Aleksandr was leaning back on one of the barstools, Drea right beside him, holding a bloody bandage to his head. Tatiana was seated in one of the armchairs Nikolai had dragged in from the lounge room, my brother behind her, massaging her shoulders. Autumn was standing next to the doctor, hands on her hips, a cross look on her face. And I was lounging back in one of the

chairs in front of the dining table, my body relaxed but my mind hyperfocused.

Several maids were working hard, cooking up a feast and trying their best to get us all to eat and drink something. The kitchen was a hive of activity, everyone unsure what to do with themselves now that the battle was over.

Father was still going off.

Wow. He was *really* fucking pissed. I'd seen him rant before, but this... this was next-level.

And we all knew better than to interrupt him when he was like that.

He would run out of steam eventually. We just had to wait him out.

When Father got to his feet in a huff as if he was about to go and hunt down my grandfather right there and then, the doctor panicked, his eyes widening.

"Sir, sit down. Please. You're in no condition—"

"I'm *fine*," Father barked, taking a step forward.

"Sit. Down," Autumn ordered, voice like ice.

Father hesitated, freezing on the spot. He licked his lips, and for the first time in my life, I saw nervousness skate across his features. "Autumn—"

She did nothing but narrow her eyes in warning.

Father collapsed back into his chair with an angry growl.

"You can grumble all you want, but your ass better not leave that chair again until the doctor is finished."

Father grunted in acceptance.

Autumn looked at the doctor. "Go ahead."

"Thank you, Miss DeValos." Frederick pulled out a pair of surgical scissors from his medical bag and, with slightly shaky hands, cut my father's shirt off his body. Blood stained Father's skin, running down his torso.

As the doctor began to patch him up, Aleksandr took control of the meeting. "How many did we lose?"

Nikolai's expression turned grim. "If we're including the men who betrayed us, eleven soldiers and six family members."

"We're *not* including those fuckers as part of our losses," Drea spat.

"Five soldiers then," Nikolai amended.

That's not too bad, I guess. Could have been worse. Much, much worse.

Aleksandr cursed. With a light touch, he pushed the bandage Drea held to his forehead away. Fury shone in his eyes. “We’ll have to notify the next of kin and begin the compensation payments.”

Every soldier who worked for us not only got paid a wage—a pretty fucking good one, if you asked me—but they also got a compensation package. Money that could be paid to anyone they designated if the worst should happen and they died in service to the Bratva. It was a way for them to know their loved ones would be cared for in the event of their deaths.

I opened my mouth to tell him I could do it, but Nikolai beat me to it.

“I’ll handle it.”

My mouth snapped shut, a sliver of annoyance cutting through me.

“Do we know what happened yet?” Arturo asked, his face a mask of anger and frustration.

“Based on the men who double-crossed us, I’d say it’s pretty obvious, don’t you think?” I said, answering Arturo’s question.

Everybody turned to look at me.

“What are you talking about?” Ilayana asked. She wouldn’t know because she lived in New York, but the others would.

“All of the soldiers who attacked us were part of the group sent over from Russia to help replenish our numbers after Dominik’s attack.” When no one said anything, I added, “From Sergei.”

Duh.

Father cursed.

“Impossible.” Aleksandr frowned, though I could tell he was starting to put the pieces together. “I vetted those soldiers myself. I interviewed every single one of them, and there was not a single trace of deceit or ill intentions from them. Sergei might have sent them to us, but they had no love for him.”

“How sure are you that they *all* were a part of the group sent over from Sergei?” Nikolai questioned.

“Mark Karamazov, Isaak Rostov, Yakov Agapov, Nazar Grigoriev, Denis Kirov, and Mishka Orlova,” I rattled off their names as I pulled a metal case from my pocket and opened it, plucking out a joint. I lit it up. “Mark, twenty-seven years old. Star tattoo on his neck. He had a slight lisp when he talked, hated cilantro, and couldn’t dribble a basketball worth a damn. Isaak had a wife and three children back in Russia. He was glad to leave them. Thought it gave him free reign to fuck as many women as he

wanted here without his wife finding out. I never liked him, but he made a mean *borscht*. Now, Yakov, he couldn't cook. Like, he was really fucking bad. I think the dude burned water one time. I didn't even know that was possible. But you know what he *was* good at? Tic-tac-toe. That squirrely little fucker beat me *every. Single. Time.*"

I took a deep drag from the joint, holding it in my lungs for a beat before exhaling, blowing out three perfect rings that drifted up into the air.

"Nazar was a snake. Didn't trust him as far as I could throw him. And you know why? Because he didn't like music. What kind of person doesn't like *music*? I'll tell you who. Psychopaths. That's who," I said, pointing the joint aggressively at no one in particular. "Denis was a cool dude. I actually kinda liked him, but he'd always check out Drea's ass whenever she walked past, and that's a big no-no—"

"He *what*?!" Aleksandr roared.

"Shh," I whispered, holding a finger to my lips. "I'm in the middle of a tangent, and you *never* interrupt someone when they're in the middle of a tangent. It's rude. Now, where was I? Oh, yeah. Lastly, Mishka. There wasn't anything *technically* wrong with her, except for the fact that she didn't think I was attractive, which, now that I think about it, should have been a massive red flag right from the get-go." I frowned, then shook away the thought. "Anyway, if that still isn't enough proof for you that I knew them, you can check their personal files. They're organized alphabetically by last name in the archives room because I'm not a lunatic, and no matter what anyone says, alphabetically by their last name is the correct and *only* way to organize files."

It was at that exact moment that Flora placed a platter-sized plate in front of me. My mouth salivated.

"Mmm. Mini burgers. *Yum.*" I groaned. I put out my joint and dove right in.

I was about halfway through my third one when I noticed how quiet the room had gotten. Looking up, my mouth overflowing with food, I glanced around.

Everyone was looking at me with surprised, wide-eyed expressions, like they'd been stunned into complete silence.

Well, everyone except my father. He had the beginnings of a knowing smirk on his lips, eyes alight with glee. If I had to pick a saying for that particular expression, it'd have to be, *that's my boy.*

But maybe that was just wishful thinking. What I *hoped* he was thinking.

“What?” I mumbled. “Do I have food on my face or something?” I wiped my lips with the back of my hand. *Nothing*.

“How...how did you do that?” Arturo asked, bewilderment in his voice.

“Do what, Arty?” I reached across the table and plucked a few fries from a bowl Flora had placed down, shoveling them into my mouth.

“You just spouted off a bunch of random facts about some soldiers like you were reading a goddamn grocery list. How did you remember all of that?”

I shrugged. “I pay attention.” *Despite what you all think*.

“Why would they do this?” Aleksandr asked no one in particular. “They were here for over six months, with no indication they were under Sergei’s control. What changed?”

“They could have been sleepers,” I suggested in between bites. “You know, planted within our ranks with the distinct purpose of gaining our trust so that when we least expected it, they could attack and catch us completely off guard. Grandfather must have gotten fed up with the failed attempts from all those fancy assassins, and in a last-ditch effort to get what he wanted—our darling father’s imminent demise—he activated his sleeper soldiers and told them to kill him.”

I’d been thinking about it a lot since the whole thing went down. He could have left those sleeper soldiers in our ranks for *years*, only telling them to act when he desperately needed them to. I had a feeling that, in his mind, he had firmly believed his bounty on my father would have been more than enough to entice the best assassins in the world to end his life. Then, with Father gone and Aleksandr in charge, Grandfather could keep his sleepers in our ranks and have them monitoring our every move and reporting back to him. Like little fucking spies.

Illayana thumped the side of her closed fist down onto the table. “That old fucking bastard,” she growled. “He not only put a hit out on Father, but he ruined your going-away party! I say *fuck him*. Let him find someone else to marry Anya Tarasova. We shouldn’t lift a goddamn finger to help him.”

Aleksandr, Nikolai, Father, and I all exchanged an awkward look with one another.

Illayana didn’t know the real—well, the *only*—reason the marriage with Anya was going through. She didn’t know Grandfather had threatened her.

Forced us into it. Hadn't given us any choice in the matter.

Her spine snapped straight. She narrowed her eyes in suspicion. "What?" she asked, looking between us.

"What, what?" I held up one of my mini burgers, offering it to her in an attempt to distract her. "Have you tried these? They're orgasmic—"

She slapped it out of my hand.

I gasped. "Illayana!"

"You lot just shared a *look*. What was it for?"

"I don't know what you're talking about." Aleksandr cleared his throat, sitting up a little straighter. "Now, we need to—"

Three.

"—come up with—"

Two.

"—some sort of—"

One.

The sound of a chair scraping across the ground echoed throughout the kitchen, like nails on a chalkboard. Illayana stood, hands placed firmly on the table in front of her, a dark, murderous look in her eyes.

"That's *bullshit*," she hissed. "You guys are hiding something. I know that look. It's your *don't tell Illayana* look."

"Paranoid much," I scoffed under my breath, even though she was totally right.

"What was that?" she snapped.

"Nothing. Jeez. Someone's moody today." A thought streaked through my head, and I whipped out my phone, checking my calendar. "Oh, no."

"What? What is it?" Nikolai asked instantly, his face a mask of concern.

I swallowed nervously. "The Red Dragon," I whispered, my voice trembling with fear.

Autumn's brows slammed down into a frown. "The Red Dragon? Who's that? I've never heard of that assassin before."

"It's not an assassin. It's what they call me when I'm on my period. And I know what you're trying to do. It's not going to work. Unlike you, I've matured and can put my anger to the side." *Um, fucking rude.* "What aren't you guys telling me?"

I slumped in my chair. "You're no fun anymore. What happened to the reckless Illayana? The fun Illayana? The Illayana who would shoot first before calming down?"

“She grew up. Maybe you should try it sometime,” she bit back.

“Ouch. And uncalled for.”

“Enough,” Aleksandr barked. He rubbed his forehead, a slight grimace on his face. He glanced at Father. Neither of them said anything. They just stared at each other, but I *knew* that stare held mountains of words none of us could decipher. They were having some sort of silent conversation the rest of us were not privy to.

Father nodded ever so slightly—barely a movement of the head—but it was clear he was giving his blessing for something.

Not that Aleksandr *needed* it. He was *Pakhan*. He could do whatever he damn well pleased. He could order our father to strip naked and do the Macarena if he wanted. Not that Father would do it, but you get the gist.

Aleksandr sighed. Drea rubbed his back supportively. He locked eyes with Illayana. Tension hung in the air.

Oh, she isn't going to like this.

“Grandfather made it very clear,” Aleksandr began slowly, picking his words very carefully. “Either one of us marry Anya Tarasova, or something bad will happen to you.”

Up until that point, Arturo had sat calmly at Illayana's side, not overly engaging in conversation except for a few comments and questions here and there. But at Aleksandr's words, he snapped right into focus, like a snake coiled to strike.

A myriad of emotions streaked across Illayana's face, as easy to read as a book. Shock. Confusion. Anger.

Guilt.

The guilt held as her gaze moved to me. “It's because of me?” she asked softly.

I liked to rouse on her a lot. Pick on her and make fun of her. But it was all in good fun. No big brother *really* wanted to see their little sister hurt. Or...God forbid...cry.

I eased the situation with a joke that held a smidgen of the truth. “Let's be realistic here. This is probably the only way I'll ever get married anyway. I'm pretty sure I was destined to go down the bachelor route otherwise.”

Her face scrunched up. She didn't like the idea that I was being forced into something I didn't want to do because of her. I couldn't really blame Illayana. I'd have felt the same way if our situations were reversed.

That slightly vulnerable look disappeared, replaced with a burning anger that threatened to set the room ablaze. “*Fuck. That,*” she snarled. “Your someone is out there, Lukyan. You shouldn’t have to give up your life because our bastard of a grandfather said so.”

I was pretty sure I’d already met her.

“What are you doing about this?” Arturo asked Aleksandr roughly. “You just going to sit there and allow that man to threaten your sister? *My wife?*”

Aleksandr sat up that little bit straighter and stared Arturo down, a heavy cloud of darkness surrounding him. Arturo stared back, unintimidated.

They were like two apex predators, locked in an intense battle where the loser had every chance of catching a bullet to the head.

I leaned toward Nikolai. “Care for a wager? I think Aleksandr will kick his ass,” I whispered, shaking a \$100 bill in the air.

“Shut up, Lukyan,” Illayana snapped.

I poked my tongue out at her. “*You* shut up.”

Drea laid a hand on Aleksandr’s shoulder. Calmness seemed to wash over him right before our eyes. He ran his tongue over his top front teeth. “What I am doing,” he began, calm but cold, “is sending my youngest brother halfway around the world to kill him.”

I clicked my fingers on both hands as I shaped them into guns, pointing them at Arturo while pumping my eyebrows up and down and clicking my tongue. “That’s me.”

He gave me a deadpan look before turning back to Aleksandr. “No offense, but that’s not good enough.”

“Um, offense fucking taken,” I snapped back.

“Lukyan, be quiet,” Aleksandr ordered.

I did as he demanded, but under protest. I gave Arturo a scolding glare so the fucker knew it wasn’t over.

“I want something done *now*,” Arturo continued. “Nobody threatens the future mother of my children and lives.”

Illayana stared at him, making lovey-dovey eyes. I stuck a finger down my throat and gagged. She scowled at me.

“I have someone,” Arturo said, completely oblivious to Illayana and me. “He’s quick. Efficient. Lethal and discreet—”

“*No offense*,” I mocked, giddy that I got to throw those words back in his stupid face, “but it doesn’t matter how good your guy is. Grandfather’s

complex is locked up tighter than Area 51. And don't give me any bullshit about Area 51 not being real. It is. Did you see the government just released confirmation they've been in contact with extraterrestrial beings—"

"Lukyannnnn," Father, Aleksandr, and Nikolai dragged out with collective sighs.

"Okay, okay, fine. We'll circle back to that. The point is, *no one* can get close to the man unless he *wants* you to. He's got twelve-foot concrete walls surrounding the entire complex. Motion detectors. 360-degree cameras. Round-the-clock manned sniper towers. He travels with a twelve-guard team in a state-of-the-art SUV with tinted, bulletproof windows and bulletproof tires. The only way to get to him is with a small army. Or for him to let you right through the front door." I leaned back in my chair and spread my arms out wide, giving a dazzling smile. "That would be me."

"You guys can't still seriously be considering this," Illayana interjected, her gaze whipping around the room. "I understand why you *initially* agreed to it, but we shouldn't be doing a goddamn thing for that man. Let him try to send someone after me. Let him fucking try."

Arturo's jaw clenched. He said nothing, even though it was clear he wanted to. It looked like he'd learned from past mistakes.

"It's a means to an end," Drea tried to reason. "By agreeing, it gives Lukyan, your father, and Autumn a way into his complex. It gives them an opportunity they would never be afforded under normal circumstances. An opportunity to get up close and personal with Sergei without arousing suspicion."

"But he *will* be suspicious. Am I the only one who can see that? He tried to force Autumn to kill Father. And when she didn't, Grandfather sent assassins after him instead. He will have heard from his spies that they're together. Any reasonably intelligent person would assume that meant Autumn *told* Father he was trying to have him killed. What's to stop Grandfather from killing them all the minute they step through his gates?" Illayana argued.

"We've been over this a dozen times," Nikolai stressed, rubbing his temples.

"Well, I want to go over it *again*."

"Yes, Princess. Anything you say, Princess," I droned.

Illayana didn't rise to the bait, but she gave me a scathing look that promised retribution. She hated being called *Princess*. Her hands moved to

her hips, and she stared the lot of us down. “Make it make sense because right now, the only outcome I can envision is Grandfather ordering his men to shoot Autumn and Father on sight, then holding Lukyan against his will and forcing him down that aisle to marry Anya.”

“That’s actually a pretty good plan,” I admitted. Everyone looked at me, their features somewhat exasperated. “What?” I exclaimed. “It is!”

“I don’t think that will happen, Illayana.” Autumn’s voice was soft. Kind. Understanding.

The doctor finally stopped dressing Father’s wound, and he leaned back, releasing a sigh. “I agree,” Father began. “Sergei may want to kill me, but there’s something he wants—*needs*—more. And that’s to save face. His reputation is the most important thing in the world to him. He’s spent his life cultivating it. Shaping it into exactly what he wants. He’ll achieve only one of two things by killing me in his home, and both options would shatter that reputation.”

Arturo cocked his head. “What are they?”

Autumn picked up a glass of water from the kitchen counter and took a sip. Before she could put it back down, Father grabbed that same glass from the bottom and downed the rest of the liquid.

“Rumors would circulate if I died on his grounds. You know how the organized crime world *loves* to gossip. Like a bunch of teenage girls in the schoolyard. They would assume one of two things. Someone managed to circumvent Sergei’s impenetrable security, break in, and kill me. That would be a bad look for him. Would mean someone got the better of him. And if one person managed to best him, what is to stop others from doing the same thing? The other would be that Sergei ordered my death *himself*. Also a bad look for him. What reason would a father have to murder his own son? Betrayal. Lack of trust. Both of which imply a loss of control on his part. And if a man like Sergei can’t keep control of his own family, who is to say his empire is any better?”

Arturo frowned, his blue-green eyes critical. “That’s paranoid thinking.”

Father shrugged. “That’s the way Sergei’s mind operates. He’s a man obsessed with how others perceive him. Sergei doesn’t measure his validation in life by the number of possessions he owns or how much money he has. He gets it from how other people view him. What they think of him. That’s why, despite the fact that we’re currently at war with each

other right now, to the outsider's eye, it looks like our bond is stronger than ever. Only the family and his men will know otherwise."

"That's why he'll never withdraw his men," Aleksandr continued. "Although he's trying to have Father killed, Sergei could never withdraw his forces and the protection it provides because it would be perceived badly by others and leave us vulnerable."

"And if we look weak, *he* looks weak," Nikolai finished.

Something suddenly occurred to me, and it made me scoff at my grandfather's genius. "Fuck, even those failed assassination attempts work in his favor. Yeah, he's probably pissed no one has managed to do it yet, but think about it. The positive to that is we look bad-fucking-ass for having thwarted so many high-profile assassins."

"That's true," Illayana agreed.

"Hang on a second. So *your* men here are technically *his* men?" Although he was married to my sister, there were still some things Arturo was not privy to. Not necessarily because we didn't trust him, but just because our business was our business.

"Yes and no," Father answered. "Sergei originally sent me here to establish a Bratva base in the US. And yes, when we first moved, all the men were under his control, myself included. However, over the years, that control has shifted. *His* men became *my* men. And when we had losses, I oversaw the hiring of new soldiers who were strictly under *my* employ. Not Sergei's. He's only sent men to me on a few occasions—both when the losses were unprecedented."

"So those soldiers who attacked us just now—"

"Like Lukyan said, were the soldiers Sergei sent over after the raid Dominik orchestrated. *Sergei's men*. Not ours. There are thousands of families in the Bratva, both in Russia and here. Although they are Bratva, they may not be active soldiers. But they can be called upon whenever we are in need. The Bratva is generational. If someone's grandfather was a soldier, all his children and their children's children are Bratva. I am particular about who I hire. I do not believe in forcing someone to risk their life for me if they don't want to. I will present employment, and it is up to them if they wish to accept. Sergei, on the other hand, offers no such choice. You either work for him, or you die."

Arturo's fingers tapped lightly on the table. "That's what separates you guys from him."

Father nodded slightly. “There are many different ways to lead. By fear. By loyalty. Sergei chooses fear—”

“And you choose loyalty,” Arturo finished.

“Well...not me anymore.” Father looked at Aleksandr, and pride shone in his eyes at the son who had taken his place as leader of the Bratva.

As the conversation droned on, I slowly began to lose interest. Everything they were speaking about was already information I had in my pretty little noggin. I didn’t need a refresher. I did that myself every night before I went to sleep.

My grandfather was a dangerous man, and despite what everyone thought, I knew that. My father had a file loaded with every detail he could get about him, and when it was decided that *I* would be the one to kill him, he had given it to me to study.

And I did.

I studied that motherfucker harder than a teenage boy trying to learn how to put on a condom for the first time. And I came up with a plan to take him down—a plan I had yet to tell anyone about.

I glanced at my phone. Dozens of notifications littered the screen. Some from various social media platforms. A few emails. Several text messages.

Katie: I miss you 😞 When can I see you again?

HOW ABOUT NEVER? I didn’t do stage five clingers. Which was exactly what Katie was.

Evelyn: DTF?

No, thank you.

Christian: Do you think having red and itchy balls means I have an STD?

PROBABLY, you idiot.

Veronica: Attachment: 1 Image

I KNEW what it was without even having to open it, and it didn't interest me in the slightest.

Unknown: What's wrong, my love? You look sad.

I STIFFENED. *It's her.*

Excitement soared through me—so much so that it took all of my willpower to keep my body from shaking.

Conversation continued on around me, but I blocked it out as I focused on those seven little words that made me feel more alive than I'd ever felt before.

You look sad.

She was watching me. But from where?

Discreetly, I glanced around the kitchen. It had to be from a camera. All the blinds were closed, so she couldn't be looking in from the outside. There was only my family, two maids, and a soldier posted by the back door that led to the outside patio in the kitchen, so she definitely wasn't in the room.

The question was...where was the camera?

My phone buzzed with another text message.

Unknown: A little to the left.

I TURNED my head in that direction.

Unknown: A little more.

Unknown: Up a smidgen.

MY EYES LOCKED on a light fixture high on the far wall.

Unknown: Hi, my love.

USUALLY, an endearment like that would have sent me running for the hills. Women knew when we hooked up that it was nothing serious. Just a good time. I made that *very clear* with every woman I slept with, and always did my best to never lead anyone on. Most got the message and understood. Some hoped, after a little bit of time, that things might change. Feelings might emerge.

They never did—

“Lukyan!”

“Hmm?” My gaze snapped to my older brother. Brows lowered, he asked in a less-than-impressed tone, “Have you been paying attention at all?”

“Of course I have,” I answered, affronted. Even though, *technically*, my focus might have dropped over the past few minutes.

Fucking sue me.

Aleksandr folded his arms across his chest. “Oh, really? What just happened then?”

“You grunted. Nikolai said something sullen. Illayana bitched and moaned. And Father sat there rubbing his temples like his head was going to explode.”

Father sat up straighter, his hands dropping back down to the table, brows creased in a frown.

“That about cover it?”

Drea released a barking laugh.

Aleksandr scowled at her.

“What?” She chuckled. “He was pretty much dead on the money.”

Aleksandr grunted, and it made Drea burst into a fit of uncontrollable laughter, Autumn joining in.

Smile on my face, I stood up, stretching out my tired and aching body. “Well, if that’s all, ladies and gentlemen, I shall bid you adieu.”

“A—what?” Illayana frowned.

“It means goodbye in fancy French talk.” I straightened the lapels of my imaginary suit jacket. “I’m sophisticated now.”

Nikolai snorted. “Says who?”

“Whom,” I corrected with a wink.

“Um.” Autumn chuckled. “That’s not right.”

“It’s not?” I shrugged. “Oh, well.” My phone vibrated again. My fingers itched to check it, but I couldn’t. I had to play it cool. If my family knew I

was texting my stalker—the stalker I’d been expressly ordered to kill—well...they might have gotten a little angry.

“Gotta run.” I turned to leave when Father’s deep, authoritative voice halted me dead in my tracks.

“Stop.” I refrained from stomping my foot and whining like a toddler. Barely. “Turn.”

I put on my most dazzling smile and faced my father.

“Tomorrow is the last day before we leave for Russia. You’re not to leave the house. Understood?”

I nodded. “Understood.” I turned. Froze. Turned back. “Wait, why?”

Father stared at me for a beat. “Your stalker.” The *duh* was implied.

Keep. Cool.

“What about her?”

His lips thinned with displeasure. I could tell he didn’t like how blasé I was being about the whole thing.

“Every attempt to locate her or learn more about her identity has failed. I do not blame you. Her ability to break in and out of our home shows how skilled and cunning she is. But without that information, we cannot accurately anticipate her movements. Only assume. She’s a wild card, and we have no idea what she will do in the lead-up to your wedding.”

“Are you afraid she’ll kidnap me?” I joked.

“Yes,” he responded with a straight face.

A sliver of excitement cut through me at the mere idea of it. I highly doubted she would do something like that, though. Or that she would even be capable of pulling something like that off. She was crazy, but I didn’t think she was *that* crazy.

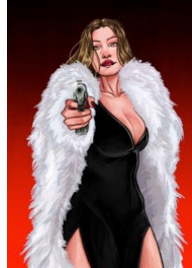
Still, the idea was...tantalizing.

I walked back toward the exit with a smirk dancing on my lips. “If she did, I’m pretty sure I would like it.”

“That’s what we’re afraid of!” someone yelled as I bolted from the kitchen.

CHAPTER SIX

LYLA



*This is crazy. **I'm** crazy. Seriously. Cuff me, take me to the loony bin, and throw away the damn key because only someone completely and utterly out of their mind would do something **this** idiotic.*

I'd done a lot of stupid shit in my life. I was the type of person who *liked* doing dangerous and reckless shit. It fueled me. Made life worth living, in my opinion. Death-defying stunts were kinda my forte. I was an adrenaline junkie at heart. Anything that got my heart rate up, my blood pumping, I was down for.

Bonus points if it could make my pussy tingle too.

But this?

This would go down in history as the stupidest thing I'd ever done... times a billion.

I was lying flat on my back, flicking through the numerous security feeds I had throughout the Volkov household as I tracked Lukyan moving from the kitchen to the stairs. Darkness surrounded me, the only light coming from the illumination of my phone screen.

It had taken all of my strength, all of my willpower not to burst into that kitchen and shoot everyone in the head for making my poor Lukyan so upset.

How could no one see how much their words and lack of faith hurt him? Were they all so accustomed to treating him that way that they were just blind to it?

I could see it, though, as clear as the night sky. That light he always had in his eyes had dimmed just the slightest bit, and I wanted to murder them

all.

I could kill them and not lose an ounce of sleep over it.

But I was well aware of how much he loved his family, and I was incapable of causing him such harm and heartbreak.

For the moment.

If it continued, though, I would take matters into my own hands regardless of the consequences.

No one hurt my Lukyan and lived to talk about it.

I listened to the entire conversation. They had all been sitting in the kitchen, talking about the aftermath of the attack from their own soldiers. I'd been watching from my usual spot when the whole thing went down. I could do nothing but watch on. Otherwise, I risked revealing myself to them.

If it had come to giving away my position or saving Lukyan, though, I would have done it in a heartbeat. Lucky for me, however, the whole thing had been over quite quickly, with not a single hair out of place on my beautiful Lukyan's head.

My phone vibrated, a text message appearing in the middle of the screen.

My Luky Bear: Who are you?

I SQUEAKED.

Oh my god.

He texted me back.

Excited, nervous energy burst throughout my entire body.

I wasn't sure if he would actually respond or not. He never had before. Granted, that was the first time I'd ever texted him, but still. My love letters had all remained unanswered. I just assumed the same would happen when I texted him too.

Keep it cool, Lyla.

I took a deep breath in, making myself count to five before typing out a response.

Me: Given the events of today, I am willing to forgo that transgression, my love. But never again. You know who I am. I am yours, and you are mine. Until death do us part.

LIGHT FOOTSTEPS ECHOED in the air, getting louder and louder with each passing second. I locked my phone and held my breath. A stream of light erupted into the room as the door opened. From my position under the bed, I could just make out a pair of black combat boots and long, lean legs clad in dark trousers.

I didn't even need to see more to know who it was. I would have known that aura anywhere.

There was a brief moment of hesitation, Lukyan hovering in the doorway before he came inside his bedroom, turned on the light, and shut the door.

I didn't even dare to draw breath.

What now, Lyla?

I DON'T FUCKING KNOW.

I'd been in his room more times than I could count. So many times, in fact, that I could map the whole place out and move around in complete darkness.

I knew the position of all his furniture. That the en suite was exactly twenty-three and a half steps from the window on the far wall. Knew he kept a collection of old-school porn magazines in the bottom of his dresser drawers. He hadn't opened them in a while. If he had, he would have seen that I replaced all the pictures of naked women with a photo of me in my catsuit. *Heh, heh.*

But I'd never—and I mean *never*—been in that room at the same time as him when he was *awake*.

Partly because I didn't trust myself not to throw away everything I had planned and demand he take me there and then.

On top of being an adrenaline junkie, I also had poor impulse control.

Surprised?

Not really.

Lukyan moved further into the room, and I remembered I needed to fucking breathe, or I was going to pass out.

Carefully, *so very fucking carefully*, I shifted my body just slightly so I could peek out from under the bed to see him fully.

My heart slammed in my chest at the sight of him. Lukyan was side-on to me, and I watched, entranced as he casually rolled his big shoulders out of his jacket. He loosened his tie with one hand before pulling it over his head, and then slowly began unbuttoning his dress shirt.

He stopped halfway, leaning forward to glance at his phone, which he'd placed down on a table beside the three-seater couch. A devilish smirk graced his lips, and he scoffed, shaking his head.

He picked it up, typed something quickly, and returned it to the table to continue undressing.

My phone flashed with another text message.

My Luky Bear: You talk as if we've met before. I'm pretty sure I would remember meeting a batshit crazy chick who's been stalking me.

MY GAZE CUT to him just as he put his phone back down again.

My Luky Bear: If you even are a chick. My sister thinks you might be a fifty-year-old, overweight, bald man who still lives in his mother's basement.

REALLY?

Me: What do you think?

HIS SHIRT CAME OFF, and my stomach clenched. Carved, pure muscle. Big, broad shoulders. Rough, tanned skin littered with various scars. Some looked like knife wounds, others like gunshots.

While it hurt my heart to know he'd endured such pain, I couldn't deny that the scars added a certain appeal.

He snapped the button of his pants open with one hand as he texted me with the other.

My Luky Bear: I think I'm bored.

MY MOUTH DROPPED open in shock. *Say. Fucking. What?*

My Luky Bear: This was mildly entertaining at the start, but now, I'm bored. My attention is a hard thing to keep, and unfortunately for you, you've lost it 🙄

I WAS SO surprised at his words I didn't even notice he'd moved closer to me until he threw his phone onto the bed above me and walked away, effectively ending any further conversation.

Oh, baby, you have no idea what you've just done.

He didn't know it, but he'd just issued me a challenge. And I fucking *loved* challenges. The harder, the better.

Music blasted in the air. Lukyan threw what looked like a remote control of some kind onto the couch before he strolled casually to his ensuite and walked inside. He pushed the door closed behind him, but not hard enough to shut it completely. It remained slightly ajar, and from my position, I was able to see him through the mirror.

He was taking a shower.

Perfect.

He wanted me to keep his attention?

Fuck. That.

I was going to fucking *take* it and never give it back.

I slunk out from under his bed, quiet as a mouse, keeping my gaze locked on him through the mirror as I moved. A few ideas came to mind, but really, only one stuck out.

Once I was on my feet, I picked up his phone from the bed, and the screen lit up. A picture of him and his family greeted me. It was one I'd seen hundreds of times before because I'd cloned his phone the first time I broke into his house, but it still made me smile nonetheless.

Aleksandr, Nikolai, and Papa D stood stoically in the back, arms folded across their chests and scowls on their faces. Lukyan and Illayana were in the front, arms thrown around each other, tongues sticking out and eyes crossed.

It was an adorable family photo, and it showed each of their personalities perfectly.

The music blasting in the air offered me some comfort as I unlocked his phone—yes, I knew his passcode, and we're not really surprised, are we? If

I made any noise, it would help to conceal it.

Eyes firmly locked on Lukyan through the small crack in the bathroom door, I clasped the zipper at the top of my jumpsuit and pulled it down. My breasts spilled out. They were fake, and I wasn't the least bit ashamed about it. I was one of those souls to be born with barely an A cup, and while I usually lived by the philosophy, *who cares what other people think, be happy with your body*, I was, in fact, not.

My breasts had been a huge insecurity of mine. Always were, going all the way back to high school and well into my teen years. When all the other girls in my grade would brag about their bra size, I would awkwardly try to change the subject without making it obvious.

The minute I was old enough, I went under the knife and never looked back. My surgeon was a miracle worker—so good that they didn't even remotely look or feel fake.

I was now a solid C cup. Happy and proud. Not too big. Not too small. Perky, plump, and the perfect size to fill a man's hands.

Lukyan's hands.

My jumpsuit hit the floor. I stepped out of it, leaving it there and climbed onto Lukyan's bed. I set his phone up on the side table, making sure to zoom out so it would capture everything, leaving no question as to where it was taken— in *his* room, on *his* bed—and set the timer for ten seconds.

I wished I could take off my mask. I wanted him to see my face, but it wasn't time for that yet.

Soon.

Watch how fucking fast I get your attention after this.

I activated the countdown. Shuffling back, I quickly got into position, leaning back, elbows firmly on the bed, both hands clasping my breasts but leaving a little space between my fingers so he would get *just* a glimpse of my nipples, and legs spread wide.

I'd intentionally left my underwear on, because come on...I couldn't give him all the goods yet. He would have to work for that.

Finally, I tipped my head back so he could only see the column of my throat.

The sound of the phone taking a picture hit the air. After a quick check, I changed it to his wallpaper and climbed down.

The water turned off. My gaze snapped to the bathroom. Lukyan stepped out of the shower, his body glistening, water dripping down his hard chest and rock-solid abs.

My eyes stayed plastered to the mirror as I quickly put my jumpsuit back on. I had to get out. Now. Slip away quickly before he left the bathroom and caught me red-fucking-handed.

But my feet stayed rooted in place, my body unable to move. He was like a piece of art. Chiseled. Sculpted. Pure perfection.

His hair was down and dripping wet, resting on his shoulders. I just wanted to run my fingers through it. I loved long hair on men...or was it just Lukyan? My fingers danced over the bracelet around my wrist—the one made out of a lock of his hair.

I never took it off, except when I was showering. That way, I always had a piece of him with me.

Move. Your. Ass!

Fuck.

I swiped up my phone and bolted out of his bedroom door, closing it softly behind me.

Luck was on my side because the hallway was clear. I knew it wouldn't be for long, though. That house was always abuzz with activity. People were coming and going all the time, whether it be their maid staff, guards, or the Volkovs themselves. I couldn't risk staying out in the open.

I jogged further down, my heart hammering in my chest, and stopped in front of the wall sconce just before the spiral staircase leading back down to the ground floor. Feeling underneath it, I waited until the switch touched my fingers and—

Click.

A triumphant smile graced my lips as the secret door beside it slid open. I ducked inside, clicking it shut behind me.

I knew every single inch of the Volkov mansion. I knew where all the nooks and crannies were. Where all the trapdoors and hidden passageways led to. Where all the panic rooms and weapons caches were.

I knew fucking everything. The moment I'd decided Lukyan would be mine, I made it my mission to learn anything and everything I could about him. I even had the blueprint of his home saved as a PDF on my phone. Not that I needed it anymore anyway. I had the whole layout memorized.

Before moving another step, I pulled up the camera feed I had in his bedroom. I wanted to see his reaction to my photo. Would he freak out, knowing I had been in the room with him the whole time? Would he like that? Would he feel angry? Threatened? Turned on?

I was hoping for all of the above.

He stood in front of his bed, towel wrapped around his waist, another in his hands, drying his long hair. His phone hadn't moved, sitting in exactly the same spot I had left it.

If I had any sense, I would gotten the fuck out then. Staying any longer put me at serious risk. There was every chance that the moment he realized I was in the house, Lukyan would sound the alarm, and then I would have them all searching for me.

The thrill alone kept me in place.

Lukyan threw the towel in his hands on the ground and leaned forward to pick up his phone. I switched to a different angle—the camera on the headboard of his bed, giving me a perfect view of his face.

“What the fuck?” he blew out, eyes widening. His head whipped from side to side, looking around the room. He dropped to one knee, checking under the bed next before standing back up, his features completely perplexed.

His attention went right back to his phone, staring at it with complete focus. I couldn't read him. I couldn't figure out what he was feeling. What he was thinking. Did he like it? Did he not like it? I needed to know—

His hand went down and grasped his cock through the towel. He groaned.

My eyes shot wide open. Giddiness enveloped me. *He **did** like it! Oh my god, oh my god, oh my god.* I had the overwhelming urge to jump up and down and do a little happy dance.

“Are you watching me right now?” he said into the empty room.

My breath hitched. *He's talking to me.*

“You are, aren't you?” The towel dropped from his waist. Lust pooled in my body. Hard, thick, and long, his cock stood to attention, his hand wrapped around it and stroking it softly. Leisurely. “Come out, come out, wherever you are,” he sang, voice layered with pleasure.

I was moving before I even knew what I was doing. He wanted me. He wanted me to go to him—

Stop!

My hand hovered over the switch that would open the secret door, taking me back into the hallway.

Fucking hell. The power he had over me...It was insane.

I couldn't go to him. Not yet. That would ruin everything. All the planning and hard work I'd done over the past year and a half. Gone. No. If I wanted him forever, I had to stick to my plan.

I stepped back from the door until my shoulders hit the wall behind me.

"You're not going to join me?" Lukyan asked. His hips began to move slightly, completely in time with the strokes of his hand. A deep, masculine groan fell from his lips, his head rolling back on his shoulders for a moment before he focused back on his phone.

On *my* photo.

"Look at you. You're a sexy fucking thing, aren't you? And bold too. Coming into *my* room. Sitting on *my* bed while I was only a few steps away. I would have killed you if I caught you. But you know that, don't you? And you like it. You like the danger. The rush. The thrill. *Oh, fuck.*"

Unable to handle it, I unzipped my suit and thrust my hand down my underwear. Pleasure shot through me the moment my fingers touched my clit. *Fuck, it won't take much for me to come.* I was already pent-up, watching him touch himself over *me*. I couldn't join him in person, but we could come together.

Lukyan's pace increased. The muscles in his body bulged. Hardening. Tightening. I matched him, my fingers moving over my clit faster and faster, my breath catching in my throat.

"You were sitting right here." He put the phone down and ran his hand over the bedspread. "Your ass...right...fucking...here." His tongue came out, and he ran it up the very spot I had been sitting in one long, languid lick.

My mouth dropped open. Pleasure burst throughout my entire body, and I came instantly, my body shaking.

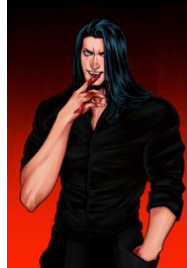
So did Lukyan. He grunted, his hips pistoning forward into his hand as he unloaded all over himself.

"*Jesus, fuck,*" he moaned, low and long. There was a beat of silence, and then he looked up at nothing in particular. "You've captured my attention again, *moya malen'kaya ten'*, *my little shadow*. I can't wait to see what else you'll do."

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER SEVEN

LUKYAN VOLKOV



“Come on, Illayana! Just...a little...further...” I stretched my arm out through the ropes as far as my body would allow, my fingers just inches away from my sister’s as she writhed in pain on the boxing ring floor.

Aleksandr had her leg locked in a hold, squeezing and twisting it in a way I knew must have been painful as fuck. But instead of succumbing to the pain, Illayana fought, stretching further, trying desperately to reach my hand.

The crowd of soldiers behind us roared, clapping their hands and cheering them on, the almost 50,000 square foot building filled with nearly every single one of our men, eager to watch how the fight would end.

Beside me stood Autumn, her red hair tied up high in a bun, face calm but focused.

It was a three vs. three, tag team match. Illayana, Autumn, and me versus Aleksandr, Drea, and Arturo. Nikolai, Tatiana, and my father sat right in front of the boxing ring, Father’s arm wrapped up in a sling, much to his protest.

It was meant to be a friendly little sparring match between the six of us. *Friendly* being the key word. But, of course, “friendly” wasn’t really in my siblings and my vocabulary.

Things turned pretty brutal pretty fucking quickly, all thanks to that competitive energy each of us possessed.

“Arghhhhh! Fucking asshole!” Illayana screamed, still refusing to give in, crawling inch by painful inch toward me. All she had to do was tap my

hand, and then Aleksandr would have to let her go. She could leave the ring, and I would be able to take her place.

Our dickhead of a brother wasn't making it easy on her, though. Not in the slightest. The corners of his lips were kicked up into a smug, playful smirk. He didn't just know that he was holding the winning ticket in his hands, that his team would be victorious. He also knew he could actually end the fight any time he wanted. If he applied enough pressure, my sister would tap out or risk having her ankle broken.

He was just playing with her. Making her suffer.

Arturo watched on anxiously from the other side of the ring, his face contorted as if he himself were the one in pain. He might have been on the opposing side, but it was clear that standing by while Illayana was being hurt was hard for him.

Although that was an almost daily occurrence for us growing up, the uber-traditional Italian man Arturo was made it hard for him to stand back and watch the woman he loved in pain.

That competitive nature in him would be cheering for Aleksandr, but his heart would be cheering for Illayana.

"Tap. You know you can't get out," Aleksandr goaded, his smirk widening when Illayana moaned in agony and her head thumped to the floor.

I had to do something or we were going to lose, and we'd never hear the fucking end of it.

"Illayana!"

Her head snapped up, eyes connecting with mine. I swiped the tip of my index finger across my body from shoulder to shoulder, twirled that same finger through the air, and then thrust my elbow up swiftly. She groaned in agony, her head dropping forward on her shoulders.

A few years may have separated us, but Illayana and I were as close as twins. And, like twins, we'd created our own little language when we were kids—except instead of using words, we used hand signals.

Illayana knew exactly what I was saying to her. Knew exactly what I was telling her to do. She knew it was the only solution to her problem.

That didn't mean she *wanted* to do it, though. Because it was going to hurt like fucking hell.

In the position she was in—lying flat on her stomach, Aleksandr on one knee behind her with her right ankle locked in his grasp—there was no way

of getting out of that hold without enduring some pain.

Lucky for our team, my sister was the most competitive one out of all of us. Illayana would do whatever she fucking had to to win. I knew she'd have no problem enduring a little pain if it meant a possible victory.

Her head slowly lifted, determination and anger burning in her eyes. Illayana slammed her palms down on the floor and growled, teeth clenched. Then, in a move that shocked the hell out of Aleksandr, she swung her left leg back, ignoring the undoubtable pain that move would have caused, and kicked him in the face.

The blow wasn't as powerful as I knew Illayana was capable of delivering, but it was enough to startle Aleksandr and force him to let her go, falling back.

Her gaze whipped to my hand, outstretched through the ropes. She dove forward. Her hand slapped against mine. The crowd roared as we switched places, Illayana rolling under the bottom rope and off the side of the ring, and me diving through the middle, rolling along the ground, and jumping back up to my feet all within a single move.

Aleksandr had just gotten to his feet when I popped up in front of him. His eyes widened slightly.

"THIS IS SPARTA!" I front-kicked him in the chest. He flew back, smacking into the ropes behind him. But before he could bounce back toward me, Arturo slapped a hand on his shoulder, effectively tapping Aleksandr out and tapping *himself* in.

Aleksandr let loose a growl filled with frustration, rubbing his sternum as he glared daggers at me.

I smiled, twinkling my fingers in a *bye-bye* gesture.

With a grumble, he and Arturo traded places.

The king of La Cosa Nostra stared me down, a twinkle of amusement in his eyes. He began to slowly roll up the sleeves of his dress shirt. "I've been wanting to do this for a long, *long* time."

I danced back, light as a feather on my feet. "Yeaaaah. I have that effect on people." I smirked. I put my hands up in a boxer's pose. "Let's dance, motherfucker."

Arturo charged. His first strike, I avoided, his fist flying past my face. He followed it through with punch after punch after punch, alternating his hands with each move.

I ducked, twisted, and dodged, primarily stuck on the defensive. I fucking hated it, but he was throwing shots too fast for me to do anything else *but* defend.

That squirrely fucker.

He hit me with a fast combo. Right punch. Left punch. Knee to the gut. That last one struck. I doubled over, my breath wheezing out of me on a painful groan. His knee came up to hit me in the face. I just managed to block it in time and charged forward, picking him up and tackling him to the ground.

The crowd roared behind us as we grappled, rolling along the floor.

Arturo was a bigger dude. Didn't pain me to admit it. He might have been bigger, but I was taller, which meant I had longer limbs.

Most likely in every scenario.

Boomshakalaka.

Arturo landed on top. The bastard. He spun quickly, wrapped his legs around my neck, and squeezed. My air constricted, and I choked, gasping for breath.

Bastard.

Bastard.

Bastard.

I fought against him, struggling to find some way out of it. I didn't have to see his face to know he had the biggest fucking smirk on his lips.

"I've got you now," he taunted, squeezing even tighter. "Maybe this will finally shut you up."

If I was able to talk, I would have said, *nothing could make me do that*, but I was barely able to draw breath, let alone speak.

A wave of dizziness washed over me. I was losing. My pride couldn't let him win. No fucking way. So, I did something completely unorthodox. The hold he had me in put his bare feet within reaching distance. In a last-ditch effort, I quickly stretched forward and tickled the bottom of his foot.

"What the fuck?!" he yelled, his entire body bucking. It was all I needed. His hold had loosened just enough for me to throw his legs apart and make my escape.

We rolled apart, both of us springing to our feet at opposite ends of the ring, Arturo in front of Aleksandr and Drea, and me in front of Autumn.

"What the fuck was that?!" he blasted. I couldn't tell if he was angry or kinda impressed by the move.

Nah, he was pissed.

I gave him a sly smile. “There’s no rule saying we can’t tickle.”

“It’s a fight! Who the fuck tickles in a fight?!”

I pointed to my chest. “Moi.” Then I smirked, spun, and tapped Autumn in.

Arturo snarled, turned, and tapped in Drea.

My smirk widened.

Arturo was raised to always treat women with respect and never hurt them. Protect them as if they were precious little gems, capable of shattering into a million pieces over the first upsetting thing to happen to them.

And while, yes, I agreed in some retrospect—women should always be treated with respect—you could bet your bottom dollar that if a chick came at me with a knife, I would do *whatever* I needed to do to protect myself and the people I loved.

Autumn and Drea took our places in the ring and immediately locked into a grapple, throwing punches here and there.

Hands on my hips, I blew out a breath, my heart beating fast. Christian approached the ring, offering me a bottle of water. I bent down to grab it, taking a big gulp. The adrenaline from the fight pumped through my veins, making my body shake.

“He got you good,” Christian commented.

“Huh?”

He tapped his eyebrow. I lightly touched the spot he indicated, a flare of pain cutting through me. Blood coated my fingertips.

What I had thought was sweat dripping down the side of my face was actually blood.

“That quick fucker.” I grunted.

Illayana laughed, then winced. She was sitting on a chair beside the ring, her leg up with an ice pack on her ankle.

I snapped my gaze to her. “What the fuck are you laughing at? We’re on the same team, you idiot.”

Her laughter stopped, the smile dropping from her face. “Fuck. You’re right. With me injured and you hurt, that only leaves Autumn at full strength.” She groaned, burying her face in her hands. “We’re gonna lose. *Again.*”

“Calm down. I’m not hurt. It’s a little cut. We can still take ’em. We just have to be smart.”

Her eyes narrowed dangerously. “I told you when we drew our names out of the bowl for teams that I wouldn’t let you use me against Arturo.”

“*Blah, blah, blah,*” I mouthed as she spoke. “Do you want to win or not?”

“Not at the expense of causing distress to my husband.”

“You used to be fun.”

The crowd groaned in sympathetic pain when Autumn flung Drea over her shoulder, body slamming her to the ground.

“Yes! Go, Autumn, go!” I yelled, cheering.

While it was clear, based on her fighting style, that Autumn had professional training, they were both quite evenly matched. Drea was a street brawler. Honed her skills from what I assumed was a lifetime of fighting on the streets. She was tough as shit, never stayed down for long, and I’d seen her in enough sparring matches to know she had no problem fighting fucking dirty.

Drea had somehow manipulated her way to the top, hammering into Autumn relentlessly. The crowd was going wild, everyone on their feet, cheering them on, demanding more. Even Tatiana—who had Nikolai anxiously at her side, watching her every move in case something happened—was urging them on.

“Are you out?” I asked Illayana.

My sister took the ice pack off her ankle and tested it, applying a bit of weight as she slowly stood up. She winced slightly, then shook her head. “No, I’m good.”

“You better be,” I grunted. “We’re almost down to two minutes on the clock, and you know what Father does when there’s only two minutes left.”

Illayana groaned, her head dropping before she slowly made her way to the stairs that led back up to the ring.

My siblings and I had played countless tag team matches over the years. Our names would go into a bowl, and whoever we pulled out would be our partner.

And it didn’t matter who the teams were—Aleksandr would win. Every. Single. Time.

Well...this time...I was going to fucking win.

They were five, six-minute rounds, and on the last round, with only two minutes left on the clock, Father would call a free-for-all. Basically, we could all jump in the ring and beat the shit out of each other.

My eyes drifted up to the analog clock suspended above the ring.

2:09.

2:08.

2:07.

Illayana joined me at my side, not an ounce of discomfort on her face.

2:06.

2:05.

2:04.

Across the ring, Aleksandr's eyes flicked upward. His body leaned forward in preparation.

2:03.

2:02.

2:01.

"Two minutes left! Free-for—"

I was already moving, ducking underneath the ropes, Illayana hot on my heels. Aleksandr did the same from the other end, Arturo only a step behind him.

Autumn and Drea were trading blows. Aleksandr and Illayana ran for each other at the same time as Arturo and I did. We clashed like a pair of raging bulls and locked into a grapple. By skill and, okay, I'll admit, a smidgen of good luck, I managed to wind my arm underneath his and thrust forward, bending his limb at an odd angle. Arturo cried out in pain. I punched him in the stomach, once, twice, three times, a pain-filled grunt falling from his lips every time, and then finished it off with a front kick to his chest.

He flew back, landing in a heap in front of the ropes. With a fancy, kung-fu kind of bullshit move, he flipped himself back up and glared at me, rage simmering in his multicolored eyes.

He charged.

I kept my body loose. Waiting...waiting...He raised his fist, preparing to strike.

Illayana was on my left. I yanked her in front of me. Arturo came to a screeching halt, his fist freezing in the air an inch away from Illayana's jaw, his face panicked and full of distress.

I popped my head around Illayana's body. "*Heh, Heh,*" I teased, then struck him in the side of the head with a high kick.

Arturo's eyes rolled back, and he went down like a house of cards.

Booyah.

"Lukyan!" Illayana whined, pushing away from me and running right on over to her poor little unconscious husband.

Both would be down for the count.

A hard body rammed into me. I went flying, landing harshly on my shoulder blade, but I used the momentum from the attack to push myself back up and onto my feet in one quick, flawless—yet slightly painful—move.

I spun.

Aleksandr stood before me, all big and broody and downright fucking murderous. I wasn't a small dude, by any means, but my big brother fucking dwarfed me.

Despite that, though, as we stared each other down, I felt good. Like it might be my fucking day to finally beat his ass.

"That was cheating, Lukyan," he chastised, crossing his arms. His chest expanded from the fucking movement alone.

The big brute.

I smirked, watching him closely. "You heard Father at the start of the match. No rules, remember?"

He grunted, cracking his knuckles. "That shit won't work on me."

Won't it?

I looked over his shoulder, dropping my face in mask horror. It was so good, so *believable*, I almost bought it myself for a second.

"Oh my god! Drea!"

Panic flashed across Aleksandr's face for a microsecond before he spun around. I ran up and kicked him in the balls from behind. He choked, a tiny, barely audible whimper falling from his lips as he dropped to his knees, hands cupping his privates.

I locked him in a choke hold, my arms wrapping around his neck, and *squeezed* with every ounce of strength I possessed. The crowd screamed so loudly it hurt my ears.

Aleksandr fought me, trying to find some way to pry me off him, but I was locked in. There was no getting out.

"I'm—going—to—fucking—*kill you,*" he rasped, struggling hard.

Yeaaaaah, he probably would.

Would be worth it, though.

“It’s beddy-bye time. Shhh, shhhh. Go to sleep. Go to sleep,” I whispered in his ear, squeezing harder. Tighter.

“You’re—dead, you—little—shit.”

“Nun-nies, little Aleksandr. Off to la-la land you go.” My arms ached from holding the pressure. It defied all odds that he was still conscious. “Go to fucking sleep, you cockroach.” I growled.

I felt the fight start to leave Aleksandr, his body slowly drooping forward.

Finally.

I guided him down as slowly and softly as I could, but when he finally lost consciousness, I couldn’t hold him up any longer, and he thumped on the ground, passed out.

Deep, panting breaths escaped me as I braced my hands on my knees. *That fucker just wouldn’t quit.*

“Sixty seconds!”

My eyes snapped to Autumn and Drea, duking it out near the corner of the ring.

This was finally my opportunity to win against Aleksandr. I had to take it.

It was kind of funny...Hurting my brother didn’t scare me, but hurting his *wife*?

That absolutely terrified me.

My brother was over-the-top protective of his little cartel queen. If I hurt her, even under the pretense of a friendly sparring match, he’d hack my balls off with a rusty cleaver and serve them to me on a silver platter.

The prospect of finally beating Aleksandr at something was far too strong to overcome, though, demolishing that tiny ball of respectful fear I had for him.

I leaped back into action with renewed purpose. Drea had Autumn on her back, pummeling into her with that scrappy energy she had. I came up behind Drea and locked her into the same headlock I’d used on Aleksandr.

I found it kind of poetic; lovers knocked out from the same technique.

Absolutely beautiful.

A love story for the ages.

Drea thrashed, her legs kicking out wildly and a string of Spanish curses flying from her mouth as I lifted her off Autumn, my arms wrapped firmly around her neck. She tried to fight, tossing and turning, looking for some sort of opening, but finding nothing. Drea at least had more sense than my brother, because when she realized she had no way to get out of it, she tapped my forearm three times.

I won. I fucking won.

I let her go, my scream of triumph joining that of the roaring crowd behind me. I raised my hands in the air, basking in the victory against my older brother and Arturo, and began to pose like someone in a bodybuilding competition, flexing my muscles, turning this way and that way, all while a growl of pure elation fell from my lips.

I fucking ate up every second of it.

Nikolai jumped up onto the ring and dangled his arms over the ropes. A grin was plastered on his lips. Continuing my show of dominance, I made my way over to him.

Amusement sparkled in his eyes. “You know he’s absolutely going to murder you for that stunt, right?” he said, referring to an unconscious Aleksandr lying face down on the ring floor.

My smile was wide. Carefree. Fucking villainous. “I know. Was still worth it, though.”

Aleksandr stirred, a groan rumbling out of him. My face dropped. I checked my imaginary watch.

“You know what? I just remembered I’m late for an appointment.”

“What appointment?” Nikolai asked, his lips kicked up into a smirk.

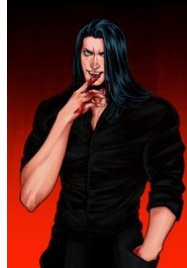
“I’ve gotta see a man about a dog. Very, very important stuff. Cheerio.” I jumped down from the ring just as a pissed-as-fuck voice cut through the air.

“LUKYAN!” Aleksandr roared.

I bolted out of the warehouse without looking back.

CHAPTER EIGHT

LUKYAN VOLKOV



“*A* dog! A sheep! A fucking horse!”

Illayana pointed vigorously at her—excuse my French—piece of shit drawing on the whiteboard in the family room, getting more and more frustrated with every failed guessing attempt.

Sitting on one of the three-seater couches, Aleksandr chuckled, a smirk dancing on his lips as he took a sip of his drink. Drea buried into his side to keep from laughing outright, and he winced at the movement, a hand flying to the ice pack sitting firmly on his crotch. He cut me a scathing look—one filled with the promise of violence and retribution for his current circumstance.

He was still salty about that kick to the balls.

I ignored him, though, way too focused on the game.

“Come on, Lukyan. Are you serious?!” Illayana growled, pointing so hard the tip of her marker was disappearing into the barrel.

“Don’t blame me for this!” I exclaimed. “You’ve got a body, head, four legs, and a tail. That could be hundreds of fucking animals, and you expect me to guess them all? You’re out of your mind!”

“I thought you weren’t supposed to talk in Pictionary?” Autumn whispered in Father’s ear beside me.

Father snorted. “You’re not. But Illayana and Lukyan play by their own rules.”

“Illayana and Lukyan can hear you,” I snapped out of the side of my mouth. “Draw something more identifiable.”

Nikolai's eyes were firmly on the stopwatch in his hands. "Fifteen seconds!"

"Come on! Hurry up!" I urged. My body was full of anxious, nervous energy as I began to pace up and down. "We're gonna lose!"

"Then it's your fault!" my sister snarled. "I can't make this any bloody easier." She drew another few lines that in no way helped me figure out what the image was supposed to be.

I started shouting out random animals, desperation filling me. "Frog! Cheetah! Lion! Rhinoceros—"

"Time!" Nikolai barked, jumping to his feet.

Illayana threw the marker at my head. I ducked. "You idiot. Rhinoceros?! What the fuck—it was a cat!"

My jaw dropped. "A. Cat?! Are you high? In what universe is that blob a cat?! If you want me to guess a cat, draw some fucking whiskers or something!"

"You. Are. Useless—"

"Alright, alright, enough." Humor flashed in my father's eyes. "Nikolai and Tatiana, your turn."

Illayana and I plopped down onto the other three-seater couch at the same time. She shoved me with her shoulder. I pushed her back. She shoved me again. I thumped her lightly in the arm. She smacked me in return. The bitch fight started instantly, both of us slapping the shit out of each other.

"Next time, I'm getting Arturo to be my partner." She grunted.

"Well, good luck to him. I hope he likes to lose because you're a shit partner," I spat.

"Don't make me separate you two," Father warned.

With a final push, we shoved away from each other. Of course, she couldn't help getting the last hit in, punching me in the thigh with the side of her fist.

Fucking ow.

Arturo was *meant* to be her partner, but he got called away on some sort of business, so that meant I got stuck with her instead. In my opinion, it was a stitch up. *Everyone* knew we fought and bickered too much to be effective partners in any game.

Tatiana flicked her hands back and forth through the air. "Help me up."

Nikolai handed the stopwatch to Drea and stood to clasp Tatiana's hands. With a gentle pull, he guided her to her feet. He gave her belly a

tender caress and kissed her cheek softly before switching places, sitting down in the seat she'd just vacated.

Tatiana waddled a few steps forward and plucked one of the Pictionary cards from the coffee table. She glanced at it, placed it face-down, picked up another marker, and made her way to the board. She wiped it clear of Illayana's horrible attempt at drawing a cat, took the lid off her marker, and had it poised in the air, all set to take her turn.

"Ready...set...go." Drea clicked the stopwatch.

Tatiana drew a curved line, almost like an oval, before adding in some jagged lines at the bottom—

"Umbrella," Nikolai immediately guessed.

"Yes!" Tatiana cheered.

My mouth dropped open. I was on my feet before I even knew what was happening. "What?! Are you kidding me?! They cheated!"

Nikolai's smirk was full of smugness. The prick. "How could we have possibly done that?"

"I don't know, but I demand a redo."

Nikolai shrugged. "Fine." He leaned back, crossing his ankle over his knee, relaxed and casual. "Do another, love," he said to Tatiana.

She went to the coffee table to pick up another card.

"Wait a second." Eyes narrowed in suspicion, I swiped up the cards and gave them a big shuffle. "Okay. Go ahead." I offered her the deck.

"It's not going to make a difference," Nikolai sang under his breath.

Tatiana picked up a card. Her lips puckered in thought. "Hmmm." She went back to the board and stared at it for a moment before she began to draw.

"Shoes," Nikolai said instantly.

She shrieked excitedly. "Yes!"

I shook my head. "Nope. No. *No way.* Bullshit. It's a bunch of rectangular boxes all stacked up on top of each other. How the fuck did you get 'shoes' from that?"

"It was pretty obvious."

"I *did* make it a little obvious, huh." Tatiana laughed.

I felt like my face was turning red. "Gimme that." I snatched the card out of her hand just to check it in case they were cheating.

They weren't.

Mental note: Tatiana and Nikolai are not allowed to be partners in any of our family games. They were too in sync. Freakishly so.

“And you couldn’t even guess a cat,” Illayana mumbled under her breath as I sat back down, taking a not-so-subtle dig at me.

“Big talk for someone who can’t even *draw* a cat,” I fired back.

She glared at me.

“Our turn!” Drea passed the stopwatch back to Nikolai and turned to Aleksandr, her face the most serious and focused I’d ever seen it before. “We can do this.” She used her fingers to point at her eyes and then turned her hand to point at Aleksandr’s. “In sync, yeah? One mind.”

I snickered under my breath. Drea was just as competitive as I was.

Maybe even more so.

“This is ours for the win, baby. Focus. Teamwork. Head in the fucking game. We got this.”

Aleksandr smiled one of his rare, carefree smiles—the kind of smile only Drea could bring out of him. “We got this,” he repeated for her sake, not his.

It was easy to see the win didn’t matter to him as much as it did her, but that he was going to try his damndest to win it for her.

Drea took a deep, concentrated breath before getting to her feet. She cracked her neck left, then right, and shook out her body like a boxer preparing to start a fight.

“You can do this, Drea. You can do this. Let’s go. Let’s fucking go.”

Everyone snickered at her antics. She walked up to the coffee table and plucked a card from the stack.

They could not, in fact, do it. Turned out, Aleksandr and Drea were worse at Pictionary than Illayana and I were.

And it was absolutely hilarious to watch.

We played games for hours, going well into the night. UNO. Jenga. Monopoly—which resulted in Illayana flipping the table because she was losing. Nikolai and Tatiana tapped out first, heading off to bed sometime around 10 p.m. Father and Autumn followed an hour or so later. Then Drea and Aleksandr.

Illayana and I were the last ones standing.

We were finished playing games. Seven screaming matches and two fist fights were more than enough. We sat in comfortable silence, the odd *crackle* from the fireplace being the only sound to cut through the room.

Neither one of us felt the need to leave yet. I suspected it was because we both knew it would probably be our last opportunity to see each other for a while, since I was leaving for Russia the next day.

A thousand thoughts ran through my mind at once, and I lost myself to the silence. To the contentment. To the thoughts taking me over.

To one person.

To. One. Fucking. Person.

My eyes were locked on my phone—or, more specifically, my screensaver.

Yes, it was of her. My stalker. My little shadow.

No, I didn't change it, because why the fuck would I? Not only was it the hottest thing I'd ever seen in my life, it was also ballsy as hell of her to sit on my bed while I was only feet away and pose for a photo virtually naked.

I traced my gaze over those sensual, luscious curves. The rounds of her breasts. The long, slender column of her neck. She knew exactly what she was doing, posing in that position, covering her nipples but also showing *just* enough to give me a little preview of what to expect. Teasing the absolute shit out of me—

“Lukyan!”

I flicked my eyes up from my phone to land on Illayana. She was sitting on the floor, back leaning against the chair behind her.

“Huh?”

“I’ve been trying to get your attention for ages. What’s so riveting on your phone that you’ve been able to flat-out ignore me for the last three minutes?” she asked, her tone light and playful.

It wasn't a *what*. More of a *who*.

My stalker had been running through my mind all goddamn day, and I'd tried everything I could to kick her out of it. I tried preoccupying not only my mind, but my body, investing all my energy into the tag team match.

That didn't work.

Then, I'd tried putting all my focus into the games at family night.

Didn't work either.

Nothing did.

She was goddamn certifiable...and I fucking loved it. Her brand of crazy and impulsiveness should have been a giant red flag.

It wasn't.

It turned me on.

Surprise, surprise, right?

The minute I'd realized what she'd done, I'd gotten harder than I'd ever been in my fucking life. So hard it *hurt*, and I'd had to relieve that pressure. Otherwise, I feared my cock would explode, and *not* in the good way.

So, I fucked my own hand and pretended it was hers.

What made the whole thing even hotter was that I knew she was watching me as I did it. There was no way she wasn't. Her past behavior pretty much guaranteed I had an audience. I knew she'd want to see my reaction to her little stunt.

I imagined she was pleasuring herself right alongside me. *Her fingers deep in her tight, wet pussy. Curling...twisting...stretching—*

"Lukyan!"

"Fucking what?!"

"You spaced out again." *Fuck. I did, didn't I?* "Seriously, what is going on with you?"

I internally groaned. The mystery woman was fucking me up left, right, and bloody center, I swear.

I locked my phone and tucked it away so it was incapable of distracting me again. I couldn't risk looking at her photo again, or I'd start spiraling down that rabbit hole, wondering what she felt like. Tasted like.

"What was your question again?" I asked, voice tight. Illayana had to have asked a question, right? She always got snappy when her questions went unanswered.

"Which one?"

"The first bloody one." I almost snarled.

"Jeez Louise, someone's moody." Illayana rolled her eyes and crossed her feet at the ankles, taking a small sip from the glass in her hand.

The silence came back, and I waited. She'd speak eventually.

"There's no talking you out of it, is there?" Illayana finally asked.

I didn't need more information to know exactly what she was referring to.

"No," I said strongly. Confidently. "This is my chance, Illayana."

She frowned. "Chance for what?"

"To prove I'm not the idiot you all think I am."

Compassion flashed across her face. "We don't think that—"

“Yes, you do. Don’t insult my intelligence by saying something that’s not even remotely true. I see it. The way you all look at me. Talk about me. Crack jokes at my expense. ‘Oh, Lukyan can’t do it. He’s untrustworthy’. ‘Don’t trust Lukyan with that important job, he’ll fuck it up’. I’ve heard it for years, and I’m sick of it. I’m sick of being made to feel like I’m just an accessory in this family. This is my chance to show *everyone* that I can do the tough shit. The serious shit. That *I*”—I pounded a closed fist into my chest—“can be relied on. I’m not going to give that up because you all think I’m not good enough to do the job—”

I didn’t realize I was on my feet until Illayana grabbed my hand to stop me from leaving.

“Stay. Don’t go. Please.” Her hand squeezed mine in earnest. “Don’t let this be our last conversation.”

I rolled my eyes and plopped back down, the fight evaporating out of me in an instant. “It won’t be. I’ll still text you. You’ll still send me daily annoying reels I won’t watch—”

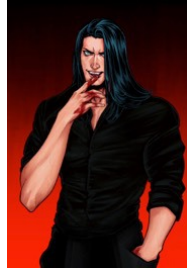
“I knew you never watched them,” she mumbled under her breath.

“—because you’re my sister, and I love you,” I finished, giving her nothing but brutal honesty.

Her face softened. “I love you too.” She reached forward and hugged me. “And I swear to God, Lukyan, if you don’t come back alive, I will never forgive you.”

CHAPTER NINE

LUKYAN VOLKOV



Something soft smacked me in the face. I woke instantly, my body reacting before my mind. The leather hilt of the knife tucked beneath my pillow at all times was gripped between my fingers as I jumped up on the bed, knees braced, arms up defensively, ready for any attack that could come my way.

My big brother was leaning against the doorjam, one foot crossed over the other, arms folded, and a shit-eating grin on his face.

I glared and threw my knife. Aleksandr didn't move a muscle, not even when the blade embedded deep into the wood right next to his head.

"You big-headed asshole!" I hissed. "I told you I need to be woken up calmly and softly from now on. I have PTSD from the last prank you lot pulled on me in my sleep."

Aleksandr rolled his eyes. "You do not have PTSD."

"Yes, I do," I stated adamantly. "My therapist said so."

"You don't have a therapist anymore because you ended up fucking your last one."

My lips curved. "Oh. Right." I took notice of the time on the clock next to my bed and let out a groan. "Why the hell did you wake me up? My flight doesn't leave for another five hours."

"Come with me."

"I don't wanna." I collapsed back onto the bed and threw my arm over my eyes.

Ain't no way. Ain't no fucking way.

I'd stayed up late the night before, well into the early hours of the morning, just hanging out and spending what little time I had left with my family before the big move. There'd been drinking, laughter, constant bickering—our usual. And I had committed every second of it to memory.

Despite the fact that I was hungover and tired as all hell, it had been worth it.

“Lukyan.”

The seriousness in Aleksandr's voice made me peek out from under my arm. On the outside, my brother was colder than Antarctica in winter. But on the inside, he had a heart as warm as the sun. He hid that kindness behind an impenetrable wall, only allowing it to be seen in rare and important moments.

This was one of those moments. I could see it—a sense of fear and fragility on his face I'd only ever glimpsed once or twice in my life.

“Please,” he uttered softly.

I shot straight up. “I'll get dressed.”

* * *

ALEKSANDR TOOK ME OUTSIDE. We walked along the gravel footpath in silence. It was 7 a.m., and despite the fact that it was early, it was still as hot as Satan's balls.

The aftermath of the attack at my going-away party had all been cleaned up, the only remnants of it left behind being the bloodstained grass.

I wasn't sure what this whole thing was about, but I had the sneaking suspicion it held a great importance to my brother.

So, I went along with him. No questions. No jokes. No inappropriate comments or remarks. Just patience, which wasn't a trait I particularly possessed in situations such as that.

I could do it for him, though.

Based on the path he was taking us down, I knew exactly where we were going. Aleksandr was a few steps ahead of me, so I just followed his lead as he took us past the warehouse, continuing down the footpath and right to the shooting range behind it.

Sitting in the middle of the field was a large, wooden structure, designed with separate sections so multiple people could fire at once. Directly

opposite it, several miles down, were the targets, set up and spaced out evenly in correlation to the spots in the wooden structure.

Usually, the target range was a hive of activity. There was always someone there, practicing and honing their skills. But that time, it was empty, not a single soul in sight except for Aleksandr and me.

He walked into the shooting structure, went right to the slot in the middle, and turned to face me, arms crossed over his chest. Sitting on the bench were three different handguns. A Glock, 9mm Luger, and an MP-446 Viking.

I arched a brow. “Seriously? You’re *testing* me?”

Aleksandr said nothing. Just continued to stand there all tough and stoic and shit. I knew the drill. He wouldn’t say a damn thing or let me leave until I did whatever it was he wanted me to do.

I wasn’t an idiot, and could put two and two together.

Releasing a sigh that I made sure was loud as fuck so he could hear it, I picked up the Glock first, aimed—

“Disassemble,” he barked.

I gave him an incredulous look. *Fucking seriously?* Fine. Keeping my eyes on him, I disassembled the gun with practiced ease, not looking away from him once as I unclicked and took apart each piece, one at a time, placing them down on the bench. Then, without waiting for prompting, I put it all back together just as fast, turned slightly, and—

Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang!

I didn’t stop until I emptied the entire fucking clip into the target. Once it was empty, I ejected the clip, slapped in another one, adjusted to the target on my right, and fired again and again.

As soon as the bullets ran out, I switched the Glock for the Luger and did the whole thing again, disassembling and reassembling it all in the span of thirty seconds before taking aim and firing all the bullets in the clips at the targets in front of me.

I didn’t slow down. I didn’t stop. I went headfirst into the MP-446 Viking, taking it apart, putting it back together, and unloading all the bullets without an ounce of hesitation, my aim fucking perfect.

Aleksandr watched me, eyes as critical as ever as he studied my every single move.

When the final bullet left the MP-446 Viking, smoke billowing into the air from the barrel, I straightened, slammed the gun back down onto the

bench, and faced my brother head-on.

“Satisfied?”

The bastard, of course, didn’t answer me. He pressed the big red button on the pole next to him. The targets shot forward from their spots all the way across the field, thanks to the metal track they were on, and stopped right in front of us. He inspected each target closely, seeing exactly where each of the bullets landed.

Most of them where bullseyes because I was a good fucking shot. There was a stray one here or there that went somewhere else. Sometimes, I liked to mix it up a little. Some of them had shots in the stomach because a gunshot wound to the stomach was painful as shit, and sometimes, you didn’t want your opponent to just straight up die. You wanted to be able to interrogate them and ask questions before they died. A couple of the others had a few shots to the groin because...well...I was evil.

Aleksandr inspected each one closely. Methodically. With the eyes of someone actively looking for a mistake.

Irritation flashed through me, and I gritted my teeth to refrain from speaking my mind.

After what felt like thirty fucking minutes, he finally gave a stiff nod, pushed the button again, and the targets flew back to their designated spots.

I thought it was over. I *hoped* it was over, but of course, I should have known better. Aleksandr was on a mission, and when my brother had his mind set on something, nothing got in his way. Nothing stopped him.

He picked up the three handguns, deposited them on the bench beside him, and replaced them with an M16 assault rifle.

I rolled my eyes. *Here we fucking go.*

He flicked the lever underneath the button on the pole. Dozens of targets popped up across the field in a random, sporadic frenzy, impossible to anticipate. I picked up the assault rifle, checked it over quickly before hiking it up, my hold perfect, the heel of the gun tucked tightly into the crease of my shoulder, and fired.

Targets sprang up, one after the other after the other, all across the field. Sometimes, one at a time. Sometimes, two or three, spread out over a distance, forcing me to shoot and adjust my aim with sharp pivots left and right.

Bang-bang-bang-bang-bang-bang!

It was easy. As if I wasn't even in control of my own body, the muscle memory from years of doing that exact same exercise taking over and guiding my aim.

I blinked, and the whole thing was over, the magazine—filled with thirty rounds—completely empty. I ejected the empty mag, took the assault rifle apart, placing all the pieces down onto the bench as I went, and then turned to face my brother.

“Are we done now, or do you want to go check my shots?”

He went to check.

The dick.

Aleksandr knew I was being sarcastic. But he was testing me for God only knew what reason, and that testing involved checking if all my shots had hit their marks.

I leaned against the back wall, arms crossed over my chest, absolutely stewing in the angry and negative emotions circling inside me.

He's just looking out for you. He's just looking out for you. He's just—

“You missed one,” Aleksandr yelled out from the middle of the field.
—a *fucking asshole*, I growled in my head.

I tracked him with my eyes as he checked each of my targets, my anger bubbling inside me, higher and higher, threatening to boil over. I wasn't sure what I was expecting when he was finished. Maybe a *good job* or, fuck, even a *not bad*. But my brother gave me none of that. He marched back to me with his “drill sergeant” expression firmly plastered on his face, nodded once, turned, and started walking back up the path we came.

He's just looking out for you.

I repeated it over and over in my head as I followed him, like the words themselves held the power to quell the raging anger inside me.

They didn't. Each step I took, my anger grew, and I found it hard to keep it all back. A slight rustle came from behind me. It was *barely* audible—something that, under normal circumstances, I might not have even heard, but I'd been honing my skills, remaining hyperalert in all situations, thanks to my grandfather's antics.

A heartbeat later, I felt it. That *creepy* feeling of someone standing right behind you. In your personal space. Breathing down your fucking neck.

I always thought it was some strange defense mechanism our bodies had to alert us to the possibility of danger. Like it was saying, *look out, there's someone with unclear intentions behind you.*

Mine was going ballistic, and I always trusted my instincts.

They guided my body right, and I *just* missed the thrust of a blade. Another second later, and I would have had a knife firmly lodged in my side. I grabbed my attacker's wrist, plucked the knife from his hand, swung his arm back to flip him onto the ground, and jammed the knife into his chest in one quick, flawlessly executed move.

Except...nothing happened.

There was no shout of pain. No blood. Just...nothing.

With a frown on my face, I pulled the weapon away to see that it had a retractable blade.

It was fake.

What the fuck? Who tries to kill someone with a retractable—Oh, that motherfucker.

My gaze snapped to Aleksandr in front of me, rage not only *burning* in my eyes, but in my goddamn soul. “Seriously? *Another* test?”

He shrugged a shoulder, completely unashamed of his actions. The anger that had been slowly building inside of me for years reached breaking point.

“You know what? *Fuck you*,” I snarled, getting to my feet, nothing but my rage fueling me.

Aleksandr took a step back at the harshness of my tone.

Sure, I said shit like that all the time. I swore at my siblings. Fought with them. But that time? That time it was different.

And Aleksandr knew it.

“I am *sick* and *tired* of you and everyone else treating me like I’m goddamn incompetent. Like I don’t know how to do my fucking job.”

“Lukyan—”

“Oh, don’t fucking ‘Lukyan’ me. Do you have any idea how much it hurts to know you have such little faith in me?”

That impenetrable armor of his cracked. “I *do* have faith in you—” Aleksandr tried to insist, but my laugh cut him off before he could say anything else. It was one devoid of humor, filled with only derision and sorrow.

“No. You don’t. Let me ask you a question, Aleksandr. And if I’m wrong, I’ll apologize, and we can move on from this like nothing happened.” I crossed my arms over my chest and glared him down. “If

Nikolai was the one going to Russia, if *he* was the one leaving today, would you have pulled this same shit?”

Aleksandr stared at me, his silence speaking volumes, saying everything he was refusing to.

I shook my head. “You know what’s funny? I don’t even *need* you to answer that because I already know. Nikolai went into the fucking lion’s den *six months ago*. He went to an undisclosed location, completely unarmed, surrounded by enemies with absolutely no backup....His circumstances were ten times worse than mine, and yet, you didn’t feel the need to ‘test’ his skills, did you?”

When he said nothing, I pushed for the confirmation I so desperately needed.

“For once, Aleksandr—*just for once*—respect me enough to tell me how you really feel. Tell me the truth.”

His words came out stiff and uncomfortable, as if they’d been pulled from him one agonizing syllable at a time. “No, I didn’t feel the need to test Nikolai.”

“But you did with me.” I didn’t phrase it like a question, but he answered it as if it were one.

Body stiff, jaw locked, Aleksandr grunted, “Yes.”

Even though I already knew what he was going to say, it still hurt.

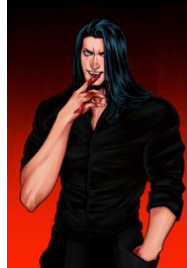
Knowing my big brother didn’t believe in me, thought I was nothing but a disappointment, cut deeper than any blade ever could. There was just something about letting down your older sibling that hit different.

Sadness took over Aleksandr’s usually cold and hard features. “*Ya prosto ne khochu, chtoby s toboy chto-to sluchilos’, bratishka.*” *I just don’t want anything to happen to you, little brother.*

I smiled, but it was all fake. “I have enough self-awareness to understand *I* am part of the problem. I behave and act a certain way, so you assume that is all I know how to be. It’s not. I can be just as serious and ruthless as you, Aleksandr. The difference between you and me is that you wear that shit on the outside. I choose to hide mine. Maybe try to remember that before you completely write me off next time.” I turned and walked away, not even giving him the chance to hurt me with whatever his reply would be.

CHAPTER TEN

LUKYAN VOLKOV



“Do you want me to hit you in the face with a chicken drumstick again? Coz I fucking will. Try me, Butcher.”

My head rolled along my shoulders until I caught sight of my father and Autumn sitting on the other side of the plane. Music blasted in my ears from my AirPods. Even so, somehow, against all fucking odds, I could *still* hear every single word coming from them.

The way they were arguing, I had no doubt people back on land could hear them.

The flight time to Russia was estimated to take between twelve to fourteen hours. We’d only been in the air for three, but it felt like it’d been a goddamn week with Mr. and Mrs. Bickerson over there.

Seriously. They needed to get a new form of foreplay. Otherwise, I was going to shoot myself in the head just for the peace and quiet.

“Go ahead, try it,” Father growled. “This won’t be like last time, devil woman. I’m not cuffed or tied down.”

Autumn smirked, fire dancing in her eyes. “You wanna be?”

I chose that moment to cough. *Loudly*. Autumn’s gaze moved to me, and a tinge of red stained her cheeks. She cleared her throat awkwardly.

“Sorry, Lukyan.”

Father smiled, leaned forward, and flicked her nose playfully. “Behave.” He gave her a light kiss on the side of her lips before getting up and coming over to join me.

I looked out the window as he took the seat opposite me. Clouds floated by, the light of the sun that beautiful mix between orange and red.

“How are you going?”

I took out my AirPods, since the fuckers weren't working anyway. “Fine,” I replied instantly, the lie falling from my tongue so easily. I'd gotten disappointingly good at concealing my true feelings from my own family.

“You don't seem like yourself. Does this have anything to do with why you didn't want to say goodbye to your brother?”

Sometimes, it really annoyed me how observant my father could be.

The final goodbye had gone pretty much exactly how I expected. Tatiana cried—hormones. Nikolai gave me a one-armed hug and told me to be careful. Illayana tried to be tough, but I could see the unshed tears in her eyes. Arturo said nothing, but nodded slightly, which *I* was interpreting as, *You're the man, Lukyan. I wish I could be more like you, Lukyan.* Drea talked a mile a minute, trying to give me some last-minute pointers on how to hurt someone with just a few touches here or there.

And Aleksandr...Well...he tried to say goodbye, but I was firmly in my petty era, and honestly, didn't feel like talking to him after what had happened earlier that morning.

I won't lie. The hurt that flashed in his eyes when I turned away from him and boarded the plane without saying a single word almost killed me.

I was mad at him for the shit he'd pulled and the constant lack of faith he had in me. But no matter how angry I was, I still loved him, and hated being the cause of that look on his face.

Father was staring at me, waiting for an answer.

“I wanna go over it again,” I said instead, ignoring what he'd asked altogether.

His lips pursed slightly in what I guessed was mild irritation. I could tell he didn't want to drop the subject. The mission took precedence, though, because of the danger it posed.

He rolled his shoulder, stretching it out. It was no longer in a sling, even though I knew it probably should have been. There was no way he was going to arrive in Russia and see Sergei with it on, though. He wouldn't want him to think he was hurt or weak. Easy pickings. He needed to appear strong. Unfathomable.

“The moment we land, you *must* be hypervigilant. Sergei will send a car to collect us. We will not get in it. I have organized our own transport that will pick us up from the airstrip and take us to the estate.”

“How do you know he will send a car?”

“Sergei tries to gain control over everything, no matter the situation. Something you and I view as small and insignificant, like a simple car ride from the airport, Sergei views as another attempt to exert his control over us. Now, your behavior plays a crucial part in making sure our plan is successful.”

“My behavior?” I frowned. He’d never mentioned anything about my behavior before. “Let me guess,” I blew out with a sigh. “You want me to tone it down, right? No stupid jokes. No sexual innuendos. No snarky comments.” Basically, be a big, boring dud.

Father smirked. “Actually, the complete opposite.”

My brows rose in slight surprise.

“I want *more*. More, Lukyan. Be your one hundred percent, crazy, carefree self, *moy syn. Chem bezumneye, tem luchshe.*” *My son. The crazier, the better, in fact.*

I chuckled, leaning back in my seat. “You’re gonna regret saying that to me.” He had no idea how *crazy* I could actually get.

No one was aware, but the Lukyan they knew was the mild, tamer version of me. A lot of the time, I had to hold myself back because I feared I was too much for them.

“In order for this to work, you need to play it up, and I’ll need to reprimand you and try to put you in your place. It has to look like you’re not a threat. That you’re just treating this entire thing like it is a fun vacation. We all have our parts to play. I want to tell you now that I do not mean anything I will say to you in Sergei’s presence. That, for this ruse to be believed, it has to look as though I am exasperated by your antics.”

“Makes sense.” I nodded.

“Once we get to the estate, he will separate us. Do not fight it. Go along with it,” Father continued, face calm. Focused. In the fucking zone. “It will be his attempt to get you alone to manipulate you. Let him think it’s working. When we land, it will be late. 9–10 p.m. From what I know, the wedding is the following day—”

“So soon?”

“You, Autumn, and I are invariables. Think of Sergei like a grandmaster chess player. He prepares for every possible scenario, thinking five, ten, fifteen steps ahead. We’re unpredictable. He doesn’t know what we will do, but he’ll try his best to foresee our actions and plan accordingly. The best

chance he has at making sure this wedding goes through without any complications is to have you at that altar as soon as possible. If he could, he'd have you there the second you stepped off the plane."

I was well aware of the fact that the deal my grandfather had with the Tarasovs was important. But the more Father spoke, the more I really started to understand how desperate Sergei was to have everything go right.

It made that devil on my shoulder whisper a sinister plan to fuck it all up just for the sake of it.

I wasn't going to listen. That bastard had gotten me into enough trouble to last me ten lifetimes.

Still, the idea was...interesting. Entertaining.

A stewardess came and stopped next to us. "Can I get you anything to drink?"

Father shook his head.

I leaned forward, staring intently at her chest that also happened to be where her name tag was. "Tahliaaaa," I murmured, rolling the name off my tongue. "That's a beautiful name."

She giggled.

The plane suddenly veered to the side. Tahlia shrieked and lost her footing, falling back into one of the seats behind her. My heart leaped in my chest, and I grabbed onto my seat at the same time Father did, holding on for dear life.

The plane leveled out not even a second later. "Apologies, folks, we seemed to have just experienced a little bit of turbulence," a female voice cut through the air.

"Jesus." I chuckled, clutching my chest with one hand. "I thought this was gonna turn into a *Yellowjackets* situation."

Autumn barked out a laugh. "Love that show."

"D-drink?" Tahlia asked, her voice shaking as she got back onto her feet. The turbulence must have freaked her out.

I waved her away politely, the look on my father's face drawing all of my attention. He looked tired. Exhausted not only physically, but also mentally. "You need to get some rest. All this shit with Grandfather...I'm guessing you've barely slept a wink."

"You couldn't be more right." He got to his feet, laying a hand on my shoulder. "You get some rest, too. Trust me when I say, you're going to need it for what's to come next."

He walked back and offered his hand to Autumn. She looked at him, shoved some of the food sitting in front of her into her mouth until it was overflowing, and then placed her hand in his, letting him help her up. They disappeared into the cabin at the back.

My head thumped back onto the headrest, and I closed my eyes, hoping to get some rest. Although my body began to relax, my mind did not. Too many thoughts were plaguing me. There was a ball of pressure sitting firmly on my chest, and I almost felt like it was stealing my ability to breathe.

There was so much riding on the mission. So much riding on *me*, and while I welcomed the chance to finally show my family exactly what I was capable of, I feared what would happen if I failed. *What if Aleksandr is right—*

No. Don't think that way. You won't fail. You're going to kill that old bastard for all the pain and suffering he's caused your loved ones, and everyone will bow at your feet for your masterfulness.

Damn fucking straight.

A rush of determination ran through me. *I can do this. I can fucking do this.*

* * *

THE PLANE LANDED in Moscow several hours later. Father had been right. The moment the doors opened, there they were, waiting on the tarmac for us.

One car, black, sleek, with a single man holding a place card with the name *Volkov* on it.

The other a big, imposing SUV, with two hulking, tattooed figures standing in front of it with their hands clasped behind their backs.

I had a feeling I knew which one belonged to Sally Sergei—

“Oh, fuck me, it's cold!” Autumn screeched behind me, her hands rubbing up and down her arms.

It was late November, which meant we'd arrived right in the middle of Russia's brutal winter. Decked out in dark trousers, long, thick wool coats, and black leather gloves, Father and I were dressed for the change in weather.

Autumn...was not.

She'd said, and I quote, "I run hot, I don't need a jacket".

Father had tried to convince her to change her mind, but she was as stubborn as he was when he had his mind set on something.

"What happened to 'I run hot'?" Father snapped, even as he removed his coat and placed it on her shoulders. He took off his beanie next, shoving it onto her head, following it up last with the gloves. Autumn shivered the whole time he put them on her.

Once she was dressed in everything my father could offer her, she placed a soft kiss on his lips, her teeth chattering. His face softened, warmth blazing in his eyes despite the cold air.

"Don't push me down the stairs this time," he murmured, chuckling softly.

Say what?

She gave him a dazzling smile. "Don't pretend like you didn't like it."

Father rolled his eyes. His features returned to normal. Hard. Stoic. With a touch of *I'll murder you in your sleep and then grab a bite of Chinese food afterward* before he turned around.

We made our way down the stairs, Father first, then Autumn, with me bringing up the rear. I was on edge, the weight of my weapons providing little to no comfort at all. Sergei and his men were enemies. They couldn't be trusted, their true intentions unknown.

Although we'd had lengthy discussions before we left about what could happen, the truth was...we didn't *really* know. Father assumed Sergei would never do something as stupid as murder his own son in his home.

What if he was wrong?

It didn't happen often, but it *did* happen.

Father could have completely underestimated Sergei, and he could just decide to take the easy option and kill him and Autumn now that they were within his reach.

I would do everything in my power to make sure that didn't happen, but even *I* knew my own strengths. Grandfather had an army at his back. It was just us three.

Although...so far...he'd been dead on the money. Granted, we'd only just arrived, but he'd said Grandfather would send a car, and the man did.

Maybe my father knew Sergei just as well as he thought.

The stewardess, Tahlia, and her partner, a man who looked to be in his early forties, were unloading the luggage from beneath the plane. They stood awkwardly, staring at the two different cars, unable to figure out where they were meant to put them.

Father ignored the car on the right, walking right past the two heavily tattooed men without even looking in their direction. Autumn and I followed.

“Mr. Volkov,” one of them called out, stepping forward. “Your father sent us to collect you.”

Father didn’t even slow his pace, walking straight up to the man holding the place card with our last name on it.

“Dimitri Volkov,” he greeted, extending a hand.

The man shook it. Nervousness vibrated from him. “H-hello sir, I’m Pedro. I wasn’t sure I was in the right place.”

“You are.” Moving to the back of the car, Father opened the door for Autumn. She thanked him and sat inside.

Now that it was clear which car we were going to, Tahlia and the man brought the luggage over and started loading it into the trunk. There wasn’t much. Just one suitcase for each of us and the bags we’d carried onto the plane.

If Grandfather asked about the lack of luggage, I already had a cover for it. If all went to plan, I wouldn’t be staying in Russia. After I killed Grandfather, I planned to go home. Sergei, of course, didn’t know that. So, I would tell him that the rest of my things would be getting shipped over in due time, even though I had no intention of doing so.

I moved to the other side of the car and opened the door.

“Mr. Volkov,” Sergei’s man tried again, his voice harsher, more insistent. “Your father will not like this.” The threat lying in his words was so obvious, even Pedro could hear it. He hurriedly rushed around the front of the car and got into the driver’s seat.

I smirked and leaned my arms on the roof of the car. “Sally Sergei will get over it, I’m sure.”

“I was not talking to you,” he said disdainfully.

“Are you talking to me now?”

“Why, you—”

“My son is correct,” Father cut in, opening the passenger-side door. “My father will get over it.” And then he climbed in, shutting the door

behind him.

The man's mouth gaped open. His gaze cut to me. I smiled, waggling my fingers in the air before blowing him a kiss and disappearing into the car.

"You have the location?" Father asked Pedro.

"Yes, sir."

Father nodded. "Let's go."

The engine roared to life, and then we were off. We drove parallel to the aircraft, and just as we turned, I saw a woman step out from inside the plane. I turned around to look out the back window as we continued to drive away.

She stood at the top of the stairs, dressed in black pants, a white button-up shirt with all the bells and whistles of a pilot uniform, right down to the hat on her head. She was staring right at the car, straight at me, as the vehicle moved further and further away.

Familiarity sparked.

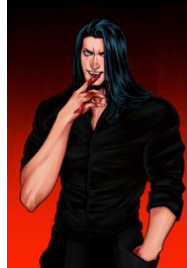
The hat and ongoing distance concealed the woman's face, so I wasn't able to see her completely, but my body hummed with awareness regardless. Curiosity streaked through me.

Her hand raised into the air, and she waved.

I didn't know why, but I waved back.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

LUKYAN VOLKOV



I'd been to my grandfather's compound before. Several times. But no matter how many times I saw it, it still blew my fucking mind.

Huge stone walls with barbed wires on the top. Dozens of men, women, and dogs on foot patrol. Tall, impenetrable towers were home to what I knew were teams of two with high-powered sniper rifles.

It reminded me of a military base.

Or a prison.

Yeah. Based on what awaited me inside, *prison* sounded better.

"Remember what we discussed," Father said from the front seat as the driver pulled up to the gate.

"Be my usual, dazzling self with added flair. Don't worry, Pops, I gotchu."

He turned, giving me an odd, perplexed look.

I flashed my teeth. "I've always wanted to call you that. Now seems like the perfect time, what with you wanting me to bring a little extra *Lukyan* to the table and all."

"I like it," Autumn chimed in beside me.

"You know what, I *knew* you would," I said back excitedly.

"It suits you, Butcher," Autumn added.

I punched her playfully on the shoulder. "We're like one mind! I think so too."

Father grunted and faced the front again. "Stop here and wind the window down, please," he told the driver.

Visibly pale and shaking, Pedro did as instructed, stopping right next to the guard dressed in military clothing and armed with a huge-ass machine gun.

Nice.

“Eto chastnaya sobstvennost’.” This is private property.

“Otkroy vorota, Viktor.” Open the gate, Viktor, Father barked out, his voice like ice. Cold. Hard. Very Boss Bitch.

Viktor bent at the waist and looked into the car.

“Dimitri, ne upolnimichena prokhodit’ cherry vorota—” Dimitri, this car is not authorized to pass the gate—

Father whipped out his gun, his arm stretched out in front of Pedro so the barrel was pointing right at Viktor’s head.

Viktor touched the radio on his vest, not taking his eyes off the gun. *“Otkroy vorota.” Open the gate.*

“Oooo, he’s so dead,” I sang.

Autumn looked at me. “What do you mean?”

“He should have called to ask for permission first. Grandfather will kill him for letting in an unauthorized vehicle.” I was only partly kidding. I was sure my grandfather would punish him, but I doubted it would be anything that extreme.

As the gate slowly began to open, I unbuckled my seatbelt and wedged myself between the two front seats. “Hey, Vik, think I can get one of those machine guns?”

“Drive,” Father ordered.

The car drove forward. I *tsked*, went back to my seat, and quickly wound down the window, sticking my head out. “I’ll hit you up later, yeah?!” I yelled out as we moved past the gatehouse. “Is it new?! What’s the model number—” Someone yanked me back into the car.

I expected to see a pair of annoyed, exasperated blue eyes staring into my goddamn soul, but all that greeted me was my father’s face, shrouded in humor.

“Keep it up.” He winked.

An evil, giddy feeling filled my body. Like he’d said on the plane, we all had our parts to play. Me, the annoying yet extremely loveable son of the grumpy, oh-so-serious Bratva Butcher.

My father, the fed up, exasperated parent, sick and tired of his child’s crazy antics.

And Autumn? Well, I hadn't quite figured out her role yet. But she did a pretty good job at calming my father down when he was pissed off...so there was that.

"Holy fucking shit balls," Autumn whispered under her breath. "You guys are like, *rich* rich. I guess that twenty-million-dollar bounty he put on you was just chump change for him, huh?" Her eyes were glued to the obscenely large, oversized McMansion sitting on the hill a short distance away.

Over 30,000 square feet, luxurious, with more bedrooms and bathrooms than one person needed...It was the epitome of wealth.

Seriously.

I counted them once. There were sixteen bathrooms.

Sixteen.

Who the fuck needed sixteen goddamn bathrooms? What, did he wake up every morning and go, *Hmm, what bathroom am I going to shit in this morning? Oh, I know, bathroom number nine. I haven't been in there in a while.*

Ridiculous. Absolutely ridiculous.

Grand floor-to-ceiling mahogany double doors opened as we made our way around the large water fountain.

Yes. You read that right. *Water fountain.* And it was three times the size of our car. It was so big it was used as a roundabout for vehicles to enter and exit easily.

Grandfather stood on the front porch, two linebacker bodyguards at his back. I hated the dude with the passion of a thousand fiery suns...but if I could look *half* as good as him when I was in my late seventies, I'd be cheering.

Tall, broad-shouldered, and stoic, he was remarkably fit for someone creeping up to eighty. With his full head of silver hair and scars that littered his skin, Sergei looked like he'd lived a long, tough-as-fuck life. That nothing could take him down.

Which was exactly what he wanted people to see.

"Who's that?" Autumn asked.

A man stepped out onto the porch. Average height. Average build. Average face.

Mr. Average.

He stopped and stood next to Grandfather. His clothes *screamed* money, right down to the fancy Ferragamo Oxfords on his feet.

Father frowned, looking at him. "I don't know." He handed Pedro a wad of bills, thanking him. "We'll collect our luggage."

With shaky hands, he took the money, nodding.

Deciding to take the reins, I stepped out of the car first in a big, over-the-top flourish.

"The king has arrived!" I announced, arms out wide. I jogged up the porch steps and encircled my grandfather in a great, big bear hug, despite the absolutely revolting feeling doing so left in my stomach. "Grandpappy! How the hell are ya?" I pulled back and gave him a friendly but *very fake* smile as I squeezed his shoulder. "You're looking goooooood. You been workin' out?"

"Lukyan," Father called out.

I glanced over my shoulder to see the car was gone, Father and Autumn standing at the base of the stairs with our luggage next to them. If it weren't for our talk on the plane, I would have actually believed he had the shifts.

He and Autumn moved up at the same time I stepped back again, and we ended up side by side in front of Grandfather and Mr. Average.

I finally got a proper look at Sergei, and oh, boy, he was not happy about that display. The rage simmering in his blue eyes was enough to set the whole house ablaze.

Heh. Heh.

"I trust you all had a pleasant flight," Grandfather said in perfect English.

Father hid his surprise well. Sergei barely spoke English. That was the first time I'd ever heard him do it in his own house before.

Like, *ever*.

I had no such reservations to hide my surprise. I pretended to clean out my ear, making a *squeak, squeak* sound. "Did you just speak English? *In your own home?*"

His eyes narrowed in irritation.

"*Dostatochno priyatnym,*" *Pleasant enough*, Father replied, voice clipped.

"English, Dimitri," Sergei snapped. "It is rude to talk in front of another person in a language they cannot understand."

Ahhh, so he is doing it for Mr. Average over there. Whoever he was, he was important enough for Grandfather to change something absolutely fundamental about himself.

That was slightly terrifying.

Autumn scoffed. She and Father looked at each other. Something unseen flashed between them. Something only *they* knew the meaning of.

Sergei's gaze flicked to her. I held my breath, curious how he was going to play it.

"Nice to see you again, Sergei Lekovich Volkov," Autumn said boldly.

Fuck. Okay. So she was just going right for the jugular. Had to love the woman's style.

Grandfather looked her up and down, judgment clear as day on his face. "I don't believe we have met, Miss?"

So that's how he's playing it, then. Plausible deniability.

A smirk played on Autumn's lips. "My mistake. You look an awful lot like a man who attempted to do business with me. Autumn DeValos," she said, placing a hand on her chest.

"I am sure I would remember doing business with a woman as lovely as yourself." An evil look took over his face. "I must admit, I was surprised to hear my son would be bringing a plus-one to the wedding. He was so besotted with his dead wife, you see. I feared he would never move on. What was her name again? Oh, that's right. Yekaterina."

Autumn and I stiffened. *That fucking bastard.* The gall he had to bring up my mother like that. Like she was just a shot to take at my father. My hands squeezed into tight fists, and I had to hold myself back from launching at him.

Father didn't rise to the bait, and I was thankful. He'd fought through all his demons when it came to my mother. Her name no longer brought forth those feelings of guilt and anguish within him.

The tiny bit of fear I could see in Autumn's eyes, however, told me she wasn't as sure about that as I was. I could understand, given what had happened the last time, but Father reassured her by grabbing her hand and giving it a tight, supportive squeeze.

"We all move on eventually. Yekaterina is my past. Autumn is my future. Now, if there's nothing else, we've had a long flight, and would like to get settled."

Grandfather took control and flat-out ignored what he said. “This is Vernon Miseris. He’s a colleague, and will be attending the wedding tomorrow.” He signaled to Mr. Average at his side.

“Hi, Vernon. It’s an absolute pleasure to make your acquaintance,” I lied out of my ass. “I’m Lukyan. That’s Dimitri, my father, and his girlfriend, Autumn. Now that we’ve been introduced, your boy is going inside because I am *starving*. You guys coming?” Without waiting for approval, I walked past Grandfather and into the house. “Love what you’ve done with the place, Grandpappy!” I yelled over my shoulder. “It’s giving nice old man vibes. Love it.”

I was only partly lying. It was actually a very nice McMansion. Plenty of lighting. Lots of space. Expensive furniture. Floor-to-ceiling windows I knew were bulletproof. Grand, opulent chandeliers hanging from the ceiling. Large spiral staircase leading up to the top levels.

Fucking bingo. There was my out.

I moved toward the stairs—

A hand on my shoulder halted me. “Where are you running off to, boy?” I barely managed to hold back a sneer at my grandfather’s touch. “We haven’t seen each other for years. Come. I’ve got food laid out in the kitchen for you. You said you were hungry, no?”

Well, fuck me sideways. I couldn’t exactly say, *No, your presence disgusts me.* I plastered on my fake smile and turned to face him. The look on his face told me I had no say in the matter. “Sure, Grandpappy. I’d love to.”

Father, Autumn, and Mr. Average were behind him.

“Excellent.” He stepped closer to me, keeping his hand on my shoulder. “Your father and Autumn may retire to their rooms. You are in the east wing,” he told them, gesturing with his hand to the left.

The intention was clear—they were not invited to dinner.

Father’s jaw clenched the slightest bit. He nodded. Taking Autumn’s hand, he led her through the large lounge room on the left. Four guards appeared as if out of thin air, following behind them.

Another tick for Father. He was right. Sergei was going to have him followed the entire time we were there.

Applying a bit of pressure to my shoulder, my grandfather signaled for me to go forward. “Let’s go.”

* * *

I SAT across from Sergei at the dining table. It was huge. Far too big for one person, but that was how my grandfather liked to do things—grand and over the top. It was big enough to seat at least thirty people. He sat at one end, and I sat all the way at the other. The table was set, two tall candles in candle holders in the middle, and food laid out across the surface.

Mr. Average was there, too, for what reason, I had no idea. He was sitting to Sergei's left, not touching any of the food. Neither was Grandfather.

Me, on the other hand? Yeah, I was eating that shit up. I wasn't lying when I said I was hungry.

There was a plate in front of me, but I ignored it, opting to just grab things left and right and shove them into my mouth with no decorum. My phone sat on the table next to me, and I couldn't help but glance at it every few minutes, eagerly waiting to get some sort of message from my stalker.

She'd been strangely quiet since my departure. I'd expected her to stop me, in all honesty, and I was a little disappointed she hadn't. If not that, I at least wanted her to make some sort of communication expressing her unhappiness about the upcoming nuptials.

But...nothing.

Just radio silence.

It made me suspicious. *What the hell is she planning?*

"Your father has explained what is expected of you tomorrow?" Sergei asked.

I looked up, biting into a chicken drumstick. *Delicious*. "Mmhmm." I spotted roasted potatoes, and my other arm shot out, fork in hand, and pierced one, bringing it to my lips. "Wait at the altar, say *I do*, and viola, you have your trade routes."

Sergei's lips thinned. "You seem unusually calm about the entire thing. You do not protest to the union?"

"Not really." I dumped the chicken drumstick into a bowl of gravy and took another bite. "Why would I? Does she have a shitty personality or something?"

"I have not spoken with her, so I do not know."

"Hmm. That's disappointing. What's he doing here?" I asked, pointing at Mr. Average with the fork in my other hand.

“I told you. He is—”

“A colleague. Right.”

“I see your manners have not improved over the years.” Sergei’s voice held a bitter tone, displaying his displeasure. “Do you need me to give you a lesson in respecting your elders?”

“No, thanks, I’m not twelve.”

My head was yanked back painfully, and suddenly, there was a knife right at my throat. I stared up into the face of one of Grandfather’s soldiers. His face was hard, eyes dead, devoid of any humanity.

“This disrespect will cease, or I will have you punished. Is that clear?” Grandfather said. I knew he was being serious. That I should probably be scared, and tread lightly from then on.

That just wasn’t me.

If I’d had any sense, I’d have rolled over and apologized. But let’s be honest, I had none.

My head still tilted back, knife at my throat, I reached up and bit into the chicken drumstick, holding it there. Then, I grabbed the soldier’s wrist and twisted. A *crack* hit the air, and he cried out in pain. I was up in a flash, spinning around him while keeping his wrist locked in my grip, and then slammed him face down onto the table, his arm bent back behind him. The knife was still in his hand. I plucked it out of his grasp and rammed it into the table right beside his head.

I flicked my hair out of my face and pulled the drumstick from my teeth, chewing softly. “Clear, Grandpappy.”

There was anger in my grandfather’s eyes *for sure*, but there was also a sliver of pride. Sergei loved strength. “Do not call me that. Release him and sit.”

“Okay.” The devil on my shoulder whispered something in my ear. I listened. I shoved the soldier’s arm up harshly, and another loud *crack* followed. He screamed. I let him go, and he crumbled to the floor, trying and failing to hold his broken shoulder.

I cleared my throat. “Excuse me. Let me just squeeze in here,” I said to the man crying on the floor as I tried to wedge myself between him and the chair. “Yep, that’s it, a little more to the side. Ah, thank you,” I blew out, sitting back down.

He continued to moan in pain, writhing on the floor. We all ignored him.

“So, what line of work are you in, Mr. Average?” I asked, reaching for more food.

Vernon frowned. He opened his mouth—

“It is of no concern to you, boy. Now, enough with the antics. Tomorrow is very important, and I will not have you ruin it all with this behavior. I am assuming your father told you what is at risk if this wedding does not go through?”

I stiffened.

Grandfather smiled. It was evil. Fucking sinister. “Ah, yes. He has. Make no mistake, Lukyan, I have no problem following through with it.”

I kept myself still, for fear that if I didn’t, I’d try to kill the fucker right there and then, all the guards in the house be fucking damned.

“I expect you to be on your best behavior. You will stand at that altar and do your duty as a Volkov, and that is it. There will be no scheming. No trying to weasel your way out of this. You’re bought and paid for, Lukyan. Like a grand, prized show horse”—*that old fucker*—“and so long as you do as you’re told, Illayana will be safe.” He picked up his knife and fork and slowly cut into the meat on his plate. “Now, tell me, what does my son have planned?”

“Why would he have something planned? Have you done something to warrant him rebelling against you, Grandfather?” I asked casually.

Darkness washed over him. It was a risky move, calling him out like that, and in all honesty, I probably shouldn’t have done it. But he’d crossed the line, threatening Illayana like that. The bastard deserved it.

“Of course not,” he responded, taking a sip from his crystal glass. “But I know my son. He does not like to have his hand forced. So, save all the trouble his failed attempt will cause and just tell me what he has planned to stop this wedding.”

“Nothing.” I stuck my fork into a bowl of beef stroganoff and spun it slowly. I had to make him believe there was nothing going on. That we had nothing planned. That we weren’t trying to...you know...kill him. “Do you really think Father would do anything to risk Illayana’s life? She’s his favorite, you know.” I popped the food into my mouth, chewing lightly. “I mean, I won’t lie. Father would definitely love to see your head on a stick, but he’d never do anything to endanger Illayana. You hold all the cards.”

The twinkle in his eyes told me he liked that. Sergei *liked* being told how good he was. That he was in charge. In control.

“I do, don’t I?”

Smug bastard.

“Business going well?” I asked, trying to keep a knowing smirk off my lips.

His body locked up. “Why would you ask that?” His voice was strained. Harsh. Worried.

My senses came to life like a shark recognizing blood in the water. “Because I’m bored, and you don’t exactly have the most riveting and dazzling personality. No offense.” Casual was my forte. I had a lifetime of practice in hiding my true intentions. While on the outside, it looked like I hadn’t caught the subtle change that question brought forth in him, I had.

My attention turned to Mr. Average. He sat silently, eating his food at a slow, unhurried pace. He didn’t try to join in on the conversation or offer any comments. It was like he was a fly on the wall, just watching the events take place.

What is he doing there? What is his purpose? And why is he watching my grandfather so fucking closely?

Sergei’s body relaxed ever so slightly. “Business is business,” he replied briskly. He cleared his throat and wiped his lips with a napkin. “Everything is in place for tomorrow. The limo will be here at 9:00 a.m. to take you to the venue. Be waiting outside. *Do not* be late.”

That was a little surprising. Given how serious he’d been lately about ensuring the wedding went through without any problems, I expected him to be by my side, taking me there himself. The fact that he wouldn’t be meant that something else needed his attention. Something more important.

I nodded. “Yes, Grandfather.”

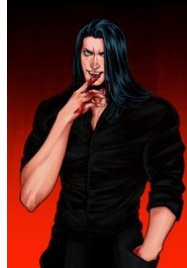
“Good.” He continued to talk, and I continued to pretend to listen, giving an odd, “Yes, sir,” or “No, sir,” or “Whatever you say, sir.”

Father was right. He laid the manipulation on thick, trying to confuse me and keep me off balance. He would act like a downright dickhead, and then change it up by trying to be my friend and asking about my life. What I liked to do. My favorite food. As if he really gave a shit.

Mr. Average didn’t speak once.

CHAPTER TWELVE

LUKYAN VOLKOV



Here it is. My motherfucking wedding day.

I looked into the mirror, adjusting my cerulean tie. I'd chosen that color specifically to bring out the shine in my pretty blue eyes. My hair was up high in a bun. It accentuated the sharpness of my jawline, and a black, fitted three-piece suit was molded to my frame.

The whole event might not have been something I'd have chosen for myself, but I was going to make damn sure I looked good doing it.

I picked up my cuff links from the bathroom counter next, putting them on. I'd received numerous messages from my siblings, all wishing me well. Their words of encouragement meant a lot. Especially coming from Aleksandr.

We hadn't spoken since I left, and even though I was yet to reply to him, I'd already decided I would call him later that night, after the wedding and festivities were over, and squash whatever bullshit was going on between us. Life was too short to bicker over such meaningless and frivolous shit. I could literally die at any moment if I stepped out of line. If my grandfather uncovered the secret plot to kill him and take over. I didn't want to die with unresolved issues.

Light, bassy music played in the air as I moved out of the en suite and into the main bedroom—a piss-poor attempt to try to lighten my mood after the conversation with Sergei the night before.

It had put everything into perspective. Highlighted exactly what was at risk if I didn't succeed. Pressure had squeezed my chest all night, making it impossible to catch even a minute of sleep. I was too busy planning.

While my father was being watched every hour, every second, I had no one. There wasn't a single guard monitoring my movements. It worked in my favor, sure, but it also pissed me the fuck off because it meant my grandfather didn't think I was a big enough threat to even bother with surveillance.

I was going to make him look me in the eyes when I killed him so he could see exactly how much he had underestimated me.

A knock sounded at my bedroom door.

"Yep?"

Father and Autumn walked in. Behind them stood a guard detail of four.

I arched an eyebrow. "Four?" I laughed, sitting down on the bed. A pair of black dress shoes sat at my feet. "Grandfather *really* doesn't trust you."

"It's actually insulting, if you ask me." Autumn strolled further in, her heels *click-clacking* along the marble floor. She was dressed in a beautiful, floor-length green dress, her blazing red hair up in a fancy updo. "That he thinks *four* will be enough to stop me if I want to do something." Autumn scoffed, shaking her head. "Insulting," she repeated.

Father followed her inside, the hint of a smile playing on his lips. He wore a dark suit, much like my own, but his tie was red, and it matched the pocket square in his breast pocket. "Yes, you made that abundantly clear when we opened the door and saw them standing in the hallway."

She shrugged. "I was annoyed. *I* warrant *at least* six. Maybe seven. Add in the three for you, and we should have a guard detail of ten, not a measly four. It's offensive. I have a reputation to uphold here."

"Wait a second, why do *I* only have three?"

Autumn gave him a look that could only be described as *Oh, honey*.

Father put a hand up in the air, palm outward. "You know what? Don't answer that. We don't have time to argue."

Autumn pouted. "What about later?"

"Fine. Later."

Because scheduling a time to argue was completely normal behavior.

He turned to look at me. I'd just finished putting on my shoes, and was officially all dressed and ready to go. "Let me look at you."

I stood.

His eyes traveled up and down my frame. He fixed the lapels on my jacket, straightening them, and then brushed my shoulders. "I hate that this

is your fate. I wanted you to marry for love, not for some trade deal for your grandfather.”

I shrugged. Everyone else seemed to care more about the whole thing than I did. Probably because no one knew what I had planned to get out of it. “Love can grow. Look at you and Autumn. Didn’t you two hate each other when you first met?”

Autumn snorted. “That’d be an understatement. He tried to kill me.”

“You tried to kill *me* first,” he said back, affronted.

“I don’t remember it that way.”

Father rolled his eyes. “Anyway, while yes, you’re right—love *can* grow—this was never the path I envisioned for you. But maybe this can be the start of a great adventure for you. After you’re married, we can step into negotiations and see about having the two of you move back to Las Vegas. Or would you prefer to stay?” His eyes did a slow sweep of the room, and he squeezed my shoulder.

I understood what he was trying to say without needing to hear the words. Grandfather most likely had a bug planted somewhere in the room—several, if I had to bet on it, and he was probably listening right that minute. Father was talking as though we had no plan to overthrow him. As if we were truly there to honor Grandfather’s orders without putting up any resistance.

“I’m happy to stay,” I answered, playing along. “As long as you can convince my idiot siblings to come and visit.”

He allowed his lips to quirk just a fraction. “I’m sure I can do that. You have everything you need?”

“Yep. I’m as ready as I’ll ever be, I guess.”

Father nodded. “I’ve looked into her. Your future wife. She seems nice. Sweet. I think you’ll like her.”

There was nothing wrong with sweet. Sweet was good. Safe.

It also sounded boring as hell.

“Cool.”

“You might want to act a little more excited.” Humor danced across Autumn’s face. “It’s your wedding day, after all.”

I flashed my teeth in a wide, open smile.

Autumn chuckled. “Better. Totally believable.”

“How was dinner last night?” Father asked, doing a lap of the room. His eyes ran over everything, searching every nook and cranny.

“Fine. It was pretty much what you’d expect. Food. Awkward small talk. A little light threatening with a side of assholery. You know, the usual.” I moved to the dresser and picked up a bottle of cologne. “There’s something off about Mr. Average.”

Autumn’s brows lowered. “Who?”

“Vernon,” I clarified, spraying the cologne at the column of my throat. “I don’t know what it is, but there’s something going on between him and Grandfather. Something they’re trying to hide.”

Father came to a stop in the center of the room, shoving his hands into the pockets of his trench coat. “I wouldn’t concern yourself with it. Your only focus right now should be the wedding, and making sure everything goes off without any problems. There’s too much at stake to think about anything else.”

He was saying that for Sergei’s benefit. So the old fart would think we were toeing the line. Falling into place. That we weren’t secretly doing the very thing he feared...planning a rebellion.

“You’re right,” I blew out. “I just can’t shut my brain off.” That wasn’t exactly right. I just couldn’t shut my brain off about one specific thing, and I was desperately grasping onto anything else in an attempt to keep my mind distracted. To keep myself from thinking about her.

Moya malen’kaya ten’. My little shadow.

Why haven’t I heard from her? She’d proven time and time again that she possessed the capability of finding out information—information she wasn’t really privy to. She would have known I was getting married, and yet, she’d done nothing about it.

No messages. No creepy love notes. In the past, she’d shown up and straight up murdered any woman who so much as *looked* in my direction, declaring her undying love for me and how we were soulmates. Destined to be together. But she’d done absolutely nothing about the fact that I was literally hours away from tying myself to another person?

Nothing?!

It didn’t make sense.

Clearing my throat, I checked my watch. 8:47 a.m. Still plenty of time. “What are my future in-laws like? Have you met them?”

Father’s lips twisted in displeasure. “Yes.” He started spouting off details about them as if he were reading them off an informational fact sheet. Small family, but with a lot of influential power and connections.

They weren't an active family within the Bratva, which was why Sergei had no control over them. But Anya's father, Akim, was the brother of some high-ranking government official, and therefore, had the strings to pull some pretty big favors.

"Akim is the definition of a man who feels as if he is owed the world. I've met him several times at high society functions. Although he uses his brother's success and connections for his own gain, he's jealous of the attention and wealth his brother possesses, and wants it desperately for himself."

"Sounds familiar," I commented. My fucktard of an uncle was a lot like that. Didn't end too well for him.

"This deal is an opportunity of a lifetime for Akim," Father continued. "It's his chance to get his foot in the door. To get out from underneath his brother's name and create his own. By marrying his daughter off into the Bratva, he opens up avenues. Connections he might not have been able to establish without his brother. He will no doubt use that as a stepping stone to gain more power. More influence."

"So he's power-hungry and willing to sacrifice his only daughter to get what he wants?"

"Yes."

"Dickhead." I moved over to the gold-plated circular mirror on the wall and did a final fit check. I hated people like that—those who were willing to sacrifice their family, the ones they were meant to love and protect, for their own selfish gain. "So steer clear of the father," I stated. "A man with such desperation to become something is dangerous." Too dangerous to try to take on with everything going on.

"That would be wise," he blew out, running a hand through his hair.

"Fine. But if he gets in my face, I can't guarantee I won't put him in his place." I accepted disrespect from my family because they were my family. I kinda didn't have a choice in it. But *never* from anyone else.

"I would expect nothing less."

Good.

I checked my phone one more time, knowing there was no message from my little shadow, but still feeling the disappointment nonetheless. "I should go. Grandfather told me to be waiting outside the gates at 9:00 a.m. for the car. Will you be coming with me?"

“Of course.” Father made his way back to Autumn. He put his arm around her, pulling her into his side. “Let’s go.”

When we got to the front gate, Viktor stood on guard, that cool-as-fuck machine gun in his hands. He was missing something, though.

His. Fucking. Eye.

There was a big white bandage over his left eye, and it didn’t take a genius to figure out it had been cut out of him.

“Youch,” I commented, stopping in front of him. “What the fuck happened there?”

He did nothing but sneer at my father.

I looked over my shoulder, my mouth dropping open. “Did Grandfather do that because he let us through the gate yesterday when he wasn’t supposed to?” I whispered under my breath.

Grimly, Father nodded once.

Fucking hell. Talk about ruthless.

“One more infraction, and he’ll lose a limb. After that, he’ll be useless to Sergei, and he will most likely dispose of him.”

The gate opened. I gave Viktor an awkward smile because I kinda felt bad for the dude. “A little harsh, don’t you think?” I asked, walking out.

Father shrugged, as if he was used to that level of brutality. “Sergei gives three chances. The first infraction, fifty whips to the back. The second, loss of an eye. The third, a limb. He makes them choose which one they want to part with. After that, well...”

Yeah. Death.

A black limo was parked out on the street. “Ooo, riding in style. Nice.”

We all piled into it. Once seated, I took a look around. I’d never been inside a limo before. At the very front was an opening with a partition that separated the front from the back. It was lowered. A woman sat in the driver’s seat. She didn’t turn around, keeping her head forward. I glimpsed a lock of honey blonde hair peeking out from the bottom of the black cap on her head.

The engine roared to life, and the vehicle moved, heading to our destination. My father pushed a small bottle of vodka into my hands. It was like one of those ones you’d see in a minibar at a hotel room.

“Some liquid courage. You’ll need it for what comes next.”

I took it and downed the whole thing in one gulp. I wasn’t nervous about what was to happen. More...apprehensive. A thousand things could

go wrong, and I had no control over any of it.

* * *

WE PULLED up at the venue. It was nice. Basic. To be quite honest, though, given my Grandfather's net worth, I would have expected something a little more boujee.

I got out of the car, walked through the lobby, and was ushered into a reception area in a trance. Almost as if I weren't in control of my own body. Like I was an outsider, watching on from above.

Before I knew it, I was standing at the altar beneath a floral arch. A man dressed in black robes was standing beside me. An aisle ran down the center of the room. There were minimal decorations. Minimal thought put into any of it. It made me purse my lips in distaste as I stared out into the room. The color scheme was completely wrong. Not to mention the fact that they'd chosen beige Napoleon chairs.

Beige.

If I had any say in it, this wouldn't have been what my wedding looked like. And I for damn sure wouldn't have selected yellow roses as the primary flower choice.

Father and Autumn sat in the front row on the right-hand side, his hand on her thigh, her hand on top of his, both giving me supportive smiles. There were a few random people in the background. People I'd never seen before—or, more than likely, never paid attention to before. The same went for the left side. I recognized no one except for my father and Autumn. My grandfather was nowhere in sight. Neither were any of his men or Mr. Average.

I wondered if we were in the right place. It didn't make sense that we'd get to the venue before Sergei did. Especially when this marriage was such a big deal for him. That he had so much at stake.

I turned to the man beside me. "What are the names of the people you're marrying?"

He frowned slightly. "Lukyan Volkov and Anya Tarasova."

Okay. So definitely in the right place then. Just to be safe, I pulled out my phone to message Sergei. With so much at risk, I couldn't afford for

something as trivial as being in the wrong location to screw everything up. When I glanced at the screen, I saw that I already had a message from him.

Sally Sergei: Running late. Continue without me.

WEIRD.

I shrugged, tucking my phone back away. That was all the confirmation I needed. I was never usually that paranoid, but with so much at stake, I couldn't help being extra vigilant.

The doors at the back of the room opened, and I held my breath. An older man stepped through, a beautiful woman around the same age on his arm in a floor-length black dress.

I released my breath. *Not her.*

Father glanced over his shoulder, his body tensing slightly when he caught sight of them. He watched the man walk down the aisle, eyes like a hawk, and take a seat in the front row on the left hand side. Tension filled the air as the two men stared each other down.

He needed no introduction. I knew the man who'd just entered was my future father-in-law.

He was big. Brawny. Mean-as-fuck attitude. He and Father continued to glare at one another before his gaze swung my way and locked on me. He had a scary vibe, sure. But I wasn't the least bit intimidated. Respectful protocol dictated I approach him. Introduce myself. I *was* marrying his daughter, after all. The look in his eyes told me he expected me to do just that. To greet him...

Yeah, I wasn't going to do that.

We locked into a stare down, neither one of us wanting to be the first to look away. Usually, I liked to keep an outward appearance of being aloof. Carefree. Mischievous. I hid the murderous, vicious beast that lived deep beneath my skin, never letting anyone else see it unless I was about to kill them. The fear that flashed in their eyes when they saw that side of me, the change, always made it worth it.

But this time...This time, I *wanted* to let the beast fucking free. Everyone thought that because I liked to crack jokes and have fun, I didn't have a dark side.

They couldn't have been more fucking wrong.

A cold, unrelenting darkness swept over me. The smile that was always on my face dropped, and the beast reared its head, shining out through my eyes. I stared him down, face hard as stone. A flicker of fear flashed across Akim's face. He squirmed ever so slightly in his seat, and his gaze fell to the floor.

I internally scoffed. Akim was all for show. He thought that because he was big and looked scary, and I was young with a playful, carefree attitude, that I was weak. That he could intimidate me into submission.

I would never submit to anyone.

Soft classical music hit the air. The doors at the back of the room opened. It took a considerable amount of effort and energy, but I wrangled the darkness back into its cage, plastered my signature smirk back onto my face, and stood taller just as a figure stepped through.

The first thing I saw was the white, ball gown-style wedding dress. It was a conservative type of dress. Not an ounce of skin was on display, lace winding up her arms, across her chest and up her neck. A veil covered the majority of her face, only a set of ruby lips on display. Everyone rose to their feet.

She glided down the aisle as if walking on air. Her manicured fingers grasped a bouquet of flowers in her hand. Her footsteps weren't rushed. They were calm. Collected. Not an ounce of nervousness.

I tracked her every movement, my eyes fixated on her as she made her way toward me. When her foot landed on the first stair, I took a step and held out my palm. Her hand slipped into mine with zero hesitation, her skin smooth and soft. Electricity shot up my spine. I took that as a good sign.

With a small pull, I guided her the rest of the way until she stood right in front of me. Our hands dropped back to our sides. She was tall. The heels she wore made her only a little bit shorter than me, her head coming up to my chin.

Silence reigned over the room. The veil was thick enough that it stopped me from seeing her face at all, but I knew we were looking into each other's eyes. The suspense was fucking killing me. I'd spent so long wondering what my future wife looked like. Spent so long stopping myself from searching for her online because I wanted to be surprised, and now, she was there, standing right in front of me.

The priest began to speak, jumping right into the proceedings, his words going in one ear and out the other, barely registering.

Shouldn't I be more excited?

Shouldn't my thoughts be on her?

They weren't. All I could think about was what a big fucking mistake I was making. I knew I had to do it. I knew I had no choice. But I just couldn't shake the feeling that it was wrong. I wanted to fucking run. Being forced into a spot like that, given no option, no choice...I hadn't thought it bothered me much, but it did, and it was becoming abundantly clear that it wasn't what I wanted.

I wanted the freedom to choose who I spent my life with. I wanted the freedom to explore, to find a love like all my siblings had. I wanted—

“Lukyan.”

Shit. I cleared my throat and stood taller. Hushed whispers rang throughout the room. In the corner of my eye, I saw my father begin to stand, concern on his face. Usually, he was hard to read. I could never tell what he was thinking, but at that moment, I could see it, clear as day. I knew that if I gave the slightest signal, he would stop the wedding, consequences be damned.

I shook my head. A frown marred his brows. Father hovered on his feet for a moment before he sat back down. No. I couldn't back out. Not only did Illayana's survival depend on this wedding going through, but it was also the only way I could kill Sergei. I had to do it.

“The rings,” a light, feminine voice whispered from in front of me. From my...wife-to-be.

“Right.” I reached inside my jacket and pulled out a square box. A matching set of rings sat snugly inside. I plucked them out and handed them to the priest, who did a quick blessing.

Burying the discontent I felt over the entire situation was easy. I'd been burying my emotions all my life. I would make the best out of it. With an almost robotic nature, I placed the ring on her finger. She did the same for me, a heavy weight settling over me at what it meant. What it represented.

After a few more prayers, scripture readings, and Russian wedding traditions, the priest said the words I'd come to dread.

“You may kiss the bride.”

Blowing out a breath, I stepped closer, grasping the edges of her veil to lift it over her head so I could finally see her face, but her hands quickly came up to rest on mine, stopping me.

I frowned slightly, but didn't think much of it, shrugging a shoulder. Instead, I leaned closer, placing a finger underneath her chin to tilt her head up, and laid a soft kiss on her lips. Barely a few seconds. Hardly long enough to gauge anything at all, really. To feel anything. It was over just as quickly as it started.

An awkward, static applause rang through the air. I grabbed her hand and turned to face the crowd. Everyone was on their feet, giving us a mixture of looks that ranged from happiness to anger. My gaze connected with my father's. He was clapping softly, like all the others, but the look in his eyes revealed his true thoughts, his true emotions. He wasn't happy that this was my fate, and I knew without him saying the words that he would take it all back if he could.

He nodded in a show of support. I returned it, standing tall. I'd done it. I'd preserved what little alliance there was between Sergei and us, ensuring Illayana's safety.

Me.

Not Aleksandr. Not Nikolai. *I* had finally made a significant contribution to our family. Even if I failed in my task to kill Sergei, at least I had that to contribute to our legacy.

Keeping my footsteps sure, confident, I led us down the aisle and out the doors. A man in a nice black suit directed me to the left, into another room with a wave of his arm. Once the door shut behind us, I blew out a breath, dropping her hand. *Thank fuck that's over.* I turned to face my wife.

My. Wife.

Jesus.

We stared at each other. She said nothing, and for once, neither did I. I didn't know what to say. I was curious if this was something she didn't necessarily want either. If it was something being forced upon her, like me. It obviously wouldn't change our circumstances, but at least it could be something we could bond over.

"Lukyan," I introduced, holding out a hand. Seemed a little redundant, but we hadn't actually been formally introduced. Usually, that would happen at an engagement party or something, but Sergei had decided there wasn't going to be one. I think he didn't want to give me the chance to back out if I didn't like what I saw.

She smiled.

She had a beautiful smile.

There were two champagne glasses sitting on a tall table near her. Picking one up, she offered it to me with a friendly smile still on her lips.

I took it without hesitation. “Thanks.” To be honest, I wished it was something a little stronger. I would take what I could get, though. I swallowed the whole thing in one go. The bubbly liquid slid down my throat easily. “Oh, that’s good,” I blew out. “And I’m not usually a champagne kinda guy.”

She still said nothing. Still hadn’t removed her veil. I thought that perhaps she was just shy. Nervous. I certainly couldn’t blame her. I was uneasy too. Or maybe she was scared. Fearful of me and our marriage. It wouldn’t be a surprise considering what her father was like. The one person in the world who was meant to protect her had sold her to further his own agenda. That had to fuck with a person.

Clearing my throat, I placed the empty glass down on the table. “I’m sorry about all this, you know. It wasn’t my choice—” A wave of dizziness washed over me. I touched my temple, swaying lightly on my feet.

Featherlight fingers gripped my elbow, helping to steady me.

“Are you okay?” she asked, concerned.

“Yeah, just...Shit, probably shouldn’t have skipped breakfast.” I laughed. Lightheadedness filled my brain, making me feel all light and fuzzy. “What the fuck—” My legs went numb, and I dropped.

My wife caught me, barely able to support my weight, and guided me to the floor. Something wasn’t right. A simple glass of champagne shouldn’t have put me on my ass. There was something in it. A drug—I’d been drugged.

“Get...my...father,” I slurred. My head suddenly felt heavy. I didn’t have the strength to keep it up any longer, and it rolled along my shoulders.

“Shhh, shh, it’s okay.”

What? What part of this seems remotely okay?

Her hands gripped the sides of my face, and she turned my head to look at her. She slowly removed her veil. My heart stopped. Hovering over me was the most beautiful woman I had ever seen in my life.

Angelic, soft, rounded features. Flawless skin. High, arched eyebrows. Smile as radiant as the sun. Mesmerizing honey-colored eyes full of light and spark.

Perfect. She was perfect.

Her gaze ran over me leisurely. She looked at me with utter love and adoration. A finger caressed down the side of my face, and she tucked a loose strand of hair behind my ear. She smiled, and it was full of triumph.

“Hi, my love.”

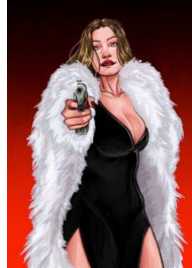
Oh, fuck.

I blacked out.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

LYLA



I hummed to myself as I set the table, placing down a plate quickly followed by cutlery. Music played lightly in the air, the room illuminated only by candles, casting a romantic light through the space. Everything had to be perfect. There couldn't be a single thing out of place. I'd been planning this for so long. I'd done numerous test runs to ensure everything went off without a hitch. I couldn't possibly fuck anything up.

Everything. Had. To. Be. Perfect.

I moved over to the long table against the wall, staring down at the array of food I'd prepared. There was a little bit of everything. Huge, perfectly cooked turkey. A full rack of lamb. Roasted potatoes. Bowls of pasta. Salad, crudités, and dip. Homemade bread. An array of different sweets; cupcakes, pies, fudge slices, chocolate mud cakes—my Lukyan's favorite. Everything he could possibly desire, right at his fingertips. The scents swirled into the air, making my stomach rumble in anticipation.

Hands on my hips, I stared at the abundance of food, trying to figure out the best way to display them. The best order to make it all look as appetizing as possible. First impressions were important.

I glanced over my shoulder, looking at Lukyan for the umpteenth time. I couldn't believe I finally had him. That we were *finally* together. Though it had been a long time coming, I could still remember the first time I laid eyes on him.

Nineteen months earlier

I WAS in the corner booth of some stylish, up-and-coming café, staring at my target. My brother's words flitted through my head as I slowly sipped my coffee.

"Watch him. Gather as much intel as you can. We need to know everything before we even think about making a move."

So I sat. I watched. I noted down everything he did. What he ordered. What he was wearing. Whether he was rude or polite to the waitstaff. Everything.

*He traveled with a team of bodyguards. Four of them, each as big as the last. They kept a close eye on him and the surrounding environment, looking for even the slightest hint of danger. Several times, I was forced to cast my gaze down to the table, taking my eyes off him so they wouldn't get suspicious. I couldn't risk drawing attention to myself. Lev would kill me if my cover was blown so early in the game. And it was a **long** game.*

For the past few weeks, I'd been tasked with following Dimitri Volkov, and follow him I did. I was very good at it. Small and sneaky, like a cat, I watched him from afar, darting behind cars or buildings so his security team wouldn't see me. I wore different disguises every day to ensure my identity wasn't compromised. It had been a long and grueling few weeks, but I enjoyed the work.

Stalking was kinda fun. Watching someone who had no idea they were being watched? It made me feel powerful. Untouchable. And based on what my brother had said, I would be doing it for a while.

It was a good thing I enjoyed it.

Across the café, Dimitri received his styrofoam cup from the barista and nodded in thanks. He deposited a \$100 bill into the tip jar, and the barista's eyes widened in shock. Couldn't blame her, really. That was one hell of a tip. But after watching Dimitri for the past few weeks, I'd come to know that about him. He was a big-ass fucking tipper, and any time he stopped into an establishment, the waitstaff would vie for him to be seated in their section.

Dimitri turned and made his way toward the exit, his guards in tow. I threw back the rest of my coffee quickly, the liquid long having gone cold, and got up, pulling my cap lower over my face. I rushed forward, weaving my way in and around the other tables and patrons, hustling to follow him.

It annoyed me how busy it was. It just made my job all the more difficult, trying to get out without drawing attention to myself. Urgency filled me. **Move, move, move—**

“Ooof.” I ran smack into a hard body. I’d been so preoccupied with trying to follow after Dimitri I hadn’t been watching where I was going. My body tipped back. Strong hands gripped me tightly, stopping me from falling flat on my ass. My eyes shot up, and my heart stopped.

Standing over me, holding me around the waist, was the most beautiful man I had ever seen in my life. Tall, broad-shouldered, with long, shoulder-length dark hair and strong features. Stunning blue eyes with the tiniest specks of brown hidden within them. Lips, curved and full. Devilish. I couldn’t move. Couldn’t breathe. Ensnared. I was **ensnared** by him, unable to do anything else but stare in awe.

My heart kicked back into gear, hammering so hard I almost couldn’t catch my breath. Heat burst inside my chest, hot and completely and utterly searing. I didn’t know what was going on. I’d never felt anything like it before.

Who is this man?

“Sorry about that, gorgeous. Didn’t see you.”

A shiver ran through me, right down to my soul. **His voice.** God, I’d never heard anything like it. His hand burned into my back, his touch holding me captive, my mission all but forgotten.

“Uh—I-I—” **Why can’t I talk? Why can’t I do anything but stare at him? Say something! Say something cute or funny or charming. Just fucking say something!** It was as if my brain had just short-circuited. It was completely fucking useless to me.

Adonis Reincarnate smirked, and my fucking heart stopped again. No man should be that fucking beautiful. He could get anything he wanted with that look...including me.

He pushed me up until I was back on my two feet again, but if I was being honest, it didn’t make a difference. I still felt as though the ground were moving beneath me. Like my legs were jello, and I was going to fall back over any minute.

He grabbed my hand, and a shock ran through my body at the skin-on-skin contact. Yeah, that definitely wasn’t normal. I’d touched a lot of men in my life, and **not one** had invoked that kind of response before. All he was doing was holding my damn hand, not kissing me.

*He bent at the waist and pressed his lips softly to the top of my hand.
I almost fainted.*

“You have yourself a good day, gorgeous.” He winked, then dropped my hand and walked away without looking back.

*My heart kickstarted, returning to normal tempo. I sucked in a harsh breath. **What the fuck was that?***

Licking my dry lips, I looked down at my hand and ran my fingers lightly over the spot where his lips had touched. I was an avid believer in soulmates. That there was one person in the world who was your absolute perfect match. Someone who would be there for you, love you, and protect you from anything. Someone so perfect for you, the universe orchestrated your lives, putting you in exactly the right place at exactly the right time so you could meet.

I had no idea who that man was, but I knew he was mine.

THE MEMORY FADED QUICKLY, but the feelings from that day still blazed just as strong.

Lukyan Volkov—the son of the man I’d been tasked to watch.

Never in a million years would I have ever envisioned he would be the one for me. My soulmate. My meant-to-be. But he was. There was no doubt in my mind.

The first few weeks I’d been following Dimitri, I never saw him out with his children. They were always off doing their own thing, and any time there was anything even remotely business-related, it had been too hard to follow him without blowing my cover. That day had been the first time I’d ever laid eyes on Lukyan, and it changed my life forever.

In front of me, Lukyan was strapped down at the head of the table, both arms tied to the arms of the chair, same as his legs. His head hung forward, still knocked out from the drug I had given him.

For months, I agonized over every single detail, dozens of contingencies in place in case something didn’t go according to plan. It was the most stressed I’d ever been in my life. Everything rode on this, and if one thing failed, it would all have been for nothing.

I went through my plan one more time in my head.

Step one: Stalk and find out everything I can about Lukyan Volkov.

Step two: Trick him into marrying me.

Step three: Cut out his tracker.

Step Four: Make him fall in love with me.

That last step would prove to be the hardest. I wasn't the easiest person to love. I was crazy, neurotic, jealous, and had a slight anger problem. It would be difficult, but I was determined to win him over, no matter what.

With one last glance at Lukyan, I turned back around. *Okay. Food, check. Drinks, check. Cutlery, check. Candles, check—*

"Miss?" To my left, Cedric walked in from the kitchen. A phone was in his hands. "It's your brother. *Again.*"

My lips pursed in distaste. *Damn it.* I was really hoping to avoid talking to him, at least while I had Lukyan to deal with. He was sure to be a little shocked and disoriented at his circumstances. I needed to give him my full, undivided attention to help with the transition. But Lev had already called three times in the past twenty-four hours. If I didn't take his call, shit would well and truly hit the fan.

"Argh, fine." I wiped my hands down the front of my apron and approached, grabbing the phone. "Yes?"

"I'm going to ask you this one time, and one time only, Lyla. Where the fuck are you?"

Always so quick to freak the fuck out. "I'm doing what you asked me to do."

"Are you? Because the last time you said that, you were spying on that good-for-nothing Volkov kid again."

My eyes swept to the man in question. He was still knocked out. "You know it pisses me off when you talk about him like that."

"And *you* know it worries me when you defend him," he snapped back. "Do I need to remind you *again* of our goal?"

"No. You've reminded me every day since I was thirteen." The resentment that had been brewing in my soul for the past ten years came bubbling up to the surface, and I was unable to hide it in my voice.

Lev must have sensed it because the background noise suddenly disappeared as if he'd moved into another room. "Lyla. Don't forget why we're doing this. What that bastard took away from us."

From you, I almost said out loud.

"Just focus on the plan. Nothing else. Get the information we need. Don't let yourself get distracted. Understand?" My eyes swept to Lukyan again. *Too late.*

"Is that it? I'm about to sit down for dinner."

Lev blew out what I could only guess was a relieved sigh, thinking he'd won. "You know I love you, right?"

"Yes."

"You know I would do anything for you, right?"

No. "Yes." If it came down to me or his revenge, I knew what he would pick...and it wouldn't be me.

Lukyan stirred, a groan falling from his lips. My heart leaped in my chest.

"Alright, I really have to go."

"Fine. Next check-in is in twelve hours. Answer my call. We're so close to the finish line, Lyla. Only a little more to go, and we'll finally have our vengeance."

I rolled my eyes. Lev was so focused on getting revenge, he couldn't see what was right in front of him. That I didn't give a shit about it. I only cared because he did. He was my brother. I loved him. When shit hit the fan, he was there for me. Sheltered me. Protected me. Kept me safe. I owed him so much more than my life. I owed him my loyalty, which was the only reason I had agreed to help him. Why I went along with his insane plan.

"Okay. Talk later." I hung up before he could say anything else.

Cedric watched me, concern in his dark brown eyes. "Are you sure you know what you're doing?"

"You've been with me every step of the way. Don't you trust me?"

"You know I do, but"—his gaze flicked to Lukyan and back—"I worry you cannot think rationally around him. He clouds your mind."

I smiled, and for once in my life, it was genuine. "No. He clears it." I jerked my head to the side, and Cedric took it as the cue it was to leave.

I loved Cedric—*not* in that way. He was more of an overprotective uncle, even though we didn't share any blood. He was only a few years older, and had been there for Lev and me when we lost our home, helping us navigate the new world that had been thrust upon us. When Lev turned eighteen, he assumed control, and the dynamic changed between us. Cedric got pushed back, going from leader to glorified bodyguard. He always said he didn't care, but I thought a part of him secretly did, which was why he chose to stick by my side instead of Lev's.

Tucking the phone back away, I quickly set the table, placing all of the food I'd cooked in a perfect display, finishing just as Lukyan's head rose, half mast, disoriented eyes landing on me.

Showtime.

“Finally, you’re awake.” I offered a warm, kind smile so he would know he was in the presence of a friend, not an enemy.

Didn’t do much good. Once awareness snaked back into his bones, he jolted and immediately started pulling at the restraints.

“What the fuck?” Lukyan hissed, yanking hard with his arms. He wouldn’t be able to break free. I’d had metal cuffs five inches thick installed into the armrests.

“Who are you? What’s going on? Where the fuck am I?”

I kept the smile on my face as I adjusted one of the oven dishes, moving it an inch to the left, then the right. “I’m your wife, silly.”

“My—what?” He was still dazed, the effects of the drug still lingering in his system. He licked his dry lips and looked around the room slowly, taking everything in.

I’d purchased the house months before, when I first started putting in place the pieces for my plan. It was a beautiful place. Sequestered. Far away from anyone else in case things got a little...loud. Three stories. Stunning, dark antique features. Real hardwood floors. Chandeliers on the fucking ceiling. The whole nine yards.

It was my dream home. Something I could see myself settling down and building a family in. It had everything I could ever want, including that warm, homey feeling I was never able to experience during my childhood.

After doing a lap of the room with his eyes, most likely looking for some form of escape—I know I would have been if I were in his position—he finally focused on the table in front of him. Hunger flashed in his startling blue eyes at all the food. My Lukyan loved food.

I’d been watching him closely for over a year. Keeping track of his habits. Routines. What he liked. What he disliked. His favorite foods. His style of clothing. I had dozens upon dozens upon dozens of journals filled with every movement he made so that when the moment came—the moment where I finally had him in my grasp—I would know everything there was to know about him.

“You’re *her*, aren’t you? The woman who’s been stalking me.” He attempted to get free of his restraints again. “Let me go. *Now*.”

I internally shivered. Oh, that hard, dominating voice. How I would love to turn it around and have it laced with submission.

All in good time.

“I would love to, but I have a feeling if I did, you’d run.” With one final look at the table, I nodded, satisfied with the arrangement, and removed my apron.

Beneath it, I wore my nicest dress. A white spaghetti strap dress that flowed out at the bottom. I let loose my hair, the locks of honey blonde tumbling over my shoulders and down to my lower back.

“I wouldn’t run,” Lukyan said, watching me closely, his eyes clear and utterly focused. “I’d kill you.”

A tingly sensation ran down my spine. *Oh, you’ll be so much fun to break.* “Would you?” I sat down at the other end of the table and fluffed out my napkin before placing it across my lap. “A little harsh, don’t you think? I just went through all this effort to cook us a nice dinner in celebration of our anniversary.”

“Our—our what?!”

“Our anniversary.” My hand reached out and clutched the wine glass next to my empty plate. I brought it to my lips and took a small sip, my eyes never leaving his. “It’s been nineteen months since we met. Do you not remember?”

Confusion and frustration mounted on his face. “What are you talking about? You’re not making any sense! I’ve never met you in my life! Let me go. Let me go now!” Lukyan struggled again, pulling his arms so hard he winced in pain, but he didn’t stop. He grunted and snarled, thrashing his body left and right.

I continued to sip my wine. “Stop. You’re just going to hurt yourself, and seeing you hurt, hurts me, my love.”

“Don’t”—*grunt*—“call me”—*snarl*—“that!”

I sat there, watching him continue to struggle. I wasn’t lying. It genuinely hurt to see him like that, seeing his skin redden at the wrists because he was pulling so hard. But there was nothing I could do. He had to find out for himself how worthless it was to try to escape.

After a few minutes, he slumped back into his chair, breathing hard. “Look, I don’t know what you want from me, but whatever it is, you’re not going to get it.”

“I think it’s fairly obvious what I want.” My eyes ran over him. Slowly. Methodically. I lingered on every one of his features. His sharp jaw. Silky, shoulder-length dark hair. His eyes, which happened to look more turquoise than storm blue in that lighting. His sculpted face and strong chin. I ran my

gaze over every inch of him, every fiber in my body taut with possessiveness. “I want *you*. I’ve done all of this”—I spread my arms out wide—“for you. So we can finally be together. We’re soulmates. I felt it the moment I laid eyes on you. That unbreakable connection. We’re *meant* to be together, and nothing and no one will stop us. Our hearts are intertwined. Bound together by forces beyond our control. It’s destiny. Don’t you see? *Fate*.”

He stared at me, mouth slightly agape in what I could only describe as befuddlement. “Oh. You’re like, *insane* insane.”

“I prefer the term *mentally spicy*,” I said, taking one last sip from my wine before placing it back down.

“Call it what you want. Crazy is crazy.”

This wasn’t the first time I’d been called crazy. Let’s be real. It wasn’t the second or the third either. We were best friends, crazy and I. We danced side by side, forever teetering along that line together. That was why it never bothered me when people called me crazy.

I was.

And I liked it that way.

My eyes stayed locked with his as I dipped my fingers into my wine glass and brought them to my chest, letting the liquid drop onto my skin. “Don’t pretend like crazy doesn’t turn you on.”

His eyes flashed with heat, his gaze tracking the liquid as it trailed down between the valley of my breasts. He adjusted slightly in his seat. “What turns me on is irrelevant,” he grunted, voice rough.

A feeling of triumph shot through me. Yeah, he was definitely turned on by my craziness.

“You can’t just kidnap me and expect me to be with you. I’m promised to someone else—”

Hot, blazing anger exploded in my chest at the mention of him with someone else. I picked up a knife and slammed it into the table so hard that the tip embedded into the wood with a deafening *bang*.

He snapped his mouth shut, not saying another word.

Wise.

Just as fast as the anger came on, it disappeared, and I cleared my throat with an awkward chuckle. “Sorry about that,” I said, smoothing my hair. “I’m spontaneously violent.”

“Spontaneously violent,” Lukyan repeated, blinking slowly.

“Yeah. But don’t worry. It’s not like, all the time. Just when people piss me off.” I plucked a few pieces of meat from the variety of trays in front of me and put them onto my plate. Something suddenly occurred to me. “Oh, how silly of me! You can’t eat restrained like that. Here, I’ll help you.” One hand on my plate, I stood and made my way over to him. Lukyan watched me with narrowed, suspicious eyes, tracking my every movement as if he feared what I would do.

“I’m not going to hurt you,” I said, sitting down in the empty seat to his left. There was some lamb, turkey, and beef on the plate. I was most proud of the lamb, so I chose that, spearing some with my fork and holding it up in the air. Lukyan remained still as a statue. “Eat,” I insisted. “You must be hungry. You’ve been out for the better part of a day, and I know you didn’t eat breakfast on our wedding day.”

“I don’t want to eat. I want you to release me,” he snarled, thrashing in his chair. “You can’t keep me here! I have to go! My sister’s life is in danger if I don’t—”

“What? Marry *Anya*?” I said her name mockingly, with a hint of derision. I placed the fork down with a sigh and leaned back. “You really thought I was going to allow that to happen?” He turned his head away from me. I reached out and grabbed his chin, forcing his gaze back on me. “You’re *mine*. Every goddamn inch of you. *We’re married. You and me.*” I showed him the wedding ring he himself placed on my finger, in case he had forgotten.

He ripped his chin out of my grasp and scowled at me. “You *tricked* me.”

I shrugged. “The particulars are irrelevant. It’s legally binding.”

Anger flared in his eyes. He thrashed again. “You can’t do this! You don’t understand what’s at stake!”

“Your sister is safe.”

He stilled. “What are you talking about?”

I picked up the fork again, holding it up to his mouth. Silence reigned between us. He held my gaze, defiance blazing in his eyes. The intention was obvious. If he wanted answers, he needed to eat. I didn’t want him going hungry. He glared, harsh and full of violence, before he slowly leaned forward, wrapping his tongue around the meat and taking it. The sight of his tongue moving the way it did, did things to me. He chewed, that glare still on his face.

I gave him a bright, dazzling smile. “Good boy.”

Something different flashed across his face. Something I couldn’t yet decipher.

“I know how much you love your family. I’ve been watching you for a long time, my love—”

“Because that’s not at all creepy,” he muttered under his breath.

“Creepy or romantic?”

He stared me dead in the eyes. “Creepy.”

“Orrrrrr?”

“Will you just tell me what the hell you’re talking about?!”

“Okay, okay, jeez. You know, you were a lot more playful all the times I watched you.”

“What can I say? Getting kidnapped and tied up by a crazy woman tends to affect one’s mood,” he snapped.

“Huh. I wouldn’t know. Can’t say I’ve ever been kidnapped before. But you? What does this make? Number two?”

“You’re hilarious.”

“I know.” I fed him another piece of meat. “I’ve been planning this for a long time. Been watching everyone in your life for a long time, whether they were close to you, or merely someone on the outskirts. Did you know Anya is madly in love with one of her bodyguards?”

His frown told me all I needed to know. He didn’t.

“Do you know *anything* about the woman you were going to marry?”

Again, he didn’t answer, not that I needed him to. I could see every single thing Lukyan did on his phone. On his laptop. On every electronic device he owned. I’d bugged them all. He didn’t once attempt to look her up.

“She’s actually very nice. Nineteen years old. Lived a very quiet, privileged life—up until yesterday, that is. Now, well, she’s on the run. Most likely living from hotel room to hotel room. That’s why it was so easy for me to take her place, you see? She had already left, and her parents didn’t even notice when I was the one walking down that aisle because they’re both too self-centered to care about anyone but themselves and their own agendas.”

“How could you possibly know all of this?”

I shrugged absently, the deviousness of my own mind making me smirk. “Because I became her best friend and convinced her to run away with her

bodyguard.”

His eyes widened in shock. “You what?”

“Well, once I became aware of your engagement, I couldn’t let it go ahead, could I? I wasn’t too happy, as you can imagine. Roast potato?” I asked, spearing the vegetable and offering it to him. He ate it quickly, clearly eager for me to continue. “I debated just killing her. Almost did a few times, actually. Would have certainly been the easier option.” I chuckled. “But I knew what would happen if I did. I knew your grandfather had threatened to kill your sister if you didn’t go through with the marriage. Which, by the way, is a really dickish thing to do. Like, I’m sorry, but that dude is a serious wanker. What kind of grandparent threatens their grandchild like that? I can see why you guys are trying to kill him.”

Lukyan stiffened. “How the fuck do you know about *that*?” he asked, aghast.

“One question at a time, my love. Anyway, so killing Anya meant killing your sister, and I know how much you love her. How close you are. I could never hurt you like that, so I had to come up with another way. I infiltrated Anya’s inner circle. Staged a run-in with her at one of her favorite clothing boutiques and worked my way up until I became someone she could confide in. She was eager for a friend. A *real* friend. Not just someone who was hanging out with her for clout or status. She latched on to me pretty quickly.”

Believe it or not, I actually started to feel a little bad for her. She was starved for true connections with people. For someone to care and like her *for her*. It didn’t take a genius to figure out why. All the women Anya had surrounded herself with were downright bitches. One of them mysteriously went missing, but I didn’t have anything to do with that.

Or did I?

Okay, yes, I did. The bitch called me a *hand-me-down whore*, so I slit her throat and tossed her into the Neva River. Her body was never found.

Whoops.

“After a few weeks, it became crystal fucking clear that Anya had a thing for her bodyguard, Nathan, and he for her. Would you like a drink? I have wine, beer, whiskey, vodka. You name it, I have it.”

Lukyan looked like he was going to refuse, but then he nodded once. “Give me the strongest you’ve got.”

Excitement stirred through my body. It was minor, barely anything at all, but to me, that was progress. I retrieved an empty glass and poured him a shot of the finest vodka I could get my hands on. I returned to him quickly and stood at his side, looking down at him.

“Open up.”

There it was again. That fucking look I couldn’t figure out.

Lukyan’s gaze remained on me as he tilted his head back slightly and parted his lips. I ran my tongue along my bottom lip in appreciation. When he followed my orders like that, it made my entire body tremble with want.

I tossed the drink back, clasped his head to keep him still, and bent down, letting the liquid fall from my mouth into his. The shock was momentary. He stiffened for the briefest second, eyes widening, but didn’t close his mouth until the last of the vodka touched his tongue. He swallowed it back quickly, and there was no mistaking that look in his eyes.

Pure, unadulterated need. Sexual tension snapped taut in the air between us. My skin felt like it was on fire under his heated gaze.

“Every time they were in the same room together, fireworks went off,” I continued in a soft whisper, my eyes boring into his. I was talking about Anya and Nathan, but Lukyan knew I was talking about *us*, too. Our unbreakable connection. “Honestly, I was surprised no one else could see it.” With a final glance down Lukyan’s hard, rigid body, I took my seat again and crossed my legs. “Turned out, Anya didn’t want your marriage any more than *I* did.” My hands moved to my lap. I pulled the edges of my dress down between my legs as I spread them a little further apart bit by bit, revealing the insides of my thighs.

Lukyan stiffened, watching me with all his focus.

“But she didn’t have a choice. Her father was forcing her hand, giving her no option. The night before the wedding, she broke down. Cried to me that she was in love with Nathan, and he was in love with her, but they couldn’t be together because of some familial obligation. I told her to follow her heart. That love is worth taking all the risks in the world. I convinced her to run away with him, and by doing so, absolved you and your family of any blame in the situation. Your grandfather can’t punish you for something that was out of your control. Anya running away meant it was the Tarasovs who backed out of the deal. Not you. I made sure that was glaringly obvious by having her leave a note to her parents, apologizing that

she couldn't go through with the wedding. Anya asked me to leave it in her hotel room with her dress. Little did she know, I would just take her place."

"How the hell did her parents not notice it was *you* walking down the aisle, not *her*? Their own daughter?"

"Like I said, her parents are incredibly self-centered. They barely paid any attention to her. Luckily for me, Anya and I are the same height, with the same hair color and build. I was dressed in Anya's wedding dress, and with the veil covering my face the whole time, they had no idea I wasn't her. When they returned home, they would have found the note I left for them from Anya, and the pieces would start to click together. It would look like Anya orchestrated someone to take her place so she could escape and disappear before anyone even noticed she was gone, giving her plenty of time to get a head start."

The slight frown on his brows told me he was still confused about something. I offered him a slice of lamb, and he took it without protest, making my insides do a happy dance. He was getting more comfortable with me. *It might be easier than I thought to get him on my side.*

"What about my grandfather?"

"Ah. He was a little harder to fool than Anya's parents. He's annoyingly observant. I couldn't risk him noticing something was off, so I had to keep him preoccupied. I had one of his warehouses raided. Dropped a little hot tip to one of his competitors that he had a shitload of inventory, ripe for the taking, and they jumped on it. He was busy dealing with the aftermath at the time the wedding was taking place."

"Jesus Christ." He shook his head, almost in disbelief. "Is there anything you didn't think of?"

I thought about it for a moment. "I doubt it. I'm very meticulous."

"Yes, I'm starting to realize that," he blew out with a deep, heavy sigh. I couldn't tell if he was annoyed or proud about that.

I would have said proud.

"So what happens now? Is this a *365 Days* kind of situation where you keep me locked up here until I fall in love with you?"

"You're already in love with me. You just don't know it yet." I winked.

"How can I be in love with someone I've never met before? I don't even know your goddamn name."

That was what I was *most* afraid of. Our families had history. A deep, sordid history that I feared would impact his opinion of me. That would

send him running in the other direction the moment I told him who I was.

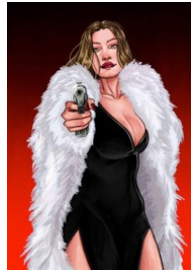
But I had to do it. I didn't have a choice. We would never move on as a couple, build a life together, if we weren't honest with each other. Until he knew.

“My name is Lyla. Lyla Voznesensky.”

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

LYLA VOZNESENSKY



“Did you say, ‘Voznesensky’?” The change in him was instantaneous. Lukyan’s body went still as stone, his voice cold, calculating. Not a hint of that boyish, playful charm I’d come to love about him.

I knew it was going to happen. Expected it. Prepared for it, even. And yet, it didn’t make it any easier, knowing we’d probably just taken a step back in our relationship.

I held my head up high, though, refusing to let it break me. “Yes. My father orchestrated the attack against your family ten years ago.”

“Your father *killed* my mother,” he snarled, eyes burning with hatred.

“And *your* father killed my entire family. I think that makes us even, wouldn’t you say?”

“Far from it,” he hissed. “My mother was beaten, tortured, raped, and left naked in a dirty, rotten building to die all on her own.”

A sliver of guilt cut through me at the sadness tainting his voice. It was irrational for me to feel. I wasn’t responsible for the sins of my father, but I still felt bad. Lukyan would have been twelve or thirteen when he lost his mother. I couldn’t help but picture that little boy...How sad he must have been when he realized what had happened.

“And your father crept into my house in the middle of the night, murdered my mother, my father, my uncle, and then dumped me and my brother off in some orphanage like we were trash,” I countered.

“Is that why you’ve kidnapped me? Why I’m here? To enact some kind of revenge on my family?”

I scoffed. “No.” I wasn’t as upset about that as I ought to be. The truth of it was, my family were assholes. My father liked to beat me when I wouldn’t follow his rules, and my mother was always too drunk or too high to notice. Or maybe she *did* notice, and just didn’t give a shit. That tracked. Either way, neither of them were winning Parent of the Year awards. If I was being honest, the Bratva Butcher had done me a favor when he killed them. I hated my parents.

Lev, on the other hand, adored them. But he had a different experience with them than I did. He was the firstborn son, after all. The legacy. He got all the love, and I got all the hate. Lev wasn’t blind to it. He’d witnessed the beatings I’d endured over the years, all because I said or did something our father didn’t like. And although he loved me, my brother never once tried to intervene. Never tried to save me from our father’s wrath. He would just come to me afterwards and help clean up the blood.

So, no. I didn’t give a shit that Dimitri had killed them.

A sad, disappointed sigh left my lips at the look on Lukyan’s face. The anger. The disgust. The hatred. He hated me, and it broke my heart. “Maybe we should call it a night. It’s been a long twenty-four hours. I’m sure you could use some rest.”

He said nothing. I much preferred his anger over his indifference. Although I wasn’t responsible for my father’s actions, I was still to blame in Lukyan’s eyes.

I got to my feet and wiped my hands down the front of my dress. “Cedric.” He walked in from the foyer and stopped behind Lukyan’s chair, hands behind his back. “Take Lukyan to his room, please. See that he has everything he needs.”

“Yes, ma’am.” He placed a hand on Lukyan’s shoulder. “Are you going to give me any trouble?”

His head rolled along his shoulders, and he glanced up at Cedric, cool, calm, and collected. “Nope,” he said, popping the *p*.

I’d watched Lukyan for long enough to know he was talking out of his ass. He had every intention of causing trouble. He wouldn’t be Lukyan without it.

But I was curious, so I let it play out.

Cedric pulled a set of keys out of his pocket and dropped to one knee. He unlocked the cuffs around Lukyan’s ankles first, then stood back up and unlocked the ones around his wrists. First the left, then the right—

Lukyan sprang up, lithe and agile like a cat, one hand on the armrest as he swung his leg up and around to kick Cedric in the side of the head.

My eyebrows rose. *Impressive.*

Cedric went down, and Lukyan bolted out of the room without a glance back.

I blew out a sigh and took my seat back at the head of the table. I picked up my glass of wine and leaned back, taking small sips, letting the alcohol swirl around in my mouth before swallowing it.

Hmm. The sweetness becomes a bit much. Should have gone with the red.

Not even five seconds later, Lukyan came running back into the room. He locked eyes with me for the briefest moment before bolting to the window on my right. It was covered with beautiful sheer curtains. He flung them open and cursed.

Behind the glass was the same thing he would have seen over the front door.

A steel roller.

They were over every inch of the house, effectively turning it into a prison. The only way to retract them was with a twenty-four-digit code only *I* knew.

I popped a potato into my mouth as I watched him run from room to room, checking every window, every door, looking for some way to escape. I stayed exactly where I was, continuing to eat, completely unperturbed.

I'd spared no expense in turning this house into exactly what I needed to ensure not only Lukyan's safety, but that he would be mine forever. There would never be any escape.

Lukyan burst back into the room, slightly out of breath. Blue eyes burning with fire snapped to me. "Let me the fuck out of here," he thundered.

"You know I can't do that, my love," I said calmly, using my knife and fork to cut a piece of meat into smaller pieces. "Now, I know you're upset. Like I said, it's been a stressful twenty-four hours for you. You've been through a lot. Had a lot of information thrown at you in such a short amount of time. Why don't you just go upstairs and get some rest—"

With a swipe of his arm, he threw half the contents on the table onto the floor. "I don't want to rest! Let me out of here right fucking now, or I swear to God, I'm going to fucking kill you."

“Kill me and you’ll never get out of here. A twenty-four-digit code is required to lift the lockdown, and only *I* know it. That’s over sixteen million possible combinations. You’ll die of starvation and dehydration long before you can guess the right one.”

He thought about it for a moment, then shrugged. “Fine.” He picked up one of the knives from the floor. “Then I’ll cut it out of you.”

Excitement sizzled down my spine. I put down my knife and fork and unfolded my legs slowly, eloquently, and got to my feet, an eager and wicked smirk on my lips. “I was hoping you’d say that.”

He blinked, momentarily shocked, before he smirked back, fire dancing in his eyes, and then he lunged. I ducked under the swipe of his knife and kicked my leg up as I leaned forward, hitting him in the face. He grunted, stumbling back on his feet, but quickly recovered, charging again.

It was a little unfair. Lukyan was at a slight disadvantage. I’d spent over a year and a half studying him. I watched him for hours when he sparred with his siblings, learning how his body moved. His favorite maneuvers. It made avoiding his strikes not necessarily easy, but it gave me a little bit of an edge.

I twisted and turned, ducked and weaved, evaded and blocked. We moved around the room, him attacking, me evading, like a beautiful dance between two lovers. Slice, duck. Stab, twist. Slash, pivot. Round and round we went.

“How the fuck are you so fast?” he grunted out in annoyance, swinging again.

“I’ve spent my whole life avoiding people. Gotten pretty good at it.”

“Nah, bullshit.” He swiped high in a fast, powerful arc, and I jumped back, narrowly avoiding it. “The way you move. Graceful. Fluid. You a dancer?”

“Maybe.” I gave him my best *come hither* eyes. “Want me to dance for you?”

The grin on his lips made my whole body shiver. He didn’t respond, but I knew what the answer would be if he did. He could try to deny it all he wanted, but I *knew* him. Knew he liked that kind of shit. Liked crazy, unpredictable moves. Liked that I was so deranged he had no idea what the fuck I was going to do.

“You can’t keep me locked up here forever.”

“I don’t need forever. I just need long enough for you to realize you can’t live without me.”

Cedric stirred, groaning. *Time to put an end to this.* There would be hell to pay when he regained consciousness, and I didn’t want to have to deal with talking him down while also keeping my eyes on Lukyan.

Switching things up surprised Lukyan because I’d primarily been on the defensive. He wasn’t expecting it, which was exactly what I was anticipating. With a burst of speed that had him widening his eyes, I darted forward, faked left, went right, twirled around him until I was at his back, and then leaped onto him, wrapping my arms tightly around his neck in a textbook choke hold.

“I’m sorry, my love. I don’t want to hurt you.”

He rasped, struggling to breathe, his body thrashing. His arms came up and gripped my shoulders, and then he threw me over him and slammed me down onto the table.

Fuck. The strength it took to do that. Jesus Christ.

We fought, him trying to pin my arms down, and me trying desperately to keep them out of his grasp. In the end, his strength won out, and he slammed my arms down, hands clasped tightly around my wrists. He was between my legs, his body bent over mine, chest heaving. My heart raced in my chest. He was so close, the adrenaline soaring through my veins making me hyperaware of every place our bodies intersected.

“Tell me the code,” he bit out harshly, staring me down.

“Why? You don’t want to leave as much as I don’t want you to leave.”

“You don’t know shit about me!”

I stretched forward, ignoring the bite of pain in my arms that the movement caused, until our faces were a mere breath away from each other’s. “I know *everything* about you, Lukyan,” I murmured softly. “I know you hide that smart, creative brain behind that idiot persona you like to put on. I know you dumb yourself down so people underestimate you. I know all you want is to prove yourself to your family and have them see you for who you truly are. I know you hide your heart behind a wall of sleazy jokes and inappropriate comments. I know you have a happy personality, but a sad soul. And most importantly of all, I know all you want is for someone to love you for exactly who you are, flaws and all.”

Shock registered across Lukyan’s face. His hold loosened slightly. I used it to my advantage and wedged my legs between us, planted my feet

against his chest, and *pushed*. He flew back. I jumped up and ran for him, reaching into my pocket. I pulled out the pen, ducked under a powerful swing of his arms, darted forward, jammed the pen into his neck, and retreated just as quickly.

“What the fuck?” he hissed, stumbling back. His eyes grew wide. Angry. He took a step forward and swayed. “What—”

“I’m sorry, my love. Sleep. Rest. We’ll talk soon.”

“What did...you...do...” Lukyan’s eyes rolled into the back of his head, and he dropped, passed out.

I looked down at the tranq pen in my hand. I didn’t want to use it. I had hoped we could have a calm, rational discussion. Of course, I should have known that wouldn’t happen. Still, a girl could dream. Guilt wormed its way deep into my chest at his unconscious form lying on the ground. I had no choice. I knew that.

Didn’t make it any easier, though.

Blowing out a breath, I tossed the tranq pen to the side just as Cedric climbed to his feet, his face a mask of anger and frustration.

He made a move toward Lukyan. “I’m going to fucking kill him—”

I swung my arm out to stop him, his chest running smack into it. “You’re going to do *nothing*. His reaction is understandable. Who wouldn’t try to escape when they’ve been kidnapped?” I straightened my spine and stretched my arms above my head, a yawn falling from my lips. “Take him to his room. Make sure he’s comfortable, and leave plenty of food and water for him. He didn’t eat much, and he’ll be hungry when he wakes.”

Cedric nodded, however begrudgingly.

I made my way toward the exit but stopped, glancing over my shoulder. “And Cedric?”

He lifted his gaze from Lukyan to me. “You’re not to harm a single hair on his head. You understand me?”

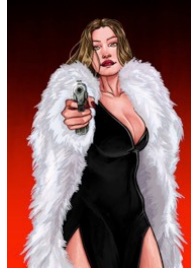
His jaw ticked slightly. “Understood.”

He didn’t like it. That much was obvious. But I had faith that Cedric would do as I ordered and not disobey me.

Ignoring the twinge of guilt in my gut that leaving Lukyan caused, I turned and walked out.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

LYLA VOZNESENKY



“*I* don’t understand. Where is Lukyan?!” Dimitri thundered.

I moved about the room, completely invisible to the Volkovs as

I went about my duties, clearing dinner. I had infiltrated Sergei’s grand estate by applying to be one of his maids a few weeks before. It was a crucial step not only in my plan, but Lev’s, too. I needed to know what was going on, and the only way to do that was to get myself into his house.

Luckily for me, Sergei needed an abundance of maids, and they never seemed to last long. The old fart had a short fuse, and it’d been well circulated that the reason he needed so many was because he lost his temper and ended up killing half of them.

I snuck in under a fake name—a fake identity curated by my brother. I told him the best way to complete our mission was to get into Sergei’s house, and he made it happen.

At the table sat Sergei, Dimitri, Anya’s father, Akim, and some random dude called Vernon. None of them paid me any attention as I picked up the somewhat empty plates in front of them. One thing I’d learned quickly was that waitstaff were quickly dismissed. We were invisible to others. Barely seen and never heard. It worked perfectly for me.

I tried to banish Lukyan from my mind so I could focus on the task at hand, but it was hard. After our conversation a few hours before, after knocking him out with that stupid tranq pen, I decided the best thing to do was a little recon. Ensure that everything had gone according to plan. That there was no blame being put on Lukyan or his family for what happened. I

hoped that, by bringing him that good news, it might help him see that although our families were enemies, it didn't mean we had to be.

Sergei glared at his son. Despite his age, he still looked good. Big and imposing. Fucking evil, if I were to pick a description. "Footage from the venue shows him being carried out by his wife."

Me. I held in my giggle. *I* was Luykan's wife. Dreams really did come true.

"And based on the note found in your home, Akim, it is safe to guess that it was *not* Anya," Sergei finished, crossing his arms over his wide, massive chest.

Akim's face flushed with anger. "I don't know what happened. If that wasn't Anya walking down the aisle, who the fuck was it?"

"Isn't it obvious?" Dimitri sneered. "She didn't want to go through with the wedding, so she had someone else take her place so she could escape." I wasn't sure if he truly believed that, or if he'd merely come up with it to steer the blame away from his family to the Tarasovs. Either way, it worked. Sergei's glare switched from Dimitri to Akim, and even *I* wanted to shrivel under it. The man had a mean glare.

"No." Akim shook his head, almost as if he refused to believe it. "No, she wouldn't do that. Anya understands her obligations. She wouldn't run."

Sergei held up the note. "Care to explain this, then? It is her handwriting, isn't it?"

Like he would know. Akim didn't even know enough about his daughter to realize she wasn't the one to walk down the aisle. Any good parent would have noticed instantly.

Clara, another maid, came into the room. She held a pitcher of vodka. Her hands shook. She was terrified, and I could use that to my advantage. I offered her the plates in my hand in exchange for the pitcher, and her smile was filled with gratitude.

I didn't want to leave the room just yet. I needed to listen to the conversation to see where everyone stood. To make sure my plan had succeeded. Clara took the plates from me, I took the pitcher, and she left, taking the dishes to the kitchen.

The air was ripe with tension. Shit was getting heated very quickly.

"He doesn't know shit," Dimitri spat. "He didn't even recognize that the woman walking down the aisle wasn't his own fucking daughter. How the hell would he know if that's her handwriting?"

“Regardless, I know it is. I’ve had it compared to the journals my men found in her bedroom.” Sergei tossed the note onto the table. “There were pages and pages detailing her love for her bodyguard. She’s been in love with him for years. Anya didn’t want to get married. That proves this note is real, Mr. Tarasov. That *you* fell short in our arrangement.”

Akim visibly started to shake. “Mr. Volkov, please—”

Sergei held up a hand. Akim snapped his mouth shut.

Boss move.

I moved to the head of the table, where Sergei sat, and poured his drink first.

“We had a contract,” he continued. “In exchange for marrying into the family, I get unfiltered access to the east and north trade routes.” He picked up a stack of papers at his side. “I held up my end of the bargain. My grandson was there, standing at the altar. *Your daughter* failed to show. *Your daughter* ran. *Your daughter* orchestrated someone else to take her place. *You* signed the agreement stating she would be there. She wasn’t. *You* failed to uphold your side, and therefore, restitution must be made.”

I moved to Dimitri next. His hands were clenched into tight fists underneath the table. It didn’t take a genius to guess he didn’t give a shit about that conversation. He only wanted to know where Lukyan was. That was why I liked Papa D. He was what a parent *should* have been like. He cared about his kids. Whether they were happy or sad. He loved them.

The pitcher clinked against Dimitri’s glass as I poured his drink.

“As I’m sure you’re aware, failure to fulfill the contract incurs a 100-million-dollar fine that you are now liable for.” *Goddamn.* “So, I’ll present you with a choice. You can pay the fine, bankrupt yourself and your family, or, you can do what I say, when I fucking say it, and I’ll let you and your wife continue to live the life you are so accustomed to.”

“Deal.” Akim didn’t even fucking hesitate. Not that he had any grounds to stand on. Just like I’d planned, *he* was the one in breach of the deal because his daughter didn’t show.

“Good. The first shipment will arrive at the docks tomorrow. Make sure it gets through without any problems. Leave.”

Akim stood, bowed his head, and rushed out without looking back.

Sergei breathed out a satisfied sigh, leaning back in his chair. “That worked out pretty well.” He chuckled, taking a drink from his glass.

The thunderstorm of anger Dimitri had been holding back unleashed in a fury. “Well?!” he roared, jumping to his feet. “My son is missing!”

Sergei merely shrugged. “So? You have two others. Your legacy is secure.”

“*My legacy?*” he whispered harshly under his breath. “I don’t give a fuck about my goddamn legacy.”

“You should. It will be all that is left of you once you leave this world. And that might be sooner than you think,” Sergei snapped.

Silence filled the room as the two hierarchies of the Volkov family stared at each other. The innuendo was clear: Sergei planned to kill his son. The only questions were the *when* and the *how*.

I poured the last drink—Vernon’s—and then went to the corner of the room, standing with my back against the wall, and waited to be called on like the other maid standing there, Lisa.

“Careful, Father,” Dimitri all but sang. “That almost sounded like a threat. What *would* everyone think if they heard Sergei Volkov wanted to kill his own son? That he could no longer control his own family? Why, it would be almost *scandalous*, don’t you think?”

Sergei’s jaw clenched. His eyes flicked to Vernon, who was following the conversation with interest blazing in his eyes.

The conversation I’d overheard back at the Volkov estate streaked through my mind. Sergei only cared about what others thought of him. That he was viewed as the scariest Mafia boss in the world. Reputation was everything in their business, after all. And it was evident that it was all Sergei gave a shit about.

His face relaxed, but even I could see it was fake as shit. “I’ll give you men to help find Lukyan.”

They’d never find him. I’d covered my tracks too fucking well.

Elaine, the head maid, came into the room and made a beeline right for me. *Oh, fuck off, you old fart.* “Retire to the kitchen and finish cleaning up. I’ll stay here.”

I wanted to argue, but I didn’t have a leg to stand on, and I certainly didn’t want to draw unwanted attention to myself. Nodding once, I handed her the pitcher and left, making my way toward the kitchen.

I was ticked that I wouldn’t hear the rest of the conversation. Then again, I’d heard enough. My plan worked, and Lukyan’s loved ones would come away relatively unscathed from the whole debacle.

It was almost perfect.

God, I'm good.

My phone vibrated in my pocket. I took it out and glanced at the screen.

Lev: Well? Can it be done? Can you get to him?

Me: Yep. Won't be easy though. I'll need an escape route.

Lev: Leave it to me. Good work, sis. I'll be there soon.

MY BODY COLLIDED WITH ANOTHER, making me drop my phone.

“Oof. Fuck, I’m sorry.”

I looked up and stiffened. *Shit.*

Autumn DeValos stood in front of me. The Crimson Death. Badass personified.

The first time I met her, I’d fangirled. *Hard.* I’d barely been able to contain my excitement. I’d been leaving the Volkov estate after sneaking in to see my Lukyan. She was looking to get in, and I was all about girl power, so I helped her out, telling her exactly what she needed to do. I, of course, knew who she was. Even before The ’Til Death Games, I knew. *Everybody* did.

She had a reputation. A scary-as-fuck reputation with a kill list a mile long. She was goddamn legendary, and the last thing I had expected was to run into her as I was trying to leave.

I’d maintained my cool. Didn’t ask for her autograph or to take a picture, even though I was dying to. Just helped her sneak in and went on my way.

Now, here she was.

I should have anticipated it. I knew she had come with Lukyan and Papa D on the flight over. I was just hoping to avoid her. She was the only person so far to have met me in person. I couldn’t run the risk of her recognizing me.

Autumn bent down and picked up my phone. “I am so sorry. I wasn’t even watching where I was going.” Her hand outstretched, she offered it back to me. “Here you go.”

I took it, trying to hide my unease under a friendly smile. “Thank you.” I pitched my words a little higher to conceal the true sound of my voice. Just in case she remembered.

“How is it in there?” she asked, inclining her head toward the dining room I’d just vacated.

“Tense.”

She chuckled. “Yeah, I bet. I knew it would be. Hence why *I’m* not in there. No way I wanna deal with that shit.”

I smiled again. “I better get going,” I said, pointing toward the kitchen.

“You know what? I’ll come with you. Not quite ready to brave the lion’s den yet.” She fell into step behind me, and I suppressed my groan. The longer Autumn was with me, the better chance she might recognize me, and that would just fuck with everything. I had to minimize my interaction with her as much as possible.

When I stepped into the kitchen, there were mountains of dishes on the bench and in the sink. It was perfect. The perfect excuse I needed to keep myself busy.

“So, how long have you been working here?” She took a seat on one of the barstools around the island bench, crossing her legs.

I kept my back to her as I began to clean up. The wig on my head itched like a motherfucker, but I refrained from adjusting it. It was dark brown, hiding my light locks perfectly. I’d taken a few precautions to hide my true identity, using makeup to obscure my facial features, and had dark, almost black contacts in. “Not long.”

“Do you like it?”

“It’s okay.”

“I can’t imagine Sergei Big-Bastard Volkov is a pleasant man to work for.”

Why the fuck is she talking to me so much?

“He’s not so bad.” Sergei was actually the worst. It’d only been a few weeks, but I didn’t need any longer to come to that conclusion. I couldn’t say that, though. Didn’t need to give Autumn any more reason to engage in conversation with me.

I turned the tap on and filled the sink with water. The dishes *clinked* and *clanked*, filling the silence between us.

“This might sound strange, but have we met before? You seem familiar.”

God fucking damn it. I forced my hands to keep steady as I dunked the dirty plates into the water and started cleaning them. “I don’t think so.”

“Where are you from? I’ve been all over. Maybe we’ve run into each other.”

“I’m sure I’d remember.”

She was silent for a moment. “Could I trouble you for a cup of tea?”

I paused, closing my eyes and taking a deep breath in to calm myself. A tingle ran down my spine, my intuition screaming that I’d been made. That I needed to get the fuck out *now*, before my cover was completely blown. A carving knife sat on the bench within arm’s reach. The idea entered my mind for a fleeting moment before I shut it down.

Autumn was far too skilled to get the drop on. Not only that, but I had a feeling that killing her would be no simple task. It would make a fuckton of noise, drawing attention right to us.

“Of course.” I dried my hands on the apron around my waist and moved to the cupboard above the stove, pulling out a mug.

“Thank you. Appreciate it. So what’s your name?”

“Paula.”

“Paula what?”

I turned the kettle on and grabbed a tea bag, placing it in the mug. “How many sugars would you like?”

“Six.”

I was unable to stop myself from glancing over my shoulder, giving her a bewildered look. “Six?”

She shrugged. “I like it sweet. Paula what?”

The tin of sugar was right in front of me. Teaspoon in hand, I counted out her sugars, placing them in the mug. “Why are you so interested in me?”

“Like I said, I feel like we’ve met before. I just can’t place it. These kind of things bug me, and I won’t be able to sleep until I figure it out—”

Loud, angry footsteps echoed just outside the kitchen. A moment later, Papa D entered in a big, furious huff.

Autumn stood, her face morphing from calculating and suspicious to loving and full of concern. She walked right over to him and hugged him. A sense of relief seemed to wash over Dimitri’s face, his eyes closing and head bending to lie in the crook of her neck as he hugged her back.

It was such a sweet moment. I couldn't help but feel a little jealous. But I had to remind myself that it hadn't been that long since Lukyan and I were finally able to be together. We would get there too. I knew it. Felt it in my soul.

"You okay?" she asked in a whisper.

"No. But I'm better now."

Awwwww.

They separated, and Autumn returned to her seat, Papa D taking the empty one beside her. The kettle *clicked*. I poured the hot liquid into the mug, gave it a stir before adding in a tiny bit of milk, and placed it down in front of Autumn.

"What happened?" she asked, taking a sip of her tea. I was all but forgotten, and I couldn't be more fucking glad.

Dimitri's cold and evil eyes landed on me. "Give us the room."

Fuck knuckles. I wanted to listen in.

Bowing my head slightly, I turned and walked out. With hurried strides, I did a loop so I would end up in one of the other rooms adjoining the kitchen, and peeked around the corner. I was now behind them, their backs to me—and luckily, still within earshot.

"-offered me his men," Dimitri scoffed. "He doesn't give a fuck if we find Lukyan. If anything, he's *glad* this happened. Sergei got what he wanted without having to pay the price for it."

"Do you think...I mean...is it plausible—"

"That the woman who walked down the aisle was his stalker? Yes. I fucking do."

Stalker was such an ugly word. I preferred the term, *loyal and loving girlfriend*.

"I warned him something like this could happen. That she was unpredictable and needed to be handled."

Autumn ran a hand soothingly down his back. "I know. Lukyan did too. I think he was just too intrigued by her. She *is* an intriguing character, after all. Remember what I told you about our encounter? She's completely fucking crazy, and you know your son."

Ahhh. So she *had* told him about when we met. I hoped she said nice things. I wanted my father-in-law to like me, after all.

Papa D sighed, leaning forward to rub his temples. "Yes, I do. Maybe I should have told him about that."

“Wouldn’t have made a difference, and you know it. She still managed to sneak into the house, even after we implemented those new security measures. Fear doesn’t hold her back. It excites her.” *True*. “The harder the challenge, the more determined she is to beat it.”

“Argh, what the fuck am I going to do?” He buried his head in his hands. “I have no idea where he is. Where she’s taken him. If he’s even still in the fucking country.”

“What about those fancy trackers you have?”

Papa D shook his head. “Tried that the second he went missing. The signal was dead. She must have known about it. Fuck! What if she kills him?”

I slammed a palm over my mouth to hide my gasp of shock and outrage. *I would never.*

“I don’t think she would.” *Yes, girl. Have my back.* “She’s obsessed with him. Infatuated with him. Lukyan is smart. He’ll play along with her delusions, and the first chance he gets, he’ll escape. Have faith in him. Until then, we need to do everything we can to help him. We’ll start with the venue. We have the plate of the car she used to drive away, don’t we?” *Already burnt to a crisp.* “We’ll track that, see where they stopped, and follow from there.”

Their words concerned me.

I had to make Lukyan *want* to stay with me. Had to make him see that he couldn’t live without me, like *I* couldn’t live without *him*. How could I do that? How could I convince him to stay? To never want to leave?

“Should I tell the rest of the family?” Dimitri asked, voice layered with uncertainty.

“I think you should,” Autumn answered honestly. “They’ll be furious if you don’t. But you need to make it clear they cannot intervene. If they were to show up here, looking for Lukyan, it could cause more trouble and put Sergei even more on edge. At least if they’re not here, they’re relatively safe. Our focus should be primarily on finding Lukyan’s stalker. If only we knew what she looked like.”

“You never saw her face?”

“No.” Autumn’s lips pursed with thought. “Just her eyes. Light brown, almost like honey. And her voice—*oh my god.*”

“What?” Dimitri’s eyes ping-ponged around the room, looking for danger. “What is it?”

“That’s where I know her from.” *Fuck.*

“Know who from? What are you talking about?”

“The maid!”

Time to go.

I spun on the balls of my feet and bolted. I ran past several other maids, all of them giving me curious looks as I made a beeline for the front door.

Lev was going to kill me. My cover was already blown, and it was all because I’d run into Autumn when I was sneaking into the Volkov estate—something Lev explicitly told me *not* to do.

Yelling came from behind me. I didn’t stop, flinging the door wide-open and running down the driveway as fast as I could. The guardhouse at the front of the property was manned, as usual, but the gate was open, a car sitting idle, waiting to drive through.

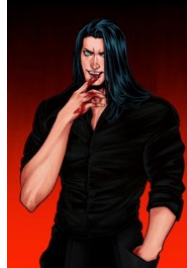
My bike was parked just outside. I only had to reach it.

Pumping my legs harder, I slipped through the open gate. I turned the corner and ran smack into a guard. I didn’t hesitate, palming a knife in the front of my maid uniform. I pulled it out and rammed it up underneath his chin, yanked it out, spun, and sent it flying to another guard, who had just raised his gun behind me.

I didn’t wait to watch him fall. I jumped right on my bike, started it, and sped away just as a round of gunfire hit the air. The ground exploded around me from bullets. Fear and adrenaline punched me in the gut. I banished it away, bent forward, tucked my elbows in, and accelerated, not looking back.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

LUKYAN VOLKOV



“We gonna rock down to Electric Avenue!”

I bolted upright, the sound of music thumping against the walls so loudly they shook, waking me from my sleep. My gaze whipped around the room. Disorientation filled me for a brief moment before I fought my way through it, jumping out of bed.

Memories bombarded me, hitting me all at once like a tidal wave. The wedding. The altar. Beautiful, honey-colored eyes.

“Fuuuuuuck.” I ran to the door. *Locked*. “Fucking fuck fuck!” There was a window to the left, thick, heavy black curtains covering the glass. I flung them to the side and was faced with a steel roller sitting just behind the glass.

“Argh!” I yelled, slamming my closed fists down onto the dresser underneath the windowpane. I spun around, my eyes darting haphazardly from one end of the room to the other, looking for another form of escape.

There was none. I was in a standard bedroom. Beautifully decorated with plush, stylish rugs, oak furniture, and a huge four-poster bed. There was a bathroom off to the side, but even from my vantage point, I could see there would be no escape from there either.

My head pounded like a jackhammer, the music playing continuously in the background not helping matters whatsoever. I needed to get my bearings. Figure out what the fuck was going on. A plate of sandwiches and crackers sat on a tall table near the door, next to a glass of water.

That was what I needed. Fuel. Then I could fucking think straight.

I grabbed the plate and sat down on the edge of the bed, not hesitating to scoff it down.

Okay. What do I know? What are the facts? I'd not only been kidnapped by the woman who had been stalking me for the better part of a year, but she'd also tricked me into marrying her. *That* was something I had not been expecting. I knew she was crazy, but crazy enough to pull off a stunt like that?

No fucking way.

Now what was I going to do? Conversation from the night before flitted through my mind. I couldn't take her words at face value. Just because she *said* everything would be okay, that my sister would be safe, didn't mean I could believe it. My grandfather made it very clear what would happen if I didn't marry Anya. How did I know that what Lyla told me was even the truth? I needed to talk to someone. My brothers. My father. Anyone. I needed to get the fuck out.

The music abruptly stopped. *Thank fucking God.* There was a rattle at the door, then, the knob began to turn. I placed my empty plate down and slid off the bed, crouching low. The door opened, and I lunged.

Lyla twisted and used my body's momentum against me to throw me to the side. I crashed into the side table up against the hallway wall, smashing it to pieces. *Ow.*

Lyla sighed. "I see you're still upset."

I looked up at her amongst the rubble to see her standing calmly in front of me, dressed in a long-sleeved white shirt, casual jeans, and a pair of black-and-white Converse.

She was fucking beautiful. I hoped I'd hallucinated her beauty, but that was certainly not the fucking case. My eyes ran the length of her body, starting from her ankles, slowly going up and up until our gazes locked. An aura filled the air—one filled with such raw, sexual magnetism it made my breath catch in my fucking throat. *Jesus.* I'd never been so attracted to someone like that before. So enamored. So fucking interested in another.

I picked myself up, wiping the dust from my clothes, and stared her down. "So what now? You going to lock me back in the room?"

"I thought we could go on a date."

I blinked, surprised. *Say what? She wants to go on a date? As in, leave the house?*

I tried not to show my excitement. This would be my chance to get the fuck out of here. “Okay. Date sounds nice.”

She smiled. “Wonderful! Let’s go.”

Lyla turned and started making her way down the hallway. I followed, my eyes scanning for anything I could use to my advantage. She led me down a large, circular staircase. First down one flight. Then two. All the way to the foyer. My eyes couldn’t help but track her ass the entire time. It was a good one. Plush and round. An image of me biting into it, leaving my teeth marks on her soft skin soared through my mind, and because I was a horny fucking bastard, my cock instantly hardened.

“Enjoying the view?” she asked casually, strolling right for the front door.

“Yes.” I didn’t see the point in lying. It wasn’t exactly like I could hide it.

She threw me a sexy-as-fuck smirk over her shoulder. In any other circumstance, I would have taken advantage of the burning sexual tension between us. It would be hot. Rough. Fucking *unbelievable*. But for once, I had to think with my head and not my dick.

She opened the front door, and I was greeted with that infernal steel roller security door. A number pad was on the door frame to the left. She entered the code in so quickly I barely managed to get any of the numbers. Not that it mattered. I wasn’t planning to be back in order to use it anyway.

The light above the number pad switched from red to green, and the door *clicked* open. I tensed my muscles in preparation. Lyla placed a hand on the door and started to slowly push it up—

I shoved her out of the way and bolted onto the front porch. *No. No, no, no.* Skidding to a halt, I stared out into the distance. “Oh, get fucked,” I hissed under my breath. There was nothing in sight for fucking miles except rolling hills littered with mountains of snow. We were out in the middle of nowhere. There wasn’t a single sign of life. No other houses. No roads. *Nothing*. The realization that escape was firmly out of my grasp hit me like a ton of bricks.

The floorboards creaked. Lyla came up to my side, a smile on her pretty little face despite the fact that I’d just tried to make a run for it.

“Beautiful, isn’t it?” She sighed dreamily. “Come on, this way.” She turned to the right and walked down the veranda, disappearing around the corner.

My gaze flicked out to the distance again. *Maybe I could—*

“The closest house is miles away, and the temperature is set to reach a low of -9 degrees today. If you think you can make it before your balls freeze, go for it,” Lyla called out.

Grumbling under my breath, I followed after her. A black Range Rover was parked at the back of the house. She stood next to the open door at the back of the car, a white fur coat now draped across her shoulder, and a white beanie over her head. In her hand was a much larger, matching coat, the fabric dangling off her fingertips.

“Not really my style,” I commented, my gaze roving, looking for something...anything that could help me escape.

“Yes, it is.” She said it confidently. With conviction. Not a single shred of doubt, like she’d bet her life on it. “It’s big and bulky. Exactly the way you like your coats, and I made sure to get it in your favorite color.”

My eyes ran over her, assessing. “How did you know white is my favorite color?”

“You forget I’ve been in your room. Multiple times. Sometimes when you were sleeping. Sometimes when you weren’t.” She winked. “I noticed a lot of your clothes were white. My guess? You like to wear it because of the way blood stands out on it.”

“Why would you think that?”

Her smile was devious. “Because that’s why *I* like to wear it.” She stepped back and gestured for me to enter the car with a swipe of her hand. “Come on. Get in.”

I ran through the options in my head. *I could stand out here, freezing my fucking ass off. Go back inside and hope for another opportunity to escape. Or take my chances and get in the car with a crazy woman who tricked me into marrying her and kidnapped me.*

We all knew which option I was going to pick, right?

Blowing out a huff that was only mildly filled with irritation, I walked down the few porch steps and over to the car. I snatched the coat out of her hand, somewhat haughtily, and climbed into the back seat. Lyla followed behind me, buckling herself into the seat next to me.

“You’re going to love this place. I did a lot of research beforehand. Made sure it was absolutely perfect. They’re rumored to sell the best *Korolevsky* cake in town.”

My head snapped to her. “*Korolevsky* cake? That’s my—”

“Favorite?” She turned to face me and gave me that fucking smirk that was quickly becoming my undoing. “I know.”

Of course she fucking did. What *didn't* she know about me would be the better question.

I'd known for the longest time that I had a stalker. Someone who was following my every move. Someone who had an obsession with me. I guessed I never really knew what that entailed until then. She seemed to know everything about me. Things that I was sure no one else knew. No one else even paid attention to.

She faced forward again. “To Tsar Café, please, Cedric.”

The man in the driver's seat nodded once, and the car began to move. He was the same dude I'd knocked out the day prior. I didn't feel bad about it. In my opinion, he deserved it.

I stared out the window, watching the world roll by. “Do you know why *Korolevsky* cake is my favorite?” I asked, keeping my gaze locked outside. I was curious exactly *how much* Lyla knew about me. Whether everything she knew was merely a coincidence.

“Because it's known as *King's cake* and you're the ‘ring-a-ding-king’?”

“You've been listening in on my calls,” I stated.

“Well, we're not really surprised about that, are we?” She chuckled.

I chose not to answer because no, I wasn't at all surprised by it. Based on what I'd observed so far, it was right on par with her. It should have bothered me a fuckton more than it did to know that she'd been essentially monitoring my calls. That she'd been spying on me. *Stalking me*. But it was so different from what I'd ever experienced that, instead of making me nervous or putting me on edge, it goddamn *thrilled me*.

“I saw your father,” she said suddenly.

My head snapped to her. “Say what?”

“You'll be glad to know my plan worked perfectly. There was no blame placed on you or your family. It all went to Anya and the Tarasovs, like I knew it would.”

“Hang on a second.” I turned in my seat to face her. My body itched to move closer, to close the distance between us and finally touch her—the woman who'd caught my attention so long ago and never given it back. “How could you possibly know that? Are you stalking my father too?” That thought didn't sit well with me.

Not. At. All.

“Once I found out you were coming here to marry, I made it a point to infiltrate Sergei’s home as one of his maids. I went there last night after our little...tiff. I thought it might reassure you to know there will be no retribution against your sister for what happened.”

I eyed her suspiciously. “You know that for sure?”

“I do.” She nodded. “Your grandfather had a meeting with Anya’s father and yours. The blame is placed solely on them.” Lyla looked at me expectantly. When I said nothing, she tilted her head. “This is where you say, ‘thank you’.”

“You want me to thank you for kidnapping me?” She really *was* crazy.

“I want you to thank me for risking my life to obtain information to put you at ease.”

But it hadn’t. Not really. Like I’d said before, I couldn’t take her word for it. I needed to hear it with my own ears.

“Yeah...that ain’t gonna happen.” A beat of silence passed. “My father...Is he okay?” He would probably be losing his shit.

“Papa D is losing his shit a little bit.” It was like she could read my goddamn mind. “You’re lucky, you know. He loves you a lot.”

Given what he did to her own father, I was quite surprised Lyla was speaking so highly of him. *Shouldn’t she hate him for what he did?*

I certainly hated *her* father for what he did to my mother, and I always would. If I could, I would resurrect that fucker just so *I* could be the one to kill him.

Despite what happened the night before, I didn’t blame her for what her father did. That would just be completely irrational. Don’t get me wrong, when I found out who she was, it had been a shock, to say the least. But Lyla had only been a child when it all happened, like me. She wasn’t responsible.

“Papa D?” I questioned, a trickle of humor skating through me.

She shrugged absently. “It’s what I call him. I think it suits him, don’t you?”

Yeah. It kinda did.

The rest of the car ride went by quickly and without further conversation. To be honest, I needed a moment to collect my thoughts. To try to figure out what the fuck I was going to do to get out of that situation and back to my family.

I counted the minutes, taking note of every turn we took. The distance between each one. How long we stayed on a straight path. The landmarks. If I wasn't able to get away during that trip, I could hopefully make a run for it from the house and at least have some idea of where I was going. So I wasn't running blind.

Lyla hummed to herself—a soft, melodically tune that I found to be quite calming and soothing. Instantly put me at ease. I studied her discreetly from the corner of my eye. She was truly a marvel to look at. Long, toned body, both slender and curved at the same time. There was definitely something there—some feeling growing in my chest. A connection that I was trying desperately to ignore.

We arrived at a small town. Very laid-back. Snow littered the ground. Dusted the rooftops like a sprinkling of icing. Rows of rustic-style buildings lined both sides of the snow-paved road. There were a few pedestrians walking up and down the footpaths, clad head to toe in winter gear.

The car pulled over to the left and stopped in front of an old sign that read Tsar Café. Cedric turned off the engine and got out. I reached for the door handle, but Lyla spoke, making me pause.

“Before we go, you'll have to put this on.” She pulled something out of a sleek black purse. In her hands was a collar—thick, made of beautiful, dark, padded leather.

My brow arched high. It reminded me of something from the kink world. Between a dom and their submissive. I'd never worn one before, but the idea had always intrigued me.

Excitement flashed in her eyes. “It's a little different from normal submissive collars,” she said, as if reading my mind. “See these.” Lyla twisted it so I could see the inside. Spread evenly throughout the leather were tiny spikes. She pulled out a remote next and clicked a button. The spikes retracted, disappearing completely into the leather. *What in the ever-loving fuck?* “Each individual spike is filled with a small dose of a sedative. On their own, it won't be enough to knock you out, but together, they'll have you flat on your ass in three seconds. You'll wear this, and if you try to escape, I'll activate the spikes, which will render you unconscious. You'll be taken back to the house, and that will be the last time you will ever be permitted to leave. *Ever.*”

Maybe I can try to wrestle the remote from her? Without it, she couldn't activate the spikes.

Her eyes narrowed. She pulled out another collar, almost identical to the other, except not as thick. “Just in case you get any bright ideas and try to steal the remote from me, your collar is synced to mine. If you get too far from it—any more than ten feet—the spikes will automatically activate, and the same thing will happen.”

How the fuck is she doing that?! It was seriously like she could read my fucking mind. As if she could anticipate my thoughts and what I would do before I even knew myself.

I’d never had someone so attuned to me and my thoughts before. It was...freaky. And yet, a part of me—a very, very, very small part of me—liked it. Like having someone who knew me so well, since it felt like most the people in my life barely knew me at all.

“Why the fuck would I agree to wear it? Doesn’t exactly bode well for me.”

She shrugged, starting to pack the collars away. “You don’t wanna wear it? Fine. We’ll just go home.”

Argh. I really want that fucking cake though!

“Wait! Just stop.”

She paused and looked up at me beneath her long lashes. The innocence Lyla portrayed was fake as shit. She was anything but fucking innocent.

“Give it to me,” I snapped. She held it up, and I snatched it out of her hand, clicking it around my neck before I had the chance to back out.

Lyla sighed, almost contently. Something streaked across her face. Something I couldn’t place. *Approval? Satisfaction? Contentment?*

Fucking what?!

I hated that I couldn’t read her as well as she could read me. I had no idea what it was, or what she was thinking, but a warm, fuzzy feeling settled in my chest at the sight of her.

Lyla ran a finger down the side of my face in a warm, loving gesture, eyes fixated on the collar around my neck. “Such a good boy, you are.”

I stiffened, unable to move, completely transfixed by her.

“It looks good on you. Suits you.”

It was a struggle, almost like lifting a car into the air, but I came back to myself, slapping her hand away. “Don’t get used to it,” I hissed. “I’m only doing this because I want that fucking cake.”

She wasn’t the least bit deterred. If anything, the entire thing made her fucking smile. “I have a feeling you’re going to be begging me to wear my

collar very soon, my love.”

A thrill streaked down my spine at her soft, sultry voice. “Don’t hold your breath.”

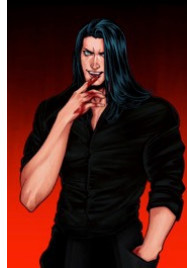
“Why not?” Lyla threw back, clicking her own collar around her throat. “Sounds like fun.” She winked before getting out.

Jesus Chirst. She was goddamn fucking crazy. And if my rock-hard cock was anything to go by, I liked it a little too much.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

LUKYAN VOLKOV



“Can I get another slice?” I asked the waitress who came by to collect my empty plate. She’d been the one to take my order originally, and looked to be barely fifteen.

“Another?” She chuckled, grabbing the empty dish and balancing it effortlessly on her forearm. “You really love *Korolevsky* cake.”

I leaned back and patted my bloated stomach. “Big, big fan.”

“Yes, I can see that. It’s definitely one of our most popular orders. I’ll be right back with your cake. And for you, Lyla? Anything else?”

Across from me, she shook her head. “No, thank you, Heidi.”

The kid smiled. “Let me know if you change your mind.” She walked away, heading for the glass display cabinet at the other end of the café filled with an abundance of sweet treats. She quickly put another slice of cake onto a plate and brought it over before disappearing into the back.

“How does she know your name?” I asked, doing another survey of the room. It was a nice place, with a sweet, rustic charm that a lot of small towns had. Customers walked in and employees greeted them by name. Knew their orders without needing them to say a word. Laughed at inside jokes with one another. An *everybody knows everybody* kinda vibe.

“Been coming here on and off for the past six, seven months. She’s a sweet kid. Her father owns the place, but he’s too sick to work. Parkinson’s. They live in the apartment above the café, and she works every day after school to help out.”

“You’ve been coming to a small town in the middle of nowhere in *Russia* to have coffee? You know you can get that at any corner store. Why

come here?”

“To establish a base. A connection. I wanted to get to know the town close to home.”

Again, strange. I felt as though there was more to it. I ate the cake a lot slower than I had the other portions, using it as a cover to covertly look for a way out. Cedric sat a few tables away, a newspaper in his hands. Several different scenarios streaked through my head, none holding purchase. All of them had a low percentage of actually working, and I couldn’t risk failing.

I believed Lyla when she said it would be the last time leaving the house if I tried anything. I had a better chance of escaping when we were out in town than at the house. Timing was everything. Risking it all for a fleeting chance at escape wasn’t worth it. I had to bide my time and wait for the best opportunity.

“I was thinking, after you’re done, we could take a tour of the town? Show you what it has to offer? It might not seem like much, but it’s actually a really beautiful place.” Something changed in Lyla’s demeanor when she spoke of the town. It intrigued me.

“Do I have a choice?”

She frowned, placing her mug down onto the table. “Of course. I would never want to force you to do something you don’t want to do.”

“Really? Then let me go.”

“This again.” She sighed, rolling her eyes. “How many times do I have to tell you? You don’t *want* to go. Not really. You *like* being here with me. With someone who can see you for who you really are and let you be wholly and unequivocally *you*.”

I was getting a little fucking annoyed with how on point she was. Lyla seemed to know me better than I knew myself. She was right, I did like it.

“I can be that with my family.” Even as the words came out, I didn’t wholeheartedly believe them.

Lyla covered my hand with her own, ripping my gaze from my plate to her. “No, you can’t. Don’t you hate it? Having to always censor what you say? Hold yourself back? I know you love your family, but they don’t know you like I do. They don’t appreciate you like I do.”

It was all getting a little too real for me. If I had any hope of getting away from Lyla, I needed to flip the script. Switch it from *me* to *her*. Gaining her trust and then deceiving her was most likely my best option.

Tricking her into a false sense of complacency and then running the first chance I got.

I cleared my throat and pulled my hand out from under hers. It left a small ache in my chest, which I actively chose to ignore.

“Why do you like this town so much?”

Her eyes lightened with joy. “I love small towns. The kind of towns where everybody knows everybody. The ones with history. Where it’s safe to walk down the streets at night. Leave your front door unlocked. Let your children play in the front yard without fear of something happening to them. A town where everyone looks out for each other and helps each other out. Where, every month, they hold quirky little town events and town meetings and stuff. I never had that growing up.”

“You said my father dropped you and your brother off at an orphanage?” I wasn’t all that surprised to hear that. Even in a blind rage, one where he was so consumed with vengeance, my father would never hurt a child.

The topic of conversation made me think of the one person in the world I tried my hardest not to think about. It caused too much pain.

I was so young when I lost my mother. Barely thirteen. I could only remember bits and pieces of her. Her smile. Warm and loving. How she would stroke my hair when I was lying in bed, sick as a dog. The beautiful, soft sound of her voice when she sang to me. Over time, I’d forgotten things. Memories of her became harder to visualize, like trying to grasp water in the ocean. Whenever it looked like it would finally gain purchase, it would slip right through my fingers.

But those things? Those were things I’d always remember.

“Yeah,” Lyla answered, running a finger loosely over the rim of her mug. “It was nice, as far as orphanages go. The staff were kind and caring, and didn’t try to pull any funny business, like I’ve heard happens at a lot of other ones.”

My father had a strict *no harming children* policy. We were all bastards, and could kill without a glimmer of guilt lingering in our veins, but children were to be protected. A lot of other criminal organizations couldn’t say the same. Those were ones we never worked with or supplied weapons to. If there was even a hint of child abuse or exploitation, my father blacklisted them. In some cases, he would even deal with them the way we dealt with all our enemies.

A slow and painful death.

“If I’m being honest, I actually preferred it over my own house.”

That surprised me enough for me to pause, lowering my forkful of cake back down.

“At least at the orphanage, I wasn’t getting beaten nearly every night.” She said it so casually, with a simple shrug of her shoulders, like it wasn’t a big deal.

“You parents beat you?”

“Just my dad.” She tore a piece of *pirozhki* off—a small, buttery pastry—and popped it into her mouth. “He had grand expectations for his only daughter, and when I fell short of them, he punished me. He wanted an obedient child who would be happy to live the life he curated specifically for them, regardless if they wanted it or not. He wanted me to act a certain way. Be someone I wasn’t. To do what he said when he said it, without commentary. Without hesitation. But fuck, I definitely had something to say about it. I’m not exactly the type to keep my mouth shut. I say it like it is, and he hated that. He’d beat me in places no one could see because of it.”

“Bet you’re glad my father killed him,” I mumbled under my breath, then stiffened. *Shit*. “Fuck, sorry. I didn’t mean to say that. It just slipped out—”

Lyla burst out laughing. It stunned me into silence. *Okay, not exactly the reaction I was expecting.*

“Yes, actually,” she admitted freely, and it stunned the shit out of me. Again.

Lyla just continued to surprise and surprise me. The way she was so unapologetically herself, regardless of how it might have made her look. It was refreshing, to say the least.

I took one last bite of cake, flavor absolutely exploding in my mouth. “You don’t care that my father killed yours?”

“Not in the slightest. If anything, I’m jealous. I would have loved nothing more than to do it myself.” Such raw fucking honesty.

So, if she hadn’t kidnapped me for some sort of revenge for what happened to her family, what was the reason? Could it truly all have been *just* about me?

“Why didn’t you?”

Her shoulder lifted in a half shrug. “Would have hurt my brother.”

Wiping my lips with a napkin, I leaned back in my chair. I chewed what was left in my mouth and then deposited the napkin on my empty plate. “You’re close with your brother?” I asked, reaching for my glass of water.

She smiled, and it was filled with love and affection. “He’s the best. A little single-minded, sure. He can kind of get stuck in his own head and refuse to budge on things sometimes. Incredibly stubborn. But he has a good heart. Deep, deep down.”

Okay. So, tight bond with the brother. Perhaps I could exploit that somehow. Use it to my advantage. I had no idea how, but I kept it in the background of my mind in case I managed to miraculously think of something.

“Being from such a big family, having so many siblings yourself, you would get it. You love them, no matter what they do or say. Even if you don’t necessarily agree with their actions, you’ll defend them and help them. Always.”

I fiddled with the collar around my neck. There was no denying the fact that I liked the way it felt. Liked its heavy weight on my skin. I liked even more that she had a matching one around her throat. “You disagree with your brother a lot?” I asked, trying desperately to keep my thoughts PG-13. If I allowed myself to think about her in a sexual way, it wouldn’t be long before I had Lyla on her back. Or, perhaps, she would have had me on mine.

“Do you disagree with yours?”

“All the fucking time,” I blew out. “In fact, we rarely see eye to eye on things. They’re a lot more serious than I am.” Probably why they were always telling me off for shit.

Guilt wormed its way into my chest at the memory of my last interaction with Aleksandr. At how I ignored him when he tried to say goodbye. I hated how I’d left things, and wanted so desperately to fix our bond.

Will I ever get that chance?

“Yeah, Lev is kind of the same,” she said with a small laugh. “I think older siblings are innately born that way. I just want to have fun and enjoy my life. Lev is hell-bent on fulfilling this stupid mission he’s had since we were kids.”

“What mission?”

For the first time, unease flickered through her eyes. Lyla adjusted in her chair, avoiding my gaze, and abruptly changed the subject. “We should

get ready to leave. There's a few stores I want to take you to before they close."

Something wasn't right. She was actively hiding something from me—something I had a feeling I wouldn't like, and it filled me with trepidation. I opened my mouth to protest, but the bell hanging over the door *dinged*, new patrons walking in. Loud, rowdy voices hit the air not a second later. It was a group of four—all men—that pack mentality vibrating from them. They whooped and hollered, patting each other on the back and cheering them on for God knows what reason.

Cedric looked over the top of his newspaper, eyes narrowing. He kept his gaze on them as they made their way to the register. A man with a mohawk leaned against the counter, chewing his gum obnoxiously loudly.

He slapped a palm down onto the surface. "Hey! Can I get some service here? It's like you don't want paying customers."

The men at his back laughed as if he'd just told the funniest joke ever.

Heidi emerged from the back kitchen, the smile on her face dropping the second she got a glimpse at the new customers. "We-we paid you already."

Paid? The frown on Lyla's brows told me she was just as confused and curious as I was.

"That was *last* week. I'm here for the payment for *this* week."

"What?" Heidi breathed, eyes widening. "But I—that's not—I can't—" Her voice cracked with distress, and her gaze flitted to the other men, who were making their way behind the counter as if they had every right to be there. Like they owned the fucking place.

She backed up until her spine hit the wall behind her, shaking with fear. The men helped themselves to food, dipping their hands into tall glass vases filled with cookies and pastries, taking a few bites only to throw whatever was left at each other, laughing boisterously.

There were four other customers in the café; a couple—a man and a woman—an elderly gentleman, and a teenager. They all got up and hurried out without looking back.

So much for that town camaraderie Lyla spoke of. It was clear Heidi was being hustled, and not one of them stuck around to help her.

Lyla watched the events unfold with critical eyes. There was a barely recognizable shift within her. She was still smiling. Still emitting an outward, friendly demeanor, but a darkness had settled over her eyes—a

darkness I was all too familiar with. A darkness that turned me right the fuck on.

Will she intervene?

I was kind of hoping she would. A part of me wanted to see her in action properly. That little fight we'd gotten into back at the house wasn't enough for me to gauge how skilled she truly was.

However, another part of me didn't want that at all because I knew what would happen. I knew my horny, deranged ass wouldn't be able to keep my hands off her if she was covered in the blood of someone she'd just killed.

Hey, we all had our kinks. Mine just so happened to be a little more twisted than the average joe.

Murder turned me on. Fucking sue me.

"Please, stop." Heidi trembled.

"Oh, we'll stop. Once we get our money." Mohawk used one finger to push a glass jar until it fell off the counter, smashing into a million pieces. "Whoops." He laughed.

The other men took that as their cue to start destroying things. They knocked over the decor. Other display jars filled with food. Dropped glass plates and mugs on the floor just to watch them shatter.

A man with spiky blonde hair started knocking over tables and chairs, laughing as he did so. His friend joined in, using the tip of a baseball bat in his hands to push the furniture over. His arms rose, preparing to strike a picture frame sitting on a side table—

"No!" Heidi ran out from behind the counter and stood in front of it, protecting it. "Please. Don't. I'll give you your money. Just, please. Don't destroy anything else."

Baseball Bat looked at Mohawk, the bat still hefted up into the air.

"Get me money then," Mohawk told Heidi.

She nodded, running back to the counter. With a *ding*, the register opened. Her hands shook as she pulled out note after note and handed them to the ringleader. He smiled like a cheshire cat, counting the cash like he'd just won big.

"Good. Same amount next week."

"Yo, hold up, Darrell," Spiky Hair called out when Mohawk went to walk out. "I'm starving. Get the bitch to make us some food."

Darrell clicked his fingers. "You know what? I think that's the smartest idea you've ever had, Ben." He looked at Heidi. "Bring us a couple burgers

and fries. Don't be stingy on the fucking salt, either." Heidi disappeared into the kitchen. Laughing and shoving each other in some kind of comradery, they all sat down, lounging across different tables.

"You seen them before?" I asked Lyla.

She shook her head. "No. But we're about to become *very* familiar."

Fuck. I adjusted myself discreetly, my cock already starting to grow hard because of that murderous fucking look on her face. I was screwed.

A few minutes later, Heidi emerged from the kitchen, another woman in a chef's outfit following close behind her. Plates filled with food balanced effortlessly on their forearms despite the fact their bodies trembled with fear. One by one, they placed the plates down on the tables. A few of the men took liberties they had no right to take, slapping Heidi and the other woman on the ass.

My gaze flicked to Lyla again. An eerie kind of calmness had settled over her. She'd done nothing but watch so far, and to be honest, I was a bit surprised. Even *I* felt like doing something, and I didn't even know them.

Heidi approached our table. "I am so sorry about that," she whispered, clearing her throat. Her eyes were red and glassy. "Is there anything else I can get you?"

"Just the bill. Thanks, Heidi," Lyla responded.

"Of course." She pulled out a small black book from inside her apron and placed it down on the table. "Whenever you're ready."

She turned to leave. Lyla reached forward, grabbing her arm. Heidi paused, glancing over her shoulder. "Who are those men?" Lyla asked calmly.

Heidi bit her lip anxiously. She lowered her voice to barely above a whisper, and I was forced to lean forward, resting both elbows onto the table, to hear her clearly. "They moved to town a few weeks ago. Told me if I wanted to keep the café safe, I had to pay them. I did. I didn't want them destroying the place or hurting the customers. I'm not the only one either. They've threatened every owner on the block, demanding cash. Roland, the old man who runs the antique bookstore across the street, tried to fight them. Told them he wasn't going to pay them anything. They broke his leg."

It was a shakedown. I'd seen it numerous times in Vegas. Small-time gangs would go into establishments and demand a payment. As long as that

payment was made, it would keep the business safe from any reprisals from the gang.

“Hmm.” Lyla shoved a couple hundred-dollar bills into the black book and handed it back to Heidi. “You got a back office in here with a lock?”

The kid frowned, no doubt confused by the random as fuck question. “Behind the kitchen. It’s where we keep the safe.”

“Take yourself in there and lock the door. Don’t come out until I say so.”

“No, no, no. I don’t want any trouble,” she rushed out.

“There’s no trouble.” Lyla smiled, and it was a purely evil and vindictive smile. “Quick. Off ya go.”

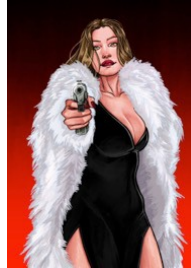
Heidi hesitated for only a moment longer before she did as instructed, running off. I glimpsed her grasp the chef’s hand, and they both disappeared into the kitchen.

Lyla finally looked at me. “Fancy a fight?”

Say no. Say no. I shrugged a shoulder lazily. “Why the fuck not?”

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

LYLA VOZNESENKY



*I*smirked.

It couldn't be any more fucking perfect. What better way to bond and build a relationship than to kill a few people together? It would be something that bound us together for life. Something we could talk about for years to come, when we were sitting around the fire, reminiscing about the good old days.

Hey, remember that time a bunch of dickheads came into the café, and we slaughtered them?

Oh, yeah, that was fun.

Nothing established a meaningful connection quite like it.

The sound of my chair scraping across the floor hit the air. It was intentionally loud, and drew every set of eyes directly to us. Lukyan leaned back, spreading his thighs, watching me.

It was my time to fucking shine. To show him how perfect we would be together.

I stood and stretched my arms over my head, releasing a yawn.

"You. Come here," the fucker with that ugly-ass mohawk demanded.

"Me?" I asked casually, hand to my chest.

"Yeah, you," Ben answered instead.

"Okay." Skipping, I made my way over to them. Cedric kept a close eye on me as I walked past him. With a subtle, barely recognizable shake of my head, I told him not to interfere.

Darrell ran his eyes up and down my body, hunger flaring in his eyes. "You're a cute little thing."

“Thank you! You’re so sweet!”

“Fucking hell.” One of the other men laughed. “She’s got no idea, does she?” He was missing a few teeth, the others stained yellow.

“Come sit down, cutie. No, not there. Here.” Darrell patted his thigh. I sat down, giggling.

“You’re handsome.”

“I know.” He buried his head into the crook of my neck, sniffing my hair. “You like a big, strong man, baby?”

I giggled again. “Yeah. But you know what I like more?”

Darrell’s hands came down onto my thighs, caressing. The other men chuckled, eating their food, throwing each other knowing glances and winks. I wasn’t an idiot. They might as well have been broadcasting their thoughts for the entire world to see. They thought I would be an easy fuck, and if I wasn’t, they were going to take me for themselves.

I let them think whatever the fuck they wanted. They would soon see how it really was.

“I like having a strong man bend to my will.” I slipped off his lap, slow, sensual, dropping to my knees in between his legs. I turned so I was facing Darrell, my hands moving to the waistband of his jeans.

“Oh, fuck yeah. Look at this bitch.” A man with a receding hairline laughed. “She’s fucking thirsty for your cock, Darrell.”

I unsnapped Darrell’s belt and popped the button on his jeans, pulling down the zipper. A repugnant smell wafted into the air from his crotch. It made me want to fucking vomit.

“Dibs on next.” Ben sniffed, wiping his nose aggressively with the sleeve of his shirt.

“No, I’m next!” the man with the baseball bat at his side barked.

“Fuck off, Sawyer! I am!” Receding Hairline blasted.

“Gentlemen, gentlemen, calm down. We’ll all get a turn, won’t we, darling?” Darrell snickered, lifting his hips so I could pull his pants down. His dick was fully out, and growing harder and harder with each passing second. It was repulsive, to say the least.

“Yes, you will.” Discreetly, I pulled a karambit knife from my waistband. It was my favorite type of blade. Curved like a tiger’s claw, it had a safety ring embedded into the handle for secure gripping. “But *you* get first honors.”

I lowered my head. Darrell's head tilted back, exposing his throat. I gripped the knife tightly and swung up in a powerful arc. The blade ripped through his throat, spraying blood in every direction. I kicked back, flipping the table, which toppled, knocking the three remaining men to the ground. I went to Ben first, jumping over the fallen table and landing on top of him, legs either side of his body, my knife to his throat.

"You said next, right?" My grin was wicked.

His eyes widened. "Wait! No!" I brought the sharp tip down right into his eye. He screamed.

Two down, two to go. This is going to be over too quickly.

A foot came flying toward my face. I blocked with my forearm, curled my hand to grip his shin, and twisted. It was Receding Hairline. He let loose a howl of pain. As he went down, I followed, using gravity and my body's momentum to drive my blade deep into his stomach. I ripped upward, his organs shredding beneath my weapon like paper.

The last man swung his baseball bat toward my head. I ducked and rolled forward, abandoning my blade. I had no choice. I spun, staying in a crouched position as he advanced, vengeance burning his eyes.

"You're fucking dead!" he hissed.

I giggled maniacally, the smile on my face getting wider and wider. Blood dripped down my face, down my chin, splotches of it hitting the floor. The tiniest bit of fear flickered in his eyes. Behind him, I saw Lukyan. He was up on his feet, watching me with an almost entranced look on his face.

I remained low, slinking across the floor like a spider as I moved slowly to my left. It just freaked the fuck out of Sawyer even more, his body frozen in place while he tracked me with his eyes, the bat beginning to tremble in his hands. He looked around at his dead friends, the dark red blood pooling around them, and decided to cut his losses.

The bat clanged to the floor. He twirled and made a run for the exit.

Lukyan stepped into his path. A sexy-as-fuck, wickedly evil grin was on his face. "Where are you going? The fun is only just starting."

"Get the fuck out of my way, man!"

Lukyan *tutted*. He took one step forward. Sawyer took a step back.

Intrigued, I stayed where I was, curious about what he would do next.

I'd seen Lukyan kill before. Watched him from the shadows as he dealt with people who stepped out of line. As an enforcer for the Bratva, that

happened a lot. It was his job to dole out punishments and inflict pain on those who fucked with their business.

He enjoyed it.

And I enjoyed watching him.

Lukyan grabbed Sawyer by the scruff of his neck. Sawyer bent to his will immediately, pleading.

“Plea-please don’t kill me. I’m sorry, okay? I won’t come in here again, I swear.”

“You think I give a fuck about that?” Lukyan scoffed. “I just want to have some fun.”

Sawyer must have glimpsed something in Lukyan’s eyes because he dropped to his knees, as if his submission would somehow save him.

It wouldn’t. That twinkle in Lukyan’s eyes...I’d seen that before. He wanted blood.

Lukyan let Sawyer go with a rough shove. “Get the fuck up.”

“No, man, please. I—”

“I said, get the fuck up,” Lukyan demanded, his voice rising along with his anger.

Legs shaking, Sawyer got to his feet, his whole body trembling.

I approached, excitement thrumming through my bones. The idea of watching Lukyan in his element...Jesus, fuck...It made me feel things in places I probably shouldn’t be feeling them.

Oh, well.

“Want one of my knives, my love?” I asked, gazing up at him. I felt like a lovestruck teenager. All I could think about was the years to come...Us, killing people who wronged us, side by side...It would be perfection.

Lukyan’s eyes flared. “You’ll give me one?”

“Of course, silly! Here, I’ll give you my *favorite* one.” I pulled out another karambit knife. This one was bloodred, with an intricate pattern of lines and swirls engraved into the silver blade.

He held it up, admiring it. “What makes *this* one your favorite?”

I masked my excitement. He was asking questions. Wanting to know more about me. His interest in me was growing. I could tell. Why else would he ask such an intimate and personal question?

“This one holds great sentimental value. It’s the one I used to claim my first kill.”

His eyes lit up as if in understanding. “Ah. I have one of those too.”

“Yeah?”

“Yeah.” He put his index through the ring on the handle and flipped it this way and that, testing the balance. “You stole it.”

The memory flashed through my head like a scene in a movie. Me, creeping into his bedroom in the dead of night, seeing him passed out in bed. There’d been a dagger on his bedside table. In the past, I had tried to restrict myself from taking things he might otherwise need, only taking miscellaneous items, like his towel from the gym. A random T-shirt. His toothbrush. A lock of his hair.

I couldn’t help the compulsion. I just wanted to keep him close to me, even when we were worlds apart, and by taking his possessions, it satiated that part of me. But there was just something about that shiny silver dagger that called to me.

So, I took it, climbed back out of his window, paused on the climb down the side of his house, and flashed it to the security camera.

I ran a finger softly down his lips. “Well, if you behave, I might just give it back.”

Lukyan didn’t move, eyes boring into mine. He cocked his head in intrigue. “How many times did you break into my room?”

“Far too many to count.”

“Why did you do it?”

Keeping my touch featherlight, I brushed a lock of hair out of his face, caressing his skin as I made my way down to the collar around his neck. “I like watching you sleep.”

His brows creased slightly. “Why?”

I didn’t really know why, if I was being honest. It just brought me peace. Quietened my brain, if only for a little while. And that was something I’d come heavily to rely on. It was one of the reasons I installed hidden cameras in his room. On those nights when I couldn’t make it in person, I could still watch him sleep from afar.

“Because I’m obsessed with you.” I winked. “But you know that already.”

“I’m beginning to see the depths of your obsession.”

“Oh, baby, you’ve just barely scratched the surface.” I wasn’t kidding. If Lukyan really, *truly* knew how deep my obsession for him ran, he’d probably run in the other direction.

Something indecipherable flashed across his face. Interest, maybe? I wasn't quite sure. But I chose to believe it was a positive emotion, not a negative one.

"I'm curious," Lukyan began, running his fingertips over the curved blade lightly, "am I your first obsession?"

Why would he ask me that?

"I'm curious," I said back, parroting him, "how would you feel if you weren't?" Of course, he was. Like I'd said on numerous occasions, we were soulmates. No one else could or would ever compare to him. But I wondered if perhaps the idea of me stalking someone else would make him jealous.

"I'd feel—"

His words were cut off when Sawyer abruptly spoke, interrupting him. *The fuck?* "Um, excuse me—"

Anger flashed across Lukyan's face. He swung the blade back in a powerful arc, slicing it across Sawyer's throat. "Can't you see I'm fucking talking?" he growled.

Sawyer choked, his hands coming up to his neck. Blood seeped through his fingers. He dropped to his knees, eyes wide in disbelief, before toppling over, dead.

I arched a brow. Lukyan stepped into my space and held the blade to *my* throat, just above the collar. In my peripheral vision, I glimpsed Cedric react instantly, whipping out his gun and aiming it at Lukyan's head.

I raised a hand, stopping him from doing anything else. With a simple wave of my hand, I commanded him to leave. He hesitated, clearly not wanting to go, but the look on my face left no room for discussion. Lukyan wouldn't kill me. I firmly believed that.

Grumbling, Cedric tucked his gun back away and left the café.

Lukyan clocked the movement, smirking devilishly. "You're that confident I won't kill you?"

"Yes," I responded without a shred of doubt. I placed my hands on his chest, feeling his heart pounding beneath my fingers. "Now, you were saying...you'd feel..."

He leaned closer, his lips only a hair's breadth away from mine as he murmured, "I'd feel...cheated."

"Cheated?"

“Mm-hmm.” Lukyan nodded. He was still so fucking close. One movement was all it would take to finally feel those lips on mine. I wanted to take it. “You can’t make a guy feel special and then just take it away like that. It’s liable to make him go a little crazy.”

“I like crazy,” I breathed.

“I’m well aware.”

Lukyan liked crazy, too, and there was nothing crazier than the shit going through my head right now. The sexual tension burning between us was off the fucking charts. It was enough to set the whole goddamn town ablaze. I stepped closer, the blade biting into my skin. His eyes flared. “Put the knife down and get on your knees,” I said, authority dripping from my voice.

He stiffened. “What?”

“You heard me.”

For a moment, he did nothing but stare at me. The seconds dragged on. Lukyan swallowed thickly, his hand shaking slightly as if he were at war with himself, one part of him yearning to follow my command, the other trying desperately not to obey.

“Why the fuck would I do that?” he asked roughly.

I raised my head and straightened my spine, staring him dead in the eyes, deep into his soul. “Because I fucking told you to.”

His eyes closed, an almost soft, barely audible whimper escaping his lips. I waited. Usually, I wouldn’t. I expected complete submission from my partners, but Lukyan and I had yet to discuss that, so I was willing to give him a little bit of leeway.

For now.

I had a feeling his past sexual exploits consisted of *him* giving the orders. Granted, it probably wasn’t the time or the place to explore those kinds of things, but when you’re in the moment, you’re in the fucking moment, and the need for him pounding in my veins made it impossible for me to ignore.

The knife he held to my throat meant that, despite my order, he was firmly in control. It was probably why it all felt so right. Why I thought it was the perfect moment to do it, despite our environment. It wouldn’t feel right doing it any other time. I didn’t want there to be any doubt that *if* he decided to follow my command, it was because *he* chose to do it. Not

because he felt forced to listen because I'd...you know...kinda kidnapped him.

Lukyan ran his tongue over his bottom lip. Slowly. Leisurely. My body heated at the sight, powerless to stop my mind conjuring up images of that tongue doing the exact same thing on the delicate, more intimate parts of my body. A moment passed between us. What kind of moment, I couldn't quite say, but it was significant. I was sure of it.

Finally, after what felt like a lifetime and a great internal battle, he stepped back. The knife clattered to the ground, and Lukyan dropped to his knees. A sense of euphoria washed over me. He looked up at me, face calm and relaxed.

There he was. The *real* Lukyan. The one craving to have the right person take control of him.

For *me* to take control of him.

He knelt, surrounded by dead bodies, blood pooling all around him. The sight of him like that, with my collar around his neck... I'd never been more turned on in my fucking life. I just wanted to take him right there and then, but I refrained. While being out in the open in a public café, with people walking past the building every now and then only added to my desire, the first time we had sex would be more intimate. It would be just me and him.

Still, I needed a little something to tide me over, or I felt as though the heat taking over my body would make me explode. And he deserved a little something, too, for listening so well.

I approached him. Lukyan took a deep breath in, his body remaining still but stiff as he watched me get closer and closer. When I was right in front of him, my pussy all but at eye level, I stopped. Using one hand, I tilted his head up to look at me. Lukyan's gaze lingered on my pussy for a moment before his eyes snapped up to me, scorching with lust.

"Want a taste?"

Warmth spread through me at the look on his face. Pure devotion. He nodded.

I caressed his cheek, running my hand lightly over his skin, down to his strong jawline, across to his chin, pausing when my thumb sat perfectly on his soft lips. Slowly, I pushed my thumb into his mouth. His lips parted willingly. Heat coursed through my veins. Wetness slicked down my thighs. *Fuck me sideways.*

Calmly, casually, I put my free hand down the front of my jeans. Lukyan stayed utterly still as he watched, a small moan bubbling up at the back of his throat. I brushed two fingers over my pussy, my head tilting back in pleasure at the sensation taking over me. I was so pent-up I feared I would come from that one act alone.

Lukyan emitted another sound—one that sent my whole body tingling. It was a cross between a growl and a pain-filled groan.

You and me both, baby.

I hooked my fingers, trying to gather as much of my wetness as I could before pulling my hand out, my fingers glistening wet. Lukyan breathed hard, his chest rising and falling rapidly. I looked down the length of his long, hard body. His cock bulged in his pants. His hands remained clenched into tight fists at his sides. It was killing him, not being able to move. I didn't need to be a mind reader to see that. And yet, he stayed still, waiting for permission.

"You've been such a good boy. Don't worry. I won't make you wait, baby."

Relief seemed to wash over him.

I used the thumb already in his mouth to open his mouth wider, and then placed my wet fingers on his tongue. "Suck, baby."

His lips closed instantly, and he sucked. *Hard*. His warm tongue swirled over my fingers as if trying to lick up every ounce of me. My pussy fucking *throbbed* at not only the feel of it all, but the sight of having him completely at my mercy.

Desperate for me.

Just as I was for him.

When I went to pull my fingers from his mouth, he latched onto me, snapping his hand around my wrist to keep it there. Desperation shone in his eyes. He wanted more. Fuck, so did I. But despite the hunger and desire roaring in my blood, reality was seeping back in.

We couldn't stay there much longer. Heidi and Suzanne, the cafe chef, wouldn't stay in the back office forever. Not to mention the fact that it was only a matter of time before someone tried to come in. Cedric stood in front of the café door, blocking it, but I'd been going to that town for months, and I knew some of the locals got a bit nutso if they didn't get their caffeine hit.

We had to go.

“That’s enough, baby,” I whispered, attempting to pull my fingers out of his mouth again. He fought me, refusing to let go, as if completely overcome with desire.

I won’t lie, I lowkey loved that he was already so hungry for me, but I had to be strong. He wasn’t in charge. I was.

I gripped him roughly by the hair and snatched his head back at the same time I yanked my fingers away. He snarled, trying to follow them like a man possessed, but I held on tight, making him wince.

“While I love the enthusiasm, my love, you’re going to have to learn to follow orders if you want more.” I leaned forward, running the flat of my tongue up the side of his face from his strong jawline up to his temple. He shuddered, his whole body quaking. I placed my lips at his ear and whispered, “While I’m dying to punish you, I don’t think you’re quite ready for that.” I gripped his earlobe between my teeth, giving it a little bite before releasing him completely.

Forcing myself to take a step back from him was hard. Probably one of the hardest things I’d ever done in my life, but it had to be done.

Lukyan remained on his knees for a moment, an almost drunk, high-like expression on his face before he shook it off.

“What the fuck?” He breathed out, as if he couldn’t believe what had just happened.

I smirked, putting the same fingers he’d just had in his mouth into mine. His taste exploded across my tongue, and I so desperately wanted more. Like I’d said to Lukyan numerous times before, I knew him. Knew everything about him. I knew his favorite color. His favorite meal. His favorite torture technique. And I knew that, deep down, beneath that golden retriever energy, he was just dying to be dominated.

And I was dying to be the one to do it.

CHAPTER NINETEEN



DIMITRI VOLKOV

“Talk to me, Butcher. What’s going on inside that stubborn head of yours?”

Autumn and I sat on a bench outside my father’s home, the cold, blistering wind making me rethink the idea of not having the conversation inside the house. But I couldn’t take the risk. I knew Sergei had bugged our room. He was paranoid enough to bug the rest of the house as well. A part of me was a little worried he might have placed listening devices out here too. It was definitely in the realm of possibility.

I had no choice, though. I couldn’t leave, or I risked catching a bullet to the heart. The only place to talk semi-freely was outside.

“Where do I even fucking start?” I blew out, bowing my head. My elbows were braced on my thighs, my hands clasped together tightly in frustration.

I told him. I fucking *told* him to be careful. Warned him that the woman stalking him was wildly unpredictable. It fucking figured. If any of my children were going to be stalked by a crazy person, it would be my youngest son. And of course, the fool would be nothing but excited by the notion.

I should have put a security detail on him. Should have had someone watching his back, but even *I* couldn’t have foreseen what would happen. As hard as I had tried, I wasn’t able to dig up a lick of information on his stalker. She was lithe and sly, always able to avoid any tails I’d tried to stick

on her. Always covering her face with masks. No matter how hard I'd tried, I was never able to uncover her identity.

It fucking irked me.

Now that insane bastard had kidnapped my son. She'd orchestrated an elaborate and, quite frankly, ingenious plot to have him all for herself, taking Anya's place.

It was goddamn fucking brilliant, even *I* had to admit.

Autumn laid a hand on my shoulder, her touch instantly comforting me. "We'll find him," she whispered softly.

"Will we?"

"Yes. We will." Autumn's voice held nothing but strength, and I grasped onto it like a lifeline, desperate for her words to be true. "She's been obsessed with him for so long, adamant on having him. I don't think she would do anything to hurt him, so we have time. Time to do everything possible to find out where she's keeping him."

I wished I could believe that. "When stalkers finally get the object of their obsession, it almost always falls short of their expectations. What they imagined it to be like. If Lukyan doesn't live up to her vision of him, the version she's created in her mind, she could punish him for it."

Her lips twisted in thought. "I don't believe that's the case here. I think it's more than just some silly obsession for her. Think about it. Look at everything she's done. The way she looks out for him. I think Looney Tunes *really* loves him. Why else would she break in here? It's a highly guarded mansion filled with the family of the man she'd *just* kidnapped. The risk alone should have been enough to keep her away, and yet, she'd been right here, less than a foot away from us."

I frowned. "You think she came here for him?"

"What other reason could there possibly be? Maybe Lukyan asked her to check in on you. Make sure you were okay after what happened, and she did it just to make him happy."

"I think you're reaching." But she did make a good point. What other reason could she possibly have for breaking into Sergei's estate like that? I'd been questioning it since the moment it happened.

I was still pissed off that she'd managed to escape so easily. If I'd only been just that little bit faster, I would have her in my possession. Would have been able to torture her until she coughed up the location of where she was keeping my son.

“Maybe. Maybe not. There’s something else troubling you about the whole situation, though. I can see it in your eyes.”

Autumn was right, as I’d come to often realize about her. She was right all the bloody time. “I fear...” How could I even put it into words? Just thinking it made me sick to my stomach. “I fear that he might not *want* to come back.”

Autumn immediately started shaking her head. “No. No, I don’t believe that. He loves you. He loves his family.”

“We’ve treated him pretty shit lately.” Honestly? I wouldn’t even really blame him. I’d come to realize my mistake, but I feared I’d realized it too late. That the damage was done. “If he falls for this woman, which is highly likely considering how much their personalities match, he might choose to stay. He might not even give a fuck that she kidnapped him to start with. Lord knows he fucking wanted it.”

“Are you afraid she’ll kidnap me?”

“Yes.”

“If she did, I’m pretty sure I would like it.”

Those had been his words. His own fucking words. Granted, Lukyan might have been joking, but then again, he might not have been.

“Have you told the rest of the family yet?” Autumn asked.

I sighed. “No.” I knew I probably should. It had been two days. Aleksandr had already messaged, asking how the wedding went. If I didn’t respond soon, he would know something went wrong.

“You know you need to.”

“I’m worried about how they’ll take it.”

Autumn crossed her legs, her mind ticking as she tried to carefully pick her words. “They won’t take it well. They’ll want to drop everything and come out here to help find him.”

“And that would be disastrous.”

“It would be.” Autumn nodded because she knew exactly what I did; they would tear that country apart to find him. “So you’ll need to explain that to them. Make them see it. I’d start with Aleksandr. Get him onboard, and Nikolai and Illayana will follow.”

My gaze flicked to the security guards Sergei had assigned to follow our every move. They never let us out of their sight. Even when we retired to our room for the night, they stayed in the hallway, monitoring and

documenting everything we did to report back to my father. “Let’s go for a walk.”

Autumn glanced at the guards, a knowing twinkle in her eyes. She nodded. I stood first, offering her my hand. She uncrossed her legs, slipping her hand into mine, and I helped her to her feet.

My arms wound around her, and I held her for a moment, just enjoying her closeness, the way her mere presence calmed the raging storm inside me. She looked up at me and smiled. My heart stopped. It was radiant. Bright and warm, like the sun. I didn’t think I would ever stop marveling at her beauty, and the fact that, despite all odds, she’d fallen in love with an asshole like me.

“What?” she asked, still smiling.

“Nothing.” I kissed her softly, every fiber in my body bursting with happiness. She laughed against my lips, her smile so wide it reached her eyes. Warmth filled my chest.

“Come on.” She slipped her hand in mine and led me down the verandah toward the back of the house. As predicted, our guard detail of four followed.

Once we’d reached the back deck, I took the lead, heading down the porch steps. There was an olympic-sized pool to the left, an outdoor area with a cabana, chairs, and tables to the right, and a square tile footpath that ran all the way down to the tennis and basketball courts at the very back of the yard. Other guards patrolled the grounds, the security having been amped up since Lukyan’s stalker had infiltrated the house.

“I still can’t get over this place,” Autumn commented as we followed the path. “With all these amenities and shit, it’s like a private resort. Must have been a dream living here.”

“Not really.” I had a lot of memories from my childhood, none of them happy. “He never let us use any of it. There were more important things to worry about than leisure activities.”

“Really?” Her voice dripped with disbelief. “You know, sometimes, I forget what a royal asshole your father is. And then you say *one* thing about him, and I’m like, ‘Oh, that’s right, he’s a cunt’. I mean, why have all this shit if you’re never going to use it?”

I chuckled softly, continuing down the path. “It’s all for show. Everything Sergei has is for show. Including his children and grandchildren.”

She grumbled something under her breath that sounded like a bunch of harsh curse words. A gust of cold, icy wind hit us. She shivered, her teeth clattering.

I cursed and pulled the lapels of Autumn's coat tighter before rubbing my hands up and down her arms in an attempt to keep her warm. "We should have had this conversation inside. You're freezing."

"No, I'm f-fine. It's better we talk about this out here, where there's a better chance of your dickhead father not overhearing us." She pulled her phone out of her coat pocket and offered it to me.

I hesitated.

"Come on. The longer you leave it, the worse it'll be." Autumn pushed it into my chest. "Take it. Call him. It might not be as bad as you think."

I gave her a deadpan look.

"Fair point. It'll probably be *worse* than you think. You still gotta do it."

"Fine." I snatched the phone out of her hands. "But I want it noted that it's under duress."

Her lips, slightly tinted blue, thanks to the cold, kicked up into an amused smirk. "Noted. Now, hurry up so we can get the fuck out of the cold."

I dialed Aleksandr's number. It rang three times before he answered.

"Autumn. Is everything okay?"

"It's me."

"Father," he acknowledged. "I've been trying to call you."

"Yes, I know."

"Oh, good. So you've been *intentionally* dodging my calls, then. Care to tell me why?"

Not particularly, I thought to myself, but I knew I had to. Autumn was right. The longer I left it, the worse it would be. Plus, I couldn't risk them all finding out some other way. They needed to hear it from me.

"Lukyan's been kidnapped. By his stalker."

Silence. Goddamn fucking crickets.

I waited, letting him process the information. Autumn gave me two thumbs up in support.

"When?" he all but growled out.

"Two days ago." I explained everything, right down to the last detail, leaving nothing out. I gave him every bit of information I had, including

how Lukyan's stalker had infiltrated Sergei's estate to—we assumed—gather information.

Aleksandr listened to it all without interrupting.

"Hold on," he said after I'd finished. A few beeps came through the phone, and then he was back. "Okay. Nikolai and Illayana are here."

"What? Where?"

"Take the phone away from your ear, Father," Illayana's soft voice followed.

"Why would I do that? I won't be able to hear you."

"Just do it," Nikolai grunted.

I took the phone away. On the screen were Aleksandr, Nikolai, and Illayana, spliced into three boxes. Their backgrounds showed they were all in different places. "Oh. Hello."

Illayana smiled, waving her hand. Nikolai nodded.

"Repeat everything you just said for them," Aleksandr said.

I did. Autumn's hand caressed up and down my back in a show of support as I spoke, which I greatly appreciated. It was hard for me, having to relay again and again how I'd failed to keep Lukyan safe, but it had to be done.

"Fucking hell," Illayana blew out after I was done. "I fucking told him she was bad fucking news. Why couldn't he, for once, just listen to reason?"

"He wouldn't be Lukyan if he did," Nikolai commented. "So what happens now? What resources has Grandfather offered to help locate him?"

"A few men, and even that was barely offered. We can't rely on him. We have to pool our own resources. Aleksandr, get on the phone with some of the other families in the Bratva. See what they've heard and what's circling the streets. Whatever information they have, I want it, no matter how inconsequential."

Aleksandr nodded, writing something down.

"Nikolai, I need you to scour the CCTV footage from the venue as well as Sergei's estate. See if you can track her movements and possibly get me a fucking ID on her. She has to show her face somewhere. Once we have a face, we should be able to get a name."

"On it," Nikolai grunted.

"And me?" Illayana asked.

Nikolai answered before I could. "Nothing. You're useless."

Illayana's eyes narrowed. She got up, disappearing out of the frame, reappearing in the open doorway behind Nikolai a moment later. She marched right for him, slapped him on the back of the head, spun, and marched right back out.

Nikolai grumbled, rubbing the back of his head with one hand.

Illayana walked back into her frame and sat down with a smile on her face. "I was thinking I can reach out to some of my Cosa Nostra contacts," Illayana began, as if there'd been no interruption. "Arturo has connections with border security and aviation. If she's left the country with him and comes back to the states, we need to know so we don't waste time looking for him in the wrong place."

I nodded. "Smart idea. Time is of the essence. This woman is too unpredictable to try and anticipate what she will do next."

"Do you think she'll kill him?" Illayana asked, voice filled with worry.

I didn't want to lie. "I don't know. If Lukyan refuses to comply, she might. So we need to find him before that happens."

"And what of our other...issue?" Aleksandr knew better than to say it outright, especially given where I was. Who could be listening.

"I'll handle it."

"How?" Aleksandr questioned.

I locked eyes with Autumn and nodded once. She smiled, throwing me a wink before she turned and walked behind me. I continued on. When our guard detail tried to follow, Autumn stood in their path, blocking them. The harsh sounds of a fight came next. I glanced over my shoulder to see she had already subdued some of the guards, two of them lying unconscious on the floor. She had the third in a choke hold while the fourth was circling her. The man in her arms slumped, knocked out. Autumn dropped him and sprang forward, catching the fourth guard completely off guard with a tackle. She choked him out just like the others in record time.

Springing back to her feet, she skipped back to my side and slipped her hand in mine, smile still firmly on her face.

"With Lukyan's kidnapping, the plan will have to change," I said, bringing Autumn's hand up to place a soft kiss on her skin in thanks. She beamed up at me. "I'll have to handle it myself."

"Again, I ask, how?"

"I've been in touch with my contacts in Sergei's ranks." I made eye contact with one of them off in the distance. Rurik Gusev. He stood on the

verandah surrounding the house, arms folded across his chest. He'd witnessed what just happened, and like I'd hoped, he did nothing to interfere. I nodded. He nodded back before turning around and walking back into the house. "He's one of Sergei's *brigadiers*, and has information about others within the Bratva who are willing to fight for a change in leadership. My father has not been treating his people right, but they're too scared to stand up to him. That's where I come in. I'll present them with another option. If I can get enough of them on board, I can overthrow him without a single loss of life. Well, except for Sergei's."

"Why wasn't this the plan to start with? We could have just done that instead of risking Lukyan." Illayana's disapproval was clear as day.

"Because it's risky," Nikolai answered instead. "Father is suggesting making a move while Sergei is still *alive*. That has the potential to be disastrous. If Sergei was dead, there would be no fear of reprisals. The fact that he will still be alive presents the fear element. He'll still hold incredible influence over them, and that fear could make his people second-guess their decision for an overthrow."

"He could literally scare them back into submission," Autumn added.

"Yes." Nikolai nodded. "Having Lukyan kill him beforehand eliminated that threat. His people would have nothing to be scared of. They would accept the change in leadership without any issue."

Illayana blew out a frustrated breath. "Okay. I get it."

"I'm still being watched like a hawk," I said, scanning the grounds. Some of the other guards had noticed our security detail was out. It wouldn't be long before a new one was issued to us. Rurik could only hold it off for so long without arousing suspicion himself. I knew that. "I'll have to do it carefully and discreetly, but for now, that's the new plan. It goes without saying, though, that finding Lukyan is the *main priority*. This shit comes second. Reach out to all your contacts. See if anyone has heard anything about this situation. Ask them if there's been a woman hanging around they don't know. Fucking anything. I don't care. Find me some sort of information. I'll do what I can from here."

They all nodded.

"Go. Report back as soon as you have something."

Aleksandr clicked off first. Then Illayana. Before Nikolai could disappear, I said, "Nikolai, wait. I have a job for you."

He frowned. "Yes?"

“I’m going to send you a photograph of someone. I need you to dig up as much information as you can on him.”

“Who is he?”

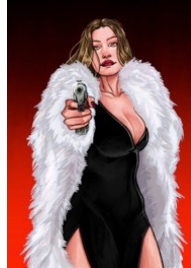
“His name is Vernon Miseris. I don’t know who he is. That’s why I want you to find out.” Over the past few days, I’d studied him with Sergei. Their relationship was strange. It was almost as if Vernon was watching him. All the time. As if he was keeping an eye on him for some reason. I wanted to know why. “Dig deep. Find out everything you can.”

Nikolai nodded. “Leave it with me.”

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER TWENTY

LYLA VOZNESENKY



“*H*ow was your day today, my love?” I asked, picking up my glass of wine.

Lukyan sat at the other end of the table, knife and fork in hand, eating his dinner. It had been a few days since the incident in town, and things between us had been slowly progressing.

I’ll admit, I wished they were moving a little faster than they were. The longer it took for our relationship to strengthen, the more time his family had to find him. Although I had covered my tracks exceptionally well, there was always a small, minute chance that they could find us before I had the chance to cement Lukyan’s love for me. But I didn’t want to rush him. He had to get there on his own. See for himself how perfect we were for each other.

He was dressed in one of the outfits I’d picked out and placed in his room for him. A white, long-sleeved button-down shirt and fitting dark pants. He was barefoot, with the first few buttons of his shirt undone to reveal the wide expanse of his chest. How one man could look so good in a plain white shirt was fucking beyond me.

His hair was up in a bun, a few loose strands cascading around his face. I liked that look on him. It was one of my favorites.

I placed my wine glass back down and picked up my fork. Lukyan still hadn’t answered my question, and I was trying not to push him. He was just staring at me, his eyes sweeping over my face, my body, searing my fucking insides.

“Penny for your thoughts?” I asked, instead of repeating my earlier question.

“You don’t want to know what I’m thinking,” he said roughly.

“Yes, I do! I always want to know what you’re thinking.” The smile on my face was wide and encouraging. I wanted him to feel safe to talk to me about whatever was on his mind. Whatever he was feeling. The good. The bad. And everything in between. A healthy relationship required safe and honest communication. At least, that was what my therapist was always blubbering on about.

“I’m thinking about how much I want to fuck you.”

Ohmygodohmygodohmygod.

Keep it together, Lyla. Keep. It. Together.

Although his words sent a massive fucking thrill through me—so much so I actually couldn’t believe I was still sitting in my chair and not riding his fucking lap—the tone he used indicated that he wasn’t overly happy about feeling the way he was.

“And that’s bad because...”

“Because you kidnapped me. I should want to *kill* you. Not fuck you.”

Should want to kill you.

That was what he said. *Want to kill you.* That meant he *didn’t* want to kill me.

That was a win in my book.

“You could pretend to kill me *and then* fuck me?” I offered.

He blinked, momentarily taken aback before raw, burning hot desire blazed in his eyes. “That, uh”—he cleared his throat, adjusting in his chair—“that sounds—”

“Hot? Exciting?”

“Intriguing.”

I’ll take that.

I took a few bites of pasta, trying to pick my next words very carefully. It had been a few days since the incident at the café, and it was the first time since then that the conversation had taken a sexual turn.

I wasn’t sure what was holding him back. I was primed and fucking ready, especially after the way he’d gotten on his knees for me. The image of Lukyan, kneeling, surrounded by dead bodies with my collar around his neck was one that appeared in my mind often. I wondered if it was the same

for him. If he was just struggling with his feelings toward me and fighting our connection.

I didn't want to rely on our sexual chemistry to win him over, but if I had to, I would. I would win him over with my body first, then my mind.

"Just out of curiosity, what *are* you into?"

Lukyan arched an eyebrow and leaned back into his chair, his thighs spreading wide. "You want to talk about my sexual habits over dinner?"

"Why not?" I shrugged. "Unless you have something else you'd like to talk about?"

"I wanna talk about when you're gonna let me the fuck out of here."

Tension shot through me, and I cracked my neck.

"Before you lose your shit, I need you to understand that I have family obligations. I have people who are counting on me. I can't just spend the rest of my life stuck in this house. In that town. Doing nothing all day."

I *tsked*, looking away from him. Okay. He kind of had a point. I couldn't expect him to spend his life like that. A soul like Lukyan's, a spirit like his, needed to be free and wild, not cooped up.

I knew that. Understood it. But I couldn't let him go. Not just yet. Not until he felt the way I did. As if he couldn't *breathe* when I wasn't near. Like his whole world would just crumble if I wasn't part of it.

I needed him as obsessed with me as I was with him. That was the only way any of this was going to work.

"Do you mean that business with your grandfather?"

"It's one of them, yes."

"You want to kill him."

"I *need* to kill him," he corrected, voice hard. "That bastard's death date is long overdue, and I'm going to be the one to give it to him."

Leaning forward, I placed my elbows on the table and clasped my hands together, excitement streaking across my face. "How?"

"How what?"

"How would you do it? Tell me. Describe it to me. In lengthy detail."

Startling blue eyes studied me curiously. "Why?"

"Because I'm fucked up, why else?" I shrugged, unashamed. "So? Come on. Tell me. What was your plan? Shoot him? Get it over with quick and easy? Or take your time? Do it nice and slow, and make him suffer for all the bullshit he's put you through?"

He looked down at his plate. It was almost empty, only a few pieces of steak and potatoes left. I studied him, the look on his face and his body language, trying to figure out for myself what he was thinking.

A shocking thought occurred to me. “You didn’t have a plan, did you?”

“It’s not that I *didn’t* have one,” he said immediately, his spine snapping straight. “I just work better when I wing it. That’s all. I planned to wait for the best opportunity. Most likely when I had him alone. Maybe in his office, late at night, after he’d had one too many drinks. I’d lull him into a false sense of security with idle chitchat, let him talk my ear off about how great and mighty he is, and then when he least expects it—” He swiped a finger across his throat, making a *kkkkkkkk* sound as he did so.

“Sounds like it could work.”

“It would have. I would have *made* it work.” He pushed his plate away, leveling his gaze on me. My skin heated. “I have a proposition for you.”

“I love propositions.” I sat forward eagerly. “What is it?”

“Me and you—”

“Love it already.”

“One on one—”

“You sure? I’m not opposed to a few extra people—”

“We fight it out—”

“Not where I thought this was going, but I’m into it.”

“If you win, I stay here with you—”

“Uh-huh.”

“And if *I* win, you let me go.”

“No,” I flat-out refused. “Nope. Sorry. No can do.”

The sexiest, devilish smirk graced his lips. “What’s the matter? Afraid you’ll lose?”

I narrowed my eyes. “I see what you’re doing.”

“What am I doing?” he asked innocently.

“You’re trying to appeal to that competitive side of me, and it isn’t going to work.”

“Isn’t it?” He winked.

Okay. It kind of was. That gorgeous, long-haired son of a bitch.

“I *know* I can beat you. I don’t need to prove it.”

“But wouldn’t it be so much fun if you did?” He breathed.

I internally groaned. *Yes. It would be.* It would be so much fucking fun, which was exactly why I couldn’t do it—

“Think about it,” he whispered huskily, his deep, seductive voice making shivers dance all over my body. “Me and you, rolling around, getting all hot and heavy. Touching. Our bodies, close, rubbing up against each other—”

“Okay.” I didn’t need any more convincing. I stood up. “Wanna go right now?”

Lukyan laughed, and it made my heart all warm and fuzzy that he found me funny. Triumph shone in his eyes. He thought he’d won, but the truth of it was, *I* had. I was looking for excuses to touch him. For a way to seduce him with my body without downright throwing myself at him.

He’d just provided me with the exact opportunity I’d been waiting for.

I wasn’t worried that I’d lose. I’d win, and in the process, I’d win his fucking heart.

* * *

I BOUNCED on the tips of my toes, excited energy pumping through my veins. Across from me, Lukyan stood on the blue mat, stretching out his long, toned body. We’d both gotten changed, me in workout gear, tight, black short-shorts, and a sports bra, Lukyan in gray sweats and a loose shirt.

We were in the gym, a small room I’d dedicated to working out. It didn’t have a lot in it. I was limited with the amount of space I had available. There was some gym equipment and a large, blue padded mat in the center of the room for sparring. I knew Lukyan liked to work out. He liked to keep himself busy, so I knew the minute I’d planned to take him that I had to have some sort of area made for him to work out his frustrations.

Cedric was standing stoically in the doorway, and I turned to face him. “You can go, Cedric.”

He eyed Lukyan suspiciously. “I think I should stay.” He was worried for me. Worried Lukyan would take the opportunity to hurt me and escape.

I wasn’t.

He wouldn’t be able to deny our sexual chemistry any more than I would. I was sure of it. There was a very good possibility that it could turn into some hot, crazy sex, and I didn’t want Cedric standing angrily in the corner to ruin that.

Fighting and sex ran hand in hand for me. For Lukyan, too, I'd bet. It was inevitable.

"I'll be fine. Go, relax. If I need you, I'll call for you."

Grumbling, he turned and walked away, making sure to leave the door open just in case.

I faced Lukyan again. He was already watching me, something dark and feral flashing in his eyes. He smirked, reached back, grabbed a fistful of his shirt, and pulled it over his head.

My mouth salivated. His chest and abs in all their wonderful glory were on complete display for me to ogle. Hard. Toned. The kind of body you only got from rigorous training.

I put my hands on my hips. "Okay, you don't play fair."

He laughed outright and threw his shirt to the side. "What? Does this"—he ran his big hands down the front of his body in a seductive caress—"distract you?"

"Yes," I admitted freely. "But I'm not concerned."

"You're not?"

"Nope." I cracked my neck, continuing to bounce on the tips of my toes. "It makes me horny, and now I'm dying to get started so I can touch you."

He laughed again, shaking his head. "You're not afraid to say whatever it is you're thinking, are you?"

"Who has time to worry about shit like that?" I put my hands up in a boxer's pose and moved my fingers back and forth. "Let's get it on, baby."

He rubbed his hands together eagerly like a man with a plan. There was a look on his face that sent a thrill of excitement shooting through me. He took a step to the right. I took one to the left. He stepped again, and I did the same. We continued until we were circling each other, the suspense building.

I watched him closely, studying his movements, his footsteps, the looseness of his body. He wouldn't catch me off guard.

"Are there rules?" he asked, continuing to take one step at a time.

"You need a safe word?"

"My safeword is *Banana Hammock*. Answer my question. What am I allowed to do?"

I smirked. "You can do whatever you want, baby—"

He lunged. I darted right. He rolled into a perfect somersault and sprang back up to his feet in the same movement, turned, and started circling me

again.

“Gonna have to be faster than that to catch me,” I taunted.

“Oh, don’t worry. I’m going to catch you.”

“And what will you do to me if you do?”

“Stay still and find out.”

I halted. He took the opportunity, pouncing for me again. He tackled me to the ground, his arm around the back of my head, cushioning my fall. Before he could do anything else, I reared forward and placed my lips on his in a fast kiss.

He stiffened, surprised, eyes widening in shock.

I pulled back and headbutted him.

“Fuck!” His head flew back, and I wedged my legs in between our bodies and shoved him off me. I spun my legs through the air in a circular motion and flung myself back upright, landing in a crouch.

Lukyan was in front of me, in the same crouched position, fire blazing in his eyes.

“Did that distract you?” I sang in a mocking voice.

He chuckled. “You’re a devious one. That won’t work again.”

We’ll see.

We lunged for each other at the same time. Lukyan unleashed a powerful roundhouse kick. I ducked underneath it, darted forward, and punched him in the stomach. He grunted, but didn’t double over as I had anticipated he would. Lukyan grabbed the back of my head and tried to slam me face down into the ground. I threw all of my weight forward instead so I flipped over. His hold immediately vanished, and I landed roughly on my back. I kicked up high, hitting him in the side of the face.

A Russian curse flew from his mouth, and he stumbled back. I rolled backward and landed in a hunch. There was no reprieve. Lukyan came right back at me, and we locked into an elegant dance of punches and strikes. Some I avoided. Some I didn’t. The same went for him.

Adrenaline surged through my body. Neither one of us was holding back, and I fucking loved it. I feared Lukyan would go easy on me because I was a woman, but he was treating me as his equal, giving me his all, and I fucking loved it. The harder... the dirtier, the fucking better.

“You’re very good,” he commented between strikes. “Fast. Efficient. Who trained you?”

“I trained myself.” I blocked a punch, my forearm coming up to protect my face, and retaliated with a swift elbow to his jaw. “Does that impress you?” I asked as he stumbled back.

Lukyan massaged his jaw, his mouth opening slightly as he worked it. “A little. You’re an impressive person.”

I melted under his praise.

He came at me again, and we locked into another battle of rapid attacks and furious blocking. The longer we went on, the more excited I became. He was right. The touching, the closeness of our bodies, the contact...It was everything I wanted and more.

I wondered if he felt the same way.

Surely, he had to. Surely, he could feel the connection we shared. The way our bodies yearned for each other. The way our souls called out to one another. He had to sense it too. It was undeniable.

He flung me over his shoulder and slammed me into the ground. I grunted at the contact, pain flaring up my back. His hand went right to my throat and squeezed. I fought against him. He wedged himself between my legs, and I felt it—his cock, hard and fucking primed, right against my center.

I grabbed a fistful of his hair and yanked back at the same time as I arched my hips into him. His snarl turned into an angry groan. He thrust forward, and a bite of pleasure shot through me.

I hooked my legs around his powerful waist, arching furiously into him, chasing more of that pleasure. “You can feel it, can’t you? How good this feels. How *right* this feels,” I rasped, his hand around my throat making it hard to speak above a whisper.

“You’re fucking crazy,” he bit out, his voice laced with pleasure despite his words. “I could kill you right now. Snap your fucking neck.”

“I know,” I moaned. “Isn’t it hot?”

He mumbled something incoherently. Something I couldn’t quite catch. But the way Lukyan’s eyes rolled into the back of his head, that look of complete and utter hunger on his face. He was enjoying himself just as much as I was.

“Maybe you need to see for yourself.” I used my free hand to knock his arm away, and used all of my strength to roll us so I was now on top.

I wasn’t sure if Lukyan had let me do it. He could have, but I was too into the moment to think more on it.

Legs either side of his body, I wrapped my hands around his neck and squeezed. Not so hard that I completely cut off his circulation, but hard enough for him to feel that sweet rush of lightheadedness.

He groaned.

“Feels good, doesn’t it, baby?” I whispered, leaning down to run my tongue up the side of his face. “Don’t deny it. Be honest. It’s just me and you here. Let yourself go.”

“Yes,” he breathed, his body *trembling*. “It feels good. It feels so fucking good.”

The smirk on my face was full of triumph. “Such a good boy you are, baby.” I let him go, and Lukyan’s head rolled as if his mind was swimming with euphoria. I slapped my hands down onto his chest hard and scratched my nails down his torso. He arched upward, pushing himself further into me, searching for more.

I couldn’t hold back anymore.

I needed him. *Now*.

With rushed movements, I ripped my sports bra off my body. My breasts bounced free.

“*Oh, fuck me,*” Lukyan groaned, desperation on his face. He reached up to touch me.

“Uh-uh.” I grabbed his hands and wrapped my sports bra around his wrists, tying him up before I slammed them back down above his head.

His eyes widened.

“You only get to touch when I give you permission. Did I give you permission?” I asked, layering a small amount of dominance into my voice.

He swallowed, then shook his head.

I gave him a soft smile. “I want to hear you speak. Did I give you permission?”

“No,” he answered swiftly.

“No, what?”

“No...ma’am?” he asked tentatively.

“I’m not a ma’am.”

“Mistress?”

“Try again.”

I wanted him to pick something he wanted. Something he was comfortable with. Something that wasn’t a question. That he was sure of.

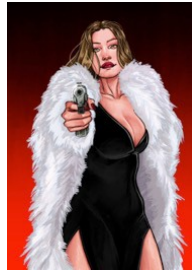
His eyes took on a reverent glow. “Huntress,” he whispered in worship. He looked up at me through his lashes, an almost shy tint to his words despite the blazing hunger on his face.

That was it. His compliance sent me soaring. I placed a soft kiss on his lips. My heart was elated at the name he’d chosen for me, and I was going to reward him for it.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER TWENTY ONE

LYLA VOZNESENKY



I sat on Lukyan's torso, my legs either side of his body, just staring at the marvel that man was. His arms were outstretched above his head, his muscles bunching and bulging, hands tied at the wrists by my clothing.

Even *I* had to admit it was a flimsy job, but I had to work with what I had. I didn't want to risk leaving to get my chains and the moment we were in being completely lost. There was too much at stake.

After all my planning, all the fantasies, all the times I'd made myself come to the thought of him, I finally had Lukyan right where I wanted him.

And I was going to take my fucking time and enjoy it.

I ran the tips of my fingers down his arms. Slowly. Sensually. His whole body shivered, goose bumps pebbling his skin.

"Do you have any idea how many times I've pictured you exactly like this? Needy and desperate beneath me?" And desperate he was. I didn't have to be a mind reader to know it. It was in the way his hands clenched into tight, unbreakable fists, as if he was having to do it to hold himself back. It was in his face, that look of utter reverence, like he would do anything I asked if I kept touching him.

"Jesus fucking christ, what the fuck is happening?" he panted, squirming as I moved my hands lower and lower.

I smirked. "You're enjoying yourself. There's nothing wrong with that. But, if you want to stop, you need only say it, and I'll stop."

"Fuck no!" he burst out, looking down at me. "Please don't stop, Huntress. Please. I'll be a good boy. I'll do whatever the fuck you want."

Just please, don't stop touching me."

My lips curved into a genuine, loving smile. I brushed my fingertips across his face in a tender touch. "I love it when you beg." I unwound the hair tie from his hair, and let the dark locks fall around him. "Fucking beautiful."

I couldn't hold myself back anymore. I needed to taste him.

Placing my hands on his powerful forearms to keep him still and right where I wanted him, I leaned down and kissed the side of his neck. I moved my lips, my tongue over his skin, working my way across his throat. Down his chest.

He panted beneath me, his body tensing and untensing. "*Fuck, fuck, fuck,*" he chanted. The way he squirmed, like it was taking everything he had not to move, made my pussy throb. The fact that Lukyan wasn't even tied down, that he could move if he wanted to and was just actively choosing not to, to *please me*, was fucking euphoria.

There was just something about having a big, strong, powerful man at my fingertips, completely at my mercy, that just did something to me. That I could make a man like him quiver at my touch, desperate to follow my orders, to please me...Fuck, it sent me on cloud fucking nine.

I circled my tongue around Lukyan's nipple, my hands wandering further down his body to grasp his cock.

He choked, his hips bucking forward. The way he responded to my touch, dear god, it made every part of me yearn for him even more.

I moved myself further down until I was level with his cock, and then I pulled his sweats down. His cock sprang out, hard and thick and twitching.

"Oh, look at you," I marveled in a whisper. "So fucking big and glorious." I used both hands to grasp his dick and tugged up hard. His body shot up. I placed a hand on his chest and pushed him back down. "Don't move," I ordered.

"I won't, I won't. I'm sorry. I just can't—fucking hell." His voice was filled with desperation, and I fucking loved it.

"Look at me."

He moved his head down, and his fiery gaze locked onto mine.

"Don't take your eyes off me. Watch what I'm about to do to you."

I stuck my tongue out. His chest rose and fell quickly with anticipation. I leaned forward and ran the flat of my tongue up his length in a soft, slow, languid lick.

The moan that fell from his lips sent a bite of pleasure through my body. I didn't think such a thing was possible—that I could feel that kind of pleasure without prompting. But that was how good he sounded.

I wanted to hear it again. I needed to hear more.

I wrapped my lips around the head of his cock and shoved it down until the tip touched the back of my throat, then I swallowed.

“Lyla!” he half-choked, his body trembling beneath me.

I felt dizzy. Dizzy on his pleasure and the control I had over him. I continued to work his cock, alternating between deepthroating him and running my tongue up and down his length. The entire time, he watched me, his heated gaze burning my fucking insides, the sexiest fucking grunts and moans falling from his lips.

My body begged for his touch. Begged for some kind of relief—*anything*. I wanted to jump right on his cock and ride him until we both were screaming out our pleasure.

But, as much as I wanted to do that, I couldn't. I'd stupidly forgotten to bring a condom into the gym, and although I was dying to finally feel his cock deep inside me, babies were not something I was interested in right now.

I had to be the responsible one.

“Lyla, Lyla, I'm going to come,” he whimpered. “Please don't stop. Please don't stop.” He chanted it over and over again, *begging* me to keep going. I would have anyway, but hearing him beg like that for me? I was absolutely powerless.

In that moment, *he* fucking owned *me*.

His entire body locked up, and he *groaned*, a purely masculine sound filled with complete and utter satisfaction. Bliss. Euphoria.

Even though I wasn't a big fan of it, I swallowed down his release, continuing to suck as more and more of it hit the back of my throat.

“Dear fucking God,” he choked out on a strained whisper. When his body stopped spasming, I rose up, swiping a thumb across my bottom lip, unable to keep the smirk off my face. His eyes flashed with something feral. Something deep and dark and full of desire.

“Can I touch you?” he asked. Pleaded. Begged.

Smirk still in place, I shook my head. “No.”

Disappointment streaked across his features. It shifted when I got to my feet and took off my gym shorts, followed quickly by my underwear,

kicking them away.

“*Fuck me,*” he breathed in reverence, his heated gaze locked firmly on my pussy.

“I’m going to use you now,” I rasped, moving up and dropping to my knees so his head was right between my thighs. He cursed, sucking in a harsh breath. “And you’re going to be the good boy you are and let me, aren’t you?”

“Hell fucking yeah,” he grunted out roughly. He reared forward, but I grasped his hair in the nick of time, keeping him just out of reach of my pussy. He whined as if he was so overcome with want and hunger that it caused him physical pain not to be able to taste me right there.

I didn’t let up. Didn’t let him touch me no matter how much I wanted it. How much my body was begging for it.

“Stick out your tongue,” I ordered.

He complied instantly, and his willingness to follow my commands sent another thrilling electric shock through me.

I kept his head still, right where I wanted it, and maneuvered myself until my pussy hovered over his mouth. I waited, letting the tension and suspense build and build. The waiting, the edging, was half the fucking fun.

“Please,” he begged. “Let me taste you. I feel like I will die if I don’t taste you.”

“Aw baby, I love when you beg. And you do it so well. Go ahead. *Taste me.*”

He dove forward, sealing his lips around me. The instant contact made me throw my head back, shouting out a cry of ecstasy. He groaned into me, like a man who loved what he was doing, the deep vibrations heightening my pleasure.

I moved my hips in time with the strokes of his tongue. “Yeah. That’s it. Just like that. Oh, you’re so fucking good with your tongue.”

Lukyan needed no pointers. No prompting. No direction. It was like he knew exactly what I liked. Could read my body, my wants and needs straight away.

He was almost *too* good, and I would have never thought such a thing could be possible. But fuck, it was, because I didn’t want it to end yet, and I knew I was already so close to coming.

“*Fuck, baby,*” I moaned, moving my hips faster. With jerky, hurried movements, I undid the flimsy attempt at restraining his hands, freeing him.

He took that as the cue it was, tucking his arms under my legs to palm my ass.

His grip was hard. Rough. Tight. Again, exactly what I wanted. What I needed. Lukyan didn't just place his hands on me—he helped move me, as if he wanted more. Wanted me to go faster against him. Harder.

“Please, choke me with your pussy, Huntress,” he groaned, kissing, licking, sucking. “I’ll be such a good boy for you, just please. Give me more. *Use me.*”

He was already so good at being submissive. “Because you asked so nicely,” I panted, and dropped all my weight on him, smothering him. I kept his head still with a tight grip of his hair and rode his face with quick, hurried movements, swirling my hips. He moaned, long and low, the sound spiraling my orgasm right to the surface.

Pleasure rushed up my spine. “Oh, oh. Yes. *Lukyan!*” My thighs clenched around his head as the most intense, white-hot pleasure exploded in my core. Lukyan didn't stop. He ate my pussy like a man starved, frenzied and full of desperation. The soft flutters of his tongue along my clit didn't ease. He continued to urge me forward, to continue riding his face even after my release had come and gone.

“It's time to stop now, baby,” I gasped, attempting to pull back.

He latched onto me tightly, wrapping his arms around my waist in an unmoving grip. “Mmm. No. Not yet,” he mumbled, his mouth moving and moving. “I'm not done.”

Despite the new burst of pleasure making its way through my body, I squeezed my hand into a tighter fist and yanked his head back at the same time I raised up onto my knees, taking myself away from his mouth.

“Now, now, baby. You've been so good,” I whispered. I ran my tongue along his lips, tasting myself, and it made me moan. “You're not ready to find out what happens when you disobey me. Not yet.”

A little bit of clarity made its way back into his gaze. He flopped back down onto the ground and released a big, shuddering breath. “Okay. What kind of drug do you have in that tight pussy of yours? Because fuck, it's addicting.”

I shook my head and rose to my feet. “Come on.” I stepped away and stuck out both hands. Lukyan sighed, a slight roll of his eyes making me purse my lips before he placed his hands in mine, and together, we pulled him to a stand.

His cock was standing at attention again, big and proud. He didn't try to cover himself, instead choosing to stretch his arms over his head.

I arched a brow. "Ready again so soon?"

His smirk was downright devilish. "I was ready the second I tasted you. I'd say let's fuck now, but I have the sneaking suspicion you have other plans."

"I do!" I squealed, bouncing up and down on the spot, beyond ecstatic he'd been able to read me so well. "There's one thing I *love* to do after I've come."

"And what's that?" he asked, humor dancing across his face.

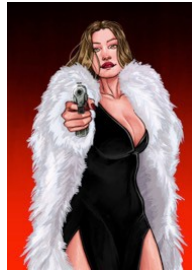
"Eat."

His hands slapped across his chest, and he swayed lightly on his feet. "A woman after my own heart."

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER TWENTY TWO

LYLA VOZNESENKY



“What’s the craziest thing you’ve ever done?”

“The *craziest thing*?” Lukyan leaned back against the couch, hiking his leg up and draping his arm over his knee. The white, fluffy robe on his body made him look both cute and cuddly and hot as fuck at the same time. A matching robe was wrapped around my body. “We might be here for a while.”

“It’s a good thing we’ve got snacks.” Laid out before us in individual bowls was an arrangement of sweets. Candy, chocolate, sodas, whipped cream, you name it. Everything one could possibly need to rot their teeth.

After our mind-blowing oral sexathon, we’d both retired to our rooms to shower. Ideally, I would have loved it if we showered *together*, but I didn’t trust myself. I wanted him so bad. So bad it fucking hurt. And while I hadn’t envisioned *me* being the one to hold out on sex, I had to do it right.

A man like Lukyan got bored easily. He’d even said it to me himself. I couldn’t risk losing his attention. I had to keep him interested, and giving up the golden ticket straight away probably wasn’t going to do that.

I was going to work and manipulate him until he was *begging* for me. Until he couldn’t bear it any longer. Then, and only then, would I give him what he’d been dying for all that time. For a lot longer than he even fucking realized.

“Yes, good thing.” He chuckled. Directly in front of him was a bowl of skittles. He reached forward, plucking a few, and then dropped them into his mouth. “So, one of the first things that comes to mind is something I did to my sister when she was seven.”

“What did you do?”

“She pissed me off, you see. The little rodent stole my slice of cake, and then had the audacity to lie to my face and say it wasn’t her. She had chocolate smeared across her mouth. Of course it was her. So I zipped her up into a suitcase and dumped her outside.”

My mouth dropped open in shock. “You *what*?”

“It wasn’t a big deal.” He shrugged, completely unperturbed about the fact that he’d locked his baby sister in a fucking suitcase. “I made sure it wasn’t done up all the way so she could still breathe, and told one of my father’s soldiers she was in there. I’m not a monster. No harm no foul. She was *super* pissed about it, though.”

“I don’t fucking blame her.” I laughed. “I’d disembowel Lev if he ever pulled a stunt like that on me.”

“Not a fan of tight spaces?”

I shivered despite the fact that it wasn’t even cold and we were sitting in front of the roaring fireplace. “No. Not a fan.” Years’ worth of horrible memories ran through my mind, but I banished them instantly, refusing to allow myself to think of them. “Was that a one-off kind of thing?” I asked.

That twinkle of curiosity in Lukyan’s eyes told me he saw that question for what it was—a deflection. He chose not to push. I had a feeling we’d probably circle back to it again at some point, though.

“We did shit like that all the time growing up.” A smile curved on his lips. It was a happy smile. Reminiscent. Full of memories. He moved a bit closer to me. Not much. Just a smidgen. But I noticed, even if he didn’t. “This one time, when we were kids—I was about eleven, Illayana nine—she got angry at me because I chopped all the hair off her barbie dolls so they were bald. To get back at me, she took my favorite stuffed animal, this awesome red-and-black bull with huge silver horns, and set him on fire! Not only that, but she tied me to a chair and made me *watch*, the little psycho.”

Laughter bubbled up inside my throat. “Why did you cut all the hair off her dolls?”

“Because she threw a toy shield at my head.”

Oh, of course. “Why did she throw a shield at your head?”

“Because I chased her with a spider, and she hates spiders.”

“Why did you chase her with a spider?”

“It was payback from the time she tried to drown me in the pool.”

“Why did she try to drown you in the pool?”

Lukyan smirked. “Because I tried to drown her first.”

“Jesus Christ.” I laughed, shaking my head in utter disbelief. “I’m scared to ask why you tried to drown her first. I feel like we’ll be stuck in a never-ending loop.”

“We kind of are.” He chuckled. “We’ve been getting each other back for shit we did to each other for years. FYI, it’s my turn, and I’m planning something diabolical.”

“I’m sure you are. How did your parents deal with you guys if you were always trying to kill each other?”

He sat forward, all energetic and bubbly. “My father came up with this foolproof idea. I’m going to assume you saw the boxing ring in our warehouse during all those times you were sleuthing around my house?”

“I wasn’t sleuthing. I was observing.”

“You were stalking.”

“God forbid a woman has a hobby.”

He laughed, blue eyes twinkling. “When we were kids, every time we’d get the shits with each other, he’d slap a pair of boxing gloves on us, push us into the ring and tell us to just fight it out. There were rules, of course.”

“Oh, of course,” I agreed, nodding my head with an amused smile on my face. “I can’t wait to hear them.”

“We couldn’t hit the face, or, you know, delicate areas.” The pump of his eyebrows going up and down made it pretty obvious what those delicate areas were. “We had to stay in there until we’d punched and kicked out all our frustrations. Then, once we were done, everything was right as rain. As we got older, the rules changed. As long as we didn’t seriously maim each other, everything was cheerio.”

“And I thought *my* family was dysfunctional,” I said laughingly.

His smile was bright, and full of love and light. “We’re just one big, happy, dysfunctional family, and I honestly wouldn’t have it any other way. Wouldn’t want it any other way.”

Over the course of time I’d spent stalking him, observing him and his family, I saw a lot of things. I had to admit, I was a little envious of the family bond they shared. It was so different from how I grew up.

Yeah, they pissed each other off a lot.

Sometimes, it seemed like it was on purpose.

But they loved each other. Would die for each other.

I knew Lev loved me, but would he *die* for me? I highly doubted it.

Lukyan picked at some more snacks, a faraway look in his eyes. The smile was still there, but there was also a hint of sadness that absolutely broke my heart. I hated seeing him sad.

“You miss them.”

He inclined his head. “Of course I do. They drive me fucking batshit crazy half the time, but I love them. It’s always been us against the world.” He stared deeply into the fire, almost as if he was losing himself to the flames. “I want to ask you for something.”

I had a feeling I wasn’t going to like whatever it was. “Yes?”

Pleading eyes locked onto me. “Let me call my sister.”

My mouth opened, a flat-out refusal on the tip of my tongue.

“*Please, Lyla.*”

God-fucking-damnit. He just *had* to use the one word that made me completely fucking powerless against him.

Soft fingers intertwined with mine. I stiffened, looking down at our joined hands. He *touched* me. Lukyan touched me *willingly*.

Relax. Breathe. Get a fucking grip.

“Why do you need to call her?”

“I need to hear for myself that she’s okay.”

A frown creased my forehead. “I told you that she’s fine.”

“Yes, you did,” he said cautiously, his thumb drawing small circles into my skin, making me shiver. “But I need to hear it for *myself*.”

“Why? Don’t you trust me?”

He blew out a huff of annoyance. “Don’t go getting all offended.”

“Oh, but I am.” It hurt, but I snatched my hand out of his grasp. “I gave you my word that everything is okay. That your family is fine.”

“I believe you.” For some reason, I didn’t think he did. At least, not entirely. “But if you want to build any kind of relationship, I need to know my family is safe and okay before I can do that. That there’s been no repercussions for what happened. *You* need to give me that.”

I grumbled under my breath, sitting back and crossing my arms over my chest. Yes. I was pouting. So fucking what? Despite how much I didn’t want to, I could see his fucking point.

And it was irritating as hell.

“Fine.” I sighed, getting to my feet.

We were in the main lounge area. It was a wide-open space, filled with beautiful mahogany furniture I'd selected myself. There was dim lightning, the illumination from the fire casting a soft yellow-orange glow throughout the dark room.

Beside the L-shaped couch was a side table. I opened the drawer, and dozens of burner phones greeted me. I pulled one out. Lukyan's eyes lit up when I made my way back to him, device in hand.

"You get five minutes," I said, putting in the four-digit code to unlock it before handing it over. "And I want it on speaker."

I wasn't concerned about any information he could possibly divulge. Even if he wanted to, he couldn't say anything compromising because he didn't *know* anything. I'd been careful not to reveal anything that could give away our location.

But I'd be an idiot to let them talk alone.

Lukyan looked the phone over. "Illayana won't answer this one. She doesn't accept calls from unknown numbers." *Huh*. Neither did I. "I need my phone."

I winced. "Yeah, that's not gonna happen. Sorry, baby, but I tossed that sucker the first chance I got. Everyone's heard of the Bratva's affinity for trackers. Couldn't risk them using that to find you."

His breath caught on a sigh. "Can't really blame you on that one. I'd do the same in your position."

"Soulmates think alike." I winked.

He shook his head, rolling his eyes.

"Try calling her."

He did, and like he'd predicted, she didn't answer.

"I told you," he said, taking the phone away from his ear.

"Try again."

"There's no point."

"Yes there is. I don't answer unknown numbers either. Nine times out of ten, they're fucking telemarketers or scammers. But if the same number calls me repeatedly, one after the other after the other, I'm more inclined to answer it because it might be someone I know calling me from a different phone. You're missing. I bet it will take her about the third or fourth call for her to answer. The hope that it might be you will be too great for her not to."

His lips pursed in thought. “Okay, I can’t deny that makes a little sense.” He tried her number again and again.

“Do you know all your siblings’ numbers off by heart?” I asked as he tried for the third time.

“Yeah. That way, if my phone is ever stolen by, oh, I don’t know, a crazy woman who kidnapped me, I can call them for help without needing to look up their number,” he said, a teasing quirk at the corner of his mouth.

“Hardy, har, har.”

He threw me a wink before blowing me a kiss. I caught it and shoved it into my mouth like I was trying to eat it.

Ring-ring, ring-ring, ring-ring—

“Lukyan, this better be you,” a light, feminine voice answered through the phone.

An affectionate smile flashed across Lukyan’s face. “It’s me, *sestra*.”
Sister.

“Holy fuck,” she breathed out in shock. “I didn’t think it would actually be you! Where are you? Are you okay? Tell me where you are, and I’ll get someone to come get you.”

His eyes flicked to me for a brief moment. “I’m okay,” he said, not answering the other questions. “I just called to make sure *you* are okay. You’re not hurt, are you? Grandfather hasn’t done anything?”

“What? No, I’m fine. Lukyan, *where are you?*”

“I don’t know.”

Rustling came through the other end, followed quickly by a door slamming. “Well, look for a street sign or something. I’m getting Nikolai now. We’ll start tracing the call.”

“This line is untraceable,” I said.

There was a beat of silence. “Lukyan?” Illayana sang, her voice pitching higher with a hint of what-the-fuckery.

“Yes?” he answered.

“What the fuck is going on?!” she blasted.

I’m a goddamn mind reader.

Lukyan looked at me for what I assumed was confirmation. I just shrugged, nodding my head. He could tell her whatever he wanted. It wouldn’t change a thing. They wouldn’t be able to find him.

“Lyla graciously let me use her phone to call you and make sure you were okay.”

“Graciously? *Graciously?!?*” Illayana shouted. “You mean your crazy, kidnapping stalker was nice enough to let you use the phone. How fucking nice of her.”

“It *was* nice of me, actually, thank you so much for noticing,” I responded.

“I was being sarcastic,” she spat.

“I wasn’t.”

“What do you want in exchange for my brother?”

I felt like shaking my head. “Nothing. There is nothing you could offer me for him because *he* is all I want. In this life, the next, and any after that. He’s *mine*, and I’m never fucking giving him back.”

Lukyan’s eyes flashed with something predatory.

“You—”

“Your brother wanted to talk to you,” I cut in, interrupting her. “I gave him five minutes, and you’re wasting them talking to me.”

Another beat of silence.

“Lukyan?” Illayana’s voice had taken a softer tone, drenched in vulnerability.

“I’m here.”

“You’re okay?” she asked again.

“Yes. I’m not hurt. I need to know...Has anything happened with Grandfather? Has he hurt you? Threatened you? Anything?”

“No. Nothing. Father said he’s fucking ecstatic. He got exactly what he wanted because the Tarasovs reneged on their contract when Anya didn’t show.”

“*I told you,*” I mouthed to Lukyan.

His hand waved through the air in an *I know, I know* kind of gesture. “What about Father? Is he still at Sergei’s estate? Is he still at risk?”

“He’s still there. The...plan is still in place. Father is going to do it.”

Illayana was talking in code, completely unaware that I knew exactly what she was referring to.

“He is?” Lukyan asked with a frown. My eyes narrowed in suspicion. There was something there. Some emotion he was masking, hiding from not only his sister, but me too.

I was going to find out what it was.

“Look, Lukyan. I don’t care if that bitch is listening.”

I chuckled, finding her attitude humorous.

“You kill her, you hear me? You kill her and come back home.”

Our eyes locked, and he held my gaze. I arched a brow in curiosity. *What are you going to say, baby? Are you going to say you’ll kill me?*

Could you?

I doubted it. He might not be consciously aware of our bond, but it was there. I felt it in my soul, and I knew that, one day, he would too.

“I’m glad you’re okay,” he said instead, and a small sense of triumph filled me. “Are the rest of the family?”

“Aleksandr is going crazy looking for you. Nikolai too. And don’t think I didn’t notice you completely ignored what I said. I know you heard me. Don’t fall for her bullshit. She’s fucking crazy.”

Her insults didn’t bother me, but I felt compelled to point something out. “You seem to be forgetting I saved your lives.”

“What the hell are you talking about?”

The frown on Lukyan’s face told me he was just as confused by that as his sister.

“Talon’s island. *I* was the one who found out its coordinates and sent them to your brother’s wife. Because of *me*, you are all alive right now. I think that’s earned me a little bit of respect, don’t you?”

“You kidnapped my brother!”

“Yes. And it’s my greatest achievement to date.” I winked at Lukyan. “Thirty seconds.”

“Illayana, listen to me,” he hurried out. “Don’t worry about me. I’m going to find a way to convince her to let me go.” *Fat chance of that happening.* “Focus on helping Father. He needs it more than I do. I’m just glad you’re all safe.”

“Lukyan, tell me something that will help us find you. What do you see? What landmarks are there? Have you seen any towns? Who is she? Give me something.”

His mouth compressed into a hard line. Again, he looked at me, and I did nothing but stare back. It would be up to him to reveal my identity. It wouldn’t help them locate us if he did. I’d purchased the house under an alias. In town, they only knew me as Lyla. They didn’t know my last name. There was nothing in my identity that could be traced back to us.

Lukyan chose to answer none of her questions. “I love you.”

“No, wait—”

Beep, beep, beep.

Silence drifted into the air. He stared at the phone in his hands, his thoughts raging behind those stunning, big blue eyes.

"I like her," I said, wanting desperately to break that silence between us.

"What?" He laughed. "She called you a crazy bitch."

Shrugging a shoulder, I took the phone from him and locked it, placing it down on the ground. "She's only telling the truth. I am a crazy bitch, and fucking proud of it. Do you feel better now?"

"Yes," he exhaled. "I do, actually."

I smiled. "Good. I'm glad."

"I'm curious about something," he said, grabbing the can of whipped cream. His head tilted back, and with a *woosh*, he sprayed it into his mouth. "How *did* you find the location of Talon's island?"

Ah.

A tiny bit of whipped cream escaped his mouth. Unable to help myself, I leaned forward and licked it from his lips with a flick of my tongue, then I moved right back. Or at least, I tried.

Lukyan's hand snapped out, and he gripped the back of my head, yanking me back toward him. His lips smashed onto mine in a brutal, punishing kiss. His tongue dove into my mouth, hot and possessing and utterly addictive.

I froze. *Our first official kiss.*

His taste exploded all over my senses, and I was powerless to fight it, clasp onto him tightly and kissing him back. Usually, I always took the lead, but that time, I didn't mind, too overcome with what was happening to even think about stopping it.

He kissed me.

With a sharp tug, he pulled me into his lap, my legs going either side of his body. His big, rough hands landed on my thighs, the contact searing, and I ground myself into him.

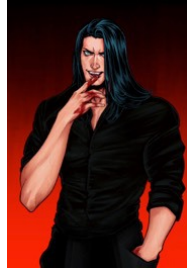
The kiss was fiery. Passionate.

Perfect.

Everything I knew it would be.

CHAPTER TWENTY THREE

LUKYAN VOLKOV



She tastes so fucking sweet.

Lyla moaned, a purely erotic sound that had lust shooting up my body. *Jesus, fuck.* I'd never been so turned on before. Never been so attracted to another before. It was fucking primal. Undeniable. My body yearned for hers, and I could no longer deny it.

I was really into the kiss. Like, really fucking into it. My cock was hard as hell, and she was grinding herself right down on it, so it only got harder. I was completely immersed in her. Her taste. The feel of her tongue. Her closeness.

So, it shocked the hell out of me when she suddenly gripped my chin and pulled back out of reach. I attempted to follow her, but her fingers tightened, keeping me rooted in place.

"Why?" I all but whined.

She laughed, this deep, sexy as fuck throaty sound that had my balls tingling. "Do you want me to answer your question or not?" she panted.

"Not right now!" When she'd licked my lips, I couldn't fucking take it anymore. I *had* to kiss her. The compulsion was too much. Too overwhelming. Too much to bother fighting any longer. Now that I didn't have to worry about my family, that they were all okay, I felt as though I could finally relax. Finally enjoy myself, even though I knew I probably shouldn't.

Oh fucking well. I liked doing shit I wasn't supposed to.

"Why not?" she smirked, all devious and shit.

"Because I want to fuck you," I admitted unashamedly.

Her smirk turned into a feral, predatory smile. She dropped her hold on my chin, and I leaned back, my eyes dropping to run the length of her tall, curvy body.

Teeth digging into my bottom lip, I asked her in a soft voice, “Are you going to tie me up again?”

Her brow arched high. “Do you want me to?”

Fuck yeah, I did. I wanted that and *more*. I was curious to explore the dynamic between us. In the past, I’d always been the dominant one. The one to take control. Handing over that control had never even occurred to me.

Until her.

Lyla rose, standing over me. “Stay,” she ordered.

My hands went up in a show of surrender, the smirk on my face mirroring hers. She disappeared into another room and returned a moment later, hands behind her back. Lyla was still in the white robe, but now there were a pair of sexy-as-fuck, black stiletto shoes with red bottoms on her feet.

My head tilted to the side. “What do you have there?”

She didn’t answer. “On your feet.”

Hell fucking yeah. I got up immediately. She did a little maneuvering, and then her hand appeared in front of her, empty. Lyla crooked a finger, urging me to come closer.

Curiosity streaked through me. I was powerless to do anything except whatever she wanted. Sexual tension skyrocketed between us, hot and utterly undeniable. When I stopped in front of her, she finally pulled out what it was behind her back.

Excitement surged in my body.

It was a collar and a leash.

Goddamn.

“On your knees before your Huntress, baby.”

I dropped, zero hesitation in my movements. Lyla’s face lit up in a pleased, warm smile, and I knew right in that moment I would do anything to please her. That I *wanted* to please her. Have her own me. Command me.

She leaned forward and gave me a soft, tender kiss on the lips. I downright *melted* at the feel of her lips on mine. “Safe word, baby?”

“Do I actually need one?” Earlier, I had joked about what my safeword was, but it was more of a flyaway comment, not something I was actually

being serious about.

“Yes. When exploring the things we’re about to explore, you always need a safe word. It helps to make you feel comfortable and reassures you that even though *I’m* controlling the scene, you are the one who holds all the power.”

My eyes lit up. “What kind of scene are we going to do?”

She shook her head, lips kicked up into an amused smile. “Nothing too crazy. I just wanna play with you for a bit.”

“Play with me?” I breathed out, my whole body shivering.

“Mm-hmm.” She trailed a finger across my jaw and down my chin. “Are you okay with that, baby?”

She didn’t even need to ask. “Fuck yeah, I am.”

“Good.” Her touch turned from soft and sweet to rough and hard, clasp my chin in a punishing grip. “Because I’m going to ring every ounce of pleasure I can out of your body. Now, pick a safe word.”

The one I said earlier seemed like the best option. “Banana Hammock.”

She nodded, standing tall once more. “You ever done anything like this before?”

“No.”

Her hand caressed down the side of my face, and I leaned into it, overcome with an emotion I couldn’t figure out. “Don’t worry, I’ll go easy on you. If there’s anything you don’t like or don’t want to do, just tell me.”

“I will.” I probably wouldn’t. I was keen for anything. *Anything*. The crazier and more fucked up, the better.

Her eyes narrowed. It was like she could sense my goddamn thoughts because she bent at the waist until she was level with my gaze. “I’m serious. Follow the rules, or we don’t play.”

“Okay, okay. I’ll tell you,” I promised.

Satisfied, Lyla nodded. She straightened her spine and held the collar up between us so I could clearly see it. “This one is a little different from the other one you wore.”

“You mean it isn’t filled with powerful sedatives?” I smirked, allowing a hint of mischievousness to streak across my face. “What a shame.”

Lyla chuckled. “This one’s got something better.” She twisted it to show me the back. Stitched into the black leather was the word *OWNED*. “Do you want to be owned, baby?”

My stomach did a dive, excitement barreling through me. “Yes.”

“Head up.”

What the fuck is this feeling I get every time she orders me around?

I tilted my head toward the ceiling. She fastened it around my throat, and I had to suppress a groan at how good the weight felt around my neck.

Her honey-colored eyes lit up with appreciation. She took a moment, just standing there, admiring me.

“God, I can barely contain myself around you,” Lyla breathed out, her fingers dancing along my skin. “Take the robe off.”

I did as she ordered, the fabric slipping from my body to pool on the floor around me. There was a metal ring on the front of the collar. She clicked the snap hook of the leash onto it, wrapped it around her fist, and tugged slightly. *Blyad, fuck.* My head swam, every ounce of me begging for her touch. It was hard to keep my hands off Lyla.

“Stand,” she commanded huskily.

My legs shook as I got to my feet.

“Come.” Spine straight, head held high, she turned and marched out of the room, me following behind her like a good little dog.

I wanted to be good for her. I wanted to please her. Because pleasing *her* pleased *me*.

Her heels *click-clacked* along the hardwood floor as she walked, echoing throughout the quiet home. My eyes were glued to her ass the entire time, so many dirty and kinky thoughts running through my mind.

What does she have planned?

What is she going to do to me?

*What do I **want** her to do to me?*

She led me up the stairs and straight to one of the rooms on the left side of the house. I’d done a thorough walkthrough my first few days there. I knew what was in every single room of the house except *that* one—it was the only room that was locked.

The jingle of a set of keys hit the air. Anticipation bubbled up inside me. It must have been something good if she kept it locked. I secretly hoped it was some kind of dirty sex room. Or maybe it was a weapons room, filled with all different kinds of knives and guns. I wasn’t opposed to a little bit of knife play.

“Is this your sex dungeon?” I asked, only mildly joking.

Lyla looked over her shoulder as she placed a black key into the keyhole. “Would it freak you out if I said yes?”

“No. It would excite me.”

“Then it’s my sex dungeon.” She unlocked the door and opened it, pulling me inside. Darkness enveloped me, and I froze, waiting for the lights to come on.

They didn’t.

“Lyla?”

“Huntress,” she whispered suddenly from behind me, right in my ear.

Goose bumps shivered over my skin. “Huntress,” I amended.

“Good.” A soft, featherlight touch danced down my back, stopping just before my ass. “You ever been taken here?”

I shook my head. The collar pulled taut, and my head snapped back. I groaned at the suddenness of it. The harshness of it. I wanted more.

“I told you before, I want to hear you speak when I ask a question. Have you ever had your ass fucked?”

“No,” I panted.

“Is it a red line?”

“Red line?” I questioned, unsure what she was asking.

“Something that is off-limits to you?”

“Fuck no. You want to fuck me in the ass, I’m all for it.”

She laughed. Deep and throaty and utterly tantalizing. “We’ll have to work our way up to that. You won’t be ready to take some of my bigger toys.”

A thought barreled its way into my head. It was born of pure jealousy. “Have you fucked other guys in the ass?”

“Baby,” she cooed, voice soft. “Are you jealous?”

“That depends. Have you?”

“I have.”

I knew it was irrational. What we did with other partners before we met had nothing to do with us. But I couldn’t help it. *I* wanted to be her fucking first. I did nothing but grunt in response.

“Don’t be jealous, baby. You know you’re my one and only.”

“I better fucking be,” I grumbled back.

Soft lips kissed my shoulder blade. “You are. Now, relax.”

Light flooded the room. I blinked, waiting for my eyes to adjust. The room slipped into focus. Black walls. A king-size bed with red silk sheets. Neon light strips bordering the ceiling. Black, faux leather velvet trunks filled with all different kinds of sex toys. Paddles. Chains. Whips. A

bondage restraint table. Long, black leather couch with what looked like metal cuffs strapped to the top of it.

My excitement fucking *soared*.

“Are those mirrors on the ceiling?” I asked in awe, looking up.

“Yes. So you can watch.”

“Watch what?”

She let go of the leash. “Sit on the couch and you’ll find out.”

Don’t have to ask me fucking twice.

My eyes ran over everything as I made my way over to it. *Fuck*. I wanted to try it all. Anything and everything.

I plopped my ass down on the couch, trying to contain myself. My cock was rock-hard at all the possibilities that room held. Lyla stood in front of me, completely fucking naked except for the black heels on her feet.

“You. Are. Fucking. Stunning,” I breathed out.

Smirk in place, she picked up her hair, twisting it into a bun at the nape of her neck before shoving a long, red pin through it to keep it secure. “You’re so sweet to me, baby.”

“The things I want to do to you are very *unsweet*.” They were downright fucking *filthy*.

The smirk didn’t waver. “All in good time. Now, place your hands in the cuffs on top of the couch.”

I did as she commanded without hesitation. There were also cuffs at the bottom of the couch—I found that out when she shackled me into them, snapping them closed around my ankles. Lyla moved behind the couch next, doing the same thing to my wrists. I didn’t even have to stretch to try to accommodate them.

“How are these the perfect distance apart?” I asked, watching her with fascination.

“I measured the length of your arms when you were sleeping and had it designed to the exact right specifications, of course.”

“Oh, of course.” I chuckled. “How silly of me to ask.”

“Yes, so silly.”

She unclasped the leash from the front metal ring, attached it to one at the back, and pulled. My head tilted back, and I watched her secure the leash around another metal ring on the floor behind the couch. When she stood, I tried to move.

I couldn't. I was completely restrained from head to fucking toe, and I *liked* it. I was stretched out completely, my thighs spread wide, my arms extended along the back of the couch, wholeheartedly at her mercy. My cock *throbbed* at the picture I made. I held in a groan filled with pure pleasure.

I tracked Lyla through the mirror as she circled me, admiring her work. "God, do you have any idea how good you look like this?"

"Not to toot my own horn, but yeah, I kinda do," I panted, squirming. Pressure was building inside me, and I felt like I needed to release it soon or I would fucking explode.

"It's so much better than I ever could have imagined. I just want to keep you in here forever, tied down like this, so you can never leave. So I can use you whenever I want."

A shudder wracked through me. "Can you touch me now? Please. I don't think I can take much more of this."

She stopped. "Bad?" she asked, concerned.

"Fucking *good*," I groaned. The feeling of the cuffs digging into my wrists and ankles, the tight, unwavering pressure of the collar around my throat, heightened everything. Made everything feel so much more incredible. My senses were going into overload. I needed relief. I needed it immediately.

"Oh, baby." She chuckled. "We're only just getting started."

"I was afraid you were going to say that," I whined.

"Don't worry, I'll make it worth it." She retrieved something from the trunk along the far wall and returned to stand in front of me. Silver glinted in the light, and I saw it.

A dagger.

"Red line?" she asked, holding it up so I could see it clearly in the mirror.

"No," I gasped, shaking my head. The collar restricted my movements, my head only being able to move slightly.

The tip of the blade touched my chest. I sucked in a harsh breath. She trailed it down slowly, *so fucking slowly*, and my breathing increased in anticipation, my chest rising and falling rapidly. It didn't feel as sharp as what I had anticipated, and I wondered if Lyla had perhaps dulled it down.

She stopped at the top of pelvis. "Red line?"

Jesus, fuck. What was she going to do? Drag it along my dick? Why was I hoping that was her intention? I really *was* fucked up.

“No,” I groaned.

“You sure?”

“As long as you don’t cut it off, we’re good.”

A soft chuckle fell from her lips. “This is one of my favorite parts of your body. I would never dream of cutting it off. Except maybe to memorialize it and have it sitting on my mantelpiece.”

“Weird, but I’m kinda into it.”

Another throaty chuckle. I liked that I could make her laugh.

Entranced, I watched as Lyla moved the blade lower and lower. My breath caught in my throat at the sight. She could fucking end me right there and then, and there wasn’t a damn thing I could do to stop her.

It turned me on so fucking much.

My cock stood tall, hard as a rock. Slowly and very carefully, she ran the dagger along my shaft. Lyla’s soft, breathy moans, the sensation of the blade touching me in my most vulnerable, intimate parts, and watching her do it all from above was fucking *incredible*. Indescribable. She was barely fucking touching me, and I felt as though I was going to come.

“Jesus, oh, fuck,” I moaned, my body shaking. “I don’t know what the fuck is going on, but it feels *so good*.”

“Good. I’m glad.” Her voice was somewhat strained, and I wondered if she was having trouble holding herself back too.

“When you said you wanted to play with me, I had no idea what that entailed.”

“Honestly,” she began, blowing out a rough breath, “I planned to play for a while, but I don’t know if I can wait any longer. Seeing you like this, so pliable and so submissive...I need to fuck you, and I need to fuck you *now*.”

That sounded both amazing and torturous at the same time. I wanted her to continue. To continue edging me in a way I had never envisioned before. But then I also wanted to be buried so deep in that tight little pussy that I could barely fucking breathe.

She threw the dagger away and dropped to her knees right between my legs. Her hot mouth closed around the head of my cock, and I jolted at the contact, a burst of pleasure shooting up my body.

“Fucking hell,” I blew out, a feeling of pure ecstasy coursing through me. My eyes were glued to the mirror, watching her as she swallowed me down. It was the most erotic thing I’d ever witnessed. Installing a mirror on the ceiling? Fucking genius.

It ended far too quickly, but I wasn’t complaining because she got to her feet, eyes burning, and I just knew I was going to get well and truly fucked.

Man, being submissive is awesome.

She retrieved a condom from the side table next to the bed and returned quickly. My body strained to be closer to her, and for the first time since she’d strapped me down, I tried to move, stretching toward her.

The wicked smirk on her face told me she saw it and enjoyed it. Enjoyed the desperation I had for her. “Are you ready to be used, baby?”

My hips thrust forward in anticipation, completely out of my control. “Yes.” *God fucking yes.* “I’m yours to use, Huntress.”

She knelt, knees on either side of my waist, and hovered over me, just outside of reach.

It was complete fucking torture.

“Are you sure you’ve never submitted to anyone before? Because you do it so fucking well.”

Her praise washed through me, a sense of warmth and light blooming in my stomach. “I’m just naturally good at everything I do.”

“So humble,” she chuckled. Lyla ripped the condom open with her mouth. “I’m going to use you like my own personal sex toy now, baby. And you’re going to sit there and take it, aren’t you?”

My head was fucking swimming. I had to remind myself that she liked it when I spoke. “Yes,” I panted.

Sexy smirk still in place, she unclipped the leash and freed my head to move. I looked down at her body. Her tits, tight and perky, were right at eye level. My mouth watered, desperation filling my bones.

Slowly, sensually, she rolled the condom down my cock.

Lyla grabbed my chin in a rough and punishing grip. “Look up, baby. Eyes on the mirror. Watch me fucking own you.” Then, she dropped herself down on me.

Pleasure shot up my spine. “Fuck!” I yelled, my body arching upward. The bite of the cuffs around my wrists and ankles only heightened the pleasure, the feel of everything.

“Yesssss,” Lyla dragged out, her hands moving up to tangle in her hair. “Yes, baby. Yes.”

Her pussy was hot and tight. Sensational. I watched her in the ceiling above me, my gaze locked on the way she moved, the curve of her spine, her hips, fucking everything.

The image of me, spread out before her, cuffed, tied down, her black collar around my neck, and her riding the absolute fuck out of me would be forever seared into my brain. Would be the only thing I thought about anytime I self-pleasured from then until the day I fucking died.

“Lyla,” I moaned, my body jostling every time she dropped down on me. “You feel amazing. Fucking hell.”

Her pace increased, her breathing fastening as she chased her pleasure. As she *used me*. Her hands came up the side of my face and pulled me toward her. My lips sealed around her nipple.

“Suck hard, baby. Suck, suck, suck,” she chanted, and I did as she commanded. Lyla’s back arched, pushing her breast so far into my mouth it was almost suffocating, and I fucking loved it.

“I’m not going to last long.” Her hips swirled, and she changed momentum, going from up and down to back and forth. The sudden change sent a burst of pleasure shooting up my cock. “*Blyad, fuck.*”

Her tit fell out of my mouth with a wet *plop*. “Keep speaking Russian to me, baby. Keep going. God, don’t stop.”

“*Ty byla sozdana, chtoby napolnit’ menya. Sozdana, chtoby udovletvorit’ menya. Sozdana, chtoby byt’ moya,*” *You were made to fill me. Made to please me. Made to be mine*, she groaned.

I couldn’t deny her words even if I wanted to. Lyla was right. I was hers. She was mine. We were perfect for each other. *Made for each other*.

Lyla fucked and fucked and *fucked*, mumbling incoherent words in Russian, filled with pleasure. I expected her to slow down, to become exhausted from all the work she was putting in. But she just *kept going*, and I knew my release was torpedoing to the surface. I was dying to touch her, to grab her hips and slam her down on my cock. But I also loved being totally and completely at her mercy like that. Who knew being restrained could be so much fucking fun?

That telltale tingle in my balls made me shiver. I was going to come. My eyes darted up to the mirror. I wanted that image of me tied down and taking her fucking in my head when I—

“Lyla!” My body locked. A powerful, mind-numbing orgasm ripped through me, and I could *feel* every shot of cum jerk out of my cock.

Lyla reared forward, and her teeth latched onto my shoulder as she let loose a cry of pure pleasure, her pussy spasming around me. A bite of pain mingled with the ecstasy flowing through my body, and it heightened everything, my entire body trembling at the rush of endorphins bombarding me. At the feel of her pussy clamping down hard, squeezing my cock.

She slumped on me. The weight of her body on mine was perfect. It felt right, and I wanted desperately in that moment to wrap my arms around her and hold her close.

Lyla leaned back, and dazed, pleasure-filled eyes locked with mine. Our chests brushed against one another as we both breathed heavily, our gazes unable to move. I couldn’t stop looking at her. She was the most beautiful creature I had ever seen.

A beautiful, tender moment passed between us. Her hand came up and brushed a lock of hair out of my face. “I’m never letting you go.”

I turned my head to kiss her palm. What scared me the most was that I didn’t want her to.

Lyla only stayed for a moment longer before she got up, disposing of the condom. She unlocked the cuffs around my ankles and wrists without delay and pulled me to my feet. I was plagued with lethargy, my body exhausted, and my mind filled with a beautiful hazy feeling that I wanted to remain in for at least a little longer.

Lyla guided me to the bed. The red silk sheets looked like they would feel amazing on my skin. Sliding out of her heels, she climbed onto the bed, still naked, and opened her arms to me.

I wasn’t a big cuddler usually, especially after sex. I never wanted to give my partners the wrong idea—that what happened between us was anything more than just sex.

It didn’t feel that way with Lyla.

I crawled up the bed on my hands and knees and rested my head on her thigh, snuggling in right between her legs. I exhaled deeply, feeling more at peace than I had in a very long time. Her fingers went to my hair, and a small moan fell from my lips as her nails scratched lightly on my scalp.

I fucking love head scratches.

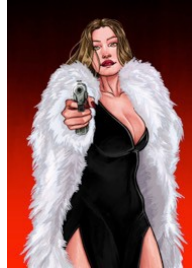
A comfortable silence followed, neither one of us feeling the need to speak, to do anything but enjoy each other’s company and embrace. It was

so comfortable I fell asleep almost instantly.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER TWENTY FOUR

LYLA VOZNESENKY



“*I*’ve said it before and I’ll say it again, this is a bad fucking idea.” Cedric stood in the center of my bedroom, feet shoulder-width apart, arms crossed over his chest, glaring me down as if it would somehow change my mind.

It wouldn’t. My mind was made up.

“You’ve made your opinion *very* clear, Cedric.” I picked up the bloodred lipstick sitting on the makeup table in front of me and smoothed it over my lips.

“Then why aren’t you listening to me?”

“Because I don’t want to.” I didn’t really need any other reason other than that, did I?

I put the lipstick down and picked up a bottle of perfume, spraying it on my wrists and the column of my throat. “Lukyan’s been cooped up in the house for days. He needs to go out and do something fun.”

“And what if your *precious* Lukyan tries to escape?” He said *precious* in a derogatory way, and I didn’t fucking like it. “What then, huh? What happens to your grand plan?”

“You know, you’re being a real party pooper. He wouldn’t do that to me.”

It had been a week since Lukyan and I got married, and although it didn’t seem like a long time in the grand scheme of things, I wanted to celebrate our one-week anniversary. Celebrate that glorious milestone together.

We'd grown close over the past few days, the bond I always knew we possessed finally blossoming, evolving into what I always knew it could be.

The unbelievable, dirty, filthy sex was partially responsible for that, but it was also the deep conversations we'd have afterwards that helped to forge our connection. Made it stronger than it already was. Unbreakable.

I knew we couldn't stay in our isolated fuckbubble forever, though.

Eventually, we would have to go back out into the real world. Face our problems.

Lukyan—his grandfather.

Me—my brother.

But until then, we were going to have some fucking fun.

That cross-as-fuck look on Cedric's face didn't change. Didn't budge. "How do you know that? How do you know he's not going to take this opportunity to run?"

I knew it the same way I knew everything else. "Because I *know* him. Lukyan is having fun with me. He enjoys being around me, like I do him. He wouldn't leave me like that. Not after all the time we've spent getting to know each other."

"You mean fucking," he responded, none to impressed.

"You find out a lot about a person when you fuck them." I winked. "He deserves to have some fun, and I want to give that to him."

"You think taking him to some club in the city is the only way to have fun? I can think of a dozen other things you can do that pose less of a risk. You know his family is looking for him."

Yes, I did know that. They'd put out a fucking country-wide call for him. I was both annoyed and incredibly impressed by the reach the Bratva possessed.

"Everything will be fine." I firmly believed that. The odds of someone being at the *exact* same club, on the *exact* same night, at the *exact* same time as us was astronomical.

When I'd first floated the idea by Lukyan, he'd been ecstatic. He wanted to go out, drink and dance just as much as I did. There was no way I could deny him that chance to make him happy, even if it came with such a risk.

"And what am I meant to tell your brother?"

"Don't tell him anything." Checking my face over one more time in the mirror, I nodded, satisfied with what stared back at me.

I was shit at applying makeup. I could only do the basics. Foundation, eyeliner, mascara, and lipstick, and even that was a struggle. It wasn't as if I didn't like it. I did. I loved the way makeup made me look. Made me feel. I just sucked at doing it, and anytime I tried to learn from Youtube tutorials, it never turned out the same.

My hair was down and straight, and I had on one of my favorite dresses—red, lacy, and tight. It would ensure Lukyan's gaze never wavered from me.

"You can't keep avoiding this, Lyla," Cedric said solemnly. My eyes flicked to him in the mirror, and our gazes held. "He'll be here soon. You have to make a choice."

I sighed deeply. He was right. Of course, I knew he was right. I'd been putting off thinking about it, hoping that if I just ignored it, the entire situation would just...go away.

But that was denial through and through. The truth of it was, I didn't want to have to choose between my brother and Lukyan. Lev's obsession with his mission would leave me no choice, though, and soon, I would be forced to make a decision.

"I know. I know. I'll deal with it tomorrow." For the tonight, Lukyan and I were going to let loose and party. We weren't going to be a crazy stalker woman or a Bratva prince. We were just going to be Lyla and Lukyan.

I stood up and made my way to the closet. A pair of red pumps drew me in straight away. I plucked them from the shelf, sliding them onto my feet before taking one final look in the full-length mirror hanging on the door.

Perfect.

Making sure to grab my purse with my phone, keys, and wallet in it, I made my way over to Cedric and hugged him. He stiffened, taken slightly by surprise.

"Thanks for looking out for me," I whispered softly.

His body loosened, and he returned my embrace, wrapping his arms around me. "Always."

Warmth flooded through me. Cedric might not have agreed with my actions, but he would always have my back, and that meant the world to me.

With a final goodbye, I left and went to Lukyan's room. It was right beside mine. I hoped we would be sharing a space soon, though.

I knocked on the door. Lukyan opened it a moment later, and my breath caught in my throat. He stood there, looking every bit like he'd just walked off a GQ photo shoot. His hair was down, exactly how I liked it. He'd chosen a white, long-sleeved shirt, tight and perfectly fitted for his body, a black corset vest with an intricate cathedral design etched into the fabric, and black slacks. The icing on the cake, though?

He was wearing my fucking collar.

Without prompting.

My stomach fluttered at the sight.

"Hold on." My hand dove into my purse, and I yanked out my phone, holding it up to take a photo.

Lukyan smirked. He leaned against the doorframe and posed for me, one hand coming up to fiddle with the cuff of his sleeve.

I snapped a dozen photos.

"Get enough?" he asked, humor dancing in his eyes.

"No," I answered honestly. It would never be enough. "But it will do. For now." I flicked through the images. "I can't wait to add these to my scrapbook."

"Your...scrapbook?" he asked, brows slightly creased in a frown.

I put my phone back away. "If you're lucky, I might show it to you one day." He wasn't ready for that, though. "You good to go?"

"Yep." His gaze ran the length of my body, and hunger flashed in his eyes. "You look—"

"Sexy? Mouthwatering? Fuckable?"

"Like you'll be the death of me," he breathed out in awe.

My heart pounded in my chest. *It's working. It's fucking working.*

"What's working?" he asked.

Whoops. I smiled sheepishly. "Did I say that out loud?"

"Yes. What's working?"

Well, might as well go all in now. "My plan to make you obsessed with me."

He said nothing, just staring deeply into my eyes. I wished I could read his mind. Know what he was thinking. Lukyan was an expert at hiding his emotions when he wanted to. I thought *I* was an expert at reading them, but I realized then that I wasn't as good as I thought I was, because I had no idea what was running through his head.

A moment passed between us. A significant, defining moment. Something crucial to the progression of our relationship. I was sure of it.

Shutters closed over Lukyan's eyes. "We should go," he grunted out roughly.

Or maybe not.

* * *

MUSIC BLASTED THROUGH THE AIR, a constant *thump, thump, thump* vibrating through my body from the bass of the R'n'B song blaring from the speakers. Strobe lights flashed different colors around the club. Smoke billowed into a cloud around us from the smoke machines. Bodies were crammed onto the dance floor, everybody dancing and letting their demons loose.

Lukyan and I included.

We jumped. We danced. We bobbed and weaved. We made absolute fools of ourselves, and neither one of us gave a shit about it, just enjoying the night. The atmosphere was electric—exactly what we needed to relax and have fun.

Club Noir was located in the city a few hours from the house. It was a good place, with an awesome vibe, cheap drinks, and good music. There was nothing harder than trying to dance to music that wasn't your taste.

For hours, we just let the beat of the music run through our bodies. Let all our dramas and worries just disappear, living entirely in the moment before us. I'd been watching Lukyan for over a year and half, and I'd never seen him so relaxed, having so much fun. It made me happy seeing him so happy. So wild. So carefree.

Exactly how he should have been.

"You're so fucking hot," Lukyan whispered in my ear. He was behind me, grinding up against my ass to the best of the music. His hands were all over me. On my hips. Fanning out across my stomach. Inching up toward my breasts and then sliding back down, absolutely torturing me.

I loved it. Loved having his undivided attention like that, especially when so many others were trying hard to get him to notice them. Women and men kept looking over at him, throwing him sultry and *come hither* looks, hoping he would ditch me for them. *Stupid bitches, the lot of them.* If

I weren't in such a good mood, I would have already killed them, but, lucky for them, I was feeling gracious.

I still needed to show everyone that he was mine, though.

A gorgeous—and I mean *gorgeous*—woman over at the bar was eyeing him hard, her gaze heated and filled with want. It didn't seem to matter that he was all over me. That, to the outsider's eye, we were most definitely together. She saw a man she wanted, and didn't care if he was there with someone else.

I hated women like that.

I was a girl's girl, through and through. If a man was taken, he was fucking taken.

We were just going to ignore the fact that I killed women who touched Lukyan.

That didn't count.

I waited for her eyes to find mine, and then I reached back, hooking my finger through the metal ring on the front of Lukyan's collar, and pulled him down. Our lips connected. It was hot. Searing. Electric.

And I made that bitch watch.

Lukyan moaned. I loved it when he moaned. It was such a hot, erotic sound that just sent tingles exploding throughout my whole body. His hands went wandering, slipping beneath my dress.

He gasped into my mouth. "No underwear?"

A devilish thrill streaked through me. "Nope." I let go of his collar and turned around, pressing my body flush against his. His cock, long, hard, and thick, pushed into my lower stomach.

"You drive me fucking crazy." He kissed me, and it was full of passion. Full of desire and lust.

"You're one to talk." Lukyan had no idea how crazy he made me.

We danced, kissed, and downright grinded the shit out of each other for so long that, when I finally came up for air, my mind was swimming.

"Let's go for a smoke!" I yelled over the music.

Lukyan nodded and grabbed my hand. His hold was tight, unwavering as he threaded us through the crowd of people around us and right to the door that led outside to the smokers' area.

Club Noir had several floors, with balconies on each level for people to go and chill out. To get away from the loud music for a little bit. Because it was nighttime and cold as shit, there weren't many people outside. Heat

lamps sat in every corner—a great but futile attempt to warm the area. Small tables, each with two chairs and an ashtray sitting on top, were spread throughout the space, offering plenty of options.

We decided to take the bench seat running along the side wall. I pulled out my metal cigarette case.

“So, I realized something,” Lukyan began, leaning back and spreading his thighs. “You never answered my question.”

“And what question was that?”

“How did you find the location of Talon’s island?”

Ah. “It was *hard*. That man had security measures up the wazoo.” With a click, I opened the case and plucked out a joint. I didn’t smoke all the time. Was more of a social smoker than anything else. I knew Lukyan was, too, but he much preferred weed over cigarettes. “But nobody is more dangerous than a woman trying to protect the person she loves. I was watching you, you know. When you were taken.”

“You were?”

“Mm-hmm.” Placing the joint in between my lips, I lit the end and inhaled deeply, letting the smoke fill my lungs before blowing it out. A slight haze washed over me. “I tracked you. Followed you to that apartment you keep in the city. The one you stay at when you’ve finished whatever work you’re doing for your father and don’t want to trek all the way home. I climbed all the way to the roof of the adjacent building and watched. As much as I could, anyway. You’d shut the blinds, so I wasn’t able to see much of anything.” I handed the joint to him.

Lukyan inhaled deeply and then exhaled, blowing out three perfect rings that drifted into the air. He didn’t seem the least bit bothered by what I was saying, which I took as a good sign.

“I saw a van pull up about forty-five minutes later,” I continued. “Four guys got out and went inside. I didn’t think anything of it. Thought they were just other tenants in the building. About ten minutes later, they came out, carrying you.”

The memory was still so fresh in my mind it could have happened yesterday, not over six months before. I remembered it all. Vividly. The shock that had run through my body. The frustration over the fact I didn’t have my sniper rifle with me. If I’d brought it, I could have saved my poor Lukyan from all that trauma of being kidnapped.

It was one of the reasons why, from that point forward, I always made sure to use my rifle instead of binoculars when spying on him. I would never allow myself to be caught unawares again.

I rubbed my hands together to generate some warmth. “Luckily, I had my bike, because by the time I made it down from the building, they were halfway down the street. I followed them through hours of traffic, numerous handoffs, and endless twists and turns.”

“Handoffs?” he asked, handing the joint back to me.

“I told you, that Talon guy had *insane* security measures. Every hour, they pulled over and handed you off to another team. The last one ended up in an empty field, where a plane was waiting.” The pure panic I’d felt when I realized I wouldn’t be able to follow...that I would lose him...It was crippling. “Every plane, no matter if it’s private or commercial, has to register a flight path with air traffic control if they’re crossing international borders. I couldn’t follow the plane, but I could find out where it was going with the tail number. They’re essentially license plate numbers for planes, stamped on the side of the aircraft. Once I had the destination, I knew where to go. It landed in a small airfield in Naples. Lucky for me, I had contacts in Italy. People who owed me a favor or two. I couldn’t make it there in time to track you when you landed, so I had them waiting. You were put in a car, and again, handed off to several other teams before finally being transported to a boat. It was a small, twenty-foot motor yacht with a fifty-litre tank. A vessel that size can only travel roughly three hundred nautical miles, and there was only one island within range. Once I had the island’s latitude and longitude, I sent it to your brother’s laptop because as much of a badass as I am, I couldn’t break you out of there alone. And that’s that. Bingo bango. Easy as pie.”

I took a deep drag of the joint. A bout of hunger hit me. “Fuck, you know what I could really go for right now? A burger. A big, fat, juicy burger. With fries. No. A *buttload* of fries. With bacon. And ohhh, melted cheese. Yum.”

Holding the joint up in the air, I waited for Lukyan to take it. When he didn’t, I looked at him. A stunned, slightly bewildered expression was on his face.

“What?” I touched my lips. “Do I have something in my teeth?” There was nothing more embarrassing than chatting away and finding out you had a huge piece of food stuck in your teeth.

Lukyan chuckled, as if I was missing some sort of inside joke only he was in on. "I'm just a little...shocked. You went through a fuckton of effort to save me and my family."

"Not your family." I stared him dead in the eyes. "Only you. Always only you." As bad as it might sound, I didn't give two baloney sandwiches about his family. My one and only priority was protecting and saving Lukyan.

His eyes bored into mine, full of hot, blazing emotion, and then he kissed me. It was soft. Heartfelt. Far different from any other kiss I'd ever experienced in my life, and it was by far the most meaningful.

I melted into him as I kissed him back, the softness of his tongue against mine making me moan. I hoped he could finally understand just how much he meant to me. How much I needed him. That when I said I would do anything for him, I truly, *truly* meant it.

His lips disappeared far too quickly, but he stayed close, pressing his forehead against mine and taking a deep, relaxing breath. We'd shared a lot of beautiful, significant moments together so far, but that one? It felt monumental.

The door to the club opened and loud, rambunctious laughter followed. Two women came stumbling out. With the moment shattered, Lukyan and I pulled apart.

"Should we go back inside?" he asked roughly.

"Yeah." I cleared my throat, trying to get my bearings. "Let's."

Music bombarded me from all sides when we walked back into the club, the drastic change of atmosphere almost jarring. Lukyan's hands landed on my hips, and he bent to whisper in my ear.

"Drink?"

Yeah. I could really go for a fucking drink right now.

I nodded.

He took the lead, pushing through the crowd of people to get to the bar. Everyone was mostly on the dance floor, only a few others waiting to get drinks. The gorgeous woman I'd clocked earlier was still there, nursing a drink as she bobbed along to the music. She was on the prowl, looking for someone to take home. I was sure of it.

There was no way it was going to be Lukyan.

I maneuvered myself so I was in between them.

"What do you want?" he asked, his hand on my lower back.

“Corona.”

He waved down the bartender. “Two Coronas, my good man.” He reached into his pocket and frowned.

I knew what he was searching for. I handed him a fifty-dollar bill from inside my purse. His lips pursed in distaste.

“I wanted to pay.”

“Well, that’s good, because it’s from your wallet.” I’d taken it off him when I kidnapped him.

Lukyan was a submissive man in the bedroom, and *that was all*. He was dominant in every other aspect of his life, and I knew that. Like I’d said a million times, I knew him better than anyone else did. Could anticipate his actions, his thoughts, as if they were my own.

He plucked the bill from my fingers and leaned his elbow against the bar, smirking. “You’re sneaky.”

“You love it, though.”

He chuckled. “I do.”

I beamed at him.

The bartender plopped two beers down in front of us. We each took one, clinking the bottles against each other in a cheers. Our eyes stayed locked as we sipped our drinks, the tension building and building, like a volcano about to erupt. We were in a crowded club, surrounded by a sea of people who were so close we could hear their conversations over the loud music. Yet it was as if we were the only people in the room. In the entire world. Nothing could break that moment—

“Hi!”

The voice was feminine. High-pitched. Coming from directly behind me.

This bitch.

Lukyan’s eyes didn’t move. Didn’t waver. The woman might as well have not said anything. His attention was completely on me.

“Hi!!” she tried again, this time louder. More forceful.

I turned around and took a step so my back was flush against Lukyan’s front. His hand came around and grasped my hip possessively.

“Hi!” I returned, the smile on my face anything but fucking friendly. “Do we know you?”

“No. But I have a feeling he”—she pointed a long, stiletto-shaped fingernail right at Lukyan—“will *want* to know me.”

“I want to rip that nail off your finger and use it to slice your throat. It’s not that sharp, you see, so it would take a while. And would hurt. A lot.”

The woman blinked, slightly shocked, and then laughed as if I’d been telling a joke.

I wasn’t. I was dead fucking serious.

“I can see why you like her. She’s got fire. But she can’t give you what I can, baby,” she said, gliding a finger down in between the valley of her breasts.

They were nice breasts. Big and full and round. But not better than mine.

I hooked a finger through the metal ring on Lukyan’s collar and yanked him forward so his head was right beside mine. “You see this? This means he’s *mine*. You understand?”

A haughty look crossed her face. “What if he doesn’t want to be yours?”

“He does.” That, I had the utmost confidence in.

“Does he speak?” she asked, inclining her head toward him in the hopes of getting him to finally acknowledge her.

“Not to you.”

Lukyan smirked. He was bent slightly forward, but he didn’t look uncomfortable. He looked like he was having fun. Enjoying himself.

“You sound worried.” She flicked her beautiful, long dark hair over her shoulder and stretched out her slender neck. I had to give it to her. She knew her most flattering angles. “A little advice, honey.” *Oh, you **did not** just fucking **honey** me.* “If you have to fight this hard to keep him, he doesn’t want you.”

She couldn’t possibly know how much her words would trigger me. That I *did* have to work hard to get him there with me. To finally have him. What she said could possibly hold some truth to it, and I didn’t fucking like it.

Anger rolled through me, blackening my vision. I lunged, my hands reaching for her throat. Lukyan’s arm instantly wrapped around my middle to stop me, and my feet left the ground as he picked me up.

“Let me fucking go!” I yelled, trying to scratch the bitch’s eyes out.

Her eyes widened, and she backed up immediately to stay out of my reach. Whatever she saw on my face told her she’d pushed me too far because she continued to back away as I thrashed in Lukyan’s ironclad hold.

It angered me further. I wanted to kill her.

“Jesus! What the fuck is wrong with you?!” she shrieked, horror in her eyes.

“Come here and I’ll fucking show you,” I growled.

The people around us started to give us a wide berth, almost creating a circle with us right in the middle.

“Calm down, baby,” Lukyan whispered in my ear. “It’s okay.”

Oh, is it? Is it okay? Is it okay for some random woman to question our relationship like that?

I continued to fight him. “Why are you saving her? Do you like her or something? Is that it? You want her?”

He chuckled deeply, the sound sending shivers down my spine. “Fuck, you’re so fucking crazy, and it’s such a goddamn turn on.” He took one more sip of his beer before placing it down on the bar, all while still holding me off the ground with his other arm.

The strength he was exhibiting was not lost on me.

“Time to go.” He turned and started walking toward the exit, me still caught firmly in his grip.

“No. No! I want to cut the bitch first. Just once! Let me cut that pretty fucking face of hers,” I snapped, twisting to try and turn around.

“Nope. We’re in a crowded club. You can’t just go around cutting people.”

He was being irrationally unreasonable right now, and it wasn’t fair. I had anger to let out, and I wanted her to be the outlet.

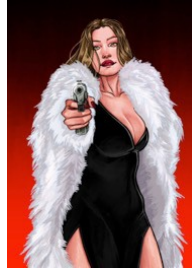
I thrashed. I snarled. I acted downright fucking feral.

“You really weren’t kidding about being spontaneously violent, were you?” He laughed.

No, I bloody wasn’t. Once I was in the mood, I barely registered anything going on around me, the drive to hurt someone almost all-consuming. I barely noticed all the attention I was drawing. Barely noticed the looks of fear and horror on people’s faces as Lukyan carried me away. And I sure as shit didn’t notice the man at the back of the club with his phone to his ear, watching us.

CHAPTER TWENTY FIVE

LYLA VOZNESENKY



*M*y back hit the brick wall behind the club, and Lukyan pinned me there with nothing but his body, pressing right up against me, every inch of him flush with mine.

I kicked and snarled, still filled with rage and a pounding jealousy I could feel right down to my bones.

“Calm down, baby,” he whispered softly. His lips ghosted over the sensitive skin of my throat in a soft kiss—his attempt to try to pacify me.

It didn’t work. I was too riled up.

“Don’t tell me to calm down. I’ll calm down if I *want* to calm down.” Irrational and childish, I know. You don’t have to tell me. But the green-eyed monster thumping in my veins made it impossible for me to see reason.

Gorgeous McBitch had a point. I *shouldn’t* have to work so hard to make him mine, and the fact that I was having to was *not* a good sign. He should know it as easily as I did, and yet, I felt as though I had to prove it to him. Show him how perfect we were for each other. I hated that feeling. That feeling of confusion and doubt.

I thrashed, trying to worm my way out of his grip. It didn’t work. Lukyan’s hands clamped around my wrists, and he slammed them up above my head.

“I like you like this.” He laughed softly, his gaze running over my face, shining with warmth.

At least he said he liked me.

“Like what?!” I barked.

“All neurotic and crazy and possessive.”

“I am *not* neurotic.”

“But crazy and possessive?”

“Well, duh,” I snapped. I might as well have that tattooed across my fucking forehead.

He shook his head, chuckling softly. “You have nothing to worry about,” he murmured reassuringly.

“So you don’t want Gorgeous McBitch?”

“No.” He chuckled again.

“You don’t want to fuck her?”

“No.”

“*I’m* the only one you want?”

He stared deeply into my eyes, that amused smile still curved on his lips. “Yes.”

I scowled. “You hesitated.”

“No, I didn’t.”

I tried to bite him, my teeth snapping an inch from his face. “Yes! You did! You know what, why don’t you go grab her and see how long she lasts in your world. I guarantee you it won’t be longer than a fucking minute, *ty beschuvstvennyy, nikuda ne godnyy pridurok*,” *You insensitive, good-for-nothing prick.*

“That’s it.” He picked me up effortlessly and turned. I found myself bent over the hood of some random car parked behind us. The glorious, heavy weight of his body followed next, his lips pressing to my ear. “Do I need to fuck this attitude out of you? Hm?”

My heart rate quickened. “As if you could,” I spat.

He kicked my legs apart and pulled up my dress, exposing every inch of me down below. The side street was dark, only the faint trace of light illuminating from the lamppost at the entrance giving me the ability to make out the shapes amongst the shadows. The muffled sounds of music and laughter hit my ears from the club, and it only excited me more, knowing we could be caught at any moment. That pedestrians walking past could catch us. *See us.*

His cold hand grasped my pussy roughly from behind. He groaned. “You’re wet.”

“I’m always wet around you. It’s annoying.” My tone was haughty and bitchy. Even *I* could hear that, but I was powerless to stop it. I got that way

whenever jealousy got into the mix.

“I like it.” The jingle of his belt hit the air, followed by the sound of his zipper lowering. “I love our sexual dynamic. Submitting to you is the hottest thing I’ve ever experienced, but sometimes, even a dominant woman needs a good, hard fucking to knock out that spicy-as-fuck attitude.”

I thumped the side of my fist down onto the hood of the car. “I do not have an attitude!”

“Yes, you do. Tell me now if you want me to stop, baby. Otherwise, I’m going to fuck you raw.”

“Of course I don’t want you to stop, you bastard!” I growled out. Nine times out of ten, I wanted to be in control. To lead. To dictate what happened, when it happened. However, once in a blue moon, I just liked to be well and truly fucked. Hard and rough and punishing.

“Good.” Not even a second later, he entered me, brutally and ruthlessly.

A pleasure-filled cry burst from my lips.

“Fuck, that’s good,” he hissed out behind clenched teeth. Then, he started to move, pistoning in and out of me like a man possessed. He held me down by the back of the neck and fucked me with an almost savage edge to his movements.

I couldn’t move even if I wanted to. His grip was iron-fucking-clad. Immovable and unbreakable.

“Oh, God, Lukyan,” I moaned. The car beneath me moved with each harsh thrust he delivered. I had no idea who owned it, but the fact that they could come back at any minute only heightened the pleasure flooding my veins.

Lukyan did some move with his hips, swiveling right and then left, going deeper inside me, and my pussy spasmed at the new sensations hitting me.

“You like being manhandled. Who would have thought.” He chuckled darkly. One hand came down to squeeze my ass. He pulled out suddenly, dropped to his knees, and ran his tongue from my pussy up to my ass in one long lick.

I sucked in a shocked breath.

Before I could do or say anything, he speared right back inside me, causing me to cry out, my head flinging back.

He shoved me back down, my cheek plastering onto the hood of the car, and continued to fuck me without pause. Lukyan didn’t do it nearly as hard

as I knew he was capable of. It didn't hurt or shock me. He was both rough and incredibly cautious at the same time, and it made my heart swim, knowing how careful he was being with me.

"This pussy, god-fucking-damn." He grunted. "You'll be my undoing."

Pleasure skyrocketed up my spine. The feel of his hands on my hips, holding me in place as he took what he wanted from me torpedoed me closer to my orgasm.

"Lukyan. Baby. Yes. Yes."

He pressed further into me, almost crushing me with his weight. "Still got that fucking attitude?" he whispered in my ear before catching my lobe with his teeth.

A bite of pain shot through me. "No," I panted.

"See? All you needed was a good fucking."

"All I needed was you."

"You fucking have me. Have had me for longer than you even know."

What does that even mean?

He kissed me. Harshly. Viciously. His tongue pushed its way past my lips to battle with my own. I moaned into his mouth, and the sound seemed to egg him on, making him move faster. More chaotically.

His cock, long and thick and hard, felt so good it made my pussy pulse and spasm. "I'm going to come," I all but whined.

"Yeah, you fucking are. Open that pretty mouth of yours," he demanded, and I was powerless to do anything except follow his command.

He rolled his tongue along his bottom lip and spat right into my mouth. White-hot pleasure exploded throughout my body in an instant. I could do nothing but tremble at the severity of it. I cried out his name, unable to quieten myself.

Lukyan cursed and sped up. "Gonna fill you up so good." He groaned. "I'm going to be dripping out of you for days."

Dear God.

With a few more pumps of his hips, Lukyan locked up, holding my hips tightly in place as he unloaded his cum deep into my pussy. The sound he made—one of pure male satisfaction—sent me to an all-new high. A level I had never reached before. I could almost swear that sound alone gave me another mini orgasm.

Lukyan collapsed on top of me. The air whooshed out of me. Despite the fact that I was having trouble breathing, I secretly loved the feel of it. It

was like one of those heavy, dense anxiety blankets. It was heavenly—

“Hey! What are you doing to my car?!” a male voice yelled out.

Uh-oh.

Lukyan snapped into action far quicker than I did. His weight disappeared in an instant, and he yanked down my dress to cover me. He grabbed my hand with his while the other tucked his dick back into his pants, and then he turned, running the opposite way from the very pissed off man coming from the entrance into the alley, dragging me behind him.

“Run!”

“Oh my god!” I giggled. The heels didn’t make it easy. I could walk in heels. Dance in heels. Sometimes even fight in heels. But run? No way.

Lukyan must have realized that because he stopped suddenly. “Jump on my back!”

Yay. A piggy-back ride.

He bent down slightly, and I leaped onto him. I’d barely gotten situated before he took off running again.

“You little fucks!” the man screamed behind us. I glanced over my shoulder to see him throw a beer can at us. “You better hope I don’t catch you!”

Lukyan and I burst out laughing as we disappeared around the corner.

* * *

“YOU CAN’T BE SERIOUS,” Lukyan snickered.

“I’m dead serious.”

“You would still love me if I was a worm?”

“Of course! I’d build you a nice home in a pot plant. Make sure you had plenty of water and the dirt was always nice and moist for you. Then, I’d carry you around with me every day so you never got lonely.”

He shook his head, laughing softly. “You are insane.”

“No. I’m thoughtful and caring.” I took a bite of my shrimp taco, an abundance of flavor exploding in my mouth. “Are you saying you wouldn’t love *me* if *I* was a worm?”

“I’m not answering this question.”

“Why not? Are you afraid of worms? Okay, how about a snail? Would you still love me if I was a snail?”

“I’m not answering it because it doesn’t make any sense,” he said, the biggest smile on his face.

“Sure it does! Imagine my consciousness was somehow transported into a snail—”

“How was it transported?”

“I don’t know. An alien did it.”

“Why would an alien transport your consciousness into a snail?”

“For shits and giggles. Obviously.”

Lukyan rolled his eyes. “Oh, right, obviously.” He chuckled, taking a bite of his own taco.

The cold air pierced my skin, making me shiver. We sat outside a few streets over from the club. After we’d been caught red-handed, fucking on the hood of some random guy’s car, we bolted. Or, more specifically, Lukyan bolted, with me dangling off his back, our laughter echoing into the air.

Once we’d made it to safety, we came across several food trucks. It was the perfect place to set up, ensuring ample business from all the party goers pouring out of the clubs on Main Street.

I took a quick sip of my Coke. “Okay, so my consciousness is inside a snail, right—”

“Can you talk?” he asked curiously.

“Of course I can’t talk. I’m a snail.”

“So putting your consciousness into a snail is plausible, but being able to *talk* isn’t?” he questioned humorously. “I love the way your mind works.” The hard shell of his taco cracked as he took another bite. “You asked me something, and now I’m curious what the answer is for you. What’s the craziest thing you’ve ever done?”

“Slight subject change, but I’ll roll with it. We’ll be circling back to this later, though. I’d say...the craziest thing I’ve ever done is pose on your bed while you were taking a shower.” I winked.

He smirked. “Funny. But I want something new. Something different. Something I don’t know about.”

He wants to know more about me. The prospect of strengthening our connection made me instantly forget the ridiculous topic we’d been discussing to search for something to tell him. We’d already had numerous conversations about our lives. They had all been mundane topics, though. Nothing deep or meaningful.

I realized something, and a flicker of sadness cut through me. “Believe it or not, everything crazy I’ve ever done is in relation to you. My life was nothing before I met you. As pathetic as that sounds.”

Lukyan frowned. “I’m sure that’s not true.”

“It is. And that’s okay, I guess. Growing up, I was always told to quiet my crazy. To be normal. Act like everyone else. I never did it. Fuck what everyone thought. If I wanted to speak my mind and act like a fool, I was damn well going to do it. But after my parents died, and Lev and I went to the orphanage, things changed. Every day, without fail, Lev would tell me I was too much. That my personality was putting us at risk. That I had to ‘tone it down’. He had this plan, you see, and it required a level of control and seriousness I didn’t possess. At least, not then. So, I buried that side of me. Locked it up tight in a box in my mind and let it sit there for years.” My eyes clashed with his, burning with emotion. “Until I met you. You changed everything for me.”

“Me?” he whispered, ever so softly. The surprise in his voice was obvious. Like Lukyan couldn’t believe *he* was responsible for such a thing. Something so monumental and profound.

“Mm-hmm.” I finished the rest of my taco and wiped my mouth before depositing the napkin in the cardboard tray beside me. “You made me realize that my crazy is a *good* thing. Not something to be criticized or looked down upon. That it makes me who I am. That I have absolutely nothing to be ashamed of. That this was just the way I am, and that’s okay.”

Lukyan’s eyes softened. He brushed a lock of hair out of my face, the gentleness of his fingers brushing against my skin making me shiver. “I know what it’s like being told to ‘tone it down’,” he said sadly. “It hurts. Especially when it’s coming from someone you love.”

“Yeah, it does,” I breathed out.

Lukyan’s thumb grazed my bottom lip, an almost entranced look on his face before he pulled back. “You’ve mentioned a few times that your brother has some plan that’s affected you while you were growing up. What is it?”

It took everything within me not to stiffen. “It doesn’t matter. I’ve decided I’m not helping him with it anymore.” There was no way I could. Not now. “He’s going to absolutely lose his shit when he finds out, but he’ll get over it.” At least, I hoped he would.

“Have you always had to do what he tells you to?”

“Kinda. Things at the orphanage weren’t bad, but they weren’t *good* either. He took the lead, and I followed. That dynamic rolled over into adulthood.”

“Do you wish it was different?”

Boy fucking did I. “I wish he would *ask* me, just *ask* instead of tell me. He says ‘jump’, and the only appropriate response is for me to ask ‘how high’. Never question him. And for the longest time, I didn’t. I love my brother. He’s a *good* brother, but he struggled a lot with our father’s death. It changed him. He was suffering, and all I wanted to do was make it better for him. Make it easier. So, I did what he told me to. I never let my crazy out. Over the last few years, it’s gotten harder and harder to do that—not having a voice or opinion on anything. I *want* to be seen. For him to notice my skills and be satisfied with what I’ve done, instead of just critiquing the way I’ve done it.”

Lukyan nodded, almost as if he understood exactly what I was saying. What I was feeling. “You’re overlooked.” There was no question in it. He said it as if he was stating pure fact.

“Yes.”

“He doesn’t see your potential. What you’re capable of.”

I sucked in a painful breath. “No, he doesn’t.”

Lukyan placed his hand on mine. The touch was light. Soft. Supportive. “What is it you want?”

Confusion wracked through me. “What do you mean?”

“In life,” he clarified. “What do you want in life?”

That was easy. “The same thing you want. To be loved and appreciated for who I am, flaws and all. I dream of a connection so strong that nothing can break it. To be wholeheartedly myself without judgment or worrying I’m being too much. I don’t want to have to hide myself from the people I love.”

He stared deep into my eyes, a different kind of tension vibrating between us. It wasn’t one fueled by sex or lust, but empathy. Something only someone who experienced the same thing could possibly understand.

He leaned forward and kissed me. It was a gentle kiss. Filled with such raw emotion it took my breath away. His tongue brushed against mine in the softest caress, sending shivers racing down my spine. It was like a moment from a fairy tale, where everything finally came together and felt right. Perfect.

He pulled back to rest his forehead against mine. Blue eyes filled with warmth locked on me. “I would still love you if you were a worm.”

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER TWENTY SIX



DIMITRI VOLKOV

“*I* need to see my father.”

The soldier standing guard in front of Sergei’s office shook his head. “He’s not taking any visitors right now.” He was dressed in the attire all the soldiers wore—military clothing, vest, machine gun strapped across his body, like he was ready to go off to war at any moment.

Neither the gun nor his large stature intimidated me.

I punched him in the throat.

He choked, eyes widening as he curled over. I rammed my knee up quickly, smashing it into his face. He stumbled back hard into the door behind him, causing it to rip open and tumble into my father’s office. He landed harshly on his back with a painful groan. I strolled right on in, skirting around his body.

Sergei sat behind his big, imposing desk, elbows planted firmly on the surface, a piece of paper in his hands. Thick glasses sat on his face. He didn’t wear them often. My father considered it a weakness to need them, so he only wore them when he was in the safety of his office.

Vernon stood at his side, holding a stack of more papers.

“Did you forget how to knock?” Sergei asked, taking off his glasses and tucking them away. He handed the document in his hands over to Vernon, who placed it on top of the others.

“It’s time we have a talk.”

“Is it?”

“Yes.”

Sergei leaned back in his chair. “Where’s your pretty new girlfriend? Are you sure it’s a smart idea to leave her all alone?”

“Autumn can handle herself. If anything, I’m concerned for anyone who gets in *her* way.”

“She is a *formidable* woman. Far better than your previous love.”

I wasn’t going to rise to the bait. A comment like that six months before would have sent me into a frenzy, but I’d dealt with all my demons from the past. They could no longer hurt me anymore.

“Why don’t we cut the bullshit, Sergei?” I took a seat in one of the chairs in front of his desk, my body relaxed and composed despite the tension coursing through me. I wasn’t scared of my father. Not anymore. Hadn’t been for a long time. But I’d be a fool not to be weary of him and what he was capable of. “You tried to have me killed.”

His eyebrow hiked up ever so slightly. Since arriving at his estate, neither one of us had acknowledged the giant elephant in the room. Sergei clearly didn’t want to talk about the subject, or he would have brought it up himself. If I was going to have any chance of killing him, I needed to rattle him.

“That will be all, Vernon,” he commanded.

The man who had been glued to my father’s side since the moment I got there frowned. “But—”

“That will be all, Vernon,” he repeated sternly.

Vernon hesitated for only a second longer before nodding, however reluctantly, and left the room, dragging the unconscious soldier on the floor behind him.

Sergei got to his feet and approached the drink cart in the corner of the room. “Drink?”

“Vodka on the rocks.”

He set two glasses down side by side and used the ice tongs to deposit four perfectly shaped ice cubes into them. He picked up a tall crystal tumbler next, pouring its contents into each glass. “I wondered if you’d ever grow the balls to confront me,” he said casually, making his way back over to me.

He was trying to shift it. Take control of the conversation. Wasn’t going to happen.

“Funny. I thought the same thing.” I leaned my elbow against the armrest and held my hand out. Sergei placed the glass in my open palm. “I

wondered if you'd ever grow the balls to stop hiding behind others and come for me yourself."

He chuckled. I waited for him to take a sip before taking one myself. I wouldn't put it past the bastard to try and poison me. "What can I say? In my old age, I've been reluctant to get my hands dirty."

"Can't handle it anymore?"

"Oh, don't worry, Dimitri. As my grandson would say, I can still throw down if I need to."

Of that, I had no doubt. Sergei might have been old, but he was anything but frail and vulnerable. I knew he would never go down easily. That he would do everything he could to ensure that if he was going down, he would drag everyone else down with him.

"Speaking of my grandson, any luck in pinpointing his location?"

I scoffed. "Don't pretend to care. It just wastes your time *and* mine, and my time is very valuable."

"Are you saying mine is not?"

"Yes."

He shook his head. "You know, I have to say, I do not appreciate this newfound level of disrespect you've been exhibiting toward me."

"And I do not appreciate the fact that you had half a dozen of my own soldiers try to kill me in my own home, but, you know, shit happens."

"You mean *my* soldiers. Do not forget, son, everything you have is because of me. I gave it to you, and I can take it back any time I want."

I leveled a hard stare at him. That was only partly true. Yes, everything I had started with him, but he didn't have the power to take it from me. Not anymore.

Sergei smiled broadly and sat back down behind his desk. He took another sip from his glass before putting it down. "I don't know what you're so upset about. You're fine. They clearly failed, so no harm, no foul."

"So, you admit it then? That you're trying to kill me?"

"Aren't *you* trying to kill *me*?"

There was no point denying it. He would see right through it. "Before Lukyan was kidnapped, yes. Now, my only focus is on finding my son."

I didn't even need him to say anything to know he was beyond dissatisfied by that. I'd grown up all my life seeing that look in his eyes. That slightly irritated expression on his face.

“That was always one of the things I was so disappointed in you about, Dimitri.” He picked up a thick brown cigar. “You allowed yourself to have such a pointless and futile weakness. Children are a means to an end. Nothing more. You have two other sons who can carry on the family name. Who cares about what happens to your youngest one? He’s the most expendable out of them all.”

“I care,” I all but growled out.

“Yes, you’ve made that abundantly clear. Another thing I’m incredibly disappointed in you about—broadcasting your weakness like that for the entire world to see. I raised you better than that.” He used a cigar cutter to remove the cap from the end, slicing it straight off. “Honestly, I have no idea where you inherited such a filthy trait from.” He pointed two fingers at me, the cigar balancing effortlessly between them. “You know what? I blame your mother. Such weakness certainly didn’t come from me.”

No. Only my raging paranoia, homicidal tendencies, and the ability to kill without a single shred of remorse came from him.

“We’re not going to talk about my mother. Not now. Not ever.” He wasn’t good enough to even speak her name. “We’re going to talk about me and you.”

“I’m not sure what else there is left to discuss. The moment I am able to dispose of you in a way that does not track back to me or make *me* look bad, I will. I no longer need you, and you have become nothing but a nuisance. You’ve done your part in furthering the Volkov line, and your contribution will be noted.”

“My *contribution*?” Fuck, I wanted to end him. I wanted to fucking *eviserate* him. I never wanted anything more in my life than to kill him right there and then, and the only reason I didn’t was because I knew he had someone watching. Someone ready to burst in at a moment’s notice and either save or avenge him. That was just the way my father worked. He planned for things sixteen moves ahead. Catching him off guard or unprepared was almost impossible, and as much as I despised it, I needed to watch myself. At least until we found Lukyan.

Then, all bets were fucking off.

“Yes,” Sergei continued. “Although minor, your contribution toward my legacy will be, as I said, noted.” He said it so casually. So blasé. Like it was a totally normal thing to say to one’s son.

“I think I contributed to it a lot more than you did, Father.”

Anger streaked through his eyes.

“Let’s put all our cards on the table, shall we?” I was done fucking around. Done with the bullshit and hidden meanings behind everything he did and said. “You want to kill me. I want to kill you. The timing isn’t right, but the moment it is, I’ll be coming for you.”

Sergei smiled, and it was filled with nothing but pure evil. He lit the end of his cigar and took a deep inhale before blowing the smoke out. “I guess we’ll see who wins, won’t we?”

“I guess we will.” The conversation was done. There was nothing left to say. I walked out, marching down the halls of the home I’d grown up in, feeling absolutely no sense of attachment to it whatsoever. I would burn it to the ground the first chance I got.

When I got to my bedroom, I found Autumn lounging comfortably on the three-seater couch, her tablet resting on her thighs as some TV show played, one hand buried deep in the bowl of popcorn at her side.

She glanced over her shoulder and smiled. “Hi, baby.”

The sound of a man groaning in pain reached my ears. I walked further into the room, and when I rounded the couch, I saw our security detail—all four of them—lying helplessly on the floor in front of her. They were stacked up on top of each other, one after the other after the other, and she had her feet resting upon them, her legs crossed at the ankles.

Humor trickled through me.

“How did it go?” she asked, continuing to snack on her popcorn.

My gaze flitted around the room.

“Oh, don’t worry about that.” She picked up a glass of water and showed it to me. Inside it were numerous small devices. “I got sick and tired of having to watch what I say, so I did a thorough sweep of the room and gathered up all the listening devices Sergei had planted.”

I chuckled. “He’ll just replace them.”

“Probably.” Autumn shrugged. “But we’re safe for now until he does.” She placed the glass back down. “So, how did it go?”

“About as expected. Everything is out on the table.” I could tell by the look on her face that she didn’t agree with the plan, but she said nothing, her pursed lips the only sign of her displeasure.

I plopped down next to her and scooped up some popcorn, throwing it into my mouth. “Speak your mind.”

“Was it wise? Telling him you want to kill him? He’ll be even more on alert now.”

“He already knew.” Of that, I was sure. “The moment he threatened Illayana, he would have known he was signing his death warrant with me. No one threatens my children and lives. *Everyone* knows that. By confronting him, I’ve thrown him off guard. I know it. He’s not used to such insubordination. I think it will push him to do something reckless.”

“Like what?”

“I don’t know. Something. Something that will leave him vulnerable.” My phone rang. It was an unknown number, which I usually didn’t answer, but Illayana had told me about a phone call she’d received from an unknown number a few days before. It had been Lukyan. I’d felt instant relief, knowing he was still alive, but it had been squashed quickly when I was told he had given no information as to his whereabouts.

I was running out of time. If I didn’t find him soon, I might never get him back.

“Yes?” I answered. *Please be Lukyan. Please be Lukyan.*

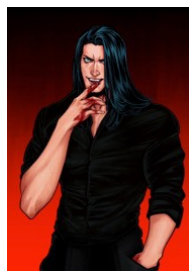
“H-hello, sir. You don’t know me. My name is Tristian. I have information you might want.”

“What information?”

He told me. My whole body came to life. “Where?” I growled.

CHAPTER TWENTY SEVEN

LUKYAN VOLKOV



“*B* ooya!” I slammed the card down. “Draw four, motherfucker.”

Cedric slammed the side of his fist down on the table so hard it shook. He picked up four cards from the deck, adding them to the ones he already had in his hand.

Despite the fact he was kinda keeping me hostage, Cedric was actually a pretty cool dude. Took a while to warm up, sure, but if I was good at anything, it was getting people to open up. He was always around. Kind of like my watcher, making sure I didn’t do anything crazy or stupid while Lyla was away.

It didn’t happen often. Lyla was usually always there, but she had to go and pick up her brother from the airport. I almost managed to convince her to take me, but she was worried about how her brother would react if he saw me. Apparently, the dude didn’t like me. Kinda harsh considering he’d never fucking met me, but whatever.

I think there was also a small part of her that worried I might try to escape. I didn’t feel that desire nearly as much as I should have. I kinda didn’t wanna leave. I liked spending time with her. She was funny. Sweet. Beyond anything I would have ever expected, and I never felt *less than* when I was with her. Never felt like I wasn’t good enough. That I couldn’t *be* myself. That I might say something stupid and get reprimanded. She encouraged me to be exactly who I was, and I cherished that. Had come to depend on it a little.

I knew I couldn’t stay there forever, though. My family needed me. The longer I stayed in that house, the longer my father was at risk. As much as I

was enjoying myself, I needed to go. I planned to talk to Lyla when she got back. We'd spent a lot of time together. We were fucking married, for God's sake, in every sense of the word. I should be able to convince her to let me go.

"Earth to Pretty Boy," Cedric said, clicking his fingers in front of my face.

"Huh?" My thoughts vanished, and I focused back on the game. *Wait a minute.* "Did you just call me pretty?"

He rolled his eyes. "As if you don't know you're pretty."

"Oh, I know. I just never expected *you* to say it." I winked.

"Whatever. What color?" he asked, referring to the game we were playing, Uno. We played a lot of games to pass the time. That was one of the ways I got him to warm up to me. It was either that or sullen silence. No thank you.

"Yellow."

He put down a yellow skip, then a yellow nine.

I put down another draw four.

"What the fuck?!" he yelled, thumping his fist down again. "How do you keep getting those?!"

"Luck." Actually, that was bullshit. I was cheating. I cheated all the time in games. Anyone who knew me knew that. Too bad for Cedric, he hadn't quite figured that out yet. He would eventually, though. There was only a certain number of times someone could win before it became suspicious. "When is Lyla coming back?"

"Why? Miss her already?" he grunted, picking up another four cards and adding them to his hand.

"Kinda, yeah. And I wanna talk to her."

"She won't let you go."

"Red," I said, picking another color. "And why not?"

"Because she's worried you'll never come back." He put down a red six.

I dropped another draw four onto the pile of cards in front of us. "Uno."

"Get. Fucked!" Cedric roared. I never would have pegged him as someone to get so serious in a card game. It was kinda hilarious. Cedric grumbled with each card he picked up from the deck. I had to hold in my snicker. "Would you?" he asked curiously.

"Would I what?"

“Come back.”

I wasn't sure what to say. Or, more specifically, what I wanted him to know. “I can't stay here forever. I've got a family. I've got obligations—”

“I didn't ask if you'd stay here forever. I asked if you would come back.”

“Why do you care? You don't even like me.”

“No. I don't. You're impetuous—”

“My, my, what a big word.”

“Reckless—”

“I prefer the term *adventurous*.”

“And childish, and Lyla loves you. I don't want to see her hurt.”

My insides softened. “I don't *want* to hurt her. I care about her. I do. But my family is in danger. We're in the middle of a war.”

He frowned. “I have a lot of connections in the Bratva. I haven't heard anything about a war happening.”

And he never would. It was an internal war. One between us and my grandfather. No one else *needed* to know. If the other crime organizations knew we were fighting amongst ourselves, they might see it as the perfect opportunity to strike and try to take us down for good.

“Just because you haven't heard of it doesn't mean it's not happening. Blue,” I said, picking a color and continuing the game. I wasn't concerned Cedric would blab about that. He didn't do anything without Lyla's approval.

Cedric put down a blue eight and pursed his lips. “I've known Lyla her whole life, and it took me seeing you two together to realize she has never truly been herself. That she's been living a lie. Don't break her heart.”

I stared at him. He stared at me back, silence reigning between us. I put down my last card—another draw four—winning the game.

It all seemed to click in his head then. “You cheated.”

“Yep.”

“You always cheat.”

“Yep.”

He shook his head, laughing. “Rematch.”

We played a few more rounds of Uno, me winning every single one—we're not really surprised, are we?—before switching to poker. We chatted the whole time, just talking shit and the topic of Lyla. Me leaving didn't resurface, which I was thankful for.

We were halfway through our third game of Texas Hold 'Em when a sound made us both stiffen.

"What was that?" I asked, looking around the lounge room.

Cedric's brows lowered in confusion. "I don't—"

BOOM!

The house shook as an explosive ripped through the front door. Cedric went flying. The concussive blast slammed against my body, sending me hurtling into the couch, causing it to tip over. Disorientation washed over me, followed by pain.

Ow. What the fuck?!

Smoke filled my vision. I coughed, a hand flying to my chest. *Jesus Christ, that hurt.* I sluggishly got to my feet. Soldiers piled into the house, squeezing through the hole in the steel roller doors, armed to the tee. One after the other after the other. I looked around for a weapon, my eyes catching on the poker for the fireplace. I felt like shit, but I had no idea who the soldiers were or what the fuck they were doing there. Arming myself was critical to being able to defend myself.

I picked it up and went to swing at the first soldier within reach—

"Lukyan!"

The poker stopped an inch away from the soldier's head at the sound of my name. I looked behind him. "Father?"

Standing in the foyer, dressed in military gear was my father, Autumn at his side, wearing identical clothing. Relief washed over my father's face as he looked at me. The poker dropped from my hands and clattered to the ground in my shock.

What?

The soldier moved away, and my father was right there, ramming into my body and wrapping his arms around me in the biggest bear hug.

"Thank God," he whispered, squeezing me tighter.

I choked, a flare of pain shooting through me.

"Shit, I'm sorry." He let me go instantly. "Are you okay?" He asked, concerned.

"I'm fine. Just, that blast knocked me on my ass."

"Yeah, I'm sorry about that. We had no choice. It was the only way to get in quickly."

"I'm so glad you're okay," Autumn said, giving me a hug.

He turned to the soldiers still swarming in. "Clear the house!"

“Father.”

He locked eyes with me, the relief swimming in his gaze making me feel guilty. While I’d been enjoying myself, having the time of my fucking life, he’d been suffering.

“What are you doing here?” I asked in a whisper.

His body went rigid at my words. “What do you mean? I’m here to save you.”

Save me. From Lyla. From the woman I love.

Two men came over, carrying an unconscious Cedric. They dropped him at my father’s feet. “House is clear, sir. There’s no one else here. Only him.”

The Butcher reared his head. The change was instantaneous. He went from concerned father to the merciless former leader of the Bratva in the blink of an eye, and it was all directed at Cedric.

“Kill him,” Father spat.

“No, don’t!” I ran forward and blocked Cedric with my body, standing in front of him. “Don’t kill him.”

Father narrowed his eyes. “Why?”

My throat suddenly felt dry. “Because.”

“Because *why*, Lukyan?”

Goddamn it. “Because he’s a cool dude, and I like him.”

“You *like* the man who kidnapped you?” Autumn asked, confused.

“Well, if we’re being specific, *he* didn’t kidnap me. He was more my watcher.”

Father slashed a hand through the air, annoyed. “It doesn’t matter if he was the one who kidnapped you or not. He participated in it. So, he’s dead.” He pulled out his gun.

“No!” I stood taller, staring my father down. “No,” I repeated strongly. More sternly. “Don’t kill him.”

His eyes held mine. I didn’t look away. I couldn’t let him do it. I just couldn’t. Autumn laid a hand on my father’s shoulder, and he turned his head. They stared at each other for a moment before he cursed, putting his gun away.

“Fine,” he all but snarled.

Relief filled my chest.

“Everybody, move out!” The soldiers immediately did as he ordered, filing out of the house. “Let’s go, Lukyan.” He moved away, Autumn

following.

My feet stayed rooted in place. Indecision warred inside me. I'd just been talking about needing to leave. The opportunity was right there, right at my fingertips, and yet, I couldn't make my feet move.

Leaving Lyla, without a single word, didn't sit right with me. Caused a heavy pressure to sit firmly on my chest, making it hard to breathe. The connection she'd been so adamant we shared solidified over my time with her. I couldn't just abandon that. Abandon *her*.

The idea of her returning home to see I'd left...The hurt she'd undoubtedly feel...hurt me. I didn't want to leave her—

"Lukyan." My eyes rose to clash with my father's bright blue ones. A somber expression crossed his face. "Let's go," he said again. There was a layer of concern and worry in his voice. In his words. As if he feared I wouldn't go with him. That I wanted to stay.

*You **do** want to say,* a little voice said inside my head.

But I can't. My family needs me. My father needs me. Lyla will understand that, won't she?

The voice didn't answer me. I didn't need it to. I already knew it wasn't true. Lyla had told me countless times that she was afraid I would leave her, and when she returned to see I was gone, it would break her.

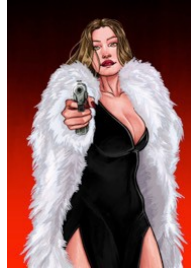
Break me.

"Lukyan." My father's voice was softer this time. More cautious. "Come with me, son. *Please*," he implored. The alarm and fear on his face was what urged me forward.

I walked toward him and left.

CHAPTER TWENTY EIGHT

LYLA VOZNESENKY



“*L*yla!”

I turned at my brother’s loud, excited voice. Lev strode toward me, a laptop bag slung over his right shoulder and a duffel bag dangling from his left hand.

“Lev!” Running the short distance to him, I jumped into his open arms, squeezing him tightly.

A sense of home instantly filled me, and I breathed out a contented sigh. Despite all our differences and disagreements, despite what his presence represented, I was so happy to see my brother. I hadn’t realized how much I’d missed him.

He was a few years older than me, but the stress and hardship of our teen years had aged him well beyond his years. His hair was light and honey-colored like mine, his eyes a similar color as well. He was only a little bit taller than me, coming in at 6’3, with a strong build and wide shoulders.

Lev laughed, returning my hug before stepping back. He went from being the warm, kindhearted brother who took care of me when there was no one else, to the hard, cruel man hell-bent on revenge in the blink of an eye.

“Did you get the information we need?”

No *how are you?* or *what have you been up to?* Just straight down to fucking business. I was compelled to roll my eyes, but refrained. “Yes.” My gaze did a quick sweep of my surroundings. “We should go somewhere more private. We need to talk.”

Lev seemed to finally take in the fact that we were standing in a crowded airport with lots of prying eyes and nosy ears. Given the reach the Bratva possessed, I wouldn't have been surprised if they were having the airports monitored.

Two hulking men appeared behind my brother—part of his security detail, I assumed. He never went anywhere without someone watching his back. “Where are you parked?” he asked.

“Just out front.”

He nodded and began walking toward the exit. I let him lead, even though he had no fucking idea what my car looked like or where exactly it was parked. But Lev loved to lead.

A cold burst of air hit me when we stepped outside. I shivered, pulling my coat tighter around my body. “There,” I said, pointing to the black SUV parked between a taxi and a red sedan.

He made a beeline straight for it. I went to get into the driver's seat.

“No,” Lev said, opening the back door. “Sit back here with me so we can talk.”

I didn't want to. The idea of someone I didn't know driving my car irked me, but I did as my brother asked—*no, demanded*—getting into the back seat. One of the men who'd accompanied him got behind the wheel while the other jumped into the passenger seat.

“Give Kane your address,” Lev said, eyes plastered to his phone.

I was most certainly *not* doing that. I would be giving Kane the address to a decoy house I'd rented in preparation for Lev's visit. There was no way I could take him home to Lukyan. Not until I'd had a chance to explain everything.

I spouted off the address. Kane started the engine and put the address into the navigation before flicking the indicator on and pulling out into the street.

“So where is he?” Lev asked.

“At his father's compound, like we predicted.”

“And the security measures?”

“Extravagant. There will be no way to infiltrate on our own. We'll need an in. My cover was blown.”

His brows snapped together. “I only just gave you that identity. How is it blown already?”

I internally winced. I had to choose my words very carefully. Lev couldn't know how far my obsession truly went. He was liable to have a heart attack if he did.

"One of the maids recognized me." Plausible. Completely plausible. "I thought it better to leave than risk capture."

"Smart. Delivering the information about the compound was more important, and crucial to the success of our mission."

More important than what? My life?

"I'm not sure this is the right course of action anymore, Lev."

He stiffened, his whole body turning to stone. Confusion streaked through his eyes, replaced quickly with anger. "This is because of that fucking kid, isn't it?"

"Lukyan isn't a kid," I gritted out behind clenched teeth.

"Have you seen the way he acts? 'Cause I'd beg to fucking differ."

"He's wild and carefree, *exactly* like me."

He shook his head, his frustration mounting. "I knew I should have given you a different job *the second* I saw how obsessed you got with Lukyan Volkov. I fucking knew it. You're too easily influenced. You allowed that fucker to manipulate you!"

Lev couldn't have given me a different job because he had no one else to do the dirty work for him. No one else he trusted, anyway. The money he'd inherited when he turned eighteen allowed him to hire mercenaries and security guards, but they could only be trusted with his life, never information about his decade-long revenge plan.

"He didn't manipulate me." He did. He totally, totally did. It was just completely unintentional on his part. "I fell in love with him and married him."

"You *what*?!" Lev roared.

I didn't flinch under his harsh tone or his fury-heated gaze. He didn't scare me. Kane's eyes flicked to me in the rearview mirror and then back to the road. His hand moved away from the steering wheel and disappeared around his side.

It didn't take a genius to figure out he'd just palmed his weapon.

I didn't move my eyes from Lev's as I pulled the ring out of my pocket and slid it on my finger. "I married him."

He seemed utterly gobsmacked. "Why the fuck would you do that?! *How* the fuck did you do that? You're telling me you got Lukyan Volkov,

the playboy of the Bratva, who's never been seen with the same woman twice, to agree to marry you?"

"The details of it are not important," I grumbled. He didn't need to know the particulars. All that mattered was that we were married. "And I did it because we're meant to be together."

"No. You did it because you thought it would save him, and it won't," he spat.

My eyes narrowed dangerously. "He's my *husband*, Lev."

"And that means you'll choose him over me? Is that what you're saying? Your own fucking brother?"

I said nothing. The truth of it was, I could never hurt my brother, but I could never allow something to happen to Lukyan either.

"Your problem is with Dimitri. Not his children."

Lev punched the seat in front of him. "When are you going to learn?! *Everyone* knows hurting his children *is* hurting him. It has always been our plan to kill them all. Wait for the best opportunity to kidnap Dimitri, use him as bait to pull all his children in, and then when they come to rescue him, we kill them all in front of him. Make him fucking watch as we cut them up piece by piece. It will absolutely destroy him, having to watch them all die for his sins. You can't just decide to pull out now. I won't allow it."

"*You won't allow it?*" I repeated, aghast.

Lev was older. Bigger. Stronger. But he wasn't better. I knew that, and, more importantly, *he* knew that. Some people were born to give the kill orders, and others were born to implement them. Born to take lives.

Lev was the former; I was the latter. He couldn't beat me, no matter how hard he tried.

Seething anger flared across his face before he was able to mask it. "I would never force you to do something you don't want to do," he tried to clarify, though his words came out rough and strained. "But you can't just back out on me now. Not after all the work we've put into getting here. Dimitri deserves to suffer. I want to *make* him suffer. I want to make him bleed and cry for what he did to me—us."

The image of Papa D crying wasn't really one I could conjure. It was hard to imagine. But I knew if there was one thing in the world capable of making the Bratva Butcher cry, it would be the deaths of his children.

“I just don’t see the point anymore,” I said honestly. “It’s been ten years, Lev, and whether you want to admit it or not, Dad kinda deserved it for what he did to Yekaterina Volkova—”

He slapped me across the face. The shock of it froze me solid. Lev had *never* struck me before, not even when I’d accidentally snipped the top of his ear off when I tried to cut his hair when we were kids. He’d even lied to our father about what happened, saying he’d done it himself to save me from his wrath.

It wasn’t until this moment that I realized he was no longer that brother. Our parents’ deaths had changed him. Molded him into the man sitting in front of me. Someone who once used to protect me, but would now strike me in anger.

“I don’t care how long it’s fucking been,” Lev growled out. “I’m going to make him feel every ounce of pain he’s caused me.”

He’d finally said *me*, not *us*. My cheek felt hot, and I knew if I looked in the mirror, I’d see his handprint clear on my skin.

“Then you’ll have to do it on your own. I want no part in it.” I kept my head high, even knowing he could possibly strike me again. He needed to see I wouldn’t be intimidated into changing my mind.

Lev must have realized that because he completely switched tactics, going from outraged to sad. “You’ve been with me every step of the way. You can’t just abandon me like this. I need you, Laylay.”

Now he was laying on the guilt. *Does he really think I am that fucking stupid?* He only called me that when he was trying to manipulate me into doing something I didn’t want to do.

Kane pulled over, having finally reached our destination, stopping in front of a bunch of apartment complexes. The engine turned off. Silence filled the car.

“Give us a minute, please,” I asked Kane and the other man.

Neither moved.

I should have known they wouldn’t listen to me. I didn’t pay their checks, after all.

I looked at Lev. He held my gaze for a moment before moving it to Kane and flicking his head to the side.

Kane and the other man got out of the car.

“I love you, Lev,” I began immediately, not giving him a chance to talk. “But I’m not going to help you with this. Even if Lukyan wasn’t in the

equation, I still wouldn't help. I've had your back this entire time. I've done everything you've asked, stalking and documenting Dimitri's every move, all hours of the fucking day and night. Being your little lapdog, doing this and that for you like I'm your personal assistant. But I'm done."

"You can't just be done."

"Yes, I can."

"You don't care that he killed our parents?"

"No, I don't." I'd felt that way for a long time, but never had the courage to say it out loud to him. Until then. "I don't care, Lev. I don't care the slightest bit. They were never parents to me. Dad would beat me nearly every single day, and Mom would let him. Neither of them gave a shit about me. Why should I give a shit about them?"

"It's the principle," he hissed. "You don't just *let* someone get away with killing someone you love."

"I don't love them. Never have." I reached for his hands and held them tightly. "I love *you*. I would die for you, Lev. But I can't help you with this. Not anymore. You need to let this go."

He scoffed derisively. "Or what? Are you going to stop me?"

I said nothing, just staring at him.

"I can't believe you," he said, shaking his head. "You know what I'm going to do? I'm going to do you a favor and forget we had this conversation. You're going to take some time and think about what you've said—"

"I'm not a fucking child, Lev, so don't talk to me like one," I warned.

"Well, if you stopped saying stupid and childish things, I wouldn't fucking have to."

I punched him in the nose.

"Christ!" Lev yelled, his head flinging back. "What the fuck, Lyla?!"

"You deserved that and you know it."

He grumbled, holding his busted nose.

I blew out a breath, exhaustion fogging my mind. Though the conversation had pretty much gone exactly as I had expected, it still wasn't the slightest bit enjoyable.

"I'm sorry it has to be this way, Lev. I am. I hate disappointing you."

I hoped he would say that I could never disappoint him. That he understood and accepted my decision. Could almost respect it.

How fucking idiotic of me.

His eyes glazed over with hatred. “Well, you have. I will never forgive you for this, Lyla. *Never.*”

My heart fractured. “I’m sorry you feel that way.” I truly, truly was.

He shook his head. “Get out.”

“Lev—”

“I said, get the fuck out. I’m not staying here with you. I’ll get a hotel room, and figure it out on my own. I don’t need you.”

Yes, he did. So far, I’d done all the legwork. He’d done nothing but issue the orders. I didn’t say that, though. “It’s my car, Lev.”

“Well, it’s fucking mine now,” he growled.

I sighed. “You’re being immature.”

“Yeah. I’m taking a play from your book. Get out, Lyla.”

“You know what, fucking fine.” Maybe he needed a little bit of time to process what I’d said to him. Maybe the best thing I could do was leave, and try to talk to him when he’d had the opportunity to calm down.

I stepped out of the vehicle, holding the door open as I peeked back inside. “I’ll call you later.”

“Don’t fucking bother. Kane!”

His lapdog appeared beside me instantly. “Yes, sir?”

“Get in the car. We’re going to a hotel.”

“Right away, sir.”

“You’re being ridiculous, Lev,” I said as I backed away from the car.

He reached across the back seat and slammed the door shut. He wound the window down next, sticking his head out. “*You’re* being ridiculous!” he said pettily.

“No! You are!”

“You!”

“Call me when you grow up!”

“Call me when you stop being a little brat!”

Why I oughta—

The vehicle sped off. Lev was still stuck out the window. He gave me the finger. I gave it back. The car disappeared around the corner.

“Fuck’s sake,” I blew out. Several pedestrians gave me odd looks as they walked down the footpath. “What?!” I snapped. “You never seen siblings fight before? Mind your own business.”

I pulled my phone out and called Cedric. The phone rang and rang before eventually going to voicemail. I tried again. Still nothing.

“Oh, come on,” I groaned to myself. “I don’t need this shit right now.” I had no idea why he wasn’t answering, but whatever the reason was, it had better be fucking good.

I quickly organized an Uber, and three hours and forty-seven minutes later, the car pulled up in front of my house. My real house.

“Jesus. That’s one hell of a reno job you got on your hands,” the Uber driver said, tearing my attention from my phone.

“Huh?” My face dropped at the sight before my eyes. “What the fuck?!” I jumped out of the car as the Uber driver yelled out, “Please leave five stars!”

Fear and worry punched me in the gut. *What happened? Is Lukyan okay? Is Cedric? Is this why he didn’t answer my call?*

I jumped through the giant fucking hole *IN THE FRONT OF MY HOUSE*, whipping out my gun. The foyer and lounge room were almost completely destroyed. Plaster and wood littered the floors. The furniture was all over the place. Glass crunched beneath my feet with every movement I made.

“Lukyan! Cedric!” I yelled out, my fear going into overdrive. I swung my gaze left to right, searching. I knew the possibility of whoever did this still being there was slim, but I kept my gun up and my senses on high alert as I scanned the area.

“Lyla,” a deep voice groaned from somewhere in the lounge room.

That was when I noticed the body lying amongst the rubble. “Cedric!” I ran over to him, dropping to his side. “Fuck, are you okay? Where does it hurt?”

“Everywhere.” He groaned again. His face and clothes were covered in dirt and dried blood.

I ran my hands over his upper body. He cried out in pain. “Shit. We’ve gotta get you to a hospital. Where’s Lukyan?”

“He’s gone.”

“Gone?” I grunted with excretion as I tried to pick him up, but he was so heavy, it was a struggle. “What do you mean, gone?”

“It—was—his family,” Cedric wheezed out, flinging an arm over my shoulder and attempting to stand. He couldn’t. His legs buckled immediately, and it took all my strength to keep him up. “I—saw them. His—father. The Butcher.”

No. No, no, no. “Lukyan wouldn’t leave. He wouldn’t.”

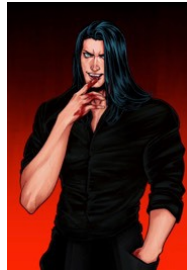
His eyes locked onto mine, a mix of pain and sadness. “I saw him walk out, Lay.”

My whole world came crashing down.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER TWENTY NINE

LUKYAN VOLKOV



The water from the shower cascaded down my back, so hot it was almost scalding. Steam surrounded me so heavily that I could barely see anything around me. I was trapped under the pressure of the water, unable to move, my thoughts all but consuming me.

I should be happy, shouldn't I?

I was finally home. Finally able to do what I'd gone all that way to do, and yet, my mind wasn't at all focused on the task as it should have been.

It was on Lyla.

I couldn't stop thinking about her.

I wondered if she had returned home yet. If she knew I was gone, and if she did, was she okay? Was she upset? Angry? Confused?

I had a feeling she would be all of the above when she found out.

"Fuck," I blew out, leaning against the tiles. Guilt was swirling inside me, potent enough for me to question if I'd done the right thing. If I should have just stayed.

I didn't want Lyla to think I had just abandoned her. That she showed her true self to me, and I just ran at the first chance I got.

But that's exactly what you did, isn't it?

Guilt slammed into me again, and I tried to shake it off.

It wasn't about her. *She should know that, right?* We were in the middle of a war that would forever define us. As much as I wanted to, I couldn't stay locked up in that house forever. I had a duty to my family. An obligation to help.

I wondered how I could fix it.

If she would even forgive me for leaving.

I touched the column of my throat in reminiscence. I missed the collar. *Her* collar. I missed its heavy weight around my throat. Missed what wearing it represented. That I was hers. *Owned* by her.

My brain went into overdrive, trying to come up with solutions—*any* solutions that would repair the giant clusterfuck I found myself in. I stayed in the shower for I didn't even know how long, running through different scenarios in my head. Every one ended with her losing her absolute shit at me.

A wave of sadness rolled through me. I didn't want her to be mad at me. The thought almost made me whimper in despair.

I have to fix this somehow. I have to. I have to—

"Lukyan?"

I pulled myself out of the spiral my thoughts were taking me down, and stuck my head out of the stream of water. "Yeah?" I grunted, wiping a hand down my face.

"You've been in there for a while. You okay?"

It was my father. He stood on the other side of the bathroom door. I could see his shadow through the small crack, and I held in my groan. I just wanted to be alone.

"I'm fine."

"I've got some food out here for you."

Food actually sounded really fucking good. "Any weed?"

His soft laughter echoed through the air. "I can have some brought up."

"That would be great." I didn't smoke a lot. Mainly when I was trying to quiet the voices in my head. They said lots of different things, ranging from homicidal thoughts to degrading ones. When I thought about it, I hadn't had a single disparaging thought since I had been with Lyla. "I'll be out in a minute."

Turning the shower off, I opened the glass door and stepped out. My feet landed on the tiles, but they weren't cold. *Thank God for underfloor heating.* After quickly drying myself off, I wrapped the towel around my waist and walked out of the bathroom.

My father was on the three-seater couch in the center of the room, plates of food sitting on the coffee table in front of him. The smell of something delicious and hearty hit my nose. Whatever it was, it was exactly what I needed.

He smiled warmly at me.

“Stop looking at me like that. It freaks me out.” I sat down on the single chair beside the couch and lifted the cloche over the food. Meat and vegetables. Was there anything better?

He frowned. “Like what?”

“All nice and shit. It’s weird.”

He huffed and leaned back, crossing his ankle over his knee. “I can’t be nice?”

“You?” I scoffed, spearing a cube of meat before putting it into my mouth. “No.”

“Rude, but after everything you’ve been through, I’ll allow it.” Father watched me as I ate, studying me with that freaky eeriness he possessed. “So? Tell me about her.”

My spine stiffened. “What?”

He gave me a *who you tryin’ to fool* kinda look. “What’s her name? You did learn her name after all that time, right?”

“How long was I gone?”

“Ten days.”

“Felt like longer.” Way, way longer. I guessed that was normal. During those ten days, we’d spent every single day together. Connecting. Laughing. Kissing. Touching—

“So?” my father questioned again. “What’s her name?”

I looked down at my hands. “Lyla,” I whispered. I couldn’t hide the emotion in my voice even if I tried.

“Hm.” His finger tapped idly on the armrest. He cocked his head, studying me diligently.

I avoided his gaze and kept eating. “What’s been happening here?” I asked—an oh-so-obvious attempt to change the subject.

“I don’t think so,” he said, shaking his head. *Damn*. “We’re going to talk about this.”

“Do we have to?”

“Yes.” There was no debate on the matter. He was using his *Pakhan* voice, even though the fucker wasn’t even *Pakhan* anymore.

“What if I don’t want to?” I picked up the cloche covering another plate of food. It was a big bowl of creamy carbonara pasta. *Yum*.

“Is there a reason why?”

“No.” Yes. I worried how he would react when he found out who Lyla was. Feared it might dredge up the past he had worked so hard to put behind him. It didn’t bother *me* who she was. But my father? I honestly didn’t know.

He sighed, shaking his head again. “When are you going to learn? You can’t lie to me.” Actually, I could. There were things I’d been hiding for a while. From everyone. I was an excellent liar when the occasion called for it. “Let me tell you what *I* think happened. I think you spent some time with her, and now you like her. Lyla. The woman who tricked you into marrying her and kidnapped you.”

I said nothing, twirling my fork into the pasta. The spaghetti wrapped around the utensil, and I shoved it into my mouth. “That would be a fair assumption.”

His foot slammed onto the ground, and he leaned forward, forearms resting on his thighs. “What kind of *like* are we talking about here?” he asked seriously. “A passing like? An *I like to fuck her and that’s it* like—”

“An *all-consuming* like,” I answered honestly.

He stared at me for a moment. “I see.”

A knock sounded at the door.

“Enter,” my father called out. A man walked in, carrying a small tin case. He handed it over and left without a word. Father passed it to me. I opened it to see three perfectly rolled joints and a small lighter inside.

I plucked one out and lit it. Inhaling deeply, I let the substance fill me. It didn’t help nearly as much as I was hoping it would.

“It doesn’t matter anyway,” I said, taking another drag. “I’m not sure if she’ll forgive me.”

“Forgive you for what?”

“For leaving.”

If the situation were reversed, I’d be pretty pissed, too, if I found out she’d left without a word. I couldn’t even deny that.

“Leaving...the house she was keeping you locked up in?” my father asked, searching for clarification.

“Yes. She has a possessive streak that rivals anyone I’ve ever met, and is prone to spontaneous acts of violence.”

“And you like that.” It wasn’t a question, and he said it with zero judgment. My father knew me very well.

“I love it. But like I said, she won’t forgive me. She trusted me, and I let her down the first opportunity I could.” Why didn’t I leave a note or something? Scribble something down and tell her I wasn’t leaving forever. Just to sort out this family shit. That I would be back for her. Why?

Everything had happened so quickly I didn’t think of doing it at the time, and now, I was kicking myself for it.

“Why don’t you call her? Explain the situation?” he asked, trying to help. I appreciated it, but—

“I don’t have her number.” Lyla was sneaky. She had numerous burner phones, and I wasn’t sure which one she used as her primary. I highly doubted any of them survived the blast anyway.

“Well, that’s an easy fix. Nikolai can find that out for you, can’t he?” He pulled out his phone. “What’s her full name? I’ll text it to him and get him right on it.”

I hesitated.

Father looked up at me when I said nothing. “What?”

I didn’t want to tell him, but I knew I had to. I loved Lyla. I wanted to be with her. There was no question about it. If we had any chance, I had to tell my family who she was and hope they would all be okay with it. The moment I had been fearing for so long was finally here, and it terrified me.

I took another deep drag of my joint. Instead of liquid courage, it was smoke courage.

“Her name is Lyla Voznesensky.”

He stiffened, going deathly still.

“Her father was responsible for Mother’s death. She was just a kid at the time, and you dropped her and her brother off at an orphanage—”

“I remember,” he said roughly.

It all came tumbling out like word vomit. I was powerless to hold it back any longer. I told him everything—minus the kinky sex stuff, of course. I told him all about her relationship with her father. That Lyla didn’t care that he’d killed him. If anything, she was glad for it. That Lyla wasn’t looking for revenge—just in case he assumed she was. I told him about how we connected, having endured the same feelings growing up. Feeling like we were too much. Too crazy. Too unpredictable. Like we were a constant disappointment to the ones we loved.

Father listened in silence throughout the whole thing, his face softening in sadness at the mention of the *too much* talk. When I was done, I felt a

little better. Like speaking my mind had made the pressure squeezing my chest lighten just a fraction.

I kept my head down, my eyes locked on my clasped hands, almost too afraid to look up and see his face. What would I find there? Betrayal for consorting with the daughter of the man who murdered my mother? Disappointment for allowing myself to be in that position in the first place? Sadness over the fact that I was hesitant to return to my family?

I honestly wasn't sure, and it terrified me.

"Do you love her?"

I finally looked up. None of the things I'd feared were showing on his face. Just compassion and understanding.

"Yeah," I got out roughly. *For far longer than anyone even knows.*

Father nodded and leaned back, releasing a big sigh. "I get it," he began softly. "I get what it feels like to love someone you think you shouldn't love. To care for someone you never thought you would care for. It's confusing. But it can also be one of the best things to ever happen to you. If you truly care about this woman, if she makes you happy, that's all that matters to me."

Relief settled deep in my chest. "It doesn't bother you? Who she is? Who...who her father was?" I asked with trepidation.

"She's not responsible for the actions of her father. Just like you're not responsible for mine."

"Do you think the rest of the family will care?"

At that, Father's brows snapped together in thought. "I think Aleksandr and Nikolai will understand. Illayana? Well...that could go either way."

"True." I took three quick puffs of the joint before extinguishing it. With the assurance that Lyla would be accepted by my father, I nodded at him. "Okay. Let's get Nikolai on it. I need to talk to her. Explain things."

"Consider it done. It will also be the perfect opportunity for me to let them all know you're safe."

I raised my eyebrows. "You haven't told them yet? I've been back for hours."

"I knew if I did, they'd want to talk to you immediately. I had a feeling you might need a moment to get yourself acclimated."

I appreciated that. He was right. There was so much going on in my mind. I needed time to collect myself. Get my wild and chaotic thoughts under control.

I allowed myself another moment to think about Lyla. To think about her face. Her touch. Her smell. The softness of her skin. The craziness of her brain. To think about how the fuck I was going to explain myself to her when I finally saw her again. And I *would* see her again. I refused to believe anything else. I thought about it all one last time, and then, I let the next problem take root, no matter how hard it was to focus on. The only reason I did it was because I had no choice.

Sergei.

“I want to see Grandfather.”

Father stiffened. “What? *Now?*”

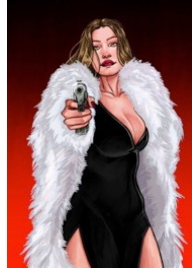
“Yes. Now.” I cracked my neck left, then right. There was no better time than the present to finally complete the last step in my plan. “Is he here?”

Father hesitated briefly, almost as if he didn’t want to answer me, fearing what was about to happen. “He’s in his office.”

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER THIRTY

LYLA VOZNESENSKY



“*H*e left! He just fucking left! I mean, who does that?! Who just leaves without a word? That’s rude, right?! Don’t you think that’s fucking rude?!”

The blond man lying helplessly on the floor of the dirty basement groaned. His companion—another man with short dark hair and bushy eyebrows—clutched at his bleeding stomach beside him, his face distraught and full of fear.

After I’d taken Cedric to the hospital, I took a walk around town. He had to stay for a few days to recover. He’d received several broken ribs, a bruised spine, and internal bleeding. Apparently, he’d been standing when the blast hit, sending him flying and causing most of his injuries. Cedric was going to be okay, thank god, but it was imperative that he rest and recuperate.

While taking care of him, I had to put Lukyan out of my mind, as hard as that was to do. I had to focus on Cedric and get him help as quickly as possible. But the moment I left the hospital, all those hot, volatile emotions simmering beneath my skin had come bursting out like an erupting volcano. It just so happened the world was looking out for me because it provided the perfect opportunity for me to vent my frustrations.

I’d stumbled across Dickhead One and Dickhead Two over there trying to rape a woman in an alley as I strolled through town. I stopped them, and decided they needed a little extra punishment before they met their end. One of the adjacent buildings just so happened to be abandoned. So, I’d dragged their pathetic asses down to the basement, and voilà.

“I did so much for him! So much! I saved his fucking life, and he what?! Just abandons me the first chance he gets?! After everything”—I stabbed Bushy Eyebrows in the leg—“I”—again—“fucking”—again—“did!”

Bushy Eyebrows cried out in pain with each strike I inflicted on him.

“I mean, is it too much to ask for a little goddamn loyalty?! Huh?! Is it?!”

His friend watched on with terrified eyes. “N-no. No, it’s not,” he agreed.

“Thank you!” I ripped out my blade, blood splattering onto my cheek, and flicked my hair out of my face. Taking a deep breath, I tried to reign in my ever-growing temper. “Look, I’m not totally unreasonable here. Of course, I can understand where he’s coming from. What a difficult position he might have been in. But to leave without a fucking word?! Nothing?! Just poof! Fucking gone! You understand, right? You understand why I’m so pissed off?”

Blondie nodded, the movement shaky and fearful. “You have every right.”

“I do, don’t I?!” I got to my feet in a huff and started pacing. It was nice, having my feelings validated, even if they were from some asshole rapist.

My boots splashed in the small puddles of water on the cement floor. The air stank of bile and rotten food. It didn’t bother me. I’d long ago become desensitized to peculiar smells.

“I don’t know what to do now. A part of me wants to track him down and drag him back by his fucking hair, but I’m mad at him, you see? *He’s* the one in the wrong. Not me! *He* should be the one to come groveling back. I shouldn’t have to go chasing after him, should I?!”

He agreed very quickly, swallowing nervously. “No, you shouldn’t.”

“You’re quite understanding, Bert. Can I call you Bert?”

He frowned. “My name is Lewis.”

I stopped pacing and stared at him.

“Bert is fine,” he amended swiftly.

I nodded, satisfied, and went back to pacing. “Oh! And another thing! He told me he understood me. That he would still love me if I was a worm, but that clearly wasn’t true because he left the first chance he fucking got!”

I lashed out, kicking an empty wooden crate in frustration. It did nothing to quell my anger.

Bushy Eyebrows began to cry. “Please,” he croaked. “I need—an—ambulance. I’m going to bleed out.”

“And I should care why? Be quiet. Can’t you see I’m trying to sort through my emotions here?!” I swung my leg in a powerful roundhouse kick, his head whipping to the side at the contact. He slumped, passed out.

I moved over to Bert. He shriveled back, pressing himself into the wall behind him as I crouched in front of him. My arms dangled over my knees, one hand clasping my knife, blood dripping from the blade. “You’re a guy, Bert. Tell me, is this normal *guy* behavior? Straight up abandoning the person they love when it conveniences them?”

His gaze darted left to right anxiously. “Uh, well, um—”

“It’s a yes or no question, Bert. What’s with all the umming and ahhing?”

“Some men have commitment issues?” he asked, his voice rising slightly with uncertainty.

“Commitment issues?” I sat down and crossed my legs, leaning forward intently. “Tell me more.”

“Well...uh...sometimes, guys can have a problem settling down.”

Interesting. “Why?” I cocked my head. “If they’re soulmates, they should want to settle down with them, right?”

Bert looked around again, as if he wanted to be anywhere but there with me. I didn’t know why. I was a fucking delight. “It’s hard to say without knowing the man. For some, it could be something to do with a past trauma. Fear of putting themselves in a vulnerable position where they could get hurt again. Or—” He snapped his mouth shut, and it made me straighten, eyeing him suspiciously.

“Or what?”

Bert shook his head. “I don’t want to answer.”

I stabbed him in the shoulder. He screamed, crying out in pain. Tears started to stream down his face.

“Orrrrr?” I pressed on.

When he shook his head again, I began twisting, slowly rotating the blade deeper into his flesh.

“Ahhh! Or he wants to keep fucking other people! Or he wants to keep fucking other people! God! Stop! Stop!”

I stopped. Not because he asked. Because his words gave me pause.

“No. He wouldn’t do that.”

Would he?

I cursed and yanked out my blade, going right back to pacing. Pacing made me feel better. Bert cried out and clutched at his shoulder painfully. Blood seeped between his fingers.

“He wouldn’t do that,” I said again, this time more to myself than Bert.

“Okay!” Bert yelled. “I don’t even know the guy! If you say he wouldn’t do that, then he wouldn’t do that! Just, please! Stop this! Let me go! I’m sorry, alright? I’m sorry for what I did. I didn’t mean to hurt that girl. It was an accident—”

I scoffed. “You ‘accidentally’ held her down and tried to stick your cock in her while she kicked and screamed for you to stop? Yeah, sounds about right. Shut the fuck up, or I’ll cut your dick off before I kill you.”

Bert’s lips slammed closed.

Bushy Eyebrows released a pain-filled gasp, and then he stopped breathing.

“Well, he’s dead.” I laughed.

“You’re *evil*,” Bert spat.

“Rich, coming from you.” I sighed, shaking my head. “I think it’s time you join him.”

“No! No, wait!” His body trembled with fear, and he tried to crawl away. He wouldn’t get far. I’d severed both their Achilles heels to ensure they wouldn’t be able to escape. I continued toward him. “Advice! You want advice, right?!” I halted. My fingers itched around the handle of my blade, eager to slice. Stab. Kill. “I-I can give you advice,” he rushed out quickly.

“Can you?”

“Yes! Yes, I can! I can—” He choked, spitting out blood. His gaze dropped to the knife I’d just thrown at his chest.

“I don’t need your advice. I just needed someone to vent my frustrations out on.” And he’d delivered to a tee.

Bert whimpered, an almost sad and painful sound falling from his lips before he flopped to the ground. I walked over and pulled my knife from his chest, wiping the blood drenched along the blade on my sleeve before holding it up in the air.

The letters *LV* were etched into it.

It was Lukyan's blade—the one I'd taken from his room. Seemed only fitting to kill with it, since he was responsible for my shitty fucking mood.

Killing Dickhead One and Two had made me feel a little better, sure, but not immensely. I was still struggling. Struggling with my thoughts and the idea that I didn't matter as much to Lukyan as he did to me.

It hurt.

It hurt a lot.

What am I supposed to do now?

You know where he is, a small voice in my mind taunted. *Go get him back.*

Yes. I did know. He'd be at his grandfather's estate. Of that, I was sure. But why should *I* be the one to seek him out? Like I'd said to Bert, *I* was the one mad at *him*.

Even if I wanted to, I couldn't. The security measures at Sergei's house had been bumped up drastically since I was last there. There was no way I could break in on my own. I'd need help. I'd need—

I groaned, running a hand down my face.

I'd need Lev.

Exhaling heavily and stomping my foot in a, yes, tantrum, I pulled out my phone and dialed his number before I had the chance to talk myself out of it.

"Have you stopped being a brat?" he answered.

"Wha—fuck you! No, wait, Jesus, fuck. Just wait." I took a deep breath in, trying to center myself. "Hello, Lev."

"Hello, Lyla. Have you stopped being a brat?"

I growled. "Yes." I would have asked if he had grown up, but it would have been counterproductive. "I need to talk to you. Where are you?"

"Where are *you*? I'll send Kane to collect you." I sent him the address of the abandoned building, and within thirty minutes, Kane arrived, parking in the alleyway.

"Get in," he grunted, opening the passenger door from the inside of *my motherfucking car*.

I did.

He did a sweep of my appearance, but made no comments. I was aware I had blood in my hair and staining my hands. I didn't give a fuck. Let it be a warning that I was in a pissy mood and liable to fucking snap any second. He handed me a black blindfold. "Put this on."

Arching an eyebrow, I turned to look at him. “Why?”

“Your brother’s orders. Either you put it on or we don’t go.”

I didn’t have the mental capacity to fight about it. I was sure Lev would eventually explain. I put it on.

After a length of time I had no way of keeping track of, we stopped. Kane removed the blindfold, and I took note of where we were.

Fucking nowhere.

We were in the bush, surrounded by darkness and trees. The headlights from the car provided the only light, illuminating a rustic old house in front of us.

“Your brother is inside.”

I gave Kane a two-finger salute. “Thanks for the lift. I hope being my brother’s bitch pays well.”

“It does. But I guess you wouldn’t know because you did it for free.”

Oh, that was a good one.

I wasn’t going to tell him that, though.

I got out and went inside.

The inside looked about as good as the outside. It was a rundown kind of place. There were holes in the walls and floors. Mold grew everywhere. Dirt and dust littered nearly every surface. In fact, I wouldn’t have been surprised if the roof caved in at any second. It was clear no one had lived there in a very long time.

A bunch of men I didn’t know were in what looked to have once been the living room, based on the worn-out couches they were sitting on. More mercenaries, I assumed. They were all lounging around, relaxing. I didn’t pay them the slightest bit of attention. Who they were or what they were doing there didn’t matter to me in the least.

“Your brother is in the last room on the left, down the end of the hall.”

Kane grunted as he shut the front door behind him.

I thanked him and went straight to where he directed.

Lev stood in front of a whiteboard when I entered the room. He had showered recently, his hair still wet and the faint traces of body wash lingering in the air. He took one look at me, glancing over his shoulder, and scoffed.

“Let me guess,” he started, an arrogant smirk plastered on his face as he flipped the whiteboard to the other side. “Your precious little Lukyan left you, didn’t he?”

I squeezed my hands into tight fists to refrain from punching him in the fucking teeth. “I don’t want to hear it, Lev.”

“Well, too bad, ’cause you’re gonna hear it. I told you so, Lyla. I fucking told you so. But do you ever listen to me? No.”

“I listen to you all the time, you bastard.”

“Not recently, you haven’t.”

Unable to keep the sadness in my soul at bay any longer, my shoulders slumped, tears stinging the backs of my eyes.

“Oh, Lyla.” Compassion filled my brother’s voice. He came over to me, wrapping me up in his arms. “I hate seeing you so upset. It breaks my heart.”

This was the Lev I loved. The Lev who actually gave a shit about me. The loving, caring big brother I’d grown up with.

“He just left,” I whispered sadly. My emotions, already low from the events of the past twenty-four hours, plummeted even further. “After everything we’ve been through, he just left, Lev. Like I didn’t matter at all.”

“It’ll be okay. It will all be okay, I promise,” he said, trying to reassure me. “I’ll make sure he dies nice and slow for you.”

That shocked me out of my depressed thoughts. “What?” I breathed. I pushed back out of his embrace. “No, I don’t want you to kill him, Lev!”

“You don’t?” he questioned, frown on his face. “Isn’t that why you’re here?”

“I want you to help me get him *back*.”

“Oh, for fuck’s sake, Lyla,” he hissed, stomping away. “You can’t be serious. You still want that fucker? You just said he abandoned you!”

“Yeah, well, there were extenuating circumstances. He’s got a lot of family shit going on at the moment—”

He swiped a hand through the air angrily. “Stop making excuses for him. They’re all the same, those Volkovs. Nothing but backstabbing, murderous bastards.”

There was no point touching that, so I skipped right over it. “I know where he is. He’s at his grandfather’s estate. I can’t break in there on my own. Not without getting caught. I need your help. Please, big brother.”

Lev looked at me, his eyes simmering with calculation. “I’ll help you,” he began, and I almost fainted from relief. “But *you* have to help *me* in return.”

I knew what he was referring to, but still, I had to ask. “With what?”

“Dimitri.” An evil, vindictive smile graced his lips. “I want his head. You agree to bring that to me, and I’ll help you get your *precious* Lukyan back.” He said *precious* with derision, like the word was almost sickening to him.

I couldn’t. Lukyan would never forgive me for *that*. He may never forgive me once he found out I played a part in trying to kill his father, even if it was only gathering intel.

Lev took my silence as compliance and nodded, satisfaction sweeping across his face. “Lucky for you, I’ve already been planning an infiltration. Given your traitorous act, I was forced to come up with a new plan. I won’t get everything I want, but at least I will get Dimitri. I just have to wait for the signal, and we’ll be going in.”

“Signal?” I frowned. “What signal? And from who?”

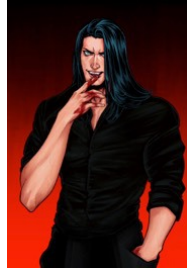
A loud, droning noise hit the air. Lev tensed, and for the first time in years, he genuinely smiled. He pulled something out from around his neck, hidden in his shirt. It was some sort of pendant, circular in design, attached to a black rope. It was lit up like a Christmas tree, blaring that annoying fucking noise throughout the room.

“What the fuck is that?” I asked, confused.

The smile never left his face.

CHAPTER THIRTY ONE

LUKYAN VOLKOV



*I*kicked the soldier guarding the door to my grandfather's office right in the chest. He went flying, his back smashing into the door, causing it to swing open. The soldier landed in a heap on the floor, and I stepped in.

"Hi, Grandfather."

Sergei was sitting on a big leather chair that faced the window along the far wall. His head turned toward me, and he sighed. "You're definitely your father's son."

I had no idea what that was about, and quite frankly, I didn't care enough to ask. "Needed to talk to you, and Sir DicksAlot over there wouldn't let me in."

"There is a reason for that. I want to be alone."

I put a hand to my heart in mock hurt. "Grandpappy, you wound me. I've been missing for ten days. Were you not concerned?"

"Not really."

"At least you're honest."

I grabbed the soldier by his boots and dragged him out of the office before shutting the door. Wiping my hands together, I walked further into the room. There were two chairs parked right in front of the desk. I hauled one over and plopped it right in front of Sergei. It obstructed his view, which, by the pursed lips, I could tell annoyed him, but whatever.

Exhaling heavily, I sat down and crossed my ankle over my knee. Silence followed. I didn't talk. Neither did Sergei. There were a few

indicators that told me he didn't see me as a threat. Not even right then, at that moment.

One, his body was relaxed and calm, not even the *slightest* hint of discomfort.

Two, he knew I was armed. My blade was clearly visible, and he made no move to arm himself just in case.

And three, he was wearing his glasses.

In the past, he'd been very careful not to wear them out in public or around other people. I'd seen him quickly whip them off numerous times whenever my father or Aleksandr entered his office unexpectedly.

He didn't even bother to hide them with me.

It worked to my advantage, sure, but it pissed me off a little to be so clearly underestimated.

The silence continued. He stared at me. I stared back. Sergei was trying to make me uncomfortable with that harsh, penetrating gaze, but it wouldn't work. Everyone else might fear him, but I didn't. Hadn't for a very long time.

I decided to be the first one to speak. "How much longer are you going to let this go on?"

"Let what?"

"This beef you have with Father. Surely, you can see how much it's affecting business."

He narrowed his eyes. "What would *you* know about that?"

I knew a lot more than anyone thought. "You're stretching yourself thin, Grandpappy," I said, my voice light and playful—exactly how he hated it. "And because of that, your game is slipping. You're in trouble," I sang.

Anger rolled over his eyes. "*I am not in trouble*," he growled.

"There's no need to lie, Grandpappy. It's only me. The useless, *expendable* grandson, remember? Who cares what I think?"

At that, he seemed to relax a touch. Kind of like an *oh, yeah, that's right* kind of moment. It was what I wanted. I didn't want him to know how drastically he'd underestimated me.

Not just yet.

"You've had a few deals go wrong, haven't you? It happens to the best of us, don't worry. It's nothing to be ashamed of."

"And why would you think that?"

"People talk."

“Not my people, or they’d lose their tongues.”

I had to admit that Sergei might be a dick, but he said some badass stuff sometimes.

“You’re right,” I admitted, nodding. “Your people know better than to discuss the particulars of your business. Even your clients know better. But there’s people out there who *don’t* know that.” I’d done an extensive investigation into his work over the last six months, including talking to people he might have overlooked.

I shifted the chair a touch closer. He didn’t notice. “You’re a paranoid man, Grandfather, but you’re also a man of habit. You’ve grown predictable.”

His mouth compressed into a hard line. He didn’t deny it, and I wondered if perhaps he agreed with me, yet refused to admit it.

“Do you want me to tell you where you went wrong? I’ll tell you where you went wrong,” I said quickly, answering my own question. “There were people lurking around when you conducted your deals. People you and your men ignored because you thought they weren’t a threat.”

He frowned. “No, there weren’t.”

I smiled broadly. “Yes, there were.” I knew because *I’d* placed them there. The moment my father told me his plan to kill Sergei, I’d decided to do a little...preemptive strike, as it were. My grandfather was a powerful man, with an almost infinite reach. It had been decades since he’d last been challenged, and that amount of time with no pushback tended to make people complacent.

There were homeless people on nearly every corner of every street, all up and down the major cities of Russia. These were people who had to fight to survive every single day. Who had to hustle day in and day out to find a place to sleep. To find something to eat. Homelessness was a serious problem not only there but everywhere around the world. Those were people who had been hard done by. Life had kicked them down, and they were struggling to find their feet again.

I’d been lucky enough to be born into a family that was able to provide for me. Provide a roof over my head, clothes on my back, and food in my belly. Some people weren’t so lucky, and I felt for them. Always tried my hardest to give back by helping them whenever I saw them.

A lot of others overlooked them. Ignored them. Pretended they didn’t even see them.

Which made them the perfect informants.

"I've been having you watched for six months, and you didn't even know it." I laughed. "Not only that, but *I've* been the one responsible for all those deals going wrong."

His spine snapped straight. "You *what?*"

"Calm down, it's not what you think. I didn't betray the family. All those supplies that were stolen from you were just stolen by me, that's all. No biggie."

Steam might as well have been coming out of his ears, he was so angry. "You little—Everit!"

I looked around the room. "Oh, is that the name of the dude you have monitoring us next door? Yeah, he's dead."

Sergei blinked, his face a mask of shock.

My father told me about how Sergei would always have someone watching his meetings, his office, just in case one of his own people tried to kill him. Everit, as I'd just come to discover, was that man. Before coming into Sergei's office, I'd made a little pit stop and sliced his throat so he would be unable to raise any alarm.

I didn't want to be rushed. I was going to take my time with it.

Savor it.

"Now, where was I?" I clicked my fingers. "Ah, that's right. My plan. Silly me. So, I thought to myself, how do you take down someone so evil, so conniving they would try to murder their own family? You have to do it in stages, you see. Break them down, piece by piece. First, I fucked with your business. I had people watching you every time you left the house, monitoring where you went. Who you saw. What you did." I ticked off each thing with my fingers, one by one. "When a delivery was set, I orchestrated for it to be taken. This, of course, set you on edge."

Which was exactly what I wanted. One couldn't just take down a man of Sergei's caliber with brute force. It had to be done meticulously.

His jaw clenched. I could almost swear a flicker of worry streaked across his face.

"With you on edge, you became more erratic. More unstable. More volatile. You remember what you did during those first few months when deliveries were going missing, right?"

He didn't answer, not that I really expected him to. That was fine. Months and months of planning had led to this moment, and I was more

than happy to continue with my reveal without his input. I felt like one of those villains in an action movie when they give a big, long speech about how they'd thwarted the hero with their grand master plan.

And I didn't care.

It was my time to motherfucking shine. To show him and everyone else just how much they'd all underestimated me and the geniusness that was my brain.

"You killed half your people, Sergei!" I exhaled, shaking my head. "You thought you had a snitch in your ranks. You were so adamant about it that when people told you they had nothing to do with it, you didn't believe them. You went a little cuckoo, and coming from *me*, that's saying something."

I stood, stretching out my body. Sergei watched me with the eyes of a predator. *Finally*. He was finally seeing me for who I was—a fucking wolf in sheep's clothing.

"Because you had so many deals go wrong, your clients were starting to doubt you. Doubt your business. And that drove you *maddddd*. Sent you spiraling even further down into that paranoid abyss. Your deal with the Tarasovs was made before I'd started implementing my plan. Something I assumed you looked into to help stretch your reach even further. But as time went on, and your shit just kept getting taken, it ended up becoming the most important deal for you because it provided you a new means to get the merchandise to your clients.—one you thought was not compromised. It was going to right everything for you. Fix everything for you. But the damage was done, wasn't it?"

I spotted a drink cart in the corner. I poured myself a drink and took a sip, swirling the liquid in my mouth before swallowing it. I deposited the empty glass back down onto the cart and continued.

"You lost numerous contracts because of your inability to fulfill them. With your business and your reputation damaged, the first half of my plan was a smashing success." I didn't just want to kill Sergei. I wanted to *ruin him*. Nothing was more important to that man than his legacy. How people saw him. I wanted to take that away from him before he died. I wanted Sergei to fucking *suffer* for everything he'd done to my family. "The second part of my plan, well, I think it's even more devious than the first."

For the first time, Sergei spoke. For the entire time I'd known him, he'd been an unmovable force. Strong. Powerful. Stoic. Suddenly, he looked his

age. Fragile and weak.

“What did you do?” he whispered.

“I fucked with your mind. You have a yearly appointment with your physician, don’t you?”

He sucked in a harsh breath. “You didn’t.”

I smiled. “I did. You’re not dying, Sergei. You’re actually fit as a fiddle. The medication you’ve been taking has been making you *worse*, not *better*. Drug-induced paranoia is a serious thing, and something you’ve been suffering with for a while.”

It took a lot of manipulating on my part, but it was all worth it. I had to pay off several doctors and nurses to get what I wanted, and it all came from my own personal cash. It was worth every penny, if you asked me.

It had been so hard to keep it all to myself. To not utter a single word of my plan to anyone over the past six months. I knew if I told my siblings or my father my idea, they wouldn’t hear a bar of it. They would think it wouldn’t work. That it was a silly plan to try and implement, and it would all be because it came from *me*.

So, I’d said nothing. To anyone. Just worked in the background to tarnish my grandfather in every aspect of his life.

It had all worked out perfectly. His own men were terrified of him because he was a loose cannon. Liable to snap and kill anyone he deemed as a threat, which, thanks to the drugs, was everyone in his orbit. His clients didn’t trust him to fulfill their orders anymore thanks to all the failed deals.

Everything had gone according to plan. There was just one thing left to do.

I crouched down in front of him. Sergei was in such a shocked trance he didn’t move. Didn’t acknowledge how close I had suddenly gotten to him. Astonished, bright blue eyes locked onto me.

“How did you do this?” he asked in bewilderment.

Not *why did you do this*, but *how*. How did I, Lukyan Volkov, the half-wit of the family manage to orchestrate one of the best takedowns in Mafia history?

My eyes darkened as the beast that stayed locked up inside me was finally set free.

Sergei’s eyes widened. “You’re—”

I stabbed him in the chest. He choked, sucking in a painful breath. My head tilted to the side in curiosity. “Do you see me now, Grandfather?” I

whispered darkly. “Do you see the man that I am?”

His hand clamped around my wrist, trying to remove the knife. I held on tight, refusing to let it budge, and grabbed him by the hair, forcing his head up so his gaze would stay locked with mine.

“I want you to look at me,” I whispered, slowly pressing the blade in deeper and deeper. “I want you to look into the face of the man responsible for ruining your entire legacy. Everything you worked so hard to achieve. It was all destroyed by *me*. The grandson you deemed a liability. The grandson you underestimated. You’re going to die today, Sergei, and you’ll die knowing it was *me* who took you down.”

Blood began to slowly seep out of his mouth and down his chin. Eyes burning with hatred, he bared his teeth at me. I had to give it to the old fart, he was one tough motherfucker.

His hand moved again, and I tensed, preparing to block any attack he might try and inflict on me in his last dying moments. But he didn’t attack. His hand wandered up and disappeared beneath the collar of his shirt.

A pendant of some sort was gripped between his fingers.

I cocked my head to the side. *What is that?*

A triumphant smile graced his lips as he pressed it. It lit up, bright and shining, and emitted a loud, ear-piercing droning noise.

Dread settled deep in my body. Whatever that thing was, it wasn’t good. I yanked it off his neck and backed away, inspecting it. “What is this? What did you do?” I pushed it again and again, hoping it might undo whatever it was designed to action, but even I knew it was hopeless.

When I looked back at him, he was slouched in his chair, my blade still stuck firmly in his chest. His eyes were vacant. Lifeless. Sergei was dead, but he’d died with that fucking smile on his face.

I looked down at the pendant in my hands again. *What is going on—*

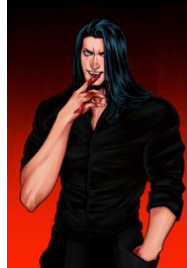
The door to his office burst open. Mr. Average stood in the doorway, chest heaving, panic in his eyes. The same pendant in my hands was around his neck— lit up exactly like Sergei’s.

His gaze snapped to my grandfather, taking in his dead, lifeless form, and then back to me.

He lunged.

CHAPTER THIRTY TWO

LUKYAN VOLKOV



“Oh, shit.”

His body rammed into me and hit me with the force of a fucking freight train. He picked me up in a running tackle and slammed me up against Sergei’s desk. A knife came speeding toward my face.

I blocked it just in time, holding it away from my eye.

“What the fuck, Mr. Average?! I thought we were friends!”

Vernon growled, trying to drive the knife forward and pierce my stunning blue eyes. How dare he! They were my best feature!

While holding his wrists in place to ensure the blade didn’t get any closer, I swung my elbow up in a swift move, hitting him in the jaw. He barely moved. Barely fucking felt it. I hit him again and again, and still, the blade kept coming, inching closer and closer to me.

“Get”—*whack*—“the fuck”—*whack*—“off me!” *Whack. Whack. Whack.*

The dude didn’t budge, and my arms were beginning to tire. I didn’t have much longer. I needed to get the fuck out of that position quickly, or I was going to end up joining Sergei.

Think. It slid an inch forward. *Think.* Another inch. *Think—*

I flung my arm out to the side, clasped a glass snow globe, and smashed it into the side of his face.

He roared in anger, fumbling backward. I kicked him in the chest. He grunted at the impact, shuffling back another few steps. I got back onto my feet and moved away from the desk. I needed space. The freedom to move around. Getting backed into a corner with that dude was not a good idea.

Vernon cracked his neck. The knife was still in his hands. With a twirl, he switched it into a reverse grip, the jagged edge facing outward for maximum damage. He seemed to change right before my eyes. Where I had once deemed him as an unassuming man, quiet and non-threatening, he was suddenly the complete opposite. Deceiving. Lethal. Dangerous.

Turned out, we had a lot more in common than I thought.

I palmed the other blade behind my back and flipped it to match his grip. We eyed each other cautiously as we circled around the room.

“Who are you?” I asked. His footwork was impeccable, his stance immaculate. He was a man with training, that much was clear, and that made him a man to be weary of.

“I’m the man hired to watch over Sergei.”

It was the most I’d ever heard him speak.

My gaze flicked to the man in question, dead in his chair, and back to him. “You ain’t doin’ a very good job. No offense.”

Noises reached my ears from the rest of the house. Sounds of battle. Fighting. Screaming and gunshots. That was when I knew Sergei’s last act before he died was completely and utterly fucking us over.

“You’ll die for that,” Vernon said, his body tensing. There was no more discussion. He struck hard and fast, swinging his blade in a powerful arc upward. I reared back, avoiding the strike as the blade whistled through the air.

He twisted immediately and went to stab me in the thigh. I pivoted, light as a feather on my feet, and swung my elbow back. He blocked it by placing his palm up near his face and tried to jab me in the stomach. Our blades clashed as I brought mine up to intercept.

We locked into an intense knife fight, slashing and hacking at one another with deadly, quick strikes. He was very good. Fast as fuck, and not at all hesitant in his moves or attacks. He got me a few times, slicing up my forearms and biceps. They were superficial wounds. Nothing to be concerned about. The adrenaline hammering inside me masked the pain, making sure I could barely feel the thing.

I kicked the knife out of his hands. It clattered to the ground. The fucker tried to tackle me again. I swerved out of the way, twisted so I was at his back, wrapped my arm around his neck, and stabbed him in the chest from behind. He cried out in pain, struggling against me. I pulled the knife out and struck again, stabbing him in a different spot. I did it over and over and

over again, hacking away at him with fury. Even when he started to slowly sink to his knees, I kept going, like a man utterly possessed. The *squelch* of each impact was like music to my fucking ears.

I finally let him go, and he fell to his back, choking and gagging on his own blood. Brown eyes looked up at me, full of pain and anger.

“You—have no idea—what you’ve done,” he gasped out. A puddle of red began to form around him.

I panted, slightly out of breath, my chest heaving.

“They’ll come for you for this. You’ll—all—die.”

Dropping to one knee at his side, I grasped his shirt and pulled him toward me. “Who? *Who* will come?”

He smiled, and it was eerily familiar to the one Sergei gave me during his final moments. Triumphant. “Everyone.” Then, he slumped, dead.

I rose back to my full height and put my hands on my hips. “Well, that was ominous as fuck.”

I didn’t waste another second thinking about it. I didn’t have the luxury. If *I* just got attacked, it was likely my father and Autumn had been too. My father told me he’d started gathering numbers for a coup against Sergei, but whether they would fight with him, instead of against him, I didn’t know. Until I knew more, I had to assume it was just us three together.

I bolted out of the office. My body collided with another one the second I stepped out into the hall. A knife came speeding toward me without hesitation. I blocked it, holding his wrist at bay, and rammed my knee into his stomach. He curled over, sucking in a harsh breath. I wrapped both arms around his head and snapped his neck. Another one of Sergei’s soldiers came zooming around the corner. He raised his machine gun.

Christ.

I threw myself to the side, bringing the dead body of the soldier I’d just killed with me. He served as a shield, bullets meant for me hammering into his back. I threw my knife as I rolled us, my blade slamming into the other soldier, right between his eyes.

I got up quickly, my senses on high alert. Disarming both men seemed like the most prudent thing to do, so I quickly stripped them of their weapons and kept them for myself.

“Lukyan!”

I spun quickly, my gun up and taking aim.

My father appeared at the end of the hall. Autumn was at his side, both of them covered head to toe in blood and...*Is that someone's ear in her hair? Jesus.* There were four soldiers with them, but they weren't attacking them. No. They were protecting them. *Guarding* them.

What the fuck is going on?

My brain ran a mile a minute, trying to piece it all together.

"You alright?" he asked, jogging over to me.

"Fine." I nodded. "You know what's happening?"

He shook his head. "No idea. Sergei's men just attacked us out of nowhere."

"Yeah," Autumn agreed. "And it wasn't like an, *Oh, I just wanna teach you a lesson* kind of attack. It was a *I wanna fucking murder you* kind of attack. And we've got no clue why. They just turned on us."

"I think I know why." I dropped to one knee and pulled out the pendant I had suspected was around the dead soldier's neck at my feet. It was lit up brightly.

Autumn's eyes widened. "Hey. Those soldiers who attacked us had those too."

"So did Sergei. Right before I killed him, he activated the one around his neck."

"Wait, you killed him?" Father asked. "He's dead?"

"He's dead. So is Mr. Average. He came bursting into the room right after, and tried to kill me because of it. He said something. Something concerning."

Father kept a close eye on our surroundings. "What? What did he say?"

"That they'll come for us. That we're all going to die."

"Who is coming for us?" Autumn's face hardened with strength and determination.

"Everyone." My gaze flicked between them. "He said, 'everyone'. I think this was Sergei's final plan. He knew we were trying to kill him, and he came up with something that ensured if we succeeded, we'd die too. This necklace is some sort of beacon. When he activated his, all the others tied to it activated, too, signaling them to attack."

"Not all of the soldiers have them, though." Autumn pointed to the four men standing guard at the end of the hall.

"He might have only given them to the people he could one hundred percent trust. If he suspected soldiers were turning against him, Sergei

would have been selective about who he included in his final plan.”

Sounded right. “We have to clear the grounds. Anyone with these pendants is a target.”

“Agreed.” Father nodded. “Let’s get to it.”

We got into formation, Father in the lead, Autumn and I at his back, and the four soldiers behind us. We made our way through the house, sweeping every room as we went. Dead bodies littered the floor. Blood coated the walls. Father and Autumn confirmed they weren’t responsible for some of the bodies, which meant the soldiers with pendants weren’t just trying to kill *us*. They were trying to kill anyone who didn’t have one. Anyone Sergei didn’t trust. Which turned out to be half of his forces.

We worked to clear the house first. It was hard, but we worked together well, and along the way, we came across more soldiers who were being targeted. When they saw my father, strong and powerful, cutting his way through the enemy like it was nothing, they joined us, *his* strength giving *them* strength. It was what always made him such a great leader—the ability to inspire and embolden those around him. People flocked to him and the power he exuded, looking for support. Guidance. Help. And at that moment, a moment of uncertainty where they weren’t sure who the fuck they could trust, my father was a like a beacon of light in the darkness.

Following him was the easiest decision in the world. I would follow him into death, and I knew I wasn’t the only one.

By the time we’d cleared the house, our numbers had increased to twelve. Fifteen including Father, Autumn, and me. We’d lost a few along the way, which was unfortunate but unavoidable

“Now what?” I asked, slightly out of breath. We stood in the foyer of the mansion, gathered together, all looking to my father for the next step.

He didn’t crumble under the pressure before him. “Now we clear the grounds. Look outside.”

I did as he asked, peeking out through one of the windows next to the front door. It was chaos out there. People were running everywhere, in every direction, not sure who was friend or foe. Total fucking carnage.

“We’re not safe until we eliminate every single person with those fucking pendants.” Father turned to the soldiers behind him. “Kill anyone you deem as a threat. No one lives.”

“Yes, sir!” they all yelled.

Something caught my eyes in the distance. *What the fuck is that?* “Father?”

He must have sensed something in my voice because he came right to me, looking over my shoulder. “Fuck.”

Half a dozen cars came speeding down the road. They rammed straight into the gates, not even slowing down, completely bowling them over. People got out and immediately started attacking.

“Those aren’t Sergei’s men,” Autumn said, her face a mask of worry.

“How do you know that?” I asked, checking the magazine of my machine gun. I didn’t have many bullets left.

She pointed to a man slicing through people like fucking butter. “That’s Morris Tyrell. He’s an assassin. So is she,” she said, pointing again. “Maggie Jones.”

“What?” Pieces clicked into place, and dread filled me. “Vernon said ‘everyone’ would be coming. He didn’t just mean Sergei’s soldiers.” I looked closer at the new arrivals. I pointed a finger. “They’ve got those fucking pendants.”

Father cursed.

“Sergei must have paid them to come if things went bad.” Autumn’s eyes narrowed dangerously. “They’ll be under contract. Obligated to follow it through regardless if Sergei is alive or not.”

“We’re fucked!” one of the soldiers behind us yelled. “We should just run! We’re going to die! We’re all going to die—”

Another soldier slapped him across the face. “Pull yourself together!”

“No one is running,” Father growled. “You shoulder your fucking weapon and fight, or I’ll kill you myself.”

“Fuck,” I breathed out. “There’s more.” Another three cars came racing toward the house.

The look on my father’s face mirrored my own thoughts. He knew we most likely weren’t going to get out of there alive. There were just too many of them. Too many to try to take down on our own.

I stood taller, refusing to let even a sliver of fear take root inside me. If I was going to die, I was going to take as many of those fuckers down with me as I could.

Father nodded, face solemn. He gripped the side of my face and brought his forehead to rest against mine. “You’re not too much,” he whispered. “You’re perfect, just the way you are. Remember that.”

I closed my eyes and took a deep breath in. His words meant more to me than he would ever know.

He pulled back to look at Autumn and smiled. “Love you, Devil Woman.”

She smiled back. “Love you back, Your Royal Grouchiness.”

Father allowed himself one more moment of weakness, his eyes filling with so much emotion it seemed to almost cripple him before he shut it down, a dark, evil beast rising in his place.

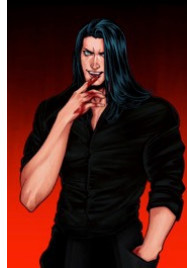
He raised his gun into the air and roared, “Kill them all!”

“KILL THEM ALL!” we roared back and ran out of the house.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER THIRTY THREE

LUKYAN VOLKOV



The moment we stepped outside, it went from zero to a hundred in the blink of an eye. There were people everywhere, blood-covered knives, machetes, and axes swinging through the air. Screams of pain and battle echoed out into the night. People fought one-on-one. Some in groups, spread out all across the yard.

I dropped to one knee, switched the machine gun to single shot, took aim, and fired. I focused on all the people who had just arrived. Autumn said they were assassins. That made them far more dangerous, and they had to be taken out first.

Bang! I swerved to the left. *Bang!* I swerved to the right. *Bang! Bang! Bang!* I didn't hesitate. Didn't even allow myself a moment to think about it. Just aimed and fired. Aimed and fired.

When my gun clicked, having run out of bullets, I tossed it to the side and palmed my knife. I leaped off the front porch and crash tackled into someone. I didn't know who he was. The pendant around his neck was all I needed to know. I drove my blade into his chest. A foot came flying toward my face. I blocked with my left, and slammed my elbow down onto his shin as hard as I could, snapping the bone. He cried out, dropping immediately.

I moved fast, rolling forward and stabbing him through his eye. As I got to my feet, a machete came hurtling toward me. I flipped to the side, spun, and threw my own knife right back. It hit its target, the woman falling with my weapon firmly lodged in her stomach.

A punch to the jaw rocked me. Pain flared across my face for a brief moment before I shut it out and locked into a battle of blows with someone.

Someone fucking *good*. She was fast. Efficient. Our forearms collided as we both blocked each other's attacks. She swung her leg in a roundhouse kick, and I reared back, narrowly missing it. Someone came at me from the right. I ducked under their attack and punched them in the face. Someone else joined in, and I found myself fighting off three people at once.

My mind shut down, and the battle rage filled me. I blocked a punch to the head with my forearm at the same time as I lashed out to the right with a side kick. I dove forward, taking one of them down, flipped myself back up, and stomped my foot down right into their face. I didn't stop. Didn't slow down. I fought with everything I had, ignoring the pain from the shots I couldn't avoid, and let the bloodlust fill me completely.

As soon as I disposed of those three, another three took their place, staring at me from a few feet away, each one with a knife in their hands and death in their eyes.

War raged on around me. I'd lost sight of my father and Autumn. I couldn't see them amongst the carnage. All I could do was hope that they were okay.

I took a fighting stance and motioned with my hand for them to run at me. They charged forward. My eyes widened. Not at them—at the fucking car that came speeding through the hole in the gate right behind them. My life seemed to flash before my eyes. The car was coming too fast to avoid. I was going to die—

The car sped forward and ran the three assassins down, their screams echoing into the night. I braced, grimacing. It completely skidded around me and came to a sudden stop. Aleksandr jumped out of the driver's seat, a Kevlar vest strapped to his chest and a machine gun in each hand, firing at will.

What?

Drea sprang out of the passenger seat, a handgun in both her hands, and began firing, each one of her shots connecting and killing whoever she aimed at. Another car pulled up beside it. Nikolai, Illayana, and Arturo appeared, each with their own weapons. They jumped right into the fight.

My family. My family was there.

Aleksandr, Drea, Illayana, and Arturo formed a circle as Nikolai came running over to me. He was dressed in the same gear as all of them. Black cargo pants, black shirt, Kevlar vest, and dozens of holsters filled with different weapons.

“You okay?” he asked.

Am I okay? “What the fuck are you doing here, Nikolai?” Don’t get me wrong, I was beyond fucking ecstatic they were there, but I was also hella confused.

“We’re here to help. Father had me look into someone—Vernon Miseris. The name is a fake. I ran it against the photo he sent me, and there was no match. It took a while, but I ended up finding out his true identity. Vlad Matosikov. He owns an assassin-for-hire company disguised as a security firm. He’s a dangerous fucking guy. I knew whatever he was doing here wasn’t good, so we jumped right on the jet and came to help.”

“What about Tatiana?” There was no way my brother would leave his pregnant fiancé at home. No way.

“She’s here.” He waved a hand in the air. A man who’d managed to get through the circle and was running up behind Nikolai suddenly dropped as a gunshot rang through the air. It was a single high-caliber shot from a sniper. “Away from the danger.” He winked. “Where’s Father and Autumn?”

I snapped back into myself immediately and cursed. “I don’t know. We got separated.”

He nodded, seeming to understand, given the chaos around us. “You go find him. We’ll hold down the fort here.”

“Alright. Give me a gun and a knife.” The cool steel of an MP-443 Grach landed in my hands, as well as a curved blade. I gave him a quick rundown of the pendants so he would know who was on our side before running off.

I attacked as I ran, shooting anyone who came in my path. I ducked under the swing of an axe and sliced up in a powerful arc, ripping open a soldier’s stomach before shooting an assassin to my left. It was by far the most intense battle I’d ever been in. The attacks never seemed to stop. People just kept coming. My gun ran out of bullets. My knife had been lost somewhere amongst all the fighting. My body fucking ached. I had bruises and cuts all over me, but I didn’t stop.

I wouldn’t stop. Not until I was fucking dead.

I rounded the side of the house and found my father in the backyard. He snapped the neck of a soldier and tossed the body to the side, breathing heavily. Father knelt down, and that was when I noticed Autumn, lying

unconscious. He brushed her hair to the side, whispering something to her, and she moved slightly. She was alive. Thank God.

I jogged toward them. "Father!"

He turned to look at me. He smiled, relief filling his eyes—

Bang!

He jolted. Time seemed to stand still, a sense of shock washing over me. Movements shaky, Father looked down. A patch of blood was growing in the center of his shirt. He looked back up at me.

"No," I whispered.

His eyes rolled back into his head, and he collapsed.

"No!" I ran forward. A man stepped down from the back porch, but I barely noticed, dropping to my knees at my father's side. "No. No, no, no." It was a shot to the chest. *A shot to the fucking chest!* "Oh, God. Oh, fuck. No. No. Dad!" I applied pressure to the wound, pressing down hard. He didn't move. Didn't make a sound. There was so much blood. *So much blood.* No one could survive that much blood loss. It completely drenched my hands, almost running down my forearms.

Autumn roused, a groan falling from her lips. She slowly sat up, dazed and disoriented eyes landing on me. "What happened?" she groaned again, hand to her head. A trail of blood slid down the side of her face. Alertness snaked back into her, and her eyes locked on my father. Her face dropped. "Dimitri?" When he didn't respond, she screamed. "Dimitri!"

Victorious laughter came from behind me. I looked over my shoulder and instantly recognized the man who'd shot my father.

"Here! Apply pressure!" I yelled. Autumn kicked right into gear, shuffling over to take my place, tears streaming down her face.

I got to my feet and strengthened my stance, standing protectively in front of them.

Lev Voznesensky stood a few feet away, eyes alight with triumph. The gun was still in his hands, smoke billowing into the air from the barrel.

"Well, well, well, if it isn't Lukyan Volkov in the flesh." He chuckled. "I was hoping I'd get to meet the man who broke my sister's heart."

Guilt swam in my chest at his words. I couldn't let it smother me. It hurt *so fucking much* knowing I'd hurt Lyla, but I had to put it to the side, deal with the problem at hand, no matter how hard it was.

It was made easier by the fact Lev raised his gun, pointing it right at me.

"Move," he commanded harshly.

That surprised me. “No.”

“Fucking move!” he growled this time, frustration seeming to mount on his face.

I stood taller, refusing to budge even a fucking inch. “No.” If I moved, I knew without a shadow of a doubt that he would finish what he started. Autumn was working tirelessly behind me to try to save my father, which I wasn’t even sure was possible. If he received another injury, no matter how minor, there would be no hope. No coming back from it. I couldn’t move. I couldn’t let Lev kill my father.

He marched over to me, each footstep full of anger. “The only reason I haven’t killed you already is because I promised my sister I wouldn’t. But if you don’t get the fuck out of my way, I *will* break my promise, consequences be fucking damned. You understand me? This is your one and only warning. Move now, or die.”

I knew he was one hundred percent serious. There was no hesitation in his words. His hand was steady and calm. Determination burned in his gaze. He was a man on a mission. Nothing and no one was going to get in his way.

No one.

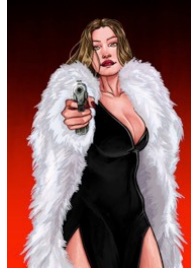
I stayed where I was, staring him down. If Lev wanted to get to my father, he would have to fucking kill me.

“Fine.” He shrugged, cocking the gun again. “Lyla will forgive me.”

Bang!

CHAPTER THIRTY FOUR

LYLA VOZNESENKY



*B*ang! “Lev! Stop!” My brother didn’t even flinch at the warning shot I’d just aimed over his head. He remained calm and still, glaring at Lukyan. His eyes cut to me, burning with hatred and vengeance.

My heart pounded in my chest so loud as we stared at each other across the yard. I almost didn’t make it. We had burst through the gates of Sergei’s estate not long after Lev’s necklace had activated with a great, almost blinding white light. My brother didn’t elaborate on its meaning. Only that it was some sort of signal. And then, next thing I knew, we were all piling into cars and taking off before I’d even had the chance to blink.

If I was being honest, I didn’t care enough to ask any questions. We were going to see my Lukyan, and that was all I needed to know. I couldn’t break into Sergei’s fortress on my own. I needed my brother’s help *and* the help of his men, so regardless of the why or how, I was going, and that was that.

When we arrived, we separated, me taking the house and Lev patrolling the outside.

He promised me. *Lev fucking promised me* that if he came across Lukyan, he wouldn’t hurt him. He wouldn’t kill him.

And I believed him.

Like a fucking idiot, I believed him.

I’d been halfway through clearing the house—which had turned out to be pretty useless because everyone inside was dead anyway—when I

caught a glimpse of them through the window. Lev, holding Lukyan at gunpoint.

I'd never run so fast in my fucking life. I made it outside just in time to fire a warning shot over my brother's head before he pulled the trigger.

"Lev! Stop!" I yelled out again, trying to keep the tremor out of my voice.

The gun didn't move, still aiming unwaveringly at Lukyan. I had to remind myself to stay strong, despite the fear almost smothering me.

"Turn away, Lyla," Lev said, voice rough.

I shook my head. "No. Lev, don't do this. Put the gun down."

"Turn. Away. Lyla!" he roared, moving forward quickly to shove the gun right up against Lukyan's temple, making him wince. Lukyan didn't move otherwise, his hands remaining in the air, palms facing outward, showing he wasn't a threat.

Panic gripped me tightly in its claws. One wrong move, one wrong word, and Lukyan would be dead.

Behind them, I could see Dimitri and Autumn. Dimitri was lying flat on his back, unconscious or dead, I wasn't sure. The front of his shirt was drenched in blood. Tears streamed down Autumn's face as she tried to stem the blood pouring out of Dimitri's chest like a free-flowing river.

He'd done it.

He'd fucking done it.

He'd shot Dimitri. Most likely killed him. And it still wasn't enough for him. Lev wanted more.

"You promised me," I cried.

That seemed to be the wrong thing to say. It only angered him further.

"*You* promised *me*!" he snarled, the gun almost shaking with fury. "You promised me you would always have my back. That you would help me—"

"I did help you! Even when I didn't agree with your plan, *I helped you*, Lev. I helped you more than anyone because you don't *have* anyone else. I'm *it*. All you have. And if you do this—"

"What?!" he roared. "You'll what?!"

I moved my gun an inch downward, letting my movement speak for itself.

His eyes widened. Realization snaked into his features, making his face drop slightly. "You'd...kill me?" he breathed out in shock.

I said nothing, unable to even voice the words. The truth of it was, I wasn't even sure if I was capable of killing him. He was my brother. I loved him. But I loved Lukyan too.

Lev shook his head. "You'd choose this lying sack of shit over me? Your own fucking brother?!"

"Don't make me choose," I whispered softly. Begged. Tears stung behind my eyes. I was powerless not to let them fall. The whole thing was tearing me apart from the inside out. I hated the position Lev was putting me in. The choice he was forcing me to make. To save someone I love by killing another person I love.

It was an unimaginable choice, an impossible task, and he was asking it of me regardless.

It wasn't fair.

Lukyan's eyes were on me. I could feel them, even if I wasn't looking directly at them. I always knew when his eyes were on me. It was a feeling I got, deep in my soul. In my heart. I moved my gaze to him, and he smiled sadly. "It's okay, baby. It's okay. Just go. Get out of here. Quickly. I don't want anything to happen to you."

He wanted me to go? To just leave him? To die? I couldn't do that.

Lukyan didn't move. Didn't attempt to get away. Whether that was because he knew there would be no escape, I wasn't sure. He just stared at me, eyes sad and filled with unshed tears. The smile was still on his face, almost as if he had accepted his fate, and was resigned to it.

The pain of seeing that look from him hurt more than words could ever describe.

"It shouldn't even *be* a choice, Lyla!" Lev blasted. "*I'm* your brother. *I'm* your family."

"*He's* my family too! He's the only one who understands me!" I shouted, moving closer. "And you would know that if you gave a crap about anyone but yourself," I seethed.

"You barely know him!"

The fucking audacity. "I've been following him for nearly two years. There isn't a soul on this earth who knows him better than *I* do."

Lev scoffed. "Well, he doesn't know you, does he? He doesn't give a shit about you. If he did, he wouldn't have left you."

His words hurt like a fucking knife to the heart.

“No!” Lukyan yelled out. It was the first time during the whole ordeal I caught a glimpse of fight in him. “That’s not true. Don’t listen to him, baby —” He winced again when Lev grabbed a fistful of his hair.

“Shut the fuck up,” he hissed. “I’ve had enough of you manipulating my sister. Don’t you hear him, Lyla? Don’t you hear how full of shit he is? He’s only saying this crap so you’ll stop me from killing him. He doesn’t care about you. Not really. He’ll never fucking choose you over his family. You’re nothing to him.”

“Would *you* choose me?”

His eyes narrowed thoughtfully. “Of course I would. I love you.”

“Then put the gun down and just walk away. Walk away from this.”

Lev didn’t move, just staring at me. I already knew he wouldn’t do it before I even said the words.

I took another step. “You won’t, will you? Because despite what you say, you would *never* choose me over your revenge.” I’d known it all along, but it still broke my heart.

“Enough,” Lev growled. “Just stop talking. Just stop—”

My brother’s gaze whipped upward, and his eyes widened in shock. People came pouring in from all sides, armed to the tee. I stayed exactly where I was, my gun still aimed at Lev as I watched person after person approach us with urgency. I recognized some of them. Lukyan’s family—Aleksandr, Nikolai, Illayana, and their partners, Drea and Arturo. They came rushing toward us, their guns drawn right at my brother.

Panicked, Lev grabbed Lukyan, moving behind him. He wrapped an arm around his neck and pressed the gun deeper into Lukyan’s temple in warning. “Stop! Stop where you are, or I’ll fucking kill him!”

As one, they all halted immediately, skidding to a stop. Anger burned in all of their eyes. There was nothing any of them could do. They were too far away to try to rush him and take the gun before he shot Lukyan. *I* was the closest one to him, apart from Autumn, but she was far too busy doing CPR on Dimitri to do anything to help.

“Put your guns down!” Lev commanded.

Everyone looked at Aleksandr. He was the oldest. The leader. The one they all turned to for guidance. I could see why. He stood there, strong and powerful, like a bear guarding its cubs. This was the first time I’d ever been scared of him. That look—that fucking look on his face was terrifying.

“Do it! I’ll blow his goddamn brains out. I will,” Lev warned.

“Then you’ll die too,” Aleksandr said roughly. It wasn’t a warning or a threat, but an absolute. Lev would die a painful and horrible death if he did it. There would be no stopping it.

Lev laughed maliciously. “You think I fucking care? I died a long time ago. I’ve accepted my fate.” He leaned forward slightly, but was smart enough to keep most of his head behind Lukyan’s to act as a shield. “I can see it in your eyes. You’re wondering if you can get me before I get a shot off.” He laughed again. “Take the risk. Go on. Let’s see who’s faster,” he taunted.

There would be no way to shoot Lev without shooting Lukyan too. No way.

Aleksandr must have realized it, too, because he let out a frustrated growl before tossing his weapons in front of him. One by one, the others did the same until they all stood there, unarmed.

Lev ducked out from behind Lukyan, face full of triumph. “You’re all so goddamn predictable. Now, I get to kill you all—”

“Don’t, Lev. Don’t do it.” I never dropped my gun, keeping it aimed at him, but I knew he wasn’t the least bit concerned. He didn’t think I could really shoot him, despite the fact that I had already threatened to do so. That was evident based on the knowing smile on his face.

“I’m sorry, little sister. I am. Not for killing this fucking family—I’ll never be sorry for that—but for the pain it will cause you. I don’t want to hurt you.”

“Then don’t.” I moved closer until I was right there, right in front of him. “Please don’t do this. Please don’t take him from me.” I sobbed, turning into a complete blubbering mess. “I am begging you. *Begging you*, Lev. Don’t make me choose between you and him. Don’t put that on me. Just let him go. Let them all go and walk away from this.” I never was a big crier, but at that moment, I could do nothing but cry. Tears poured out of my eyes so much that I couldn’t stop them even if I wanted to. “Please. For me. *Please.*”

He smiled, and that was when I knew there would be no changing his mind. No matter what I said.

“Sorry, little sister.” Time slowed down, and I watched agonizingly as he began to squeeze his finger over the trigger—

I stabbed him in the side of the neck. The gun went off, but it was too late. Lukyan had wrestled out of his grip the moment I struck. Lev had

been too preoccupied keeping an eye on my gun to notice my left hand behind my back—the one that had been gripping a knife.

Lev choked, coughing out blood. He looked at me, not only in shock but betrayal.

The betrayal. Oh, god, the betrayal in his eyes fucking killed me.

Lev began to fall. I darted forward and caught him before he could hit the ground.

“Hold your fire!” Lukyan roared.

I didn’t even bother looking to see what he was talking about. At that moment, I didn’t care.

I looked down at my brother, struggling to breathe, blood pouring out of the side of his neck, and I broke. “I’m s-so sorry, Lev,” I sobbed, holding him tenderly. “I didn’t want to do this. I-I—” The words got stuck in my throat, and I cried harder. Memories flashed through my head like a scene from a movie. Memories of him and me, laughing. Eating ice cream. Staying up late at the orphanage, hiding under the blanket and playing shadow puppets with a torch. Him, bumping his shoulder against mine and smiling. Us running down the street to get away after we’d just stolen candy bars from a convenience store. Him holding and comforting me after I’d woken up, screaming from a nightmare.

They all played, one after the other after the other, making the guilt over what I’d just done swallow me whole.

I sniffed, wiping the tears falling down my face with the back of my hand. “Please”—*hiccup*—“forgive me,” I begged. “I’m so sorry. I love you. I’m so, so sorry.” I tried to wrap my hands around the knife to apply pressure to the wound, but it was useless. There was too much blood.

Lev looked up at me, sucking in a harsh breath, only to cough up more blood. “I...” He swallowed thickly and reached for me. I moved my head closer until his hand touched my cheek and closed my eyes, sinking into his touch. “Will...*never* forgive you,” he growled out.

My eyes snapped open.

The hatred, the rage staring back at me was crippling.

“I...wish...Father had killed you.” His hand moved fast to my throat, and he started strangling me.

I whimpered. What was left of my heart shattered into a thousand tiny pieces. Impossible to ever mend.

Lukyan was there in an instant. He grabbed Lev's hand and yanked it away from me, but in the end, it didn't matter. The strength vanished from Lev almost immediately, and his whole body slumped.

He was dead.

Lev died, and he used what last strength he had left to try and kill me too.

Darkness crept into my mind. Into my soul. Into my heart. A paralyzing kind of darkness that, once it had me in its clutches, I knew would never let me go.

I had just killed the only person who had always been there for me. The only person who loved me. Protected me. Cared for me.

How could I do that? How could I betray him like that? He was right. I don't deserve his forgiveness.

I sank deeper into the darkness. It surrounded me, suffocating me, and I let it. My mind, my body...I felt like I was drifting. Drowning.

"Lyla?" a voice so soft and nurturing called out to me.

I looked up from the dead body of my brother and locked eyes with Lukyan. He was watching me with apprehension. Fear. Worry.

Sadness.

There was sadness in his eyes.

The realization of what I had just done hit me like a ton of bricks.

I couldn't take it.

I got up and ran.

"Lyla! Wait!"

I didn't. I kept running.

Dozens of guns aimed my way. It didn't slow me down. I had to get away. Escape what I'd done. I needed to run and never look back. Never let my sins catch up with me.

"Lower your weapons! Don't shoot!" Lukyan called out from behind me.

I rushed past Aleksandr, Drea, and Nikolai on my left, Illayana and Arturo on my right. They let me go, their eyes following me as I ran away.

"Stop! Baby, stop! Just wait!"

I ignored Lukyan, jumping into one of the cars at the front of the property. The keys were still inside. I started the engine and shifted it into gear.

Lukyan's hands slammed down on the hood of the car. He breathed heavily, eyes never leaving mine. "Wait. Don't go. Stay with me. It's okay. It will all be okay."

A part of me appreciated his words. The fact that he was trying to comfort me. But another part—the part of me riddled with guilt and anguish—squashed it in an instant. "No, it's not okay. And it never will be." I punched my foot on the accelerator and went zooming backward.

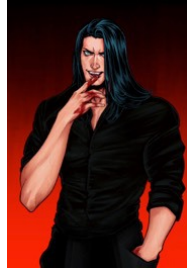
"NO! Lyla!" Lukyan screamed.

I spun the wheel and sped off into the darkness.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER THIRTY FIVE

LUKYAN VOLKOV



Three months later

“*W*here is she?” I roared into the face of the man at my feet, veins popping out of the side of my neck.

He shrank back, dark brown eyes shrouded in fear. “I don’t know! I swear to God, I don’t know!”

I held up the six-by-nine photograph again so he could see it clearly. “Lyla Voznesensky. She’s a client of yours, isn’t she? No. Don’t answer that. It was a rhetorical question because I already *know* she is. She came to you a few weeks ago, and now, I want to know where she is.”

“I already told you! I have no idea where she is!”

I stabbed him in the shoulder. He screamed—a loud, ear-piercing sound that echoed around the darkened room of his office in downtown Las Vegas. “I don’t believe you,” I snarled.

Rodrick Peterson was one of the go-to people for creating new identities. For the past three months, I’d been searching for Lyla, looking under every nook and cranny for even the slightest hint of where she could be hiding. And so far, I’d found fucking nothing. It was like she’d *poofed*. Disappeared into thin fucking air.

After the events that transpired at my grandfather’s estate in Russia, things had been...chaotic, to say the least. My father’s injuries had been severe. Critical. He’d been airlifted from the grounds and rushed straight to hospital. Aleksandr and Nikolai remained behind to deal with the fallout

from the bloodbath while Illayana, Autumn, and I went with Father. After hours and hours of surgery and countless blood transfusions, the doctors managed to pull him back from the brink of death.

It was a shock. Witnessing the gunshot firsthand, seeing with my own eyes how much blood he'd lost...I'd resigned myself to the fact that he wouldn't make it. Had tried my hardest to brace myself for the inevitable pain and anguish that would succumb me should he die.

Most people wouldn't have survived a straight shot to the chest like that.

But my father wasn't just *anyone*.

He was the toughest, baddest, most resilient fucker I'd ever known.

If anyone was ever going to tell the Grim Reaper to fuck off, it would be him.

While we'd been in hospital with him, Aleksandr and Nikolai were sorting shit out back at Sergei's. It turned out, you couldn't have a full-blown shootout in your backyard without attracting some sort of attention.

The law enforcement kind of attention.

Lucky for us, Sergei had the local police department in his back pocket—easy to do when you were one of the most powerful and influential men in Russia. Business might have been a little rocky, but my grandfather was always efficient at making sure he had the authorities right where he wanted them.

Cops came. It was unavoidable. But with a few words from Aleksandr and some cash, they turned and went on their merry way with a word of warning to clean up the mess quickly.

From there, things moved swiftly, and the days and weeks that followed passed by in a blur. Aleksandr remained in Russia for two months to handle affairs while Father was recovering, and Drea, Illayana, Arturo, Nikolai, and Tatiana returned home to keep on top of things there. Once Father was on the mend, he, Autumn, and Aleksandr came back to Vegas.

There was no funeral for Sergei. No wake where people talked about how much they would miss him and what a great life he had led.

The bastard didn't deserve it.

With his death, the *Pakhan* title fell to my father, and his first order of business had been to cement clear control of the organization in Russia. It didn't take much. *Everyone* heard about what happened. How we'd managed to thwart Sergei's last desperate act to kill everyone he deemed

untrustworthy, despite overwhelming odds. The families in the Bratva were quick to fall in line behind my father with zero outcry.

And me?

I spent every goddamn waking moment searching for Lyla. With Sergei dead, the threat hanging over my family died with him.

She didn't want to be found. That much was obvious. I could understand why, and sympathized with her. She was hurting. To save me, she had to kill her own brother, someone she loved and cared for. It was an unfair position to be in. An impossible decision to make.

And yet, she'd done it.

For me.

To *save* me.

I had to talk to her. I had to make sure she was okay. I just wanted to be there for her. Comfort her. Help her.

I didn't know why she wouldn't let me.

"Okay! Okay!" Rodrick groaned. "I'll tell you whatever you want to know! Just please, stop hurting me!"

I let go of the knife, leaving it lodged firmly in his shoulder, and dangled both my forearms over my knees. "Lyla Voznesensky," I repeated, pointing to the picture.

He licked his dry lips, panicked eyes darting all over. "Yes. Yes. I remember her. She came to me a few weeks ago, asking for a new identity. New name. New social security number. The works."

"And did you give it to her?"

"Of course I did! I-I didn't realize she was an enemy of the Bratva. I swear. Otherwise, I wouldn't have helped her."

I cocked my head. "Who said she was an enemy?"

He blinked. "Well, I—uh, assumed—why else would you be looking for her?"

"Because she's my fucking woman," I said with complete conviction. "Tell me where she went."

"I'm telling you the truth, sir. She didn't tell me her plans or where she was going. All she asked me for was a new identity, and I gave it to her. That's it. I swear."

I eyed him suspiciously. In rationality, he was probably telling the truth. It didn't make sense for Lyla to confide in him and tell him her plans. "Fine. I believe you."

He let out a huge sigh of relief.

“What’s the name of her new identity?”

That relief vanished in an instant. His next words came out terrified and hesitant. “I can’t tell you.”

Of course he couldn’t. Client confidentiality was a big thing in his business.

I didn’t fucking care.

“Look, Rodrick, I like you.”

“You—you do?” he asked, frowning.

“I do. You seem like a lovely chap. Really.” I pulled another knife from the holster at my hip and swished it in the air between us. He froze, his whole body stiffening. “But I really need to find my girl. You see, she thinks I abandoned her. She killed her brother to save me, and she thinks I don’t care about her. I can’t have that. I can’t have her thinking something so terrible. I need to make amends. And you’re getting in my fucking way—”

“No, no, no,” he began instantly, shaking his head. “You don’t understand—”

“Oh, I understand. If people found out you were giving the names of new identities away, it would mean the end of your business. After all, people are coming to you to use those new identities to hide. Kinda defeats the purpose if you start blabbing what they are.”

“Yes. Exactly.”

“The problem is, Rodrick, I don’t fucking care.” I stabbed his other shoulder. His cry of pain mirrored the first, drenched in pain and agony. “*Nothing* is going to stop me from finding her. *No one* is going to stand in my way. I will cut every inch of your body if I have to, to get the information I want.” I frowned at the two knives sticking out of him. “You know what, this is a little unsymmetrical. The right is a little further up than the left. Let me fix that.” I yanked out the knife in his right shoulder and rammed it back in a few inches lower.

“Ahhh!”

I nodded. “Better. Sorry, that was really going to irk me. Anyway, where was I? Oh, yes. I was threatening you.” I reached behind my back and retrieved another knife. I had an almost endless supply on my person at all times because, in my opinion, one could never have too many weapons. “I’ll start with your leg.” I tapped the tip of the blade against his shin. “I’ll

take the skin off, inch by agonizing inch, and if you still haven't talked, I'll move onto your other leg. Then your arms. Back. Stomach. And then face. It'll be tough work, keeping you alive the whole time. The human body can only withstand so much pain, so if we have to take breaks in between, so be it. But the end result will be a full-body flailing. Trust me when I say that is something you *do not* want to experience."

Rodrick paled so much I feared he would faint before I even made the first slice.

"Whadda say, Rodrick?" I tapped the blade on his shin again. "Are you gonna start talking, or am I gonna start slicing—"

"Melissa Anderson," he blurted out instantly.

I smiled and patted his cheek twice. "Good man."

* * *

THE SOUND of a wailing baby hit my ears the minute I stepped through the front door. I stayed in the foyer for a moment, taking a deep, calming breath to bury the anger and frustration I felt at another failure. Another disappointment. At the fact that I still didn't have Lyla in my arms. I buried it as deep as it could go, refusing to allow that anger near the babies.

In the lounge room was Drea, trying and failing to soothe baby Ivana while Nikolai sat in the armchair, nursing baby Aleksei, holding a bottle to his mouth.

The twins were born about a month after the ordeal in Russia. They were a few weeks early, which had terrified Tatiana. She wanted to keep them in there for as long as possible, but the babies had decided they were ready to enter the world, and made their appearance a few days after Christmas. They'd both been born happy and healthy, much to everyone's relief.

Aleksei pulled in at a whopping nine and a half pounds with a full head of dark hair and cute, chubby cheeks. Ivana—who I found out was named after Tatiana's father, Ivan—was roughly eight pounds. She had lighter hair, taking after her mother, and the kid was very particular about who she let hold her.

Drea was, unfortunately, not one of those people—case in point, the screaming newborn in her arms.

I plastered the fake smile on my face—the one that had been my go-to facial expression for the past three fucking months—and walked into the lounge room. “Hey, hey, hey, what’s going on? What are you doing to my niece?” I asked, taking her from Drea.

The crying stopped immediately.

Drea’s mouth dropped open. “Why?” she whined softly, almost stomping her foot in outrage. “I’ve been trying to soothe her for twenty minutes, and you just come in and she stops straight away? That’s not fair!”

I smiled down at Ivana, my heart so full of love and light, giving her my pinky to wrap her little hand around. *This* smile wasn’t fake. It was the only one that wasn’t. “What can I say? Babies love me,” I said, falling into that easy rocking rhythm you couldn’t help but do whenever you had a baby in your arms.

“Again, I say, no fair. You’d never even met a baby before they were born.”

“I told you I would be the favorite.”

She pointed an accusatory finger at me. “Just you wait. I’m coming for that title.” Then, she smiled lovingly at Ivana. “Goodbye, Princess. Sleep well,” she whispered, rubbing the top of her beanie-covered head in a soft, soothing caress. Her gaze whipped up to me, and she pointed two fingers at her eyes before swiveling them to me in a *I’m watching you, it’s on motherfucker* kind of gesture before she said a quick goodbye to Nikolai and Aleksei and walked out.

I laughed softly. “She’s salty, isn’t she?”

“Little bit.” Nikolai chuckled, placing the empty bottle down on the side table. He maneuvered Aleksei to his shoulder and began gently patting his back.

He’d fallen into the father role effortlessly, almost as if he’d been born to be a parent. I’d never seen him so happy. The pure love and adoration on his face when he looked at his children was nothing short of heartwarming.

Kinda made me want a little rascal of my own, to be honest.

“Go easy on her. She tried everything to settle Ivana, and you waltz on in and she just falls asleep.”

I looked down, and yep—sure enough, the little one was fast asleep. Grinning, I said, “I can’t help that I’m the favorite.”

“No, but you like it,” Nikolai snickered.

I flashed my teeth in a wide smile. “Yeah, I kinda do.” I sat down on the couch beside him, making myself comfortable. “Where’s the missus?”

“Getting some much needed rest. She was up all hours of the night, breastfeeding the twins.”

Aleksei burped, spitting up on the cloth slung over Nikolai’s shoulder before starting to cry. “Shh, shh, shh, it’s okay, it’s okay,” he soothed, rubbing a hand up and down his back. “How did it go? Did you find her?”

“No.” I sighed, disappointment and anger pounding inside me. I beat it down. I promised myself that I wouldn’t lose my shit near the babies. “She hadn’t been there in weeks. I did manage to get the information on her new identity, though, so that’s a plus.”

He nodded, rocking back and forth in his chair. “Send me the details. I’ll put it into my programs and be on the lookout.”

I inclined my head. “Appreciate it.”

My siblings had been nothing but supportive of my quest in finding Lyla. They’d all witnessed her kill her own brother in order to save me and Father. That negated any negative feelings they might have originally had after learning her identity. Like Father had assumed, Aleksandr and Nikolai understood. They didn’t hold Lyla responsible for what her father did. And could even understand why Lev would want revenge.

Any of us would have done the same in his place.

Illayana? Well...she took a little longer to come around. She’d been so young when Mother was killed, and although she knew Lyla was in no way responsible for it, it was hard for her to differentiate. Hard for her to let go of the past. Illayana had eventually agreed to help me in my search, like my other siblings had, but she made it noted it was under protest.

I think the phone call she’d had with Lyla during my captivity had affected her mood about the whole situation, though she refused to admit it.

Leaning back, I adjusted Ivana so she laid flat on my chest, and looked around the room, my mind a jumbled mess. “I just don’t know why she’s running from me,” I admitted, my thoughts running wild.

Nikolai pursed his lips. “She’s in *pain*, Lukyan. She lost her brother. Someone who was incredibly close to her. And from what you’ve told us about their relationship, he was the only one who was there for her. It will be hard for her to deal with his death, let alone come to terms with the fact that *she* was the one who killed him. Imagine how you’d feel if you had to kill one of us to save her. You’d be tormented.”

He was right. Of course, I knew that. Had even told myself the same thing on numerous occasions. Didn't help in dealing with it, though.

I exhaled heavily. "I just want to be there for her."

"And you will be," he said with conviction. "Just don't give up. Find her and let her know you'll be there for her, no matter what. That's all she needs."

I tossed one of the twins' soft toys sitting beside me at him. "When did you get so wise?"

He caught it effortlessly and threw it to the side. "I've always been wise. You've just never paid attention before."

I grunted. "Hardy, har, har." I went quiet for a moment before speaking again. "I gotta say, it still surprises me how supportive you're all being about this. I could have sworn you'd all tell me I was crazy for wanting her."

He gave me a sad look. "I hate that you'd think that of us. All we've ever wanted is for you to be happy, Lukyan, and it doesn't take a genius to see that she makes you happy. I've never seen you care so much about someone before. Be so focused on their happiness and well-being. To be honest, when we heard you'd been kidnapped, we kinda knew you'd come back completely in love with her."

"You did?" I frowned. "How?"

"She's everything you've ever wanted. Beautiful. Smart. Confident. Brave. She has the same type of personality you have. I always thought you'd need someone opposite to you. Someone to calm your crazy, but that was stupid of me to think. You need someone who matches you. Challenges you. Someone who can keep up with you. Someone even crazier than you are, and, well, she's definitely that. Only someone absolutely fucking nuts would walk into a room full of enemies and trick you into marrying her."

I smiled at the memory, and all the rest that followed. "Yeah. That was pretty fucking nuts." I chuckled. My gaze moved to the ring still on my left finger. I hadn't taken it off. Never would, if I had the choice, and I hoped she was still wearing hers.

Nikolai looked past me at the sound of footsteps. From the way his face lit up like a fucking Christmas tree, I didn't need to turn around to see who was coming down the stairs. There was only one person who could illicit that kind of infatuated look on his face.

“Don’t worry,” he said quickly. “I’ll send her identity to the rest of the family, and get them all searching for her. We’ll find her.”

I truly, truly hoped so.

Tatiana walked into the lounge room, her blonde hair down and falling past her shoulders. She was wearing a black silk robe, tied at the waist, with a pair of fluffy pink slippers on her feet.

Nikolai smiled, love and light in his eyes. “Hey, Mama,” he whispered lovingly. “Did you get a good rest?”

“The best.” She moaned, stretching her arms above her head. “How did they go?”

“Good. Aleksei finished his whole bottle and just fell asleep. Ivana took a little longer to settle.”

“But don’t worry, Uncle Lukyan came to the rescue.” I winked. “She’s konked out. Hey, T.”

“Hey Lukyan.” She smiled. “Did you find her?”

I shook my head, that anger beating inside my head again. The fact that I was holding a tiny little baby in my arms helped to alleviate some of it, but it was still there, like an unrelenting pressure in my brain. “I’m hoping that will change soon, though. Here you go.” I got up and went to hand Ivana off, then paused, maneuvering her sleeping form so I could pull out my phone. “Actually, can you take a photo of us?”

Tatiana smiled, taking the device. “Sure.” She held it up and took a few pictures. “You’re not going to post these online, are you?”

“No. I know your rule. No pictures of the babies on social media.” Both Nik and Tati were very strict on that rule. The Bratva had many enemies. They didn’t want to risk anything happening. No one outside of the family even knew she’d given birth yet, or that she’d had twins. We were all being very secretive about the whole thing to ensure the twins’ safety.

“Thank you.” She handed the phone back to me.

I looked at the photos, smiling. “These are perfect. Thanks.” I handed Ivana off to her mother. She stayed asleep, cuddling deep into her chest. “Where’s Aleksandr?”

“I just saw him in his office with your father,” Tatiana said, her eyes firmly plastered to her beautiful daughter in her arms.

“Cheers. I’ll catch you guys later.”

Neither one looked at me again, both too focused on their sleeping children. I couldn’t even blame them. The kids were damn cute.

As I made my way upstairs toward Aleksandr's office, I sent the photo of me and Ivana to Illayana.

Me: Attachment 1 photo.

:Told ya. Favorite.

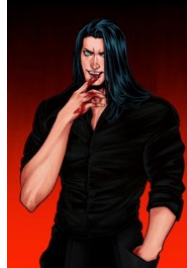
Illayana Butt Face: 🍆 Soak it up while you can. I'm coming for that spot.

HA HA. In your dreams. If I had to bribe those kids with money to stay the favorite, I would damn well do it

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER THIRTY SIX

LUKYAN VOLKOV



“Knockity, knock, knock,” I said, rapping my knuckles on Aleksandr’s office door. I opened it without waiting for a response.

Aleksandr was sitting behind his desk, face grumpy and stoic as per usual. Father sat in one of the two chairs in front of him, looking a little worse for wear. Understandable, given he was still recovering from, you know, almost dying. He was slightly pale, and looked as though he was trying to catch his breath.

“Uh-oh,” I sang, walking in and taking the free seat beside him. “Does Autumn know you’re out of bed? I thought you were only allowed one hour of activity a day?”

He glared at me. “I am a grown man. If I want to get out of bed, I will get out of the damn bed.”

“Oh, really?” I pretended to reach for my phone. “Should we tell Autumn that?”

“No!” Father lunged forward and immediately winced, grasping his chest. “Okay, fine! She doesn’t know I’m out of bed, alright? She’s doing a grocery run, and I snuck out. Happy?”

I smiled. “Yep.” Sometimes, I just liked fucking with him. It was so much fun.

Autumn had been nothing but vigilant when it came to Father’s recovery. She had a doctor on standby twenty-four-seven in the event of an emergency, had voice recordings of the doctor’s instructions with how much medication to give him and when to administer it in case she couldn’t

remember, and kept Father on a very strict exercise regimen. Only an hour of physical activity a day. Not a minute more or less.

I crossed my ankle over my knee. “What we talkin’ about?”

“We’re finalizing the details for Mikhail,” Aleksandr grunted, tip-tapping away on the laptop in front of him.

“Ah. Right. I’m still surprised he agreed to go.”

“Of course he would agree to go.” Father leaned back into his chair, blowing out a sigh of relief. Maybe I *should* text Autumn. It was clear the old bastard was overdoing it. Again. Fuckers had a hard time keeping still. “It opens up a whole new market for him.”

“Yeah, yeah, I know. But it also creates a fuckton of work for him, too. As your liaison, he’ll be overseeing all Bratva business in Russia for you, right?” With Sergei gone, we needed someone to oversee affairs in Russia for the foreseeable future. Father would be the obvious choice, but he’d chosen to remain in Vegas. He didn’t want to be away from his children—and now, grandchildren. Life was fucking short, as we’d all come to see. Father wanted to spend what time he had left in this world with the people who mattered the most to him. Going to Russia and being *Pakhan* would have taken that away from him. He didn’t want that.

Aleksandr was *Pakhan* here. He couldn’t go. Nikolai and Tati had built lives in Vegas. Tati had her father and school, and Nikolai was Aleksandr’s second, so they were out. Illayana, of course, was Queen La Cosa Nostra. And me?

I just didn’t want to do it.

Plain and simple.

I was capable, sure. If I had to, I knew I could fucking rock it. I just didn’t want to. All my family was here. Not to mention the fact that I was a little preoccupied at the moment, searching for the love of my fucking life.

That was when Mikhail, one of my father’s oldest friends, offered to handle things in Russia for a while. He was probably the only other person Father trusted to do it.

“Yes.” Father nodded, answering my question. “He’ll be in charge, and given leave to act as he sees fit. Once a quarter, he’ll report to me with the business earnings and inventory levels.”

“That will keep him pretty busy. Shit’s calm now, but it always picks back up again eventually.”

“True.” Aleksandr placed his elbow on the table and touched his chin thoughtfully. “But Mikhail can handle it. I don’t think he would have offered unless he was sure he could do it.”

Hmm. Maybe. People agreed to shit all the time without truly understanding what they were getting themselves into.

For as long as I could remember, Mikhail only had to worry about himself and his business. He was a cool dude. I liked him. He was kind of like our designated uncle because our real one was a piece of shit. Mikhail ran his own business as a loan shark. He would lend people money—outrageous, obscene amounts of money—and give them ample time to pay it back. Some did and some didn’t. The ones who didn’t had to work off their debt in other ways. He was fair, and didn’t abuse those who worked for him like a lot of other people did, but he could also be vicious as hell when the occasion called for it.

“It’s not like he’s getting nothing out of it. I doubt he would have even offered if that were the case.” Father chuckled. “He’ll be working closely with our clients, both new and old. The potential to build up his own business in the process is staggering.”

“It is,” Aleksandr agreed. “Nikolai ran the numbers. Fucker’s likely to pull in more than us by the end of the year.”

We were just entering March, so that was saying something. “Guess he’s not totally selfless.” I laughed. “When does he leave?”

“He already has.” Father reached for the glass of water on the desk, and struggled. I rolled my eyes as I got to my feet and grabbed it, handing it to him. “Not one word,” he warned, taking it and relaxing back instantly.

I raised my hands in surrender, walking back to my chair.

He gulped it down like a man getting his first taste of water in days before exhaling heavily. “He left a few hours ago. I’ve been in touch with Rurik. He was my contact in Sergei’s ranks before the takeover. He will show Mikhail the ropes until he can do things on his own.”

“And you’re sure Rurik can be trusted?”

Father nodded and held out his glass to me. I took it and placed it back on the desk. “He’s loyal. He was loyal to me even when Sergei was alive.”

Didn’t hurt to ask.

The sound of a door slamming shut made my father jump.

“Dimitri-fucking-Volkov, you better not be out of that bed!” Autumn’s voice rang throughout the house.

“Oh, fuck,” Father blew out under his breath. He waved his hands back and forth in the air quickly. “Help me up. Help me up.”

“Uh-uh. No. Way,” I said, shaking my head. “I’m not getting on *that* woman’s bad side. I heard about what she did in California three years ago to that MC gang. She slaughtered all sixteen of them on her own, all because she was pissed off.” I continued to shake my head. “I ain’t getting in her way. Sorry, Pops. You’re on your own.”

Aleksandr arched a brow in surprise, no doubt at the *Pops* comment, before chuckling softly.

Father glared at me.

“What?” I asked innocently. “I’ve got a point. You know I’ve got a point. Zander, tell him I have a point.”

“He has a point,” my older brother agreed immediately. “Even I wouldn’t cross her.”

“Scaredy-cats. The lot of you,” Father hissed.

Loud, thunderous footsteps followed next, and then Autumn stormed into Aleksandr’s office like an inferno, eyes zeroing in on Father like a sniper scope. “I knew it!” she blasted, marching forward. “I knew you wouldn’t stay in bed. Dimitri! The doctor was very clear! No strenuous activity, and you’ve already reached your allotted time for the day!”

Father smiled. “Hi, baby.” His voice was soft and sweet—two things I would have never associated with him in the past.

Autumn narrowed her eyes. “Don’t you ‘baby’ me. You promised.”

“Technically, I didn’t break that promise,” he rushed out, holding a finger in the air. “I’m sitting down. I’m still resting.”

“Oh, really?” She folded her arms across her chest. “Grab that glass on the desk.”

Father’s eyes darted to me and then back to Autumn. It took everything in me to hold in my snicker as Father reached forward, his face twitching as he tried to hold back the agony he was so clearly feeling at the movement. A pain-filled groan rumbled in the back of his throat. He still kept trying to reach for it despite the pain, refusing to admit what we all already knew—he shouldn’t have been out of bed.

Stubborn old bull.

“Okay, enough,” Autumn said, slicing a hand through the air. She marched over and slapped his hand away just as his fingertips grazed the glass. “You’re not well enough to be out of bed and you know it.” Her gaze

whipped to Aleksandr and me. “And *you two* shouldn’t be enabling him. If you need to conduct business, do it from the foot of his bed. You”—she pointed at Father—“up.”

Father didn’t even try to argue. “Yes, dear.”

There was no stopping the snicker that time.

Autumn grabbed his hand and helped him to his feet. He groaned again, leaning into her and resting more than half his body weight on her. Aleksandr and I immediately got up to help, but she waved us off.

“It’s alright. I got him.”

I wiggled my fingers, smiling. “Bye, Pops. Enjoy your rest.”

He just narrowed his eyes.

Yeahhhhh. I would pay for that later.

Aleksandr said his goodbyes and moved to shut the door behind them. He turned, plastering his back to the door, and crossed his arms over his chest.

“Go ahead.”

I dropped the facade and let the anger take over. “FOR FUCK’S SAKE!” I roared, grabbing one of the chairs and throwing it against the wall. “Why can’t I fucking find her?! WHY?!” I kicked the other chair over. “WHY?!” I picked it up and smashed it onto the ground. “WHY, WHY, WHY?!”

The chair broke, splintering to pieces under the force. I wasn’t even close to being done. I’d been burying my anger from the moment I got home because I promised I wouldn’t lose my shit near the twins, and it was my time to let it all fucking out.

“I don’t understand! How have we not found her yet?! We can find *anyone*! Fucking anyone! Why not her?! WHY!” I kicked. I punched. I screamed bloody fucking murder, letting all my emotions out. And Aleksandr stood there the entire time, not moving a muscle. Just watching.

He knew the drill by that point. This wasn’t the first time, after all. Or the second. Or the third. Every time I came home empty-handed, every time I came home without Lyla, I lost the fucking plot, and there wasn’t a damn thing I could do about it.

After the first time, when I’d completely destroyed the downstairs living room, Aleksandr made me promise to come to him. Made me promise to find him, no matter where he was or what he was doing so he could be there

to help me through it. To help pull me back. But it was getting harder and harder to do.

“SHE’S MINE!” I grabbed a full bottle of vodka from the drink cart and pegged it at the wall. Then another. Then another. Glass smashed all over the room. “MINE! MINE! MINE! She belongs with me! ME! LYLAAAAA!”

I wasn’t sure how long that time lasted. Had to have been a while because by the time I had calmed down, I was entirely out of breath, and Aleksandr’s office was completely destroyed.

I leaned against the wall and crumbled to the ground, completely exhausted.

Aleksandr came over and sat down beside me. “Feel better?”

“No,” I breathed out. “Not even a little bit.”

He nodded as if he completely understood and placed a hand on my shoulder in comfort. “Did you find anything?”

I sighed. “I did get information on a new identity she could be hiding under. Nik is going to start looking for her. Hopefully, something comes up.”

“You don’t sound optimistic.”

That was because I wasn’t. Months of zero leads weighed on my mind. I didn’t have high hopes, but that didn’t mean I would give up. If it took the rest of my life to find her, then so fucking be it.

“I won’t rest until I have her back.”

He patted me on the shoulder. “Neither will we. I know this is difficult for you, but just know we’ve got your back. Lyla proved herself by saving you over her own brother—a decision that no doubt would have been incredibly hard for her to make. Who her family is doesn’t matter. The only thing that does is that she makes you happy. Nik already sent the details to me. Same for Illayana and our contacts. Don’t worry, we’ll find her.”

I truly hoped so.

We sat there in silence for a moment, me consumed by my emotions and Aleksandr just there, a strong, unmovable, calming presence.

“I know I’ve said it before, but I’m proud of you. The work you did with Sergei was exceptional,” he said, voice soft.

I exhaled. I knew it was coming, and still, his words helped break through some of the anger still lingering in my bones. He was trying to help

me forget by switching the subject—something he always did—and I appreciated the attempt.

We'd long ago resolved our issues. After he and the rest of the family had come to Russia, we'd spoken in depth about what happened before I'd left. He'd even taken it a step further and *apologized*—something my older brother was not known to do often.

"Told ya. Not just a pretty face," I joked, trying to lighten the mood, lighten my soul, but it didn't work.

Nothing would work until I had Lyla back with me. I was sure of it.

"I'm serious, Lukyan, and I'll say it as many times as it takes for you to believe me. What you did, what you accomplished was nothing short of genius. For months, we were hearing chatter that Sergei's shipments were being intercepted. That someone was fucking with him. But we had no idea who. It was brilliant, targeting him through his business. It put him on edge. Made him even more paranoid and suspicious of everyone around him. It resulted in him making mistakes he never would have made otherwise. Why didn't you tell anyone about your plan?"

I avoided his gaze. Telling him the truth was the best course of action. I'd been lying so much over the past two years. I didn't want to lie anymore. I wanted to be honest, and have him finally see me. "I didn't think you'd agree with it. I thought you'd tell me it was a shitty plan and to drop it. No one ever takes my suggestions seriously."

Pain flashed in his eyes. "I'm sorry for that. I'm sorry you not only felt like you couldn't come to me, but that I also wouldn't listen to you. You didn't deserve that. You didn't deserve for me to treat you that way, and I'm sorry."

I could see how guilty he felt, and I hated it. "Zander, you've already apologized. A bunch of times. You don't have to keep doing it."

"Yes. I do." He said it adamantly. With complete conviction. As if he believed it with his entire heart and soul. "You were right. For years, I've treated you like you can't be trusted to handle the important shit, and I never should have done that to you. You had every right to put me in my place before you left. Just because we convey ourselves in different ways doesn't mean you aren't as smart or as serious as the rest of us. You shouldn't have had to, but you proved yourself over there. With your plan, you took down our biggest, toughest enemy, and you did it all by yourself, with no help from any of us. Fuck, we didn't even know about it until *after*

the fact. You proved us *all* wrong, and I want you to know that I couldn't be more proud and honored to call you my brother."

Damn it. "Well, here come the fucking waterworks." Not really. But tears were definitely gathering in my eyes. He would never know how much his words meant to me. All I'd ever wanted was for my family to see me and accept me for who I was. To value my skills and what I could bring to the table without criticism or judgment.

It was a day I never thought would come, and yet, here it was. The moment I had been waiting years for. And while I felt ecstatic at finally hearing my older brother saying he was proud of me, I couldn't enjoy it. Not really. Because I wanted Lyla there with me.

I leaned over and hugged him. He stiffened for the briefest moment, taken slightly by surprise, but then relaxed and embraced me back.

"Thank you," I whispered. "I appreciate it."

He cleared his throat before leaning back. "Of course. I'm only saying what I should have said years ago."

"Still. It's nice to hear it."

His head tilted to the side in assessment. "Lyla still on your mind?"

Always.

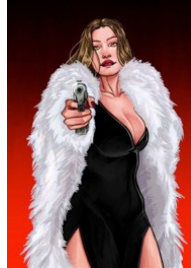
I just simply nodded.

"We'll find her," he said again, determination in his voice. "I promise you, we'll find her."

Her face appeared in my mind, the ache in my soul almost excruciating. *Where are you, baby? Where are you?*

CHAPTER THIRTY SEVEN

LYLA VOZNESENKY



Month one

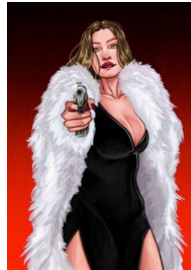
[illegible]

*killed my brother. I killed my brother. I killed my brother. I killed my brother.
I killed my brother. I killed my brother. I killed my brother. I killed my
brother. I killed my brother. I killed my brother. I killed my brother. I killed
my brother. I killed my brother. I killed my brother. I killed my brother. I
killed my brother. I killed my brother. I killed my brother.*

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER THIRTY EIGHT

LYLA VOZNESENKY



Month two

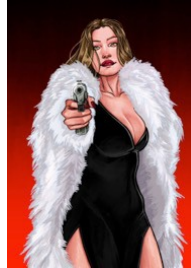
[illegible]

brother for a man who left me. I killed my brother for a man who left me. I killed my brother for a man who left me. I killed my brother for a man who left me. I killed my brother for a man who left me. I killed my brother for a man who left me. I killed my brother for a man who left me. I killed my brother for a man who left me.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER THIRTY NINE

LYLA VOZNESENKY



Month three

“*M*a’am, please, calm down.”

“Stop telling me to fucking calm down! I told you, I want my beef jerky!”

I eyed the customer, mentally telling myself to take three deep breaths. “I understand that. But you have to buy one first. It’s buy one, get one free.”

“And I told you, I don’t want two. I only want the free one!”

The overwhelming urge to roll my eyes hit me, and I only just managed to beat it back. My gaze swung to the teenage manager on shift with me. She wasn’t watching, her eyes plastered to the phone in her hand, smacking her lips loudly as she chewed the gum in her mouth.

I’d been working in this corner convenience store for a few weeks, and it *sucked*. It was my futile attempt to try and forget what happened. To try and distract myself from the horrible, all-consuming guilt that lived permanently in my brain.

It was a small place. For hours, I stood behind the counter, surrounded on all sides by plexiglass with barely enough room to move, let alone fucking breathe. But that wasn’t the worst part.

Serving customers was the worst part.

Customer service was not my forte, and whoever came up with the phrase, *the customer is always right* was a fucking bone head. Newsflash, the customer was *not* always right. In fact, they were rarely fucking right.

Why people thought they knew more about a business than an attendant who actually worked there was beyond me. It drove me literally insane. Not to mention how rude people were to service attendants. Like a simple *please* and *thank you* were too fucking hard to utter.

“I understand that, ma’am,” I blew out behind clenched teeth. “But as I said, the promotion is *buy one get one free*, which means in order to receive the free one, you must first *purchase one*.”

Was I speaking another language? How fucking hard was that to understand?

“I don’t care what the promotion is!” the woman yelled, sweeping her hand across the counter and throwing a whole bunch of merchandise to the floor. “I want my free beef jerky, and you better give it to me! The customer is always right!”

Andddd there it was.

The fabric of my uniform irritated my skin. Add that to the sound of the desk fan blowing beside me, the hum of the refrigerators, the *smack-smack* of Becka’s lips as she chewed her gum, and the customer’s irritating, shrill voice, and it all pushed me into a full-blown sensory overload.

I fucking snapped.

I pushed my face right up against the plexiglass, pointing a finger at her. “Listen here, you stupid, shrill little bitch. I’m a heartbeat away from jumping over this counter, smashing your face into the ground, cutting off all your hair, and slitting your goddamn throat, you hear me?”

The woman blinked in shock. “You-you can’t speak to me like that,” she said, flabbergasted.

“I can talk to you however the fuck I want to talk to you. If you want that jerky, show me the fucking money. Otherwise, get the fuck out of here before I kill you and sell your organs on the black market.”

She fled so quickly she left her phone behind. I wasn’t sure if it was my words or my tone. Perhaps both. Maybe she finally realized I was dead fucking serious.

I didn’t know and I didn’t fucking care.

Good-fucking-riddance.

I killed my brother.

I stumbled back, my hand flying to my chest, pain slicing my heart in two.

*No. No. **Go away.** Get the fuck out of my head. Leave me alone.*

For nearly three months, I'd been bedridden. Unable to move. Unable to breathe. Unable to cope with the haunting fact that I had killed my own brother, his last words playing like a broken record, over and over again in my head. Never stopping. Never easing. Never giving me a moment of relief.

I will never forgive you.

I will never forgive you.

I will never forgive you.

I killed the one person in the world who loved me. Not only that, but I killed him for someone who left me. Abandoned me. *That* hurt almost as much.

I couldn't take it anymore. I had to get out. I had to get away from the voices—not only Lev's, but my own. The constant reminder of what I'd done. In an attempt to forget, I had gotten myself a job. A job that was meant to distract me. Keep my thoughts from slipping. But it wasn't working.

Nothing was working.

I couldn't get the voices to stop. The guilt to ease. I just wanted the guilt to go away.

A shadow fell over the counter. "Pack of Marlboro Lights, please," a light, familiar, feminine voice said.

I looked up and stiffened.

Fuck.

Illayana De Luca stood in front of me, looking as beautiful and badass as ever in a red pencil skirt, black blouse, black trench coat, and black stiletto Louboutin heels. Her hair was down and straight. Makeup flawless and perfect. A gold Cartier watch dangled from her wrist. A huge diamond ring sat snugly on her third left finger. Her earrings were gold, and probably worth more than anything I owned. Illayana looked like she'd just walked off a model fashion shoot.

We stared at each other, absolute silence reigning between us. I didn't know what to do. What to say. Seeing her brought forth an avalanche of thoughts and emotions I'd been trying my hardest to bury for months.

Long dark hair. Crystal blue eyes. Mischievous smirk. Lukyan's face flashed in my mind before I could stop it, along with pain and anguish.

I killed my brother for a man who left me.

I shook my head, mentally demanding the voice to leave me alone again. I cleared my throat, turned around to retrieve the packet of cigarettes, and faced her again. "What are you doing here?"

"Hello to you too. It's nice to officially meet you."

"Is it?" I highly doubted that. My gaze swept the counter, looking for a weapon. Something sharp and pointy I could use to defend myself. Scissors. A ruler. Even a goddamn pen would do—

"There's no need for that. I'm not here to hurt you."

"You're not?" I frowned. "You're not here to kill me for what happened to your father?"

"Nope." She pulled some cash from her pocket and held it out to me. "I'm here to talk."

Talk? Just...talk? That surprised me. Part of the reason I was running was because I was sure the Bratva were hell-bent on revenge for what had happened to Papa D.

I scanned the cigarettes through the till. "Talk about what?"

"You and my brother."

Another bout of pain hit me. *I killed my brother for a man who left me.* "There is no 'me and your brother'." As much as I wished there was. I took the cash from her and opened the register. I quickly put the money away in its designated slots, got out her change, and handed it over to her, along with the smokes. "Have a nice day," I said, plastering a big, fake smile on my face, trying as hard as I could to just move her along.

My identity was burned. I would have to run again. Granted, I wasn't that upset about it. This life sucked. Mainly the job. For the next one, I would be avoiding any customer service-related jobs like the plague.

She chuckled, not moving a muscle. Humor danced in her eyes. "You got a break coming up?"

"Negatory. I'm really quite busy." *How the fuck did she find me, anyway? Does that mean Lukyan is looking for me too?*

Don't be ridiculous, that voice in my head said. *He left you, remember? He doesn't care about you. It was all a game to him. Lukyan played you, and the first chance he got, he escaped, just like Autumn said he would.*

I didn't want to listen to the voice, but it had a point. I thought we were soulmates, but after what had happened, I was questioning everything. Questioning every interaction we had. Every word he said.

“Yes,” Illayana dragged out, glancing around the empty store. “You sure look it.”

“I am!” I didn’t know why I was getting defensive. I had nothing to be defensive about.

Her face suddenly turned serious, any trace of humor disappearing in an instant. “Ten minutes. That’s all I ask. Ten minutes.”

“I don’t have ten minutes.”

“Sure you do.”

“No. I don’t.” I took a deep breath to calm myself. The last thing I wanted to do was get in a fistfight with her. “Look, I don’t want to be rude, but you and I have nothing to talk about,” I said sternly. “So you might as well go.” I couldn’t do it. I couldn’t have this conversation. If I did, I wouldn’t make it. I wouldn’t survive.

“I respectfully disagree. We have *everything* to talk about. My brother is hurting, and you’re the *only* one who can fix it. I’m not leaving until we have a discussion, even if I have to wait here all night.”

“What?” I breathed out in surprise. “Lukyan is hurting?”

“Of course he is. He’s been running himself ragged looking for you these last few months.”

I bit my lip, looking away. Hearing he’d been searching for me made my heart flutter. *Did our time together have a bigger impact on him than I thought? Does he actually...love me?*

“I saw that,” Illayana said, a hint of giddiness in her voice. “I saw that spark in your eyes. That hope. Come onnnn. You know you want to talk to me. Everybody does. I’m a delight to talk to.”

Familiarity sparked. Behind that serious exterior, I could see a playfulness that mirrored Lukyan’s—a similarity between the two siblings that could not be missed or ignored.

My soul had been deprived of Lukyan’s light for ninety-three days, seventeen hours, twenty-seven minutes, and forty-one seconds, and even though it was his sister standing in front of me, not him, a tiny bit of the pain that had been battering my heart and soul since our separation eased.

I missed him.

God, fuck, I missed him.

I missed him more than I could ever put into words, and yet, I couldn’t stop running from him. Couldn’t stop hiding. Couldn’t face what I’d done.

Denial was a powerful emotion, and right then, it was my best fucking friend.

But the prospect of finding out if he was truly missing me was too good to pass up. I looked back to Illayana and sighed. “Ten minutes.”

* * *

ILLAYANA TOOK a drag of the cigarette, inhaling deeply before blowing it out. Smoke billowed into the air, dancing upward into the pitch-black sky. We stood on the street out front of the store, the cold wind of the night battering against my body, making me shiver and goose bumps pebble along my skin.

Two men stood beside a car parked across the road. I recognized them instantly. They were the identical twins I’d seen with Lukyan after Tatiana’s mock fashion show. I knew they were Illayana’s bodyguards. Another two men were patrolling a little further down the street, their eyes scanning their surroundings diligently, constantly on alert.

The queen of La Cosa Nostra traveled with an entourage. It had surprised me the first I’d seen it. Illayana was deadly. Quick, efficient, with absolutely no qualms about killing someone. She didn’t need anyone to protect her. In fact, people needed protecting *from her*.

“I’m not a big smoker, you know,” Illayana said, breaking the silence. “But every now and then, I get that craving for something to take the edge off.”

“Have you tried weed? That really does the trick.”

She chuckled. “Yeah. It’s not my thing. I greened out the very first time I tried it, and haven’t been able to do it since.”

I nodded. *Understandable*. “How did you find me?” I asked, switching the topic.

Illayana blew out another cloud of smoke. “Wasn’t easy. You sure move around a lot. Almost gave up hope, actually, but my brother found the info for your new identity.”

Rodrick Peterson...That fucking jackass. He blabbed, and I was going to end his life because of it.

“We all put our best trackers on it. I just happened to find you first,” she finished.

“I’m surprised you care.”

“To be honest, I don’t. Not really.” *Okay, then.* “I’m here for one reason and one reason only. Lukyan.”

I stared out into the dark, unsure of what to say, so I said nothing.

“I know my brother well,” she continued. “Better than he probably thinks I do. He’s been different since you came into his life. Even more so after you kidnapped him.”

“Different how?”

“Just...different. He spends every waking moment searching for you. He cracks jokes, but his heart isn’t in it. His light is gone, and I have a feeling it’s here with you.”

I looked down at my feet. Her words made me feel a mixture of emotions. Happy. Sad.

Angry.

The anger wasn’t at him. Or her.

It was at myself.

I killed my brother.

I killed my brother for a man who left me.

The feelings taking root inside my heart overwhelmed me to the point that I didn’t give a fuck about putting on a front anymore.

I broke down.

“I can’t handle it.” I sobbed, crumbling to the ground, covering my face with my hands. “I can’t handle it. I can’t handle it.”

Illayana crouched down with me immediately, voice layered with concern as she asked softly, “Can’t handle what?”

“What I did,” I whispered, my voice cracking. “*I killed him.*” Each word was laced with agony. “I killed my own brother. The only person who has ever loved and cared for me. I killed him, for a man who doesn’t give a shit about me—”

“That’s not true,” Illayana insisted. “Lukyan *does* care for you.”

I looked up, shaking my head. “No, he doesn’t. Otherwise, he wouldn’t have left. I know what he did. He played along with me. Played into my ‘delusions’ to earn my trust, and then just left the first chance he got. He didn’t mean any of it. None of it. And I ended up killing the one person in the world who truly loved me for someone who only claimed to.”

She exhaled a deep sigh. “Look, I say this in the nicest way possible, but that’s fucking stupid.”

I blinked and hiccuped. “What?”

“If you had seen my brother these last few months, you wouldn’t be thinking that. Not at all. Those thoughts never would have even made it into your head. Lukyan has not stopped looking for you. Not once. He has everyone out there searching for you, and I mean *everyone*. Even other crime syndicates. He’s exhausted every option available to him, calling in all the favors the Bratva is owed to try and find you. He throws fits when he comes home without you, and I mean full-blown, tantrumy, throws-shit-around-and-knocks-things-to-the-floor kind of fits. He’s not the same man he was before. He’s consumed by you, and I know he’ll never be happy until he has you back.”

I breathed heavily, unable to comprehend what she was saying. “Why did he leave me then?”

“Come on. You’re smart enough to know why. He wouldn’t have done it unless he had to. By that point, shit with my grandfather was at boiling point. He had a job to do. Lukyan *had* to leave. He had to finish it for the sake of our family’s future. Also, you can’t just kidnap someone and expect them to stay with you forever.”

My brows snapped together in thought. “Why not? Didn’t your brother do that with his now wife?” I asked, arching a brow. During my time stalking Lukyan, I’d obtained a lot of information. Seen a lot of things—one of which was Aleksandr keeping Drea locked up in their house.

If it worked out for them, it could have worked out for us. That had been my thought process, and what had given me the idea to kidnap Lukyan in the first place.

“Okay, one, it’s creepy that you know that, and I’m not even going to ask *how* you know that—”

“I saw it while I was stalking Lukyan,” I said, like it was the most normal thing in the world.

Because it was.

“Right.” She clicked her fingers, forming them into the shape of a gun and pointing it at me. “Creepy. And two, my brother *did* kidnap Drea at the start, yes, but he knew a relationship could never form unless he let her go, and she came back willingly. And she did. Lukyan would have come back to you too.”

“You don’t know that.”

“If how Lukyan has been acting the last few months is any indication, I think I do.” She took one last drag of the cigarette before dropping it to the ground and stamping it out with her heel. “Like I said, I know my brother, and I know he will never give up until he finds you. Once he sets his mind to something, there’s no stopping him. He’s like a dog with a bone. Lukyan has decided he wants you, and he won’t rest until he has you. Remind you of anyone?” Her brow arched up high, a knowing smirk on her lips.

“Oh, you’ve got jokes,” I said humorlessly.

“Yeah, well, that one was too good to pass up.” She chuckled.

I grunted. It was pretty good.

Exhaling heavily, I leaned my back against the brick wall behind me and stared up at the night sky. Her words made me happy, of course, but I couldn’t drag myself out of the pit of despair that had me firmly lodged in its grasp.

It didn’t take away the pain I felt. The hole in my heart that Lev’s absence caused.

I wasn’t sure anything would.

A featherlight touch jolted me out of my stupor. Illayana’s hand was on my shoulder, compassion drenched over every inch of her face. “I know you’re hurting,” she said softly. “I can’t imagine the agony you’re in. How hard it would have been to kill someone you love in order to save another. It was an impossible decision, and I thank you dearly for the choice you made. You saved my brother’s life, and for that, I’ll always be indebted to you.”

Tears gathered in my eyes.

“I know you’re struggling. In your shoes, I would be the same. But you’re not alone. Lukyan wants to be there for you. Stop running from him, and let him help you.”

I wanted to. God, I wanted to. But... “I can’t get his face out of my head,” I said in a small voice. “That look of betrayal in his eyes...It haunts me.”

I cried. I cried harder than I ever had in my life, the tears never seeming to ease.

Illayana reached for me, almost as if she wanted to hug me, but then she stopped herself. “I don’t know you. I don’t know the words to make you feel better. But Lukyan does. You have no reason to believe a word I say, I know that. All I can do is assure you that my brother never would have left

you unless he had to. Unless he didn't have a choice. He would have gladly stayed with you forever if our family wasn't at stake. I am one hundred percent certain of that. That choice you made...That hard, impossible, soul-crushing choice to save Lukyan wasn't for nothing. It was for love. A love you both feel. You don't have to suffer like this. *Please*. Let me take you to him. Let me help you."

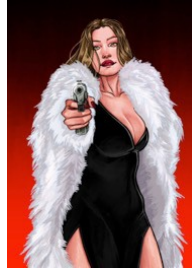
I looked into her eyes—eyes that reminded me so much of Lukyan's—and saw nothing but sincerity. Nothing but the desire to help. "I thought you didn't care."

She smiled and helped me to my feet. "You'll come to see I'm full of shit sometimes."

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER FORTY

LYLA VOZNESENKY



After a quick *fuck you* to Becka and the convenience store, we made a pit stop at my shitty apartment to pick up the few possessions I owned, and then we were on our way. The flight had been long and tedious. Illayana and I didn't talk much, if at all. I think she could see I needed a bit of time to sort through my thoughts and emotions, which I appreciated.

It wasn't awkward at all. Partly due to her identical twin guards. Those two bickered more than an old married couple, and the whole thing had been quite entertaining to watch. At first, they'd been on guard around me, much like the other two—whose names I came to find were Lorenzo and Adrian. But once they'd realized I wasn't a threat to Illayana, they relaxed.

When we pulled up in front of the Volkov estate, the nerves set in. It would be the first time I was walking into that house *invited*. Every other time I'd been there, it had been to stalk. To sneak in and watch Lukyan do whatever he was doing. I'd been in that house more times than I could count, and yet, this was the first time I was actually nervous to walk inside. Unsure of what was waiting for me.

Illayana said Lukyan missed me. That he wanted me there. That he'd been searching nonstop for me. But I still worried that when he actually saw me, all my fears about our relationship would come true.

That it had all been a game to him.

That he didn't really care for me.

Miss me.

Love me.

My fingers tightened around the scrapbook in my hands; it was the only thing that calmed me down. It possessed the photos of Lukyan I'd taken when I was watching him. Not all of them, of course. It wasn't big enough for that. The others were all packed away safely and securely in my bags.

"You okay?" Illayana asked when the car stopped.

"Not really," I admitted, clutching the scrapbook tighter. "I'm feeling a little nervous, to be honest."

"Nervous?" she asked, cocking her head. "Nervous about what?"

"Going inside."

She chuckled, snapping off her seat belt. "Correct me if I'm wrong, but haven't you been inside before?"

"Dozens of times. But this is the first time I won't be hiding."

"Hmm." She looked up at the house in thought before coming back to me. "You have nothing to be nervous about. Everyone will be excited to see you."

*Everyone? What the fuck does she mean by **everyone**?*

"Come on, let's go." She got out of the car and made her way to the porch steps.

I took a deep breath, trying to calm my nerves. It didn't work. Anxiety beat inside me like a steel drum. The only plus side to the whole thing was that it was the first time in three months that my thoughts hadn't been consumed by Lev.

Illayana waited patiently on the front porch for me, no sense of urgency from her at all. She was letting me take my time. Gather my strength. Psych myself up. Which I fucking needed.

"Here we go." I cleared my throat, gripped my scrapbook tighter, and exited the car. Each step I took up to the house felt monumental. Felt like a step in the right direction. Like I was right where I needed to be.

Illayana gave me a warm smile, encouragement in her eyes. She inclined her head to the two soldiers standing guard before opening the door and leading me inside.

Light greeted me when I stepped into the foyer, followed by an aroma of smells that had my stomach rumbling. I'd always thought it was a very lovely home. Warm and inviting with a nice, cosy feel. There were little things here and there that personalized it. Made it feel like a *real* home instead of just a house people lived in. It was the picture frames on the walls. The knick-knacks on the shelves that didn't really fit in with the

aesthetic, but you knew held great sentimental value. The scratches and dents in the walls from god knew what. It all contributed, adding character.

Despite the nervousness fluttering through my body, the homely aura instantly helped to relax me, taking some of the tension out of my spine.

I can do this. I can do this.

“This way.” Illayana led me out of the foyer and down the hall on the left, opposite the winding, circular staircase. Loud voices and laughter hit my ears. Illayana didn’t slow her stride, marching right up to a large, formal dining area.

“Sorry I’m late,” she announced, walking in. “I had to pick up a friend.”

Friend?

I followed her in, and the room went from a buzz of activity to dead fucking silence at the drop of a hat. Sitting at a large mahogany table that was overflowing with an array of different foods was...fuck...everyone.

Well, almost everyone.

Papa D and The Crimson-motherfucking-Death were at the head of the table, sitting side by side. Aleksandr and Drea were on one side, their faces mirrored in shock, forks frozen in the air an inch away from their mouths as they stared at me. Nikolai, Tatiana, and *two freaking babies* were on the other side. Their eyes were as wide as saucers. Illayana’s husband was beside one of the babies, holding a bottle to the little one’s mouth. He was the only one who didn’t seem remotely surprised by my presence, a slight smirk on his lips.

Where is Lukyan?

I cleared my throat, standing a little taller under their scrutiny. I might have been nervous as hell, but I would be damned if I let it show. The silence was deafening, and everyone was fucking staring at me like they couldn’t believe I was standing right in front of them.

Hello, awkward city.

My eyes ran from person to person, and my nerves shot right back up, almost fucking crippling me.

This was a bad idea. This was a bad idea. This was—

Dimitri stood. My eyes snapped to him. Our gazes locked.

A memory came barreling into my head. A memory from my childhood. Of a giant, terrifying man coming into my bedroom in the dead of night. Despite the fact that he was covered in blood, his face was soft, kind, as he

looked down at me cowering in my closet—the closet my father locked me in as punishment.

He crouched until he was at my eye level and offered me his hand.

I didn't know him. Had never seen him before. But my soul told me I could trust him. That he wouldn't hurt me.

And I had been right.

He'd taken me from that house. From that hell. And although the orphanage he'd dropped me off at wasn't the best, it was way better than my home.

Dimitri and I stared at each other for a moment longer before he slowly moved out from behind the table, hobbling with each step. Autumn immediately got to her feet to follow him, but he waved her off, and she sat back down, however reluctantly.

I involuntarily clutched the scrapbook in my hands tighter to my chest, as if it could somehow protect me. Why, I wasn't sure. I was never one to get scared. *I* did the fucking scaring. But the uncertainty of everything kept me frozen on the spot, unable to move. Unable to breathe. Unable to do anything except watch the Bratva Butcher get closer and closer.

The Volkov siblings and their partners watched his every step as he came toward me, the tension building and building, smothering the air.

I had no idea what he was about to do. Would he kill me? Cuss me out? Tell me to stay away from his son? After all, I was, in part, responsible for what happened to him. I helped Lev gather the information on him, which resulted in him catching a bullet to the chest. Not to mention the fact that I had kidnapped his son. Everyone knew that man did not fuck around when it came to his children.

He probably wanted to straight-up murder me.

He stopped in front of me. We stared at each other for a moment, and then his arms wrapped around me, and he embraced me in a hug. I stiffened, sucking in a shocked breath, my eyes widening.

What. The. Ever-loving. Fuck?

I stayed still, too stunned to move a single muscle. He was hugging me. The Bratva Butcher was *hugging me*.

And I had no idea what to do.

The hug was light. Comforting. Supportive. Everything a hug ought to be, and I couldn't help but feel wistful.

I'd never received a hug like that from my own father, and it wasn't until then that I truly realized what I had been missing.

Dimitri stepped back and offered me a warm, kind smile. "*Dobro pozhalovat' v sem'yu, dochka.*" *Welcome to the family, daughter.*

For the third time in less than twenty-four hours, shock catapulted down my spine, and my eyes widened even more. With those five simple words, he told me all I needed to know, and all my fears vanished in an instant. Dimitri accepted me. He actually accepted me, even after learning of everything I had done. Warmth flooded my heart. "*Spasibo.*" *Thank you*, I said softly.

"Oh my god," Tatiana cried, wiping the tears from her cheeks.

We all looked at her.

"Ignore me." She sniffled, fanning her face. "My body is still a big hormonal mess. This is just so sweet. I can't—oh—he said *daughter*." She sobbed. Like, full-on sobbed, and a round of laughter went around the table.

Nikolai patted her on the back. "There, there, my love. Let it all out."

The tension that had been building instantly dissipated as we all watched Tatiana sniffle and wipe her nose.

Glass shattered, echoing around the room, along with a gasp of surprise. My gaze swerved behind Dimitri to see Lukyan, standing in the doorway, a broken plate and food scattered on the floor around his feet.

Our gazes clashed. My heart stopped in my chest.

"Lyla," Lukyan whispered, shocked.

I thought maybe after months apart, my feelings for him could have eased. Not be as powerful or all-consuming as they had been before.

That was wishful fucking thinking.

They were just as strong as ever. Stronger, even. Every part of me yearned to be near him. To touch him. To feel him. To feel the beat of his heart underneath my hands. To feel the silkiness of his dark, long hair.

We stared at each other from across the room, so many unspoken emotions swirling between us it almost seemed to overwhelm me. Then, he was moving, marching toward me like a man on a mission.

I stayed where I was, unable to make my body move. Dimitri stepped out of the way, and then Lukyan was right there, right in front of me. His hands grasped both sides of my face and he pulled me close, resting his forehead against mine. He closed his eyes and inhaled deeply, as if he was breathing me in. As if he could finally relax.

“You’re here,” he murmured, and those two words held a mountain of meaning.

I smiled. “I’m here.”

His eyes opened, and they were filled with so much love I couldn’t believe I ever questioned it. “You have no idea how much I missed you.” He kissed me, his lips featherlight against mine, and I melted into him, kissing him back.

My world instantly righted itself. All the chaotic emotions I’d been feeling the past few months seemed to diminish bit by bit, and my soul brightened. If it was possible to see it, it would be blazing brighter than the sun.

The kiss deepened. I moaned, moving closer. Like it always did with us, it went from zero to a hundred like the flip of a switch.

“Whoa, whoa, whoa, PG-13 please. There’s youngins around.” Tatiana laughed.

Lukyan grinned against my lips, chuckling softly before pulling back. He turned to face the table, clasped my hand in his, and said, “Everyone, this is Lyla. My wife.” His smile was bright and beaming. Bigger than I’d ever seen it. Almost blinding.

Illayana nudged me in the ribs with her elbow and gave me a knowing smirk. “Told you. You were his light.” Then, she walked over to the table and sat down next to Arturo. He leaned forward and gave her a soft, loving kiss on her cheek, whispering something in her ear that made her smile.

Autumn stood, clapping her hands once. “Well, don’t just stand there. Come join us.”

Dimitri took his seat next to her as Lukyan led me around the table, officially introducing me to everyone. One by one, I shook their hands, each one offering me a kind smile and telling me how happy they were to have me.

It was more than I could have ever hoped for. More acceptance than I’d ever received in my life, and a sense of home hit me.

“Okay, so I think we’re all wondering the same thing,” Tatiana began as Lukyan pulled out a chair for me to sit down. *Oh, god. What? What are they wondering? When my obsession with Lukyan started? How many times I snuck into their house? What weird, crazy things I’ve done to make Lukyan mine—* “What’s with the book in your hands?” she finished, her fork pointing right at my scrapbook.

Oh.

I smiled, holding it up with pride. “This is my scrapbook.”

“Scrapbook?” Illayana asked, putting some chicken on her plate. “Of what?”

“Lukyan, obviously,” Nikolai said, giving her a *do you seriously need to even ask that question* kind of look.

Illayana glared.

“Yes. Lukyan.” I opened it up, flipping through the pages. “These aren’t all my images. Just my favorites. Like this one”—I pointed to a picture of Lukyan walking down the street, a pair of Ray Bans over his eyes, an ice cream cone in his hands, his tongue swirling around it—“And this one”—I flicked to the next page and tapped the picture on the bottom left corner. It was one of Lukyan sleeping. “It’s kind of dark because it’s night time, but he looks so cute here. Oh, and this one.” The next photo I pointed out was one of him in the warehouse. He was shirtless, hair up in a bun with a few loose strands cascading around his face, sweat dripping down his abs. Cloth was draped around his hands, and his arms were out wide, a triumphant, smug smile on his face. “This one I have as the screensaver for my phone because I love it so much.” I held up my phone to show them, smiling.

My smile dropped slightly when I realized everyone was just staring at me. I smashed my lips together, looking awkwardly around the table. *Shit. Maybe showing them the magnitude of my obsession might not have been a good idea—*

“Did you pose for this one, Lukyan?” Drea asked, laughing.

“What? No.” He looked at the last photograph a bit closer. “But it is a good one, isn’t it? Can you send me that, actually? I look pretty good in it.”

Illayana sat forward eagerly. “Do you have any embarrassing ones?”

“Yeah. Like any of him falling on his face?” Nikolai smirked.

“Or getting beat in the ring?” Aleksandr joined in.

“Excuse me, if I remember correctly, *you’re* the one who got your ass beat the last time we were in the ring,” Lukyan said smugly, winking.

“You cheated!” Aleksandr snapped. “You know you’re not allowed to kick in the nuts!”

“Father said no rules.” Lukyan shrugged. “Nuts are fair game. Wasn’t my fault you didn’t think of it.”

Aleksandr stood abruptly. “You wanna go again? Let’s go. Right now.”

“Sit down, Aleksandr,” Dimitri commanded. “It’s dinnertime.”

Aleksandr sat, grumbling under his breath.

"I've never seen you so worked up before, Aleksandr." Tatiana's smile was full of amusement. "I gotta say, it's hilarious."

"I'm not worked up," he rushed out. "But I was *undefeated* before that day. It's not fair he ruined my undefeated record by cheating."

Illayana snorted. "Lukyan cheats. We all know that."

"Hey!" Lukyan blasted. "I resent that. I don't *always* cheat."

"Mmm, you kinda do," I added in, laughing. "Cedric told me how you kept cheating in Uno."

"You can cheat in Uno?" Autumn asked, frowning.

Lukyan nodded, placing his elbows on the table and leaning forward eagerly. "Yeah. It's actually really easy. I'll show you one time."

"What's that?" Arturo asked, his eyes narrowed in thought.

"What?" I looked over the scrapbook. "Oh, this? These are dental records."

"You have his dental records?" Drea chuckled.

I nodded. "Yep. And his last physical from the doctor. Also this"—I flipped to the next page, showing them the lock of hair I had taped to the inside—"It isn't the first one I got. That one is here, on my wrist." I showed it to them with pride. "But I wanted another one just in case I lost this one."

"Very logical," Nikolai said.

"Thank you!"

"Oh, man, look at his face." Illayana laughed, pointing to Lukyan.

Lukyan's smirk was only getting wider and wider the longer he looked at my scrapbook.

"He likes it," Autumn said, shaking her head with amusement.

"Of course he does," Papa D chimed in.

I was glad he liked it. I put a lot of work into it to make it absolutely perfect.

Light chatter filled the air, and I couldn't help but smile as conversation bloomed all around me, everyone talking and laughing as they ate. It was such a fun atmosphere—something I never had in my own home growing up. Everyone laughed. Made jokes. Gave each other shit, but in a loving way that you knew was all in good fun. They argued and bickered. Tossed food at one another and jabbed each other in the shoulder when someone said something ridiculous. One sibling would say something, and another

would disagree just for the hell of it, just to rile the other up. I laughed so much my stomach hurt.

They included me in their discussions, asking me all sorts of questions in an effort to get to know more about me, and not once did I feel any sense of judgment or out of place.

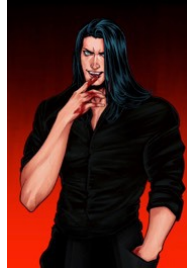
I felt at peace

I felt...for the first time in my life...like I was home.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER FORTY ONE

LUKYAN VOLKOV



“Take off your shirt,” Lyla panted, pushing me down onto the bed.

“Lyla,” I moaned as she kissed my neck. Her lips on my skin were nothing short of ecstasy, and I was having a hard time focusing. “Baby, we need to talk.”

The last fucking thing on Earth I wanted to do was talk. Especially now, with my wife’s hands slowly moving down my chest. But we had to. There was shit we needed to discuss. Issues we needed to address. What happened with her brother was horrible. When I put myself in her shoes, it hurt to even think about killing one of my own siblings, and Lyla had lived it. Endured it. Something like that would scar someone’s soul. She needed to talk it out. Deal with the trauma such an act would have brought forth, and I wanted her to know I was there for her. For whatever she needed.

I wanted to be her support person. Her lifeline. The person she could rely on, no matter what. The person who—

“Oh, fuck me,” I breathed out when she grasped my cock in an ironclad vice.

“I don’t want to talk. I want to *fuck*.”

“Me too,” I whined. “*Me. Fucking. Too*. But we have to talk about what happened. We have to deal with it—”

She gripped my chin, pinching my lips together roughly to silence me. “Listen to me. I know we have to talk. I know there’s shit we need to work out. But I haven’t felt your cock inside me in over three months. We can talk *after* I’m done with you. Do you have a problem with that?”

Hell fucking no.

I shook my head.

Lyla smirked, and it was nothing short of devious. She let me go and stepped back, her face switching from Playful Lyla to Huntress in the blink of an eye. “Take off your clothes and get further up on the bed.”

My whole body wracked with shivers. “I missed you ordering me around.” I did as she commanded, stripping out of my clothes until I was completely naked, and then jumped on the bed, shuffling backward until my spine hit the headboard.

I cocked my head, intrigued as she bent down and reached into her duffle bag. She pulled out a long, thick chain.

My cock hardened instantly. *What’s her plan? Chain me to the fucking bed?*

Please be yes.

“Arms out to the side.”

I flung my arms out so fast they smashed into the headboard with a loud *bang*.

Lyla chuckled, running her fingers up and down the chain as she slowly approached me. “Eager, are we?”

“You have no idea. I can’t keep my body from trembling.” I really, seriously couldn’t. Having her in my room, in my space, walking toward me with that sexy fucking look in her eyes had me almost vibrating off the goddamn mattress.

She stopped beside the bed and stared down at me. Tension skyrocketed between us. My body craved her. Her touch. Her scent. Not only my body, but my heart. My soul. Every inch of me from top to bottom.

When I had first walked into the dining room and saw her standing there, it was as if a huge pressure lifted from my chest, and I could finally breathe again. For the past three months, I’d been walking around like a ghost, barely a shell of my former self. Like I was an empty husk, just going through the motions.

Then, Lyla appeared, like a demon emerging from the shadows, and my heart kickstarted back to life.

Lyla wound the chain around my wrist before securing it to the pillar on the headboard. She climbed on top of me, legs either side of my body, and looped it around the back of the bed, stretching it out to reach my arm before winding it around my other wrist. Lyla pulled it tight, and I was unable to do anything else except groan at that delicious bite of pain. Lastly,

she clicked a padlock through the chain, and there I was. Officially at her mercy.

Exactly where I wanted to be.

She sat back, admiring her work. Admiring *me*, her gaze drenched with heat and longing. Her eyes lit up, and I knew without her having to say a word what was on her mind.

“You want to take a picture for your scrapbook, don’t you?” I grinned.

She seemed to suddenly go shy, which was so out of the norm for her. I found it utterly adorable. “Yeah.”

I relaxed my body, grin still firmly in place, and rumbled, “*Davay, lyubimaya,*” *Go for it, baby.*

Excitement burst all over her face. Lyla jumped off and stood at the foot of the bed before digging her phone from her pocket. She held the device up, snapping a few pictures at different angles.

“Fuck, you look so good.” Her free hand dived into the front of her pants, almost as if she couldn’t wait another second to touch herself over me. A soft moan fell from her lips.

A deep, overwhelming hunger hit me, making me squirm, my hips involuntarily thrusting upward. “Oh, don’t tease me, baby. Bring that pussy over here. I want to taste you.”

She arched an eyebrow. “Is that how you ask your Huntress?” There was a slight reprimand in her voice, and I wondered if she would punish me for that.

I wanted her to.

Shivers shot down my spine. “Please,” I amended. “Please let me taste your pussy.”

Lyla placed the tip of her finger on my shin and sensually ran it up my leg as she made her way around the bed, each step she took slow. Almost seductive. “Have you been a good boy, baby?”

“Yes.” I nodded rapidly. “I’ve been a good boy. I’ve been *such* a good boy. I promise.”

“Hmm.” Her finger continued to move up and up, gliding over my cock, teasing the absolute fuck out of me and almost making me come from that one touch alone. “Show me. Stick out your tongue.”

I did without hesitation.

“Good,” she sang approvingly. “Don’t move.”

Oh, man. I both loved and hated when she said that. It meant I would enjoy what was about to happen, but it would also be complete fucking agony.

Lyla stripped out of her clothes quickly and climbed back on the bed. I barely had enough time to marvel at the gloriousness of her naked body before she stood directly in front of me and placed her pussy on my mouth.

She moaned. I moaned. We both fucking moaned like no tomorrow. Her taste exploded on my tongue, and I sealed my lips over her, sucking hard on her clit.

Lyla moved, grinding herself down on me. *Taking* her pleasure with absolutely no qualms, and I loved it.

I loved every moment of it.

I groaned deep in my throat. My hands clenched into tight fists, and I pulled against the chains, desperate to touch her. To feel her skin beneath my fingers. To grip her ass and make her ride my face harder. Faster.

“Yes. That’s it. You’re such a good boy, letting me use you,” she praised, and it egged me on, knowing I was pleasing her.

I moved my mouth in time with her thrusts, flicking my tongue, trying to utterly devour her. Lyla moaned the entire time, my name falling from her lips, drenched in passion.

“Mmm, baby. You taste so good.” The chains rattled loudly as I fought against them. It only seemed to spur her on more, knowing I was unable to move. Unable to do anything. Lyla had complete freedom to do whatever she wanted to me.

It turned me on.

My cock was so hard it hurt.

Her hands came down and gripped both sides of my face, and she held me exactly where she wanted me, riding my face harder.

“Oh, baby. Lukyan. Your tongue. *Your fucking tongue.*” She panted heavily.

I leaned forward as much as I could, needing more of her. Needing to drown myself in her. I sucked. I licked. I swirled my tongue over her clit. I knew she preferred a slightly rougher touch, so I used my teeth to nibble around her pussy, sucking at her skin, the inside of her thighs. I let my tongue hang out loosely and shook my head as much as her grip would allow, trying to downright bury myself inside her. To get as close to her as humanly possible.

Her head flung back, and she let out a cry of pleasure. She quickly slapped a hand over her mouth to muffle it, and I yanked hard on the chains, wanting to rip that fucking hand away so I could hear her.

“Oh, god. Oh, fuck.” Her thrusts slowed as she came down from her orgasm, and then she moved back slightly. She looked down at me. Hunger burned in her eyes. It made my heart pound in my chest, knowing she wanted me, *needed me* as much as I did her. She gripped my chin roughly and leaned down.

My whole body trembled as she ran her tongue up and around my lips, licking herself from my face. “You taste even better with me all over you,” Lyla murmured huskily.

I whined. “You’re killing me, Huntress.”

She licked my face again. “I like you needy and helpless.”

“You’re evil,” I whimpered.

“Yeah.” A devilish smirk curled on her lips. “But you like it, though.”

“I do. I so fucking do.” I nodded earnestly.

“Don’t worry, you’re going to like this part too.”

Lyla climbed off the bed, and my body went to follow. The chains snapped taut.

“Noooo.” I almost cried. “Come back, baby. Come back.”

Lyla pulled a chair from the small lounge set in the middle of the room and dragged it over. She sat down, put her feet up on the side of the bed, and spread her legs wide.

“*Fuck me.*” Her pussy was dripping wet. Soft and pink and covered in tiny little bite marks from my teeth.

Such a fucking turn on.

Her hand disappeared, and then a knife appeared, flipping through her fingers. My eyes widened. “I’m going to fuck myself with your knife. You’re going to watch. And then I’ll give it back to you, so that every time you use it, you’ll remember this moment. Remember *you’re mine*. Always. ’Til death do us fucking part. And if you ever leave me again, I’ll use this knife to cut the rope I will use to keep you tied up in my house forever so you can never escape me.”

“Slightly terrifying, but also incredibly hot,” I breathed out.

There was a sheath over the blade, which I was thankful for because I didn’t want her to accidentally cut herself. She held the knife out to me until the handle touched my lips. “Suck it. Make it nice and wet for me, baby.”

I sealed my lips around it and slathered as much saliva as I could onto it, swirling my tongue the same way I did when I licked her pussy, my eyes never leaving hers.

Her hand caressed the side of my face lovingly. “Good boy,” she whispered.

I melted under her praise.

The handle left my mouth, and she leaned back, adjusted herself slightly to get comfortable, and then the handle disappeared into her tight hole. She moaned, arching her back.

Fucking, fucking, fuck, fuck.

It was a delicious kind of torture, watching her fuck herself with my knife while I was chained to the bed, unable to do anything except watch. Watch as she palmed one of her breasts, squeezing tightly, wishing it was my fucking hand instead. Watch as her hips rolled. Watch as the handle went in and out, in and out, wishing it was my cock in that tight little pussy.

It was agonizing. And the hottest thing I’d ever seen in my life.

I couldn’t take it anymore.

The chains around my wrists snapped taut as I stretched toward her, trying to get as close as possible. “Please. Please, I’ll be your good boy. I promise. Just please, let me touch you. Let me fuck you.” I was a begging, pathetic mess. I knew that, and I didn’t fucking care.

Lyla’s eyes snapped to me, burning with fire. She threw the knife to the side and climbed on top of me. “Condom?” she asked, getting into position.

I barely had enough common sense left in me to utter, “Side drawer.”

She reached forward, plucked one out, sheathed my cock, and then dropped herself down on me quickly, as if she couldn’t wait another moment to feel me inside of her.

I knew the feeling.

We both moaned at the same time, the overwhelming sensation overtaking us both. Her pussy was hot. Tight. Squeezing my cock with a vicelike grip.

Heavenly.

Pure. Fucking. Heaven.

Lyla started to move. The sight she made...I couldn’t stop looking at her.

“You’re so beautiful,” I breathed out in reverence, pleasure shooting up my spine. I wouldn’t last long. It’d been over three months since I last

came. I was built up, ready to explode, especially after the hot fucking show she'd just put on.

Lyla's hands wound up her body and tangled in her hair. "Tell me you want me."

"I want you," I moaned.

"Tell me you need me."

"I need you."

"Tell me—"

"I love you," I panted heavily, each bounce on my cock ripping a deep groan from my lips. "I love you. I love you. I love you." She didn't even need to tell me to say that. I would have gladly said it on my own. "I've loved you for longer than you even realize."

"Lukyannnn," she screamed out, her body trembling. Her pussy clamped down on my cock, rippling around me, the pleasure so intense my ass lifted off the bed. I thrust upward as my own orgasm ripped into me with such force it took my fucking breath away. A long, deep, masculine moan rumbled out of my throat, and I fell back down onto the bed. Lyla followed quickly after, collapsing forward onto my chest.

We both tried to catch our breath. My heart raced, beating so fast I feared it might jump right out of my chest. Lyla placed a soft kiss on my pec before climbing up and unlocking the padlock. She untwined the chains from around my wrists before settling back right where she was, resting comfortably on top of me.

I wound my arms around her instantly, holding her close. "I missed you so much."

"Did you?" she asked in a quiet voice.

The hesitation in her voice made me pull back slightly. "Of course I did." When she didn't move to look back up at me, I grabbed her chin softly and forced her eyes to me. "Don't you know how much I love you? How much I can't get you out of my head? You're all I think about. Day and night."

She bit her lip nervously.

"What?" I asked, voice soft. "You don't believe me?"

Her eyes darted down.

"Don't do that," I whispered. "Talk to me, baby."

"I—" She took a deep breath in as if she was gathering her thoughts. "For the last three months, I thought you didn't care."

Hearing that broke my fucking heart. “Baby.” I grabbed her face with both hands, staring deep into her eyes, hoping she could see my sincerity. “All I’ve done for the last three months is look for you. I never wanted to leave you. Never. The only reason I did was because of the shit with my grandfather. As soon as that was handled, I was going to come back to you.”

“Really?”

“Yes.” I poured as much emotion into that one word as I could. “There was never any doubt in my mind that you’re the one for me. I love you more than I could ever put into words. Ever convey. You’re the first thing I think about when I wake up in the morning, and the last thing when I go to sleep. Every part of me yearns for you. My heart. My soul. My light. It’s yours. It’s all yours. Forever until the day we die, and beyond that. You once said ‘we were bound together by forces beyond our control’. That we were destiny. Fate. You were right, baby. I was meant to be yours, and you were meant to be mine. I will never let anything or anyone come between us again. I promise.”

Tears gathered in her eyes. She buried her face into my chest, burrowing into me. I let her, squeezing her tight. I didn’t blame her for being skeptical. We’d built such a strong connection, and then when I just left, it had hurt her. I understood what she was feeling, and I would do whatever I could to make it right.

We laid like that for I didn’t even know how long. Just enjoying each other’s company. Each other’s presence. Neither one of us wanting to move. I stroked her head, running my fingers through her hair. She drew little circles into my skin, the feel of her breath fanning out over my chest setting me completely at ease.

All my life, I’d been searching for something, and I never even realized it.

It was that. That feeling of absolute belonging. Connection. Like I’d found the other half to my soul.

“I’m sorry about your brother,” I whispered softly into her hair. Lyla stiffened in my arms. I tightened my hold on her, fearing she would get up and leave because of the painful topic.

“He wasn’t always like that,” she began in a quiet voice. “When we were kids, he was the only one who was nice to me. My father used to lock me in the closet whenever I misbehaved. His version of ‘misbehaved’ ranged from not doing as I was told to speaking when I wasn’t spoken to.

The slightest thing would set our father off. As his firstborn son, Lev had always been exempt from his wrath. I wasn't. He would lock me in there, sometimes for days at a time, with no food or water. Lev was the only one who gave a shit. Not my mother or the maids or soldiers. No-one. Just Lev. *Only Lev.*"

Hearing what her father used to do to her made me wish I could drag him from his fucking grave just to send him right fucking back. The bastard.

I kept that anger locked away from her, not wanting it to touch her, and continued to rub small circles into her skin with my thumb.

"He used to sneak me food under the door. Sit outside the closet and sing songs to me so I would know he was there. He was my big brother. My protector. And I killed him." Her voice broke, and along with it, my heart.

"Baby." I held her even closer, wishing there was some way I could take that pain from her. Endure it myself so she wouldn't have to. "You know it wasn't your fault, right?"

She sniffed and lifted her head. Red eyes found mine, shining with tears. "If not mine, then whose?"

"*His.* You *begged* Lev to walk away. You begged him to let his revenge go, and he couldn't. Your pain that day was clear for everyone to see. He should have chosen you over his revenge. He should have wanted to spare you the pain of the choice you had to make, and he didn't. He only cared about getting what he wanted. Nothing else. That's not your fault." Her gaze lowered, but I wasn't having it. I raised her head up and grabbed her attention once more. "*It's not your fault.*"

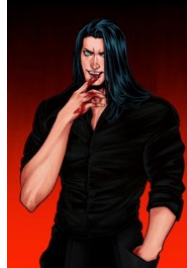
"It hurts so much." She sobbed.

Pain lanced at my heart, seeing her so torn up. "I know, baby, I know." I buried her face into my chest, holding her as tightly as I could as she cried for her brother. "I'm here. I'm here."

Lyla let go. She grieved the loss of the only family she'd had left, and I held her the whole time, letting her work through it for as long as she needed. There were no words I could say to make that pain go away. All she needed was my support, my love, and she had it. From then until the end of time and beyond.

CHAPTER FORTY TWO

LUKYAN VOLKOV



It's not easy, living two lives.

I stared out over the dining table, my eyes running over all the trays of food, looking for anything out of place.

Today was the day. Today was the motherfucking day.

Everything had to be perfect. I didn't want anything less. Lyla didn't deserve anything less.

The table was set immaculately. I'd googled the best way to set a table, and made sure it looked exactly how it did in the Youtube tutorial. Flora and a few of the other housemaids had offered to help, but I'd respectfully declined. I wanted to do everything myself, and I mean *everything*.

I cooked all the food. Hand-picked the flowers sitting snugly in the vase in the center of the table. Lit the candles all around the room. Laid the rose pedals on the floor. Set each piece of cutlery, plate, and wine glass in exactly the right spot. I wanted Lyla to see the effort I put in. See how important it all was to me that everything be absolutely perfect *for her*.

Only for her. Because she deserved the world.

I wore my best suit. My hair was down because I knew she loved it the most that way. My face was clean-shaven. I'd buffed my shoes so they were sparkling. And the pièce de résistance—her collar, snapped securely around my neck.

Despite the excitement coursing through my veins, I couldn't help but be a little nervous too. I hated being nervous. It was so out of the norm for me, but I knew it was a good kind of nervous because today was the day that everything finally revealed itself.

The day that I spoke the *whole* truth, for the first time in two years. No lies. No carefully worded answers or phrases. Just the whole truth and nothing but the truth.

My phone dinged with an incoming text message.

Illayana Butt Face: Pulling up now.

MY BREATH CAUGHT in my throat. *Fuck, here we go.*

I did another quick glance around the table, making sure there wasn't a single thing out of place. A speck of fluff was sitting next to Lyla's plate. I picked it up and glared at it.

"What are you doing? Are you trying to ruin everything?!" I hissed at the inanimate object. "Fuck off before you destroy all my hard work." I flicked it away and rubbed the sleeve of my jacket over that spot vigorously, making it spick-and-span again.

Laughter and footsteps echoed to my ears from the front of the house. My spine snapped straight. *She's coming.* I cleared my throat, straightened the lapels on my jacket, and took my position by the front door.

I cracked my neck one side, then the other before blowing out a deep, calming breath.

You can do this, Lukyan. You can do this—

Lyla walked in. My heart stopped dead in my chest. She was so goddamn beautiful. I honestly had no idea what I had done in a previous life to be so fucking lucky. Her hair was down in waves, cascading over her shoulders. Her honey-colored eyes were lit up bright. Sparkling. And her smile?

God, her fucking smile.

It took my breath away every time I saw it.

Lyla froze in the doorway, looking at me and then the—not to toot my own horn—beautifully decorated table behind me. "What is this?" she breathed out in shock.

I bowed gallantly at the waist, turning my body as I spread my arm out wide. "Your dinner awaits, my lady."

Lyla giggled and did a fancy curtsy. "Why, thank you, good sir."

I offered my hand, and she placed hers in it. My gaze snagged on the wedding ring on her finger, and a burst of pride exploded in my chest.

She is mine. All fucking mine.

I led her over to the head of the table and pulled out her seat.

She giggled again. "I have no idea what's going on, but I am *loving it*."

I chuckled. "Thought you might." I winked. I went back over to the door and gave Illayana a hug. "Thank you for your help," I whispered.

"Anytime," she replied, returning the hug.

She, of course, didn't know what the dinner was about. Just that I needed her help distracting Lyla while I set it all up. Maybe one day, I would tell my siblings.

Maybe not.

She stepped back and waved to Lyla. "Thanks for breakfast. See you later."

"Yeah, see you later! And hey, I still want that spar soon," Lyla said, a smirk of excitement curling on her lips.

Illayana's smirk mirrored hers. "Definietly." And then she left.

"You sure you want to spar with her? She fights dirty," I said jokingly, but also not at the same time because I knew from firsthand experience Illayana did whatever she needed to do to win a fight.

Lyla's smile was big and bright. "Oh, I'm sure. I've seen her fight. I think it'll be fun."

I laughed, shaking my head. I retrieved the bottle of champagne from the ice bucket and popped it open.

Lyla arched a brow. "Champagne? What are we celebrating?"

"It's our anniversary," I said casually, pouring the champagne into her glass.

She frowned, thinking it over. "No, it's not."

I poured my glass next and placed the bottle down on the table before taking my seat beside her. I picked up my drink, leaned back, and crossed my ankle over my knee, staring her dead in the eyes. "Yes. It is."

Two years earlier

MY FATHER THOUGHT he was being followed. I thought he was just being his usual paranoid self, but hey, no one gave a shit about my opinion. He told me to watch him from afar to see if anyone was tracking his movements. So,

that was what I was doing, even if I thought he was being absolutely crazy. No one in their right mind would follow the Bratva Butcher.

I stayed at least a hundred metres behind him at all times as he walked down the street, his bodyguards right at his side. I'd chosen a pretty awesome disguise, even going the extra mile and getting a custom-made wig and facial hair to better hide my appearance.

If my father was being followed, I couldn't afford to be recognized. If I was going to catch the imaginary stalker my father had conjured in his mind, I needed to watch without being watched, which was easy to do now that I looked nothing like myself. I had short, spiky red hair, a full beard—also the same shade—and big, horn-rimmed glasses.

I was still killing the look, of course, but at least no one would think I was Lukyan Volkov in that getup.

For hours, I tracked my father as he went to various stores along the Vegas strip, and I felt like I was going to die of boredom—

A figure caught my attention from across the street. I froze, stunned. A woman slinked in and out of the shadows, her gaze securely fastened on my father.

Holy shit. He was right. He is being followed.

Interest sparked in my soul in an instant. My head cocked to the side as I studied her. She moved fast. Slick. For such a tall woman—at least six foot, I'd have guessed—, she moved with such grace and fluidly. Her movements were precise, and she didn't draw attention to herself. If it wasn't for the fact that I was actively searching for something out of place, I doubt I would have even noticed her myself.

My feet moved on autopilot as I tracked her tracking my father. She ducked in and out of stores, never losing sight of her target. When my father stopped, she stopped, pretending to tie her shoes. When my father turned, she turned, gazing in the windows like she was interested in what was there.

She was totally inconspicuous.

*Excitement burst in my veins. **Who is she?** I was dying to know.*

*** * ***

FOR THE PAST MONTH, I had been watching the mystery woman track my father. In retrospect, I probably should have told him what was going on.

*That he was right. Someone **was** following him. But...I didn't want to. I didn't want him to do something to make the woman disappear. She intrigued me too much.*

I wanted to know her.

There was something about her that just called to me. A kindred spirit. I was sure of it. So, I told my father there was no danger, but as a precaution, I would continue to follow him from the shadows to ensure it.

The woman had been very careful to hide her identity. Every time I saw her, she was in a different getup. Her hair was always different. So were her eyes. And I could have sworn her nose was a different shape the last time I saw her too.

It made me beyond curious about what she actually looked like. Who she really was. I needed to get closer. I needed to get some of her DNA so I could run her through our system. Try to find out her true identity.

I sat at the counter of the café, drinking from my mug, my eyes firmly on the woman while hers were firmly on my father as he collected his styrofoam cup from the barista and deposited a very large and generous tip in the tip jar.

The cap she was wearing was cute.

I discreetly took out my phone and snapped a few photos of her. For memories. To look at when I missed her. Because I did. I missed her when I wasn't watching her. I knew it was quickly becoming an obsession, and I didn't care. That woman had been the first thing to grab my attention in years. I wasn't letting that go. Never.

My father headed for the exit. The woman threw back whatever liquid had long since gone cold in her mug and went to follow.

Something spurred me forward, telling me not to let her get away.

I couldn't take it anymore. I had to meet her. The idea to stage a run-in burst into my head, and then the next thing I knew, I was out of my seat, moving toward her, hunting her down—

"Ooof." She ran smack into my chest. She'd been so preoccupied watching my father she hadn't even seen me coming from the other side. Her body tipped back and my arms wrapped around her waist, stopping her in mid-air. Heat shot up my spine from the contact.

Her gaze snapped to me, and my heart stopped dead in my chest.

*The most beautiful pair of honey-colored eyes stared deep into my fucking soul, taking my goddamn breath away. Those were her **real** eyes. I*

was sure of it, and they would be forever seared into my brain.

There was something familiar in them. Something that my soul recognized. And I wondered if I had finally met her. My forever. The only one who could match my crazy.

There was a way to test that. If I could make her as obsessed with me as I was with her. Then, I would know. I would know she was perfect for me. I would know that I'd found the one person I would never have to hide myself from. I quickly took all of her in, committing every single detail to memory before turning on the Lukyan charm.

"Sorry about that, gorgeous. Didn't see you."

She shivered in my fucking arms. "Uh—I-I—"

I smirked. Her mouth dropped open.

That's it, baby, get a good look. Come follow me instead.

I wanted to shift her attention from my father to me because, if I was being honest, I was getting jealous that she wasn't following **me** instead. I wanted her attention—all her fucking attention—and I would do whatever I needed to, to get it.

I pushed her back up onto her feet and, as much as I didn't want to, moved back slightly. I grabbed her hand, and kept my gaze locked with hers as I bent at the waist and placed the softest, smoothest kiss on the top of her hand.

She swayed slightly.

"You have yourself a good day, gorgeous," I rumbled, winking before turning around and heading for the door.

Each step I took was pure agony. I wanted to go back. To talk to her. Demand her to tell me every single thing about her. Bring her back to my house and tie her to the bed so she could never leave.

I hoped I'd done enough to spark her interest.

Come, my little shadow. Stalk me.

* * *

My love,

I am both devastated and hurt by your act of betrayal last night. Don't you see how perfect we are for each other? How well we fit together?

*We're inevitable, you and me. Like death. We're bound together by forces
beyond our control.*

I felt it the first time I laid eyes on you.

Didn't you feel it too? I know you did.

*Let this gift be a lesson for you, my love. Not only a show of my complete
and utter devotion to you, but also a display of what shall happen should
you betray our love again.*

Yours always, in this life and the next,

L

*I KEPT the giddiness I felt over Lyla's love letter to myself as Aleksandr read
it outloud.*

Lyla. Her name was Lyla.

*It had taken me a while to figure out her identity, and oh, boy, it had
come as quite a fucking shock. I wasn't sure who I imagined she would be,
but the daughter of the man who murdered my mother, who, in turn, my
father murdered for retribution was the last person on this earth I expected.*

*It had taken me a while to come to terms with, but in the end, it didn't
matter to me. Lyla was a child when everything happened, like I was. She
wasn't responsible for her father's actions, just like I wasn't for mine.*

*Who she was didn't matter to me. What she was doing following my
father didn't matter to me. All that did was that she was mine, and I would
do whatever it took to have her.*

*Lying to my siblings about who she was was hard. **Beyond hard.**
Pretending like I had no idea what was going on when, really, I was the one
pulling all the strings, was even harder.*

But I had to.

*My siblings loved me. I knew that. But they didn't trust my judgment, as
made abundantly clear by Aleksandr's earlier words.*

"Lukyan will just fuck it up. He's unreliable."

They couldn't know anything about Lyla.

*So, when Aleksandr asked, "What betrayal is she talking about? And
what gift?" I lied.*

Effortlessly.

For the greater good.

*"Well," I began, keeping my tone light to hide my deception. "I went
out last night and ended up fucking this chick in the alley."*

Lies.

Lies, lies, lies.

That never happened, but for the purpose of keeping my secret, I had to say I did. Sure, there was a tiny sliver of guilt worming its way into my heart at having to lie to my older brother's face like that, but there was no way I could tell him I was hopelessly in love and obsessed with my stalker.

He just wouldn't understand. He would tell me I was being crazy. **Again.** Acting irresponsibly.

I had to show not only him but **everyone** that Lyla and I were perfect for each other.

"I'm assuming that's the betrayal she's talking about," I continued, gripping the box in my hands tighter. "Because this was her gift." I didn't want to part with it. It was the best gift I'd ever received in my life. Nonetheless, I placed the medium-sized box down onto the table and waited.

Aleksandr picked it up with trepidation and looked inside.

It was fingers. Ten perfectly manicured fingers of a woman Lyla **thought** I'd had sex with. The truth of the matter was, I hadn't touched another woman since the first moment I'd laid eyes on her....because she was right. I felt our connection the first time I saw her.

Scrawled on the inside of the lid was:

She lost her fingers for daring to touch what doesn't belong to her. Take care with who you allow to touch you, my love.

LYLA HAD BEEN WATCHING ME, like she did most nights. I **was** at the club. I didn't lie about that part, but I was there for business. The club owner had been late for his payment to the Bratva, so my father sent me to collect it.

The club owner didn't have it. Surprise, surprise. And instead tried to offer me something else in a bid to buy more time.

Or should I say, **someone else.**

He pushed one of the girls who worked the club at me, thinking what everyone else thought.

The playboy of the Bratva couldn't say no to pussy.

Neither one knew that my heart had been claimed a long, long time ago. I was firmly a one-woman man.

The woman ran her fingers across my chest in a sultry attempt to get in my pants—which I promptly declined—and then, the next morning, those very same fingers were sitting in a box on the hood of my car, wrapped nicely in a big, beautiful red bow.

I'd never been more turned on in my life. My little shadow was possessive of me. **Killed** over me.

It was the hottest thing I'd ever seen, and only made me more head over heels for her than I already was.

* * *

“RING-A-DING-DING, YOU'VE GOT THE KING,” I answered.

“Where are you?” Nikolai asked.

I couldn't tell him where I **really** was. So, I said the first thing I could think of that would garner no more questions.

“Getting my dick sucked. Why?”

“We need you home. Now. Family meeting.”

Say something Lukyan-like.

“Can I finish first?”

I could almost **feel** him rolling his eyes through the phone. “We have a lead on Father.”

My spine snapped straight and the binoculars fell from my hands. **What?** “Be right there.”

I silently cursed to myself as I hung up the phone and started packing away my gear. I didn't want to leave. I'd brought enough food and water to be camped out here for days. But my father was in trouble, and if we finally had a lead on him, we had to act on it. I had to go.

I snapped the stand on my sniper rifle back into place and loaded it into my suitcase. After zipping my backpack shut, I flung it onto my back and picked up my binoculars again, needing one last look to tide me over.

In the next apartment building over, Lyla sat on her couch, surrounded by darkness, the only light illuminating from the television in front of her. She'd been parked there for hours, immersed in whatever program was playing. Honestly, I couldn't tell you which one she was watching. My focus never left her. Not once.

She had a bucket of popcorn in her lap, and several empty energy drink cans on the floor around her.

Her brother had come over earlier. Lev Voznesensky. I couldn't quite put my finger on it, but there was something about him I just didn't like. Maybe it was the way he spoke to her, like he was talking down to her. Maybe it was the way he would bark orders at her and expect her to follow them.

*Whenever Lyla wasn't following me, I was following **her**. She'd bugged my phones and laptops to keep track of me, so I had to get another phone—one she didn't know about that I used solely for the photos and videos I took of her. Photos of her walking down the street. Sitting in a restaurant, eating lunch. Riding her bike.*

She'd meet up with her brother once a month, the location different every time, and discuss something so important they'd play music to hide it. Just in case anyone was listening.

I wasn't sure what it was, but I knew it had something to do with my father and why she was following him.

I allowed myself ten more seconds. Ten more agonizing seconds to catalog and imprint her every detail into my mind before leaving.

If I was lucky, I could hopefully be back later tonight to watch her before she went to bed.

As I pulled up at home, I quickly adjusted my clothing. I had a part to play in all of it. I couldn't have anyone be suspicious about where I was spending my time.

My fingers pulled and plucked at my hair, making it as messy as I could. I shrugged out of my coat so it hung loosely around my shoulders, and then undid my shoelaces to give off the appearance I'd dressed in a hurry, before rushing inside.

** * **

SHE'S HERE.

Lyla is here.

I stayed motionless, making sure to slow down my breathing to give off the illusion of sleep as Lyla crawled through my bedroom window. So far, Lyla had snuck into my room three times, and each time, it had been hard to remain still. Every part of me loved having her in my space. I just wanted to

acknowledge the burning connection between us and fuck her on every surface in my bedroom.

Lyla did nothing but watch me. Sometimes, for hours on end.

It excited me. Made me want to give up on the insane plan I'd concocted and court her like a regular person.

But we weren't regular people. Finding someone to match my crazy was extremely important to me. In everyday life, I treated everything like it was a game.

*This was anything **but** a game.*

*This was my chance at happiness. **Lyla** was my chance at happiness. And I would do whatever I needed to do to grasp her and never let her go.*

She was perfect for me. In every way, shape, and form. Nothing held her back from going after what she wanted. Not even a fully fenced property with a twenty-four-hour security detail and dozens of guard dogs.

She'd seen those obstacles and gone, "Okay, let's have some fun" before making her way up to my bedroom.

I laid flat on my back, my hands behind my head, face up toward the ceiling, eyes still closed. I kept my breathing slow and steady—hard to do when I could feel Lyla's gaze burning into the side of my face—and tried to slow the excited beat of my heart as she knelt beside me.

She didn't touch me. Never did. She just sat there and watched me sleep.

** * **

I WALKED BACK into the kitchen with the iPad in my hands and showed it to Nikolai. "Look."

"What am I supposed to be looking at here?" he asked, eyes darting all over the screen.

It was security footage from the night before. Footage of Lyla breaking into my room and stealing my dagger.

I'd debated long and hard about whether or not to show my siblings the video. Up until that point, they'd only pegged Lyla as a minor inconvenience. Nothing too serious or anything to worry about.

I wanted to change that.

I wanted them to see what an absolute badass she was. The potential she had to improve our family and make it stronger. That she was able to

get through our mountains of security, up the side of the house, through my bedroom window, and watch me sleep for hours without breaking a fucking sweat. All completely undetected.

I wanted them aware of her.

In awe of her.

Like I was.

So, I'd accused Illayana of stealing my dagger to have an excuse to show them the security footage. To show them the very first glimpse of my one true fucking love.

"You've seen this?" my brother asked, concern on his face.

"Yep." I couldn't keep the excitement from my face even if I tried.

Nikolai groaned. "Why do you look like that?"

"Like what?" I smiled innocently.

"Like you're giddy with anticipation. You shouldn't be. This woman broke into your room and watched you sleep for over an hour. She's dangerous. And crazy."

*"I know." **Isn't that awesome?** "My two favorite things. I can't wait to meet her." **Properly.***

* * *

"BEFORE YOU LEAVE, there's something else we need to discuss." Aleksandr held my gaze, and I thumped back down into my seat.

"What did I do now?" I sighed, because let's face it, I was the preferable fuck up in this family.

"You haven't done anything—"

"For once," Nikolai added with a chuckle, and I cut him a glare.

"It's about your stalker."

Inside my soul lit up like a fucking Christmas tree, but I had to play it cool. I couldn't let them see how the mere mention of her excited me to no end. "What about her?"

*"Did you know **she** was the one who sent the location of Talon's island to Drea? Or that **she** was the sniper who saved you in the arena?"*

I widened my eyes, even though I had already expected as such. "She was? How could you possibly know that?"

Drea was the one to answer. "Because I didn't order anyone up there. Neither did Arturo, Mikhail, or my brother."

"Okay? I don't get what the big deal is. If what you're saying is true, it means she saved me. Saved **us**."

They should all be singing her fucking praises, not talking about her like she is some sort of problem to take care of.

If it wasn't for her, we'd all be dead.

"The big deal is, that woman is highly trained, highly skilled, has managed to sneak in and out of the property completely undetected, and we still have no idea who the fuck she is. The big deal is that she is a massive, massive threat, and the moment she realizes she can't have you will be the moment everything changes."

He was talking about the arranged marriage with Anya. Offering to take Aleksandr's place had been a spur-of-the-moment decision. Aleksandr and Nikolai both couldn't do it now that they were head over heels in love. As someone hopelessly in love, I understood the pain it would cause them, having to marry another. I couldn't do that to them, and if no one married Anya, Grandfather would kill Illayana.

I didn't have a choice. I **had** to take his place, otherwise, my sister would die.

Not to mention the fact that it was my one chance to show my siblings I wasn't as unreliable as they all seemed to think I was.

I had a plan.

There wasn't much longer to go. I would do my duty to my family, marry Anya, and then, once my grandfather was dead, terminate our arrangement and finally be with Lyla again.

I was well aware of the fact that it was a risky plan, but any plan with so much at stake was a risky one, no matter what it was.

I couldn't get out of marrying Anya, as much as I wanted to. But there was nothing saying I had to **stay** married to her after. Especially once Sergei was dead.

The only variable in the whole equation was Lyla. I'd been edging her for months, pushing her to act. She hadn't yet, and the suspense was killing me.

She had to have something planned, but what?

"We need to find her and deal with her. She's following **you**. That means you're the only one who can do it. You do whatever you need to do to find

her, and you kill her. Understand?” Aleksandr finished.

*I understood that was what **he** wanted me to do. What **he** believed to be the best course of action.*

But I didn't.

That all too familiar sliver of guilt sank its way deep into my bones, but nevertheless, I said the words, lying to my brother. Again. “Got it.”

* * *

Me: Who are you?

I OPENED my bedroom door and froze in the doorway. A smirk curled on my lips. Lyla's delectable scent filled my senses, and I almost moaned from the excitement.

She's here.

Two words I absolutely loved to utter, even if it was only inside my head.

I allowed myself one more moment to lock down the exhilaration hammering in my veins before walking in and shutting the door.

*I flicked on the light and went straight to stripping off my clothes. I wasn't sure exactly **where** she was, just that she was there.*

Watching me.

Always watching.

So, I undressed slowly. Seductively. Giving her plenty of time to admire me and enjoy the show because...only the best for my girl.

Unknown: Given the events of today, I am willing to forgo that transgression, my love. But, never again. You know who I am. I am yours and you are mine. Until death do us part.

OH MAN. She's absolutely fucking insane.

I'm such a goner.

After exchanging a few more text messages, I decided to throw caution to the wind and see how far I could really push her. See if she would finally let loose some of that craziness I fucking loved so much.

Me: This was mildly entertaining at the start, but now, I'm bored. My attention is hard to keep, and unfortunately for you, you've lost it. 🙄

NOT TRUE.

Not true at all.

*She held **all** my attention. From now until the end of time.*

But I wanted to see what my little shadow would do when challenged.

I walked over to the bed, tossed my phone down, and headed for the shower.

Take the bait, my little shadow.

* * *

I DRIFTED BACK to consciousness but stayed completely still, not making it known that I was awake. I was strapped to a chair. That much, I was sure of. Both my arms and legs were bound, and whatever drug she'd slipped into my drink was still coursing through my body, making me slightly lethargic.

Quietly, carefully, I opened one eye and peeked around the room. Lyla was standing in front of a long table along the wall, dressed in a beautiful white dress. She was humming to herself as she fiddled with a bunch of plates and trays filled with food.

She'd done it.

She'd actually done it.

*I joked about it to everyone, but I hadn't envisioned her **actually** kidnapping me.*

Fuck, my whole body was on fucking fire.

The fucking balls on that woman to not only kidnap me from my own wedding, but play the part of my bride.

It was insane. Outrageous. Completely fucking mad.

And also, pure genius.

She was nothing short of amazing.

But I had to be careful. I had to play the part. Pretend I had no idea who she was, or that I'd been stalking her for a hell of a lot longer than she'd been stalking me.

*I didn't want to scare her off.
I needed to make her completely and hopelessly in love with me first.
Then, and only then, could all be revealed.*

LYLA STARED OPEN-MOUTHED AT ME.

I cleared my throat and sat up straighter. "More champagne?" I asked, holding up the bottle.

I was nervous. Beyond fucking nervous. I wasn't entirely sure how she would react to the knowledge that I had been aware of everything.

Aware of everything she had been doing from the moment she began following my father. Apart from the whole *kidnapping* thing.

But I thought I had winged that part pretty well, if I did say so myself.

Lyla still hadn't said anything, gawking at me in complete and utter shock.

"Penny for your thoughts?" I asked, smiling cautiously.

She finally snapped her mouth shut. She picked up her wine glass and downed the whole thing in one go. She placed it down and then picked up mine, doing the exact same thing.

I poured her another glass.

She downed that too.

Then another.

Then another.

By the sixth, she stopped, still giving me that absolutely bewildered expression.

I mashed my lips together and waited anxiously for her to say something.

"Okay," she finally blew out, eyes turning calculating. "Are you saying you've been *manipulating* me this entire time?"

I winced. "*Manipulating* is such an awful word. I like to think of it more as *me steering you in the right direction.*"

"That direction being you?"

I squared my shoulders and puffed out my chest. "Yes."

She took the whole bottle of champagne that time, taking a big gulp. "That woman, the one from the club. Did you—"

"I didn't sleep with her. Didn't touch her. I haven't touched another woman since the first moment I laid eyes on you. I told my siblings I had

because that's what's expected of me. Told them I had been screwing some chick when I was kidnapped by Talon—”

“No, you weren't.” She frowned. “I was there that night. If you had a woman in your apartment, I would have killed her.”

I smirked. “I know. I only told my siblings that so they wouldn't ask what I was doing in some random apartment in the city.”

“I thought you went there to rest because you couldn't be bothered driving back to your house?”

“No,” I said softly, shaking my head. “I only stayed there because it was easier for you to watch me there. I like it when you watch me.”

Silence reigned between us. I had to keep myself from fidgeting. For the first time ever, I couldn't read her. Couldn't read her thoughts or how she was feeling, and it made me sick to my stomach.

Did I go too far again?

Is what I did too much? Am I too much—

She leaped across the table and jumped at me, her lips smashing into mine. My chair tipped backward, and we went sprawling to the ground.

“Oh—ow, fuck.” I groaned and laughed, my mouth still sealed to hers.

Lyla kissed me even harder. “You're even crazier than I am,” she breathed against my lips. “And I fucking love you for it.”

I smiled wide.

My girl was perfect.

The End

OceanofPDF.com

A LITTLE NOTE FROM ME TO YOU

Wow. I can't believe this moment is finally here. The end of the *Bratva* series.

Thank you all so much for being a part of this journey with me. I couldn't have done it without you.

A massive thank you to my partner, Pierce, for being an unwavering force of encouragement and support while I pursued my dream.

Thank you to my best friend, Nikita, for always being a shoulder to lean on when I was struggling.

Thank you to my amazing editor, Brittany, for all your hard work in making these books the best they could possibly be.

And lastly, thank YOU, the reader, for taking a chance on me.

This is a bittersweet moment. I hope you all loved Lukyan and Lyla's story as much as I loved writing it.

While this is the end of this story, do not fret. I have lots of things still planned for the Volkov's.

Thank you from the bottom of my heart.

T J x